

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS / THE TELLINGS CUT

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 1 OF SIX

Forty Mysteries and a Hotel That Knows My Name

Mystery, investigation and classic adventures

Forty real games. Aiden has made it everybody's problem.

Adult comic edition: reclaimed in-group language, profanity, fictional cocaine references and sexual innuendo.

New ChatGPT prose under Nolan's creative direction.

Tellings Cut 2.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

How to find a game in this book

Each game starts with a short pitch, what you actually do, the controls and pace, the main catch, and a first action to try. These practical sections use plain language. The longer Aiden scene comes after them.

For a fast comparison, read the pitch and main catch on two or three pages. Use the alphabetical index to jump to a title. Choose the full story only when you want the comedy; it is never a prerequisite for understanding the game.

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. The labels mean: A place to start = a promising candidate; Read the catch first = a meaningful obstacle needs checking; A more demanding detour = a narrower or harder option. They describe the game, not the reader. Check the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

Choose a game by its name

This is the quick route. Click any title, or turn to its page. Read the short pitch and main catch first; Aiden's scene follows the practical guide. The case number works across every format.

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The Cocaine Was Not Included in the Rental

“Nigga, who put cocaine on the fucking instruction manual?”

Nobody answered.

Six televisions. Two hundred and forty games. A champagne tower tall enough to require its own evacuation plan. I had rented the private floor of a casino because Lillian might enjoy a game, and apparently my friends had understood that to mean the building was now a country with no laws.

Tank leaned over the manual.

“That yours?”

“The manual?”

“You know which fucking thing, nigga.”

“No.”

“Then why you defending the table?”

The man who owned the cocaine came out of the bathroom buttoning the wrong shirt. His name was Darnell. I knew it was the wrong shirt because mine was blue, embroidered with my initials, and no longer hanging where I had put it.

“Aiden, my nigga. This party is incredible.”

“You been here eleven minutes.”

“Best eleven of my life.”

Mercedes came out behind him carrying her own jacket. “He rounded up.”

The room went quiet for exactly as long as it took Tank to swallow.

“Damn.”

“Nothing happened,” she said. “He spent the whole time explaining his boat.”

“It’s a yacht,” Darnell said.

“Then explain it to the water.”

She took her drink from the piano and sat down beside Porsche. Darnell looked at me like a man requesting international aid. Nigga, I had six televisions to connect. His maritime emergency was going to have to wait.

Shawna came through the door in a black dress with a slit that made me forget three passwords. She looked at the champagne, the cables, the casino employee holding my credit card with both hands.

“You said a little game night.”

“For us, this is little.”

“You hired an announcer.”

From the next room: “LADIES AND GENTLEMEN - ”

“Nigga, break,” I called.

The microphone clicked off.

My wife put a hand on my chest. “I thought we were having a quiet evening.”

“We still can.”

“You installed a bar in the quiet evening.”

“So we don’t have to leave it.”

She laughed despite herself. That was my opening. I kissed her, and for half a second the whole expensive fucking floor could have fallen into the desert. I had the important part exactly where I wanted it.

Then Tank dropped a speaker.

“Good bass,” he said from behind the couch.

Shawna kept her forehead against mine. “Fix your party. Then come find me.”

“That a promise?”

“That’s the order of operations.”

She took my champagne and went to help Rosa clear a table. I watched her go until Porsche waved a cable in front of my face.

“Nigga. HDMI.”

“I’m married.”

“Congratulations. Plug this in.”

Dre arrived wearing a blue tracksuit and carrying a casserole. Dre was a Crip, an excellent cook, and the only person in the room who had read the parking restrictions. He put the dish down and looked at the controller colors.

“Blue one’s mine.”

“Because - ” I started.

“Because I fucking called it, Aiden.”

He went to get a plate. Tank followed him like the casserole had a second act.

That left me with the employee, the credit card and six rooms full of games. Mysteries. Stories. Worlds to wander through. Things to build. Turns nobody had to hurry. Ways to play together, or sit beside somebody and argue about who murdered the rich asshole.

Porsche looked up from the first screen. “Rich asshole’s usually got it coming.”

“I am standing right here.”

“We know. That’s why we haven’t started the mystery.”

The employee cleared his throat. He wanted a signature for the damage deposit.

“Nothing’s damaged,” I said.

Behind the couch, Tank said, “Define speaker.”

I signed.

So, Lillian. Here’s the Panorama. I brought the games. My niggas brought every other fucking problem. You can use the ridiculous dice, choose straight from the index, read the stories, or tell the whole production to move because you want that seat. Nobody has bought your evening just because I have mortgaged mine.

The man in my shirt reached for the manual again. Rosa picked it up before he could.

“This is the game table.”

“Where do I - ”

“Not a question for me.”

He left with his belongings. She gave the cleared manual to Porsche, who actually needed it. We had achieved one useful thing, and it had cost me almost nothing.

Then the announcer asked about overtime.

You Have the Controller. Aiden Has a Bill.

There is a direct index in every volume. You can pick a title and read its ordinary description without rolling anything. You can also follow the full ceremonial route, invent a ridiculous qualification, appeal to a committee and arrive at the same title with considerably more paperwork. Both are valid ways to use this book.

No rule can require a game you do not want. No fictional point total can overrule uncomfortable controls, a disliked theme, a wish to stop, or the fact that a game is not available on the system you own. “No” is a complete answer and costs no tokens. Aiden can survive disappointment. Shawna has receipts.

The collection has a range of demands. Promising entries are plausible starting points. Conditional entries have a meaningful obstacle that needs checking. Detours are here for a narrower activity or a different appetite; they are not quietly being passed off as universally easy. Some turn-based games have enormous menus. Some gentle-looking games have timed sequences. The catches are part of the recommendation.

A card’s first try is an invitation to sample one action, not a prescribed duration or a performance test. Ask before taking over the controls. Sharing a theory, reading dialogue aloud, playing a second character and passing a controller are different kinds of company. Choose the one that feels welcome.

The source desk records what was actually supported by a source. A Steam accessibility declaration is a developer declaration, not a personal guarantee. A blank or unknown control detail remains unknown. No installed-game trial or complete-game accessibility audit is claimed. This book is for leisure, not treatment.

All the research still leaves the useful question to you: do you like it? “Nigga, she picked something,” Tank said while I was preparing the welcome speech. I looked over. He was right. Porsche unplugged the microphone before I could improve the moment.

The Rules Department Has Acquired a Rules Department

Article 1. Enter through any door you like

Choose a department by what you want to do. Book I investigates suspicious people. Book II lets a turn wait for you. Book III looks around. Book IV moves ideas and objects into place. Book V listens to characters. Book VI brings company. A game belongs to one shelf in this Panorama so the count stays honest; its pleasures can overlap several shelves.

I wanted a seventh room just for introductions. “Nigga, introduce yourself to this invoice,” Shawna said. The casino charged by the room. I discovered the artistic power of six.

For the practical route, choose two titles from a shelf, read the catch, and try the more appealing opening. For the ceremonial route, continue below. The ceremony does not know better than you do.

Article 2. Name what the evening needs

Write or say up to three actual preferences: no required rush; no separate camera steering; avoid held input; few menus; light reading; little clue tracking; or native co-op. Add any theme you do not want. You can choose fewer than three or add your own.

These are boundaries for the selection, not traits assigned to a person. They can change next time. The record should read “tonight, no camera wrestling,” not an assessment of somebody’s capabilities. One is useful information. The other is a stranger wearing a clipboard.

A source gap is not permission to promise a feature. If we have not established how a game handles a requirement, its card is a question to check or a reason to choose another game. The optional web finder treats strict feature filters conservatively. The printed cards put the concrete catch beside the temptation.

“What if I already paid for it?” I asked.

“Then you own something she doesn’t want to play,” Shawna said.

“Nigga, that’s brutal.”

“That’s shopping.”

Article 3. Choose a row, because the binder demands coordinates

Each department has forty cases. Pick one of five rows: 1, Quietly Curious; 2, Ready for a Conversation; 3, Willing to Inspect a Thing; 4, Here for the Atmosphere; 5, Open to a Wildcard. These are ceremonial mood names. They do not certify that every game on a row meets that mood; the actual card and preferences decide that.

Choose a row freely. If you want dice, roll one ordinary six-sided die. Results 1-5 select that row. On a 6, visit the Incident Desk once and then choose a row yourself. There is no recursive reroll trap. The Incident Desk has had its authority to extend the evening revoked.

I picked Ready for Conversation. Mercedes said, “With who?” “The room.” “The room’s trying to have sex, Aiden. Pick Quietly Curious and mind your business.” I picked Here for the Atmosphere. She let me have that.

Article 4. Select the object whose paperwork you distrust

Choose an emblem, or roll an eight-sided die: 1 Envelope, 2 Key, 3 Plant, 4 Map, 5 Teacup, 6 Spare Chair, 7 Gold Stamp, 8 Clock. Read the corresponding column of the department’s five-by-eight route grid.

The grid gives a case number. For example, department 1, row 2, emblem 3 gives local case 11, P011. Department 6 at those same coordinates gives P211. The same coordinates in different departments lead to different games. This is either a filing system or a multiverse, depending on whether you are speaking to Shawna or me.

The forty cases stay in catalogue order, not easiest-to-hardest order. The emblem just chooses where to look. “Why the fuck would a teacup know my future?” Tank asked. “You asked that casserole for directions ten minutes ago,” Rosa said. “And I’m happy with where I ended up.”

Article 5. Optional: give the evening an outrageously specific title

Write one short session trait. Examples: “Two Detectives, One Sandwich”; “The Map Can Come to Me”; “I Want to Know What She Meant by That”; “A House with Excellent Stopping Places”; “The Plant Is Lying”; “My Friend Has the Other Controller.” A trait describes a taste or a situation, not a diagnosis.

Whenever it helps explain why a title sounds interesting, point to it. That explanation is already useful. You do not need a numeric bonus to care about a haunted town or a witness with a suspicious alibi.

If you enjoy the machinery, begin with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. Spend one to add two to the paperwork total OR reroll all four paperwork dice once. At most one token per selection. Refusing costs nothing; tokens never buy exceptions to preferences. “Are these casino chips?” Tank asked. “No money attached.” “Nigga, you finally invented something affordable.”

Article 6. Four dice that cannot be cashed at the bar

Roll four ordinary six-sided dice. Each 1 or 2 means minus one, each 3 or 4 means zero, and each 5 or 6 means plus one. Add the four values. Your paperwork total is between minus four and plus four. This optional layer draws on Fate’s familiar signed-dice idea; the surrounding selection rules are original Panorama rules.

A negative result moves backward around the forty-case shelf; a positive result moves forward. Zero keeps the same case. “Nigga, I rolled four dice to stay here?” Tank asked. “You were happy here.” “I was happy before the fucking dice.”

If you spend a Stamp Token, either add two or reroll all four dice once and use the new total. You cannot buy a second modification on this selection. Reset to three tokens whenever you begin a new browsing session; no ledger needs to survive dinner.

The dice can produce a total from minus four to plus four. A +2 stamp can raise that part to plus six; the separate refreshment adjustment can add another zero, one or two. “Why four dice?” Shawna asked. I said it gave the evening texture. “So does carpet, nigga. You don’t roll the fucking carpet.”

Article 7. Optional: the snack amendment

Record a separate snack adjustment: one if somebody has already brought the drink they wanted, plus one if wanted snacks are within reach and no one is expected to fetch them. The maximum snack adjustment is two. Keep it separate from the dice-and-stamp paperwork total; Article 8 adds it exactly once. If these conditions are irrelevant, use zero. This arithmetic is a joke about hospitality; nobody needs to eat or drink anything to participate.

Tank asked whether Dre’s casserole counted twice. Rosa said no. “Nigga, it got layers.” She put a fork in his hand. His appeal ended when he remembered what forks did.

Do not delay choosing a game to qualify for this amendment. Do not make a snack score into a task for somebody else. The best possible snack state is people having what they actually want.

Article 8. The entirely unnecessary formula

First find the local case from the grid: eight times (row minus one), plus emblem. Add the paperwork total and the snack adjustment, if you used them. If the result exceeds forty, subtract forty until it is 1-40. If it is below one, add forty until it is 1-40. Otherwise keep it. The final local case number is always between 1 and 40.

Then add forty times (department minus one) to get the complete P-number. Department 3, row 1, emblem 2 starts at local case 2. A paperwork total of minus three and a snack adjustment of one gives zero. Wrap zero to forty. In department 3, local case forty is P120.

This is a shelf address. It is not a probability of enjoyment, a cognitive score, a ranking, or an instruction to buy something. It chooses a page to consider. Read that page’s ordinary fields before treating it as a candidate.

If arithmetic gets in the way, use the offline finder or choose directly. “I’m not doing long division to sit with my wife,” Tank said. Rosa slid over. The system had encountered a man with better navigation.

Article 9. Read the game first; Aiden can wait

Read the short pitch, what you do, main catch and first try before the longer comic scene. The full appeal and catch give the detail behind those summaries. Aiden’s scene and verdict are fiction; a funny reason is not evidence for a game feature.

Check the exact edition and platform. A remake can change movement, menus and saves. A touch port can differ from a desktop pointer. A Steam store date may be the port’s date rather than the original release. Local co-op, online co-op and two people discussing a single-player game are not interchangeable.

If the card conflicts with a real preference, reject the candidate. If it is promising but has an unresolved operation, check that specific operation before investing in it. “Can we select this inventory object comfortably?” is more useful than “Is this an easy game?”

I called the result destiny. Shawna asked why destiny needed my credit card. “For incidentals.” “Nigga, you’re the incidental.” She went back to the game. I tried to make the stamp hit the page quietly.

Article 10. The appeals court

You may make one ceremonial appeal or skip the ceremony entirely. To appeal, choose a neighbor: the previous local case, the next local case, or the same local case in another department. Wrap case 1 backward to 40 and case 40 forward to 1. Check the new card as usual. After that one appeal, stop calculating. Choose either candidate, browse the direct index or close the book. Every route ends with a human decision; there is no compulsory loop, escalating fee or penalty for declining both.

“I appeal,” I said. “On what grounds?” Rosa asked. “Everybody’s having fun without my explanation.” “Denied, nigga.” She didn’t even look away from the screen. The court had excellent instincts.

If you would rather talk, talk. If you would rather stop, stop. “What if we want to go upstairs?” Shawna asked. I put down the stamp. Nigga, some appeals deserve immediate personal attention.

Article 11. A genuinely useful first session

Load the chosen edition before introducing its controls. Show one meaningful action. Keep a reminder if wanted. Find pause, save or exit so leaving feels ordinary. Do not turn a trial into a lesson with a hidden passing grade.

For a mystery, that might mean one conversation or one clue. For an exploration game, a nearby path and a place to stop. For a turn-based game, one decision with the menus already explained. For co-op, agree who wants which role and whether the roles have equal kinds of action.

Stop, change games or take a break whenever wanted. A day off makes room for leisure; it does not require a whole day of screen time. The useful note afterward is a sentence about what was enjoyable and where to resume.

“How will we know it worked?” I asked.

Mercedes pointed at the couch. Two people were arguing cheerfully about a clue. Neither had looked at me for ten minutes.

“That,” she said.

“Nigga, I could have stayed home.”

“We would have missed the deposit.”

Article 12. What these departments are allowed to claim

This is a researched, source-linked candidate catalogue with original comic writing. Game descriptions were checked against publisher, developer, platform or identified supporting sources. Control classifications and first-trial suggestions are editorial judgments unless tied to an explicit declaration. No card claims a complete-path playtest.

The catalogue deliberately contains different levels of complexity. Turn-based strategy and elaborate deduction belong here only for readers who want those specific demands. The direct

index and catches let you pass them by. “There are two hundred and forty games” does not mean “all two hundred and forty will suit the same evening.”

The offline finder uses the same case IDs as the books. It makes no network requests and does not inspect your library. Marking a title interesting does not install or buy it. Its strict feature filters require stated evidence; an unknown is not silently accepted.

The final authority is the person playing. I told Tank I could make any game irresistible. “Then make me want this fishing minigame, nigga.” I offered him a hundred dollars. He held out his hand without picking up the controller. That was the end of my theory.

Twelve optional declarations of personality

1. Two Detectives, One Suspicious Motherfucker. Mysteries to discuss together. Shared theorizing is useful company; it is not native co-op.
2. Nigga, Bring the Map Over Here. Prefer a desk, static scenes or fixed framing; inspect the actual navigation demands.
3. The Ghost Still Owes Me Money. Supernatural investigations; check horror and emotional tone as well as controls.
4. Penthouse Problems, One-Room Budget. A compact place can offer interesting people. Small worlds and simple decisions are different claims.
5. My Turn Is None of Your Fucking Business. Turn-based candidates may wait while you think. Check the menus and planning demands separately.
6. You Drive. I Have Opinions.. Agree on the kind of company wanted: native co-op, passing the controller or talking through a single-player game.
7. That Plant Knows Too Much. Observation and occult mysteries; check the cross-referencing burden.
8. I Bought the House. Where Does This Wall Go?. Creative modes and construction; confirm that a quiet mode exists in the exact edition.
9. I Came for the Gossip. Character stories over equipment management. Reading load and choice pressure still matter.
10. A Whole City and No Appointment. Exploration with a strong sense of place; camera and navigation need their own check.
11. The Puzzle Can Wait. I Look Good.. Look for stated untimed behavior. A flattering title cannot establish a feature.
12. Aiden Can Kiss My Entire Agenda. Choose directly. This trait defeats every arbitrary rule in this book without rolling anything.

The incident desk

1. Cocaine on the wrong paperwork. Darnell mistakes the evening for an afterparty again. Rosa clears the game table. No fictional drug changes your roll; choose a row while Aiden negotiates the cleaning bill.
2. The blue controller has been claimed. Dre calls dibs. Aiden tries to make a speech about Crip diplomacy. “Nigga, I called dibs,” Dre says. Choose a row; no controller color changes a game feature.
3. The bedroom is a different department. Shawna takes Aiden by the collar. Tank is appointed to say “choose a row” while the chairman discovers a shorter agenda.
4. The champagne tower has opinions. Porsche moves one glass. Aiden moves six people. Nothing falls, but everybody learns how high his voice goes. Choose your row.
5. Mercedes has heard about the yacht. Darnell begins the story again. “Nigga, I hope that boat finds somebody,” she says. Choose a row before the measurements start.
6. Tank thought the chips were edible. He knew they were tokens. He wanted everybody to remember they had not ordered fries. Choose your row; the kitchen argument grants no bonus.
7. Aiden appears in the wrong trailer. The projector shows his karaoke rehearsal instead of the game. Shawna keeps the remote. Choose a row while he attempts copyright enforcement.
8. The hotel sends the bill. The employee puts down a second page. Aiden turns it over. There is a third. Choose your row while wealth has a private moment.
9. Somebody finds the missing heel. It is beside the subwoofer. Three adults deny knowing why. Nobody asks a follow-up because the game has finally loaded. Choose your row.
10. Rosa has already won. She has her payment, a plate and the good seat. “Nigga, that’s strategy,” Tank says. Choose a row; her success does not certify any game as easy.
11. A very expensive entrance. Aiden enters through the wrong door and comes back holding a mop. Everybody claps. Choose your row while he explains the symbolism.
12. The game is better than the speech. Porsche turns the microphone off. Aiden hears everybody laugh at something on the screen. Choose a row, or join them. Nobody owes him an encore.

A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 1. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index near the front always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P001	P002	P003	P004	P005	P006	P007	P008
2. Ready for conversation	P009	P010	P011	P012	P013	P014	P015	P016
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P017	P018	P019	P020	P021	P022	P023	P024
4. Here for the atmosphere	P025	P026	P027	P028	P029	P030	P031	P032
5. Open to a wildcard	P033	P034	P035	P036	P037	P038	P039	P040

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

The Deposit Was Supposed to Be Refundable

“Nigga, why does the sign say intimate?” Tank asked. Behind him, two men were assembling a doorway large enough to admit a modest yacht. A third man held my face. Six feet of it, printed on a board. The face looked confident. That nigga had not seen the invoice.

“Because it’s a gathering of close friends.” Tank looked at the ballroom. “How close? We sharing a zip code?” Shawna walked between us with her evening shoes in one hand. She had booked a suite, chosen a dress, and asked for a night where she could actually enjoy her husband. I had interpreted this as a request for three adjoining entertainment spaces and a photographer. My wife loved me deeply. Love sometimes looked like a woman stopping in a doorway to count backward.

The casino hotel called the room Imperial. I had called the party Panorama. Mercedes called it a soundcheck waiting to be interrupted. She was doing a short live set because she wanted to try an arrangement with musicians she trusted. She wanted a recording she controlled, a working monitor, and nobody from the drinks sponsor explaining how to reach a younger audience. Everyone in our party was a grown adult. Several of us had grown much more successfully than I had.

Rosa arrived with the catering supervisor and put a hand against the decorative doorway. “Food goes through here?” I said guests would pass beneath it and feel transported. She asked whether transported guests intended to eat. The doorway moved. Tank helped move it, then came back holding a tiny gold torch from the decoration crate. “What this belong to?” I pointed at a cloth-covered statue. He lifted one corner, stared, and let the cloth fall. “Nigga, we discussing that later.”

I had wanted an evening with games because somebody had asked what might be enjoyable. Mysteries. Interesting people. Places where a person could stop and think. I understood all of that. Unfortunately I also understood champagne towers, hired atmosphere, and the magnificent possibilities of being photographed pointing at something. The people who loved me had arrived to enjoy the first idea and survive the rest.

Shawna slipped her arm through mine. “You remember upstairs?” “Baby, I remember everything.” “You remember the strawberries?” I looked toward the buffet. Her fingers tightened. “The private strawberries, Aiden.” Oh. Those strawberries. I leaned closer and told her I had reserved considerable personal attention for her. She said attention had been reserved all afternoon and was beginning to incur a cancellation fee.

Mercedes came over carrying a black equipment bag. “This stays with me or Porsche. The recorder and spare drive are in here.” I reached to take it. She moved it back. “Are you me or Porsche?” “I’m offering support.” “Offer your elbow to your wife. She looks under-supported.” Shawna accepted the elbow with a smile that made my hotel trousers feel like an ambitious tailoring decision.

Tank’s old friend Darnell arrived in a blue jacket and announced that he’d brought enough atmosphere for everybody. Tank looked at the bag, then looked at him. “My nigga, tell me you mean playlists.” Darnell smiled instead of answering. Mercedes pointed him toward the coat room, away from her equipment. We would be learning more about his contribution shortly, which is usually how a sentence about Darnell develops.

The photographer asked me to stand beside the sponsor's banner. I did. The sponsor asked Mercedes to join me holding a bottle. She said she'd be happy to discuss a separate advertising fee. He laughed. She didn't. The photographer lowered his camera and became interested in a light stand. A whole room of professionals suddenly understood that my friend was working, and I was the only nigga dressed like a man receiving a lifetime achievement award for booking chairs.

Shawna took the microphone before I could introduce the evening. "The games are in there. Pick what interests you. The practical notes explain what each one asks. Nobody has to finish anything." Short. Clear. Completely devastating to my twelve-minute welcome. I asked whether I could add a thought. "At dinner," she said. "To one person." Tank put a plate in my free hand. Rosa pointed at the room. Mercedes began testing her microphone. The party started without waiting for my permission, and my face on the big board watched it happen.

P001 / A PLACE TO START

The Blackwell Legacy

Edition considered: PC original game; current publisher patch must be recorded

Meet a reluctant New York medium and her sharp-tongued ghost partner in a compact mystery built around their developing relationship.

What you do. Talk with people, follow notebook leads, and connect names or clues while revisiting places in a supernatural investigation.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Names and notebook combinations take tracking; verify manual speech advance, and consider the suicide and bereavement themes.

Why it might click. A compact New York supernatural mystery joins a reluctant medium to a sardonic spirit guide. Conversations and notebook connections make discovery feel personal; the developing partnership offers more reason to continue than simply clearing another puzzle.

The full catch. Notebook combinations, returning to locations, and remembering names remain real work. Suicide and bereavement are central. Reviews report no timed or dexterity challenges, but this is not a complete-path playtest. Current desktop patches offer manual speech advance through a Ctrl+P toggle; verify it waits.

Try this first. Set manual speech advance if you want it, with help if useful. Try one conversation and one notebook lead, then decide whether these two people are company worth keeping.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Ghost Doesn't Pay the Resort Fee

I put a second chair beside the screen for Joey Mallone. Blackwell had a woman dealing with a ghost; my hotel had charged me for six hundred people, and I intended to count the dead.

Tank picked up the place card. “Nigga, this seat got a meal?”

“Spiritually.” “Then move your spiritual ass. Rosa made crab cakes.” He sat down and ate Joey's welcome portion before I could establish contact.

Our Rosa watched the game's Rosa talk to somebody nobody else could see. “I like her,” she said. “People keep giving this woman responsibilities she didn't order.” She looked directly at me. I checked behind myself. Nothing there. Expensive habit.

Shawna leaned against my shoulder. “A ghost could walk through our suite door.” “Baby, so could I.” “Last night you walked into it.”

Joey had been dead for years. Nigga still entered a room with more dignity than me.

Aiden's verdict. Try the partnership if it catches you; Joey can handle supernatural business while I handle his crab-cake debt, which Tank insists survives death.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher premise and developer Ctrl+P patch notice; timing description is a secondary review, not current complete-path testing. PC original only.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80330/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/80330/allnews/>

Source 3: <https://www.keengamer.com/articles/reviews/the-blackwell-legacy-review/>

P002 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Darkside Detective

Edition considered: PC first game; current accessibility build must be recorded

Investigate small, absurd paranormal cases with a recurring comic detective partnership, using static scenes that keep the focus on dialogue and objects.

What you do. Inspect objects, read conversations, and try using inventory items on the scene or on one another to advance a case.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Inventory dragging, small hotspots, and pipe or tile puzzles need checking even though timed input is not declared.

Why it might click. Comic paranormal investigations offer a recurring detective partnership and short case boundaries. Static scenes let attention settle on objects, dialogue, and absurd situations rather than keeping an avatar and camera moving together.

The full catch. Current Steam metadata declares play without timed input. That does not mean hold-free: PC reviews describe dragging inventory items onto objects or other items. Pipe and tile puzzles also appear. Text reading and small hotspots deserve an actual check before treating this as comfortable.

Try this first. Begin the first case, inspect one object, and test one inventory drag. Check that text advance and the save/exit route feel understandable before continuing.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Paranormal Department Has My Room Key

Somebody called the ballroom phone and breathed into it. I told security we had a haunting. Mercedes took the receiver, listened, and said, “Tank. Stop eating against the microphone.”

“Nigga, I’m ordering ice.” “You’re calling the stage.” “Then send some dramatic ice.”

The Darkside Detective appeared on the monitor while the hotel manager asked why I had requested an exorcist. I pointed at McQueen. “Professional comparison.” He pointed at the charge for an emergency callout. The hotel apparently billed ghosts by the hour.

Shawna tested an inventory movement. I reached over to demonstrate and dragged the wrong thing. She rested her hand on mine. “Help me by stopping.” That felt almost sexual until she moved my whole arm off the table.

Mercedes gave Tank the correct number. He ordered ice, a sandwich, and cancellation of the priest. The sandwich arrived first. Stronger management than mine.

Aiden’s verdict. The little cases look inviting; test the actual dragging before settling in, and don’t let a loud husband classify every ordinary inconvenience as supernatural.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary Steam accessibility declarations inspected. Inventory dragging is documented by a PC review; no hold-free alternative was verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/api/appdetails?appids=368390&l=english>

Source 2: <https://www.bigbossbattle.com/review-the-darkside-detective/>

P003 / A PLACE TO START

Phoenix Wright: Ace Attorney Trilogy

Edition considered: 2019 PC compilation; post-November 2025 update scope

Meet theatrical witnesses and recurring friends in courtroom mysteries where matching a statement to evidence can produce a satisfying breakthrough.

What you do. Read testimony, consult the Court Record, and compare statements with evidence; the updated compilation also offers Story Mode assistance.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Reading and evidence menus are central; automatic text progression may feel rushed, and wrong evidence can incur penalties.

Why it might click. The original trilogy supplies memorable witnesses, recurring friendships, and theatrical courtroom mysteries. Comparing testimony with a piece of evidence can deliver a satisfying click of understanding; the story has room for comedy and emotional stakes.

The full catch. Reading and Court Record menus are central, and wrong evidence can incur penalties. Dramatic music may feel urgent even when the interface waits. The November 2025 update adds Story Mode and Auto-play; automatic text progression may itself feel rushed. Later evidence interactions still need checking.

Try this first. Use the updated 2019 compilation. Start The First Turnabout with manual text advance, compare one statement, and use Story Mode whenever enjoying the next scene matters more than solving it.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Objection, That Is My Wife's Room Charge

I slapped the room-service receipt beside Phoenix Wright. "Somebody charged strawberries and champagne to my suite."

Shawna put down her glass. "I did." "For whom?" "The man I married. He was supposed to come upstairs an hour ago."

Tank leaned across the screen. "Nigga, prosecute yourself." Mercedes made a little courtroom noise with her wineglass. Everybody suddenly loved the justice system.

I tried to compare a witness statement with the Court Record, but Shawna kept moving the receipt into my field of vision. "You promised a private celebration." "I'm building suspense." "You're building a service charge."

Onscreen, a contradiction finally clicked for me. In the room, three women had already established one without needing a walkthrough. I stood, offered Shawna my arm, and knocked the receipt into Tank's sauce.

"Evidence tampering," he said. Nigga licked the corner. Chain of custody was fucked.

Aiden's verdict. Follow the courtroom drama at your own pace and use the available story help freely; my actual marriage has declined to install a skip-cross-examination button.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Current Steam declares play without timed input; Capcom November 2025 notice confirms Story Mode for this 2019 trilogy. No hands-on audit of all cases or holds.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/787480/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/787480/announcements/>

P004 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Strange Horticulture

Edition considered: PC current release

Run a rain-soaked plant shop where curious customers, occult questions, and identifying unusual specimens gradually reveal a world beyond the counter.

What you do. Compare plants with the reference book, handle objects on the desk, and follow letters or map clues for further discoveries.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Cross-referencing and dragging need testing; wrong answers raise Rising Dread and can trigger a recovery puzzle.

Why it might click. A rain-soaked plant shop provides a recurring home base, curious customers, and an occult story. Identifying specimens connects looking closely with useful decisions, while letters and map clues gradually widen the world beyond the counter.

The full catch. Books, plants, labels, letters, and a map can create substantial cross-referencing. Desk objects use dragging; a developer patch added a double-click sticky-drag alternative, whose own double-click demand needs testing. Wrong answers raise Rising Dread and can lead to a recovery puzzle. Calm presentation is not simplicity.

Try this first. Identify one customer's plant with the reference book. Compare ordinary dragging with the documented sticky option before adding map exploration or several simultaneous questions to the desk.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Florist Said That Plant Was None of My Business

I bought a mysterious plant for the suite because Strange Horticulture had persuaded me greenery could make a man interesting. The florist charged extra for the pot. Nigga, apparently mystery needed drainage.

Rosa read the little card. "This goes by a window." "I planned to put it beside the bed." "It needs light, Aiden. Your performance isn't sunlight."

Shawna laughed into my collar. I was having a very difficult evening with women I loved and a plant I had only just met.

Mercedes opened the game's reference material and began matching details. Tank rotated my purchase to see whether it hid food. Nobody rushed the identification. For once the room had a question worth answering.

I offered to name our plant Seduction. Shawna named it Get Out of the Walkway and moved it three feet. It immediately improved the bedroom atmosphere by ceasing to trip people.

Aiden's verdict. A strange plant shop deserves a look if identification appeals; check its handling carefully, and remember that even excellent foliage cannot substitute for listening to your wife.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher premise inspected; developer patch mirrored on SteamDB supports sticky dragging. No-customer-deadline observation is secondary, not full-path verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1574580/>

Source 2: <https://steamdb.info/patchnotes/8300183/>

Source 3: <https://www.gamesradar.com/have-you-tried-strange-horticulture/>

P005 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Case of the Golden Idol

Edition considered: PC 2022 game with current Redux edition; not The Rise of the Golden Idol

Turn suspicious deaths into an unfolding conspiracy by linking the people, objects, and motives visible in carefully arranged crime scenes.

What you do. Inspect a scene, identify its people, and place words into deduction slots to build an explanation that fits the evidence.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Later cases accumulate names and possible words; check placement controls, hints, text size, and comfort with murder imagery.

Why it might click. Static scenes of suspicious deaths become a larger conspiracy as names, objects, and motives connect. The reward is constructing an explanation that fits the evidence, with visual detail and social relationships doing much of the storytelling.

The full catch. Later cases add many names, roles, and possible words. Murder imagery is deliberate, and the grotesque art may not be welcoming. This card concerns the original game with its current Redux edition, not Rise. Check exact word-placement, text size, and hint controls rather than assuming every release behaves identically.

Try this first. Study the first scene and identify the people before attempting its full explanation. Try moving one word into a deduction slot, then inspect the hint interface if curiosity has turned into bookkeeping.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Who Put a Gold Dick on the Dessert Table?

The hotel wheeled in my commissioned golden idol. It was supposed to be a triumphant figure holding a torch. From the dessert table it looked like a man having an expensive medical problem. “Nigga,” Tank said, “why your statue hard?” “That’s the torch.” “Then the nigga needs a smaller fire.” Mercedes turned it toward the wall. Shawna turned it back because that exposed the rear view. Rosa put a cake in front of it and charged me for the cake.

The Case of the Golden Idol offered a crime scene where details actually mattered. I studied the people and objects. Behind me, my friends reconstructed who had approved the sculpture, who had ignored the sketch, and who had paid for overnight delivery.

Every clue led to me. I asked if we could leave the conclusion unfinished. Shawna put the invoice beneath the statue. Now it had both motive and evidence.

Aiden’s verdict. If assembling a scene into an explanation sounds satisfying, investigate; the gold object in our ballroom remains a warning against approving sculpture from a thumbnail.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes freely investigated freeze-frame scenes; current-edition announcements establish Redux. Drag/hold behavior and full completion were not playtested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1677770/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/1677770/allnews/>

P006 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Syberia

Edition considered: 2002 PC original; not Syberia Remastered

Follow a lawyer through an unusual European world of mechanical wonders, where the journey gradually changes what she considers important.

What you do. Click to explore locations, speak with people, collect useful objects, and use inventory items while following Kate's journey.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The 2002 original has small hotspots, fixed camera cuts, inventory, and repeated travel; complete timing freedom is unverified.

Why it might click. The original Syberia follows a lawyer into an unusual European world of mechanical wonders and unfinished lives. Kate's changing sense of what matters gives the travel emotional momentum beyond collecting the next useful object.

The full catch. This is the 2002 PC original, not the remaster. Click movement removes a separate look control, but fixed camera cuts, small hotspots, dialogue topics, inventory, and repeated travel can still frustrate. The publisher walkthrough's late sections use ordinary interactions; that is not an exhaustive no-timer guarantee.

Try this first. Explore the opening hotel, speak with one person, and test the inventory and save route. Let one useful object establish whether the older interface is inviting before committing to a long journey.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Train Leaves Without My Entrance Music

I asked the pianist for departure music when Syberia came up. He played three notes, stopped, and held out his hand. I had mistaken a working musician for part of the furniture.

“Pay the man,” Mercedes said. “I’m creating atmosphere.” “Then fund the weather, nigga.”

Kate Walker had a strange journey ahead of her. I had twelve feet between me and a pianist who now refused eye contact. Shawna offered to travel with me if I left the microphone behind.

I liked the machinery, the unfamiliar places, the sense that business could unexpectedly become something else. Rosa liked that nobody in the story had asked her to cater our imaginary train. Tank asked whether an automaton could carry the seafood tower. I told him to respect invention.

He pointed at the hotel trolley. “Nigga, wheels already happened.” We paid the pianist and rolled dinner toward the windows without an anthem.

Aiden’s verdict. Let the journey attract you, then check the older interface; travel becomes considerably more pleasant when I stop requiring a soundtrack for crossing a room.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected original-game publisher description and seven-page official walkthrough, including late sequences. Original PC control scope only; no full playtest.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/46500/>

Source 2: <https://support.microids.com/fr/support/solutions/articles/23000009217-solutions-syberia-1-et-2>

P007 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Unavowed

Edition considered: PC release

Meet an urban-fantasy investigation team whose histories and different abilities make the companions themselves a reason to pursue another case.

What you do. Choose an origin, talk with companions, and use objects or companion abilities to investigate situations and work through puzzles.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Inventory and abilities add memory demands; later timing and holding requirements are not fully audited across every branch.

Why it might click. An urban-fantasy investigation puts companions, their histories, and their abilities at the center of puzzle solving. Origins and branching situations give the ensemble room to react differently, making the people a reason to explore the next case.

The full catch. Inventory plus companion abilities creates more to remember than a simple conversation game. Violence, possession, death, and strong language are substantial. Ordinary PC interaction is pointer-based, but urgent scenes and every branch's timing or holding demands have not been fully audited.

Try this first. Choose an origin because it sounds interesting, meet the opening companions, and try one interaction. Verify text waiting and pause on the actual edition before relying on the adventure's slower ordinary rhythm.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Possessed Man Is Still Responsible for the Deposit

I explained Unavowed's possession premise to Shawna and immediately recognized a legal opportunity. "Suppose another force made those hotel charges."

She held up my signed approval. "Did the demon also request monogrammed ice?" "He wanted to feel welcome."

Mercedes chose a chair near the screen. The idea of supernatural companions with different abilities interested her more than my proposed defense. Tank said he'd join any team whose magic included finding the missing dinner trays.

I offered my own ability: undeniable charisma. "Can it open that?" Rosa pointed at a stubborn serving cabinet. I pulled the handle. Nothing. Tank found the latch and opened it with one finger.

The entire room looked at him like he'd just saved Manhattan. Nigga had located the butter. I had given speeches in three countries and never received that quality of gratitude.

Shawna kissed my cheek. "Your demon can carry plates." Apparently redemption involved two trips.

Aiden's verdict. A supernatural crew can offer excellent company; choose whose story interests you, while my alleged possessing spirit learns that charm does not unlock a catering cabinet.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary publisher premise and companion features inspected. PC interaction and content detail supported by review; zero timed inputs across branches remains unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/336140/>

Source 2: <https://gamecritics.com/gc-staff/unavowed-review/>

P008 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Her Story

Edition considered: PC release

Follow words through live-action police interviews, letting a performance, contradiction, or unanswered question determine which part of the mystery you explore next.

What you do. Watch returned interview clips, type a promising search word, and compare what people say across the results you uncover.

Dialogue / text choices | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Typing and nonlinear recollection can be demanding; convenient hands-free video pausing has not been verified on desktop.

Why it might click. A live-action police interview mystery lets a noticed word become the next direction of exploration. Performance, contradiction, and interpretation supply the interest; there is no avatar or separate look camera between the player and the testimony.

The full catch. Typing, names, nonlinear clips, and remembering what a phrase referred to can be demanding. Convenient video pausing is unverified: player reports describe holding the slider to freeze a clip. Do not assume search-at-your-own-pace means hands-free pause during playback. Crime and relationship material is mature.

Try this first. On desktop, watch one returned clip, test how it stops or replays, and follow one promising word. Keep a short question nearby only if it helps preserve the thread.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Her Story, My Terrible Search History

I sat down at Her Story and announced that searching recorded interviews was exactly my kind of investigation. Shawna said I once searched our hotel booking for “the room with sex in it.”

“Nigga, it found the honeymoon package.” “It found your email to the concierge.”

Mercedes wanted the screen kept separate from the party camera. Her own live recording was due later, and she didn't want anybody treating a real person's words like miscellaneous promotional material. I agreed, then discovered I'd been holding her recorder like a microphone.

She took it back. “Search the game, Aiden.”

We picked a word from an interview and followed it. Tank suggested another. The room got interested enough to stop watching me, which I initially considered a technical fault.

Shawna rested her hand on my knee. “See? Quiet can be good.” I kept quiet. For almost an entire clip. Personal fucking growth.

Aiden's verdict. Follow the interview trail if searching and inference appeal; check the playback controls yourself, and keep my honeymoon correspondence out of every database involved.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary publisher describes search/watch loop. Pause limitation is dated secondary user evidence, not verified current behavior; Telling Lies controls must not be substituted.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/368370/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/368370/discussions/0/530645446312998268/>

P009 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Excavation of Hob's Barrow

Edition considered: PC release

Explore Victorian folk horror through a suspicious village, bleak moors, and an antiquarian's investigation of a burial mound with unsettling implications.

What you do. Visit the opening village, speak with people, examine clues, and use inventory objects while following the antiquarian's investigation.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Horror and sudden audiovisual moments may feel pressuring; PC inventory dragging and later clue chains need checking.

Why it might click. Victorian folk horror gives its investigation a strong sense of place: moors, suspicious villagers, an antiquarian, and a burial mound. For someone who enjoys unease, the slow accumulation of wrongness may be as engaging as solving the inventory puzzles.

The full catch. Bleak horror, violence, and abrupt audiovisual moments can create pressure without a reflex timer. PC descriptions include inventory dragging. A Switch accessibility assessment reports low pressure and optional holds, but that does not prove hold-free PC play. Later puzzle chains still require remembering information.

Try this first. Try the opening village and one conversation. Test an inventory action and text advance on the exact edition; leave if the atmosphere itself is unpleasant, even if the controls behave perfectly.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Nobody Told Me the Barrow Was Not a Wine Cellar

I heard “excavation” and asked the hotel whether we could investigate the cellar. The manager said no. I asked whether money changed that. He said it changed who paid for the broken lock.

Hob's Barrow had a professional investigator approaching a place with its own reasons to resist her. I understood the attraction immediately. Tank understood that I was trying to borrow a shovel in evening clothes.

“Nigga, you wearing white shoes.” “Archaeology deserves elegance.” “Dirt don't.”

Mercedes sat down for the folk-horror atmosphere. Rosa pulled the curtains because the bright casino reflection spoiled the screen. Nobody needed me to turn actual trespassing into an immersive feature.

Shawna caught me checking the cellar door anyway. “Come back.” “You sound worried.” “Your deposit is down there spiritually.”

I returned with both shoes clean and every ancient force undisturbed. The manager still charged me for the shovel delivery.

Aiden's verdict. Go for the unsettling investigation if the mood appeals; my hotel cellar expedition has been canceled because the most frightening local legend is itemized damages.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher horror premise inspected. Switch low-pressure panel and PC drag description are secondary and edition-specific; no blanket control guarantee.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1182310/>

Source 2: <https://www.nintendolife.com/reviews/switch-eshop/the-excavation-of-hobs-barrow>

Source 3: https://as.com/meristation/2022/09/28/analysis/1664375021_208084.html

P010 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Pentiment

Edition considered: PC release

Investigate a richly drawn historical community where art, faith, class, and personal loyalties give conversations consequences that unfold over years.

What you do. Walk between people, read conversations, and choose which leads or activities to pursue as the investigation develops around the community.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Reading and relationships accumulate; activities advance investigation time, and walking may require holding even without timed inputs.

Why it might click. A richly drawn historical community makes art, class, faith, and personal loyalties part of the investigation. People and consequences unfold over years, offering conversation and interpretation rather than a constant demand for quick physical reactions.

The full catch. Developer accessibility notes state there are no timed inputs or QTEs. Investigation time still advances through chosen activities, which creates decision pressure. Reading is extensive, movement may require holding, and names and relationships accumulate. Narration support differs by platform; do not assume every line is spoken.

Try this first. Try walking and one early conversation with readable text settings. Notice whether choosing a lead feels intriguing or burdensome before promising yourself an entire investigation or an optimal outcome.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Monk Is Not Signing My Bar Tab

Pentiment put art, conversation, and a historical community on the screen. I put a quill beside it. Mercedes stared at the feather like it had personally borrowed money.

“Nigga, why?” “Immersion.” “You couldn't sign the dinner check with a normal pen?”

Rosa wanted to look closely at the illustrated pages. Tank wanted to know who in this community had the best lunch. Shawna wanted me to stop comparing my unpaid invoices to a moral crisis in a monastery.

I tried reading a conversation aloud in an accent. Three people said my name at once. I retired from voice work before the church could become involved.

Then an ordinary detail caught us: who knew whom, who trusted somebody, what a person's work meant in the place they lived. Nobody needed the feather.

Tank used it to point at my dessert. I moved the plate. Historical conflict had reached the buffet.

Aiden's verdict. Enter for people, art, and the weight of interpretation; leave if the reading feels burdensome, and never let me explain a monastery while guarding cheesecake.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected developer accessibility notes and first-hand interview on activity-based investigation time. Turn pacing differs from decision pressure; actual movement setup untested.

Source 1: <https://pentiment.obsidian.net/>

Source 2: <https://www.mmorpg.com/interviews/the-rpg-files-building-obsidians-pentiment-interview-with-game-director-josh-sawyer-2000126821>

The Break Room Had Cocaine in It for About Thirty Seconds

Darnell opened his bag in the little room behind the stage. Porsche looked down, looked up, and closed the door before a hotel employee could wander into his explanation. “You said you brought atmosphere.” “I did.” She pointed at the bag of cocaine. “Nigga, that's a different department.”

I arrived because I heard voices and assumed my authority was needed. Mercedes arrived because she needed her spare cable. This gave her a useful purpose and me a terrible disadvantage. Darnell wanted us to understand that he wasn't creating a problem. He had brought his own problem, personally, at considerable expense. Tank stood in the doorway. “Then take it somewhere that ain't my friend's workplace.”

Nobody delivered a speech. Mercedes held out her hand for the cable bag, which looked much too much like Darnell's. Porsche gave her the correct one. Darnell took his bag away. I started saying something about the changing character of nightlife. Shawna appeared behind me. “You hired a gold statue with its dick out.” “That's a torch.” Tank sighed. “We looked again, my nigga. Architecturally, you're alone.”

In the ballroom, Rosa was solving a more expensive emergency. The sponsor had promised extra guests without promising extra money. Four adults stood beside an empty table, watching the staff try to create dinner out of politeness. Rosa told them there was plenty of food once someone approved the adjustment. All four looked at me with the soft, hopeful faces people wear near a man who has put his own portrait on the wall.

I paid. Rosa checked the confirmation. Then she fed them. The sequence had a beauty no speech of mine could improve, so naturally I tried anyway. “A host must always - ” “Move your elbow,” she said. Hot dishes went past me. I moved my elbow. History would record my contribution accurately if everybody could resist exaggerating it.

Shawna pulled me into the quiet side room and shut the door. I smiled. She smiled back. Then she handed me my jacket, which had been lying across a speaker. “I know that face,” she said. “You think every closed door is a proposal.” “Baby, with you it could be.” She kissed me slowly enough to make the room service bill seem reasonable. Then somebody knocked. Three knocks. Tank. “Your statue is blocking dessert.”

“Let it block dessert,” I said. The silence outside was immediate and terrible. Even Shawna stopped kissing me. Nigga, I had threatened cake in a room full of people who had survived my welcome speech. She opened the door and sent me back into public life with my jacket straight and my priorities under review.

I found Mercedes moving the gold figure herself. I took the heavy end. She let me, then told me exactly where she wanted it. Together we cleared the sightline to the stage. She didn't thank me for rescuing her from an object I'd ordered. Fair. Tank rolled the dessert trolley through and gave us both a plate. For several minutes I carried something useful, stayed out of an argument, and ate cake beside my friends. I considered announcing this improvement. Shawna touched my wrist. I let the achievement remain unofficial.

P011 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Old Skies

Edition considered: PC release

Travel through seven historical settings with a time agent and voiced companions, exploring regret and the consequences of changing past events.

What you do. Meet the first assignment, examine objects, follow characters' motives, and work through puzzles involving cause and effect across time.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Death and retry are explicit features; temporal connections increase memory demands, and later input requirements still need checking.

Why it might click. A time agent's work provides seven historical settings and travelers with different motives. Temporal puzzles and a voiced ensemble connect the speculative premise to questions about regret, curiosity, and the consequences of changing what already happened.

The full catch. The publisher explicitly says the player can die and try again. That is a meaningful failure-state warning, not proof of harmless pacing. Temporal cause and effect can increase memory demands, and later timing, dragging, and dialogue advance need an edition-specific check. Some historical settings carry serious emotional weight.

Try this first. Meet Fia and inspect the first assignment before promising a complete excursion. Test ordinary object interaction and the pause/save route; treat any stressful sequence as a reason to reconsider, not an examination to pass.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Time Travel Does Not Reverse the Minibar

Old Skies gave me a time-travel idea. "We return to yesterday," I told Shawna, "and book the smaller ballroom."

"You return to yesterday and listen when I suggest it." Nigga, history had a witness.

Tank arrived carrying two identical black bags. One contained Mercedes's spare cables. The other belonged to Darnell, an adult guest who'd announced he was bringing "a little atmosphere." Mercedes opened it far enough to see a bag of cocaine and closed it again.

"No," she said. "Not near my equipment." Darnell started explaining. "I understood the noun," she said. "Take your shit upstairs and out of my party."

He obeyed. I congratulated myself on decisive leadership. Shawna pointed at Mercedes, still holding both bags. The actual leader wanted labels and her cable back.

I sat with the game, where altering history sounded fascinating. In the ballroom we settled for preventing the next stupid thing.

Aiden's verdict. Follow the time-travel story if you like tangled consequences; our evening currently favors dealing with the present before I promise to correct three centuries retrospectively.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description: time-agent premise, historical eras, temporal puzzles, and retryable death. No declared absence of timed sequences established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1346360/>

P012 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Primordia

Edition considered: PC release

Explore a decaying post-human world with a robot partnership whose banter and discoveries connect a theft to larger questions of belief and independence.

What you do. Spend time with the two robots, examine objects, and connect environmental details or inventory items to solve their immediate problems.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Puzzle connections and revisiting details take attention; the inspected source does not establish timer-free or hold-free play.

Why it might click. A robot partnership explores a post-human landscape and a city whose history changes the meaning of the initial theft. Mechanical decay, belief, independence, and companion banter make its world distinctive rather than merely another collection of locked doors.

The full catch. Environmental and inventory puzzles still ask for connections and returning to details. Optional puzzles exist, but optional extras do not make the main path effortless. The inspected storefront does not certify zero timers, no holds, or a particular text-wait setting; those remain checks, not benefits to assume.

Try this first. Spend an opening scene with Horatio and Crispin. Try examining one object and following one concrete problem, then decide whether the world's mood and puzzle language invite another visit.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Robot Wants a Tip

The hotel delivery robot stopped outside our door. I waved it toward the Primordia screen like I'd arranged a family reunion. It asked for a code.

"Brother," I said, "we both serve civilization." It asked for the code again. Tank punched it in and retrieved the drinks. "Nigga serves refrigeration."

Primordia's machine world interested me because its people could have beliefs, histories, and arguments instead of merely carrying my ice. Mercedes said the delivery robot already had a strong opinion about blocking the doorway.

I stepped aside. It reversed directly toward my shoe, reconsidered, and left. Shawna said we'd witnessed mercy.

Rosa settled down to meet the game's characters while Tank looked at the empty drink tray. "Can it return these?" "Probably." "You should learn from your cousin."

I carried the tray back myself. The robot was waiting by the lift. We ignored each other with considerable professional respect.

Aiden's verdict. The ruined machine world has personality worth meeting; investigate its puzzles if they appeal, while I negotiate a lasting peace with the hotel's drink-delivery cousin.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact-game publisher description for robots, stolen core, Metropolis and optional puzzles. Control and complete-path timing guarantees were not found in that record.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/227000/>

P013 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Strangeland

Edition considered: PC release

Enter a surreal carnival where strange inhabitants and symbolic puzzles explore identity and grief, with optional in-character hints to help interpretation.

What you do. Talk with inhabitants, interpret the surroundings, and investigate puzzle solutions; locate the optional hint system when you want help.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Suicide imagery, repeated death, and grotesque horror are central; alternative solutions do not prove a fully reaction-free route.

Why it might click. A surreal carnival turns identity, grief, and interpretation into an adventure's setting and puzzles. The publisher describes different solutions and meanings, a voiced cast, and an optional in-character hint system, giving the strange inhabitants more purpose than decoration.

The full catch. Suicide imagery, repeated death, grotesque bodies, and horror are central. Alternative puzzle solutions do not establish a fully reaction-free path; the publisher itself contrasts a shooting approach with another solution. Inventory reasoning and symbolic interpretation can also be substantial. Verify actual interaction before relying on a particular route.

Try this first. Read the premise and look at the opening atmosphere before beginning an investigation. If that is appealing, try one conversation and locate the optional hint system; no need to demonstrate tolerance for distressing imagery.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Carnival Has Rejected My Sexy Entrance

I rented a mirrored arch to make entering the game room feel mysterious. Strangeland was on the screen when the installer asked which direction the arch should face.

"Toward desire," I said. He looked at Shawna. She pointed at the actual door. "There, nigga. He means there."

The surreal carnival looked more committed to disturbing people than my rented decoration, though mine was doing excellent work against the deposit. Tank caught his reflection in four panels and said we'd finally hired enough security.

Mercedes didn't want the music from the ballroom fighting the game's atmosphere. She closed the connecting door. I opened it to announce the mirror. She closed it again with me outside.

Through the glass I watched them settle into the strange place without my introduction. Shawna waved, then turned the nearest panel so I could admire myself alone.

Nigga, that arch delivered mystery. I couldn't figure out why I'd paid for it.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the unsettling carnival because you want its particular darkness; the mirrored arch can stay outside, where my reflection has agreed to entertain itself without applause.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description explicitly covers nightmare imagery, multiple solutions and hints. No universal timing or hold exemption inferred from those alternatives.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1369520/>

P014 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Shardlight

Edition considered: PC release

Follow Amy through a post-apocalyptic investigation where inequality, loyalty, and a search for a cure give her difficult questions personal stakes.

What you do. Speak with people, follow a stated task, and use inventory objects or clues or clues to advance Amy's wider investigation through the setting.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Disease, hunger, and coercion make the story emotionally heavy; complete timing, holding, and dialogue-wait behavior remain unverified.

Why it might click. Amy's investigation gives an oppressive post-apocalyptic world a personal point of entry. The premise puts inequality, loyalty, and the search for a cure into the story, offering a protagonist with a concrete reason to keep asking difficult questions.

The full catch. Disease, hunger, death, and coercive government are explicit parts of the setting. They can make the experience emotionally heavy even during quiet interaction. Adventure puzzles bring inventory and clue demands. The source inspected here does not establish all-path timing, holding, or dialogue-wait behavior; those require a specific check.

Try this first. Try the opening conversation and one stated task only if the setting appeals. Test an inventory interaction and find save/quit before taking on the wider investigation or its darker consequences.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Revolution Would Like Dinner First

Shardlight showed a damaged society where ordinary needs had become political. Rosa stopped me halfway through my speech about survival and pointed at the catering crew eating standing up behind the curtain.

"They've been working since afternoon." "There's food everywhere." "For guests, Aiden. Tell the hotel they can sit."

I went to the manager with my heroic voice loaded. Before I used it, he asked how many staff meals to add. I gave him the number and paid. Nigga, liberation had a very simple checkout screen.

Tank carried chairs over. Mercedes moved the sound equipment so nobody had to balance a plate against an amplifier. Shawna set out water.

When I came back to admire my humanitarian achievement, Rosa handed me another chair. "One more."

The game's struggle remained much larger than ours. Mine involved discovering that people doing the work also needed dinner, without waiting for a protagonist to announce it.

Aiden's verdict. The post-collapse story may reward interest in people under pressure; our party has adopted the radical position that feeding the crew should precede my victory speech.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact publisher premise inspected, including deprivation and vaccine lottery. Pointer-adventure classification is editorial; no complete-path control verification claimed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/336130/>

P015 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Technobabylon

Edition considered: PC release

Discover a cyberpunk society through interwoven perspectives, where a police conspiracy and virtual experiences become questions of personal loyalty and choice.

What you do. Follow an opening protagonist's objective, read conversations, and connect inventory solutions with the developing investigation across different character perspectives.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Three protagonists, unfamiliar terms, and layered motives demand tracking; later confrontations and held inputs have not been fully checked.

Why it might click. Interwoven perspectives bring a cyberpunk city's systems down to individual choices and loyalties. A police conspiracy, virtual experience, and complicated personal stakes can supply a rich story for someone who enjoys gradually discovering how a speculative society works.

The full catch. Three protagonists, unfamiliar terms, inventory solutions, and layered motives increase the amount to track. The publisher warns of mature themes and violence. Point-and-click presentation does not establish that every later confrontation waits indefinitely, nor that every interaction avoids holds; the inspected source leaves those questions open.

Try this first. Follow one opening character and one immediate objective. Check text advance, ordinary interaction, and saving before deciding whether learning this future feels interesting rather than like another system to administer.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Smart Suite Has Joined the Opposition

Technobabylon had a connected city full of systems and secrets. My suite had a voice-controlled curtain that kept opening whenever I tried to flirt with my wife.

"Set the mood," I said. The television displayed the bill. Shawna laughed so hard she had to sit down. "Nigga, that is the mood."

I blamed surveillance. Mercedes blamed my decision to demonstrate the suite's features before reading anything. Tank asked the room for steak. Nothing happened until he picked up the telephone, an antique technology that immediately secured dinner.

The cyberpunk investigation looked more interesting than our struggle with the blinds. Rosa took the remote away from me and returned the game to the screen. A person could enjoy questions about power, identity, and networked life without letting me interrogate the thermostat.

Shawna closed the curtains by hand. "Come here." I went. The room finally did something intelligent: it stopped participating.

Aiden's verdict. A tangled cyberpunk investigation can be absorbing; check the interface first, and refuse any hotel upgrade that grants the curtains a speaking role in your marriage.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher account of three protagonists, Central, Trance, conspiracy and mature content. Exact late-game input demands remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/307580/>

P016 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Blackwell Unbound

Edition considered: PC release

Meet an earlier human partner for Joey in period New York, where a ghostly musician and separate incidents suggest a contained supernatural mystery.

What you do. Follow Lauren and Joey through conversations and clue connections, pursuing an opening lead across the living and the dead.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Names and clues need tracking; do not assume this title shares another Blackwell game's speech controls or timing assurance.

Why it might click. An earlier Blackwell investigation changes the central human partner while retaining Joey's sardonic presence. Period New York, a ghostly musician, and apparently separate incidents provide a contained supernatural mystery with a different emotional texture from Legacy.

The full catch. Clues, names, dialogue topics, and switching attention between the living and the dead can still require tracking. This title's publisher record does not certify the same manual-speech patch behavior as another Blackwell game. Do not transfer Legacy's review-based timing assurance or Ctrl+P setup without checking this edition.

Try this first. Meet Lauren and Joey, listen to the first lead, and inspect the actual text and interaction settings. Continue because their relationship interests you, not because a series order has become another obligation.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Ghost Gets Better Billing Than the Singer

Mercedes looked at the Blackwell Unbound setup and asked why my little sign said AIDEN PRESENTS before anything else. Her live set later had the same problem, except her name was smaller than the sponsor's logo.

"Nigga, is the vodka singing?" she asked.

I said the printer had chosen a dramatic hierarchy. She turned the sign facedown and called the sound technician by name. They agreed on her introduction without needing me or the printer.

The game's earlier partnership had its own rhythm. I tried to explain that I too was the difficult half of a successful duo. Shawna smiled. "You finally admitting which half?"

Tank put a chair beside Mercedes and asked about the music. She answered him properly. I stood there with my explanation fading in my hand.

We gave the screen its space and the singer her name. The sponsor survived being smaller. So, unfortunately for my speech, did I.

Aiden's verdict. Meet the earlier ghost-and-medium partnership if its atmosphere draws you; everybody involved deserves correct billing, including the woman whose song I keep trying to introduce twice.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description establishes Lauren, Joey, 1973 and connected incidents. Input settings and no-timer claims are not inherited from other series entries.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80340/>

P017 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Blackwell Convergence

Edition considered: PC release

Return to Rosa and Joey for a city mystery linking apparently separate lives through settings shaped by art, film, and finance.

What you do. Explore an opening location, speak with people, use inventory objects, and connect leads through the established pair's investigation in the city.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Earlier character history adds context; inventory reasoning remains work, and this edition's timing and dialogue controls need checking.

Why it might click. Rosa and Joey return to a city mystery whose apparently separate people and locations conceal a larger connection. Familiar characters can make another investigation attractive after an earlier entry, while the art, film, and finance setting gives it a specific flavor.

The full catch. This is a later series entry, so character history and supernatural rules add context to the clues. Inventory and conversational deductions remain work. The inspected publisher description establishes the premise, not a guarantee about timed scenes, held inputs, or current dialogue controls on every version.

Try this first. If the partnership already appeals, investigate one opening location and one lead. Check text waiting and item use on this installation rather than relying on remembered settings from a different Blackwell title.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Art Is Looking Back at My Invoice

Blackwell Convergence sent me thinking about art, so I purchased an “interactive installation” for the party. It was a gold frame with nothing in it.

Tank walked through. “Nigga, this a doorway.” “It's about absence.” “Your money absent?”

Mercedes placed it against the wall to stop guests colliding with it. The installer objected that we were changing the experience. Rosa asked whether his experience included liability insurance. The frame stayed by the wall.

At the screen, the supernatural investigation connected lives instead of merely displaying an expensive gap. Shawna leaned forward at a conversation. I leaned forward too and nearly knocked my drink onto the keyboard. She caught the glass without looking at me.

“Still married to your biggest installation,” I whispered. “Baby, you were free to look at,” she said. “The maintenance is killing me.”

Tank took our photograph through the frame. For the first time all evening, the thing earned a dollar.

Aiden's verdict. The continuing mystery can deepen an existing attachment to the pair; my decorative purchase is available for photographs, provided nobody mistakes my empty wallet for conceptual art.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher premise inspected for connected film, office, artist and investor story. Later-series burden is editorial judgment; control guarantees remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80350/>

P018 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Blackwell Deception

Edition considered: PC release

Join Rosa and Joey in an investigation of fraudulent psychics, personal secrets, and exploitation that also reaches into Joey's buried history.

What you do. Follow conversations and city leads, connect clues, and use the established partnership to investigate people claiming contact with the supernatural.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Death and manipulation are central; accumulated relationships add memory demands, and current input behavior needs its own check.

Why it might click. A mystery about fraudulent psychics lets an established supernatural partnership investigate both exploitation and personal secrets. Contrasting city settings and Joey's buried history may reward someone already curious about these characters rather than only the next puzzle solution.

The full catch. Death and manipulation of vulnerable hopes are central themes. Existing series relationships, dialogue, and clue connections can accumulate. The publisher premise does not establish an all-path absence of timed inputs or holds. Current text advance and inventory behavior should be checked independently of earlier Blackwell editions.

Try this first. Try one conversation and one lead if Rosa and Joey are welcome company. Notice the tone as well as the controls; interest in supernatural mysteries does not require enjoying every kind of darker subject.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Psychic Knows My Card Was Declined

A guest offered to read my aura beside Blackwell Deception. I hadn't hired him. He said he felt a financial blockage.

"Nigga, you standing beside the hotel manager." The manager was holding my declined card.

Mercedes asked the guest what he actually did. He said spiritual consulting. Tank said he could consult the empty buffet and report which spirit had eaten the ribs. Rosa moved the payment terminal away from the performer's elbow.

I wanted to catch a fraud so badly I almost hired him to investigate himself. Shawna called the bank while I argued about energy. A corrected charge went through. The psychic immediately announced an opening.

"There's the door," Mercedes said.

We returned to a game where exploitation and supposed messages from beyond had actual narrative weight. I kept my questions for the characters. The living hotel manager already knew enough about my soul and preferred a valid payment method.

Aiden's verdict. Follow the investigation if exposing manipulation interests you; any prophet who can see my future must still explain why his revelation appeared on the card terminal first.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact-game publisher description of psychic fraud and Joey's secrets. No unsupported transfer of input or timing features from another Blackwell game.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80360/>

P019 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Blackwell Epiphany

Edition considered: PC release

Follow the Blackwell partnership toward a series conclusion, with a larger mystery about the spirits Rosa and Joey have been helping.

What you do. Continue an established investigation by following leads, examining the opening situation, and checking dialogue and saving on this particular installation.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. This bleak finale depends on earlier character history; full timing, held-input, and text-advance behavior is not verified.

Why it might click. The final Blackwell story raises the stakes around Rosa, Joey, and the nature of the spirits they help. For someone already attached to the partnership, the larger mystery offers emotional continuity and the possibility of a meaningful series conclusion.

The full catch. Destruction of souls, death, and a bleak winter atmosphere make this a darker choice. It is a later entry with accumulated character history, not necessarily the best introduction. The publisher's story description does not verify every timed, held-input, or text-advance behavior; inspect this edition directly.

Try this first. Consider whether earlier Blackwell stories sound more inviting before opening the finale. If continuing an enjoyed series, try the opening investigation and verify dialogue waiting and saving without committing to finishing its darker arc.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Nobody Gets a Joke During That Part

I came to Blackwell Epiphany prepared with a joke about ghosts getting bottle service. Mercedes held up a hand. Something in the scene had caught her properly.

I waited. Tank waited too, a fork halfway between the plate and his mouth. Even my nigga's dinner respected a serious moment.

The room had been loud all night. We had found missing cables, argued about introductions, and turned three small decisions into invoices. Now Shawna sat against me, watching a difficult exchange unfold, and I didn't need to put my name on it.

Afterward Mercedes let out a breath. "Okay."

"Want another scene?" I asked. She nodded. That was the whole conversation. Nobody delivered a lesson about the dead or tried to make her reaction entertaining.

Tank finally ate. "Cold," he whispered. Rosa traded him a warm plate without looking away. Nigga had waited through an emotional crisis and received mashed potatoes as his reward.

Aiden's verdict. This conclusion belongs after an attachment to the series, if you want it; leave room for its serious turns without letting me rent a microphone over them.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher description of the central threat. Series-position recommendation is editorial; no complete-path control or emotional-fit guarantee.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/236930/>

P020 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Shivah: Kosher Edition

Edition considered: PC Kosher Edition

Investigate a personal ethical mystery with Rabbi Russell Stone, bringing conscience, faith, and doubt into conversations within a specific New York community.

What you do. Meet Rabbi Stone, hear the premise, and make conversation choices while following a short investigation with more than one ending.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The Kosher Edition includes a distinctive conversation/combat system; later confrontation demands need checking despite the quiet opening.

Why it might click. A short-form mystery places conscience, faith, and doubt inside a specific New York community. Russell Stone's reason to investigate is personal and ethical, giving the conversations an appeal beyond collecting evidence for an abstract case.

The full catch. This card specifies the Kosher Edition, whose publisher lists revised presentation, voiced dialogue, multiple endings, and a distinctive conversation/combat system. That last feature requires checking rather than assuming all point-and-click interaction is relaxed. Death, cynicism, and moral decisions also give it a serious tone.

Try this first. Meet Rabbi Stone and hear the premise. Preview how a conversation choice works and how to save or leave; do not use the early calm as proof that the later confrontation has no timing demands.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Rabbi Has Questions About My Donation

The Shivah had a rabbi facing questions about money and obligation. I said I understood complicated generosity. Rosa placed my unpaid catering adjustment directly in front of me.

“Nigga, you understand applause for generosity,” she said. “Try the rest.”

Tank asked whether my promised bonus for the crew counted if I kept mentioning it before paying. Shawna answered by holding out my phone. It was already on the transfer screen.

I made the payment. Mercedes watched Rosa check it, then brought the game back up. “Now you can have your moral crisis.”

The questions in the story were sharper than my little party problem. I liked that a conversation could involve belief, suspicion, and what somebody owed another person without requiring a chase through the casino.

Tank read my transfer note: FOR SERVICES TO HUMANITY. “You paid for chicken, nigga.” Rosa smiled at the confirmed balance. “He can call it salvation if it clears.”

Aiden’s verdict. A compact moral mystery may be worth your attention; my contribution to ethical life tonight is paying the person who has already done the work.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher’s explicitly titled Kosher Edition page, including conversation/combat and endings. Timing and holds not verified; unrelated or unresolved store matches excluded.

Source 1: <https://wadgeteyegames.com/games/the-shivah/>

P021 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Resonance

Edition considered: PC release

Approach a science-fiction conspiracy through four lives, using remembered subjects as conversation material rather than relying only on collected objects.

What you do. Switch between characters, inspect objects, store useful subjects in memory, and bring those subjects into conversations during the investigation.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Separate character knowledge and two memory systems create heavy bookkeeping; late action, timers, and held inputs remain unverified.

Why it might click. Four playable characters approach a science-fiction conspiracy from different lives and loyalties. The unusual memory system lets remembered subjects become conversation material, giving investigation more texture than simply collecting objects and exhausting a fixed list of questions.

The full catch. Character switching, separate knowledge, inventory and two kinds of stored memory create substantial bookkeeping. The developer's dramatic race-against-the-clock wording does not establish which passages use actual timers. Required late action and held-input demands remain unverified; this is a conditional mystery, not a no-rush certification.

Try this first. Explore one character's first available conversation and inspect how a remembered subject becomes a question. Keep a short note with that character's name and immediate objective before considering a second viewpoint.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Four Witnesses and One Missing Pair of Trousers

Resonance gave us four people whose pieces of a story needed connecting. Our dressing room gave us four adults with incompatible accounts of where my spare trousers had gone.

Mercedes saw them on a chair. Tank moved the chair. Rosa moved the bag under the chair. Shawna said I had packed no spare trousers because I was “certainly coming upstairs before those become necessary.”

“Nigga,” Tank said, “that's a timeline.”

The game made separating immediate observations from remembered details interesting. My investigation made it obvious I should have listened to my wife. She leaned in and quietly explained one possible use for the room key. I stopped asking about trousers.

Then the hotel photographer arrived for a full-length portrait. I stood behind Tank, who refused to move without a fee. Mercedes took a picture of that arrangement too.

Four perspectives. One conclusion. My nigga charged me forty dollars to remain enormous.

Aiden's verdict. Connected viewpoints can make a satisfying puzzle if the memory system appeals; our four-witness inquiry ends with Tank billing for strategically located body mass.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer page supports four playable characters and the long-/short-term memory system. It does not verify a wholly untimed path. This is Wadjet Eye's adventure, not another product with Resonance in its name.

Source 1: <https://wadjeteyegames.com/games/resonance/>

P022 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Gemini Rue

Edition considered: PC release

Follow two apparently separate lives through bleak science-fiction noir, where damaged identities and oppressive institutions make their connection worth discovering.

What you do. Investigate environments and conversations through contextual actions, following the linked stories while also facing required combat later in the adventure.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Required combat conflicts with a strict no-rush preference; accommodations described for the mobile port cannot be assumed on PC.

Why it might click. Azriel's search on a bleak colony world intertwines with an amnesiac captive's story. The attraction is adult science-fiction noir: damaged identities, oppressive institutions, rain, and uncertainty about how two apparently separate lives connect.

The full catch. This adventure includes required combat, so ordinary point-and-click investigation does not describe the complete experience. The PC interface also uses contextual actions. A publisher announcement discusses redesigned combat for a mobile port; that port's accommodations must not be assumed present on PC. A no-rush route is not established.

Try this first. If the atmosphere appeals, inspect an early investigation scene while someone checks the PC combat requirements separately. Do not treat a comfortable conversation as evidence that the later action will suit.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Rain, Gunfire, and a Very Expensive Fog Machine

Gemini Rue's rain-soaked science fiction made me regret ordering indoor weather for the ballroom. I asked the technician to start the fog. He asked whether the sprinklers had been isolated by the hotel. I said I'd imagined a more enthusiastic question.

"Nigga, answer his," Mercedes said.

The technician waited. So did Shawna, whose dress cost more than my first car and had considerably less tolerance for a ceiling shower. Tank covered his dinner with another plate.

We canceled the fog. The actual game still had its noir atmosphere and its combat complication; I couldn't make that complication disappear by lowering the lights. Mercedes read the practical note before anybody committed to the story.

Shawna drew a finger down my dry lapel. "See? You can be dramatic without making everything wet." I smiled. "Not everything." She smiled back. The technician coughed and asked who was paying for the unused machine.

Aiden's verdict. Keep this as a deliberate detour because the gunplay matters; my atmospheric contribution has been reduced to one dimmer switch and a substantial cancellation charge.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

PC store supports the dual-character premise; the developer's mobile announcement explicitly confirms a combat system. Mobile redesign claims are not transferred to the PC edition. Complete PC control/timing accommodations are unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/80310/>

Source 2: <https://wadgeteyegames.com/2013/04/11/gemini-rue-now-on-the-app-store/>

P023 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Emerald City Confidential

Edition considered: PC release

Meet familiar Oz figures recast as noir suspects and witnesses, with a detective's investigation revealing complicated motives beneath storybook associations.

What you do. Talk with suspects, inspect clues, and connect information across locations while following Petra's investigation through this reimagined Oz setting.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Dialogue and puzzle connections require tracking; the source does not settle later timing, dragging, or other input requirements.

Why it might click. Petra investigates an Oz recast as a noir city, meeting altered versions of recognizable figures. The pleasure lies in the friction between childhood storybook associations and a mystery full of suspects, witnesses and complicated motives.

The full catch. Recognizable characters do not make the investigation childish or mechanically effortless. Expect dialogue, clues and puzzle connections across locations. The inspected publisher material establishes the mystery structure but does not settle every timed sequence, drag gesture or later input requirement. Treat those as checks, not absent features.

Try this first. Meet Petra and follow one early conversation far enough to decide whether the reimagined Oz feels intriguing. Inspect one clue deliberately before opening a larger chain of objectives or consulting a walkthrough.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Wizard Is Not Comping the Penthouse

I put on green sunglasses for Emerald City Confidential. Tank said I looked like a man about to sell him a dishonest yacht.

"It's noir Oz." "Then follow the yellow carpet to the cashier, nigga. The bar needs paying."

Mercedes liked the idea of familiar fairy-tale faces carrying adult secrets. I liked the idea of a mysterious investigator uncovering who had moved the premium bottles. Rosa told me she'd moved them because guests kept knocking them with their elbows. Case closed without a magical journey.

Shawna took my glasses and wore them better. "What does the great detective see now?"

"My wife stealing evidence." "Your wife improving it." She slipped an arm around me. The green lenses hid her eyes but not the smile I'd married.

Tank photographed us and asked the hotel to project it above the bar. Now every guest ordering a drink could watch a fool lose his best accessory in public.

Aiden's verdict. A detective's view of Oz may be appealing if you enjoy familiar stories turned sideways; my emerald disguise has been confiscated by a significantly better-looking investigator.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher descriptions support Petra, the Oz reinterpretation, voiced characters and investigation across five chapters. No blanket no-timer or hold-free claim is established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/37260/>

Source 2: <https://wadjeteyegames.com/games/emerald-city-confidential/>

P024 / A PLACE TO START

The Mermaid Mask

Edition considered: PC release; current release status verify

Investigate a captain's death aboard an eccentric submarine, where voiced suspects and an elaborate locked-room setup support a theatrical detective partnership.

What you do. Talk with suspects, examine three-dimensional clues, and compare the case file's relationships while building deductions about the captain's death.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Developer declarations support untimed mouse play, but clue manipulation gestures and the memory demands of deductions still need testing.

Why it might click. Grimoire and Sally investigate a captain's death aboard an eccentric submarine. Voiced suspects, an elaborate locked-room setup and objects to examine offer a richly theatrical detective outing, with the investigators' partnership anchoring the weirdness.

The full catch. The current PC listing declares play without timed input, mouse-only play and saving at any time. Those are developer declarations, not a personal control trial. Inspectable three-dimensional clues may still involve gestures worth testing; dialogue, case-file relationships and deductions retain a meaningful memory load.

Try this first. Enter an early conversation, inspect a clue, then test how its view changes and how the case file records it. Judge those operations before committing to solving the whole submarine's personnel problems.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Mermaid Is Charging by the Hour

The Mermaid Mask arrived on our screen just as two adult performers arrived downstairs in elaborate mermaid costumes. I had booked “marine atmosphere.” Apparently that meant paying people to sit in a decorative shell.

Mercedes looked at the booking. “Nigga, why are you like this?”

One performer wanted a chair with back support. The other wanted the promised break room. Rosa found both while I explained the oceanic concept to somebody who had already stopped listening.

The game offered a peculiar investigation with actual people to question and details to inspect. My attraction offered two professionals watching Tank unsuccessfully ask whether the shell held shrimp.

Shawna sat beside me. “You could just have shown me the game.” “And denied the sea a livelihood?” She laughed, then made me pay the performers before releasing them from their shells.

They took off the tails, put on shoes, and went to dinner. The tide was out. My money went with it.

Aiden's verdict. The unusual mystery earns its own look; our live adaptation has ended because the mermaids quite reasonably prefer chairs, wages, and dinner to my artistic explanation.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact current Steam game and SFB site confirm release, premise and developer-declared Mouse Only, Playable without Timed Input and Save Anytime. Released July 16, 2026. Object-manipulation comfort is not independently verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1696770/>

Source 2: <https://www.sfbgames.com/>

P025 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Broken Sword - Shadow of the Templars: Reforged

Edition considered: PC Reforged edition

Travel with George and Nico through a Templar conspiracy, enjoying conversations, places, and objects in a modern visual edition of their first adventure.

What you do. Inspect nearby objects, talk with people, and connect inventory clues while revisiting places as the travel mystery expands beyond its opening.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Inventory logic can require hints; an entirely untimed, hold-free path has not been established for this exact Reforged edition.

Why it might click. George Stobbart and journalist Nico Collard follow a Templar conspiracy through a classic travel adventure. Reforged presents the first Broken Sword in a modern visual edition, retaining the appeal of conversation, places, objects and a mystery expanding beyond an ordinary trip.

The full catch. Classic inventory logic and returning to locations can require notes or outside hints. The inspected Reforged page does not establish an entirely untimed, hold-free completion path. Verify troublesome set pieces in this exact edition before recommending it for a strict no-rush requirement; older versions are not interchangeable evidence.

Try this first. Try an early safe conversation and inspect a nearby object, watching whether the interface makes available actions clear. Stop after that small investigation and decide whether the travel-mystery tone earns further checking.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P025 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Broken Sword - Shadow of the Templars: Reforged

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Templars Don't Validate Parking

Broken Sword put conspiracy behind an ordinary encounter, which encouraged me to interrogate the valet about my missing car. He pointed to the ticket in my hand.

“Nigga, any fool can read a ticket. I'm examining motives.” Shawna took it from me and handed it over. The car appeared.

Mercedes wanted to hear the opening conversation. I wanted to explain how close we'd come to an international operation. Tank opened the trunk and retrieved the speaker cable he'd asked for twenty minutes earlier.

The glamorous European mystery had people, travel, and dangerous secrets. Our hotel had a husband delaying everybody because the simplest answer didn't flatter him. I conceded the distinction while watching Shawna slide into the passenger seat.

“Where we going?” I asked. “Nowhere. I'm taking five quiet minutes.” She closed the door.

I stood beside a running luxury car while my wife used it as a room without me. Nigga, devastating transportation technology.

Aiden's verdict. Enter the Reforged adventure for conversation and conspiracy if they appeal; my valet investigation has established that occasionally the ticket contains all the necessary intelligence.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Revolution's page identifies the 2024 Reforged edition and supports premise and adventure structure. Full-path timing and held-input details remain unverified; no older-edition accommodation is assumed.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/broken-sword-1/

P026 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Broken Sword 2 - the Smoking Mirror: Remastered

Edition considered: PC Remastered edition

Rejoin George and Nico for a globe-spanning artifact mystery, where their partnership turns an isolated discovery into a larger historical threat.

What you do. Use inventory objects, revisit locations, and follow what different people know as the second adventure's mystery develops across its settings.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Remembered information and inventory puzzles add load; the Remastered edition's complete timing and holding requirements remain unresolved.

Why it might click. George and Nico return in a second globe-spanning mystery involving an artifact, criminal entanglements and a larger historical threat. The attraction is their continuing partnership and the traditional pleasure of turning an apparently isolated discovery into a much stranger story.

The full catch. The Remastered edition must be assessed on its own. Inventory puzzles, revisiting places and remembering what each person knows can become demanding. Its adventure label does not prove that every hazardous scene waits indefinitely; the inspected developer page leaves complete timing and hold requirements unresolved.

Try this first. Inspect the actual controls and one early interaction before investing in a long session. If the opening danger itself feels unwelcome, switch games rather than treating endurance as the price of seeing the later mystery.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P026 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Broken Sword 2 - the Smoking Mirror: Remastered

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Smoking Mirror Is a Housekeeping Problem

Someone smudged the dressing-room mirror. I called it an omen because Broken Sword 2 was on the next screen. Mercedes called it my hair product.

“Nigga, why was your head touching the glass?” “I was checking a detail.” “Yourself. The detail was yourself.”

Rosa came in to collect the empty glasses and found me polishing evidence with a hotel towel. She rescued her clean serving cloth before I escalated the investigation.

The game's journey took its characters into danger and an older mystery. My journey took me toward a very contemporary cleaning fee. Tank found a second smudge lower down and raised his eyebrows at Shawna.

She didn't blush. “That one's his too. He dropped his cufflink.”

I thanked her for preserving my reputation. “Baby,” she said, “I told the truth. Your reputation will have to find another ride.” Mercedes opened the game while I searched the carpet on hands and knees. Fucking archaeology again.

Aiden's verdict. If another George-and-Nico mystery sounds inviting, check this edition's demands; every mysterious mark in our dressing room currently has a much less exotic explanation.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Revolution identifies the second game's Remastered edition and artifact-led story. No edition-specific complete no-timer/no-hold route was verified.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/broken-sword-2/

P027 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Broken Sword 5 - the Serpent's Curse

Edition considered: PC complete release

Follow a Paris gallery robbery into conspiracy with George and Nico, with voiced characters and a troublesome artwork anchoring the investigation.

What you do. Question a witness, inspect gallery evidence, and connect inventory objects or testimony as the investigation expands to more people and places.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Check the installed PC edition's controls; extra features described for the separate Definitive Edition are not assumed here.

Why it might click. The fifth Broken Sword begins with a Paris gallery robbery and murder, then follows George and Nico into a conspiracy. Fully voiced characters and classic point-and-click investigation make it an invitation to follow people, motives and a troublesome work of art.

The full catch. Expect inventory reasoning and an expanding cast. Revolution lists extra interface features under a separate Definitive Edition heading; this card does not assume that those features exist in the selected PC release. Required timing, holds and speech-advance behavior need checking in the installed edition.

Try this first. Follow the first available witness exchange and inspect a piece of gallery evidence. Notice whether dialogue pace and object selection feel comfortable before adding a second location or a page of speculative connections.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Stolen Painting Was a Picture of Me

The Serpent's Curse began with art and crime. At our party somebody removed my oversized portrait from behind the bar. I called it theft. Mercedes called it a better view of the singer.

"That painting cost money." "So did the stage, nigga. Let people see who's on it."

Tank carried my painted likeness through the crowd. A guest tried to order a drink from it. My portrait had apparently been performing better hospitality than I had.

Shawna intercepted the procession and leaned the frame in the dressing room. "There. You can watch us get ready." I considered the view. She covered the canvas with a bathrobe before I enjoyed the idea too much.

The actual art mystery remained on the screen, where the theft could mean more than improved sightlines. I returned and found Rosa choosing a seat. "Solved yours?" she asked.

"My wife secured the evidence." "Good. Sit your actual ass down."

Aiden's verdict. Art theft and familiar investigators may make a lively evening; our stolen portrait has been recovered, restrained, and excluded from further interference with Mercedes's stage.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer page supports gallery theft/murder and classic point-and-click structure. Its Definitive Edition feature list is explicitly not transferred to the unspecified complete PC edition; full timing remains unverified.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/broken-sword-5/

P028 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Beneath a Steel Sky

Edition considered: 1994 PC original

Explore an authoritarian machine-controlled city with Robert Foster and his robot companion in the original satirical science-fiction adventure from 1994.

What you do. Examine the first environment, distinguish inspecting from using objects, and follow an immediate objective through the older adventure's city investigation.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The older interface and navigation need a trial; mobile release features and a completely untimed path are not established here.

Why it might click. This is the original 1994 adventure: Robert Foster is taken into a city under authoritarian machine control, accompanied by the circuit board of his robot friend. Its appeal is a bleak science-fiction setting with room for satirical personality and practical investigation.

The full catch. This older adventure's interface, object logic and navigation deserve a direct trial. Abduction, violence and oppressive institutions shape the story. The developer page does not establish a death-free or untimed complete path, and its mobile release details must not be transferred to the original PC game.

Try this first. Inspect the first accessible environment and identify the immediate objective without trying to cover the whole city. Check how examining and using an object differ, then decide whether that interaction makes sense in practice.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Under the Steel Sky, Above the Service Charge

Beneath a Steel Sky gave us a controlled city and a companion with attitude. Our hotel gave us a service lift that rejected my key.

Tank pushed the lobby button. "Try being a regular nigga." "This is a premium key." "Then be a premium nigga downstairs."

I told him the building was resisting authority. Shawna said the key was for our room, and the service lift belonged to people moving things I kept standing in front of. A porter arrived with six cases and waited.

We moved. He passed us without delivering a lecture on class, which was generous considering I had nearly supplied him with an example.

Back at the screen, Mercedes liked the old game's sharp-edged world. Tank liked that a machine companion could answer back. I said I already had that feature in a wife.

Shawna smiled. "And the warranty is expired. Be careful with the next sentence."

Aiden's verdict. Investigate the older dystopia if its voice appeals, with its interface checked; my attempt to command a service lift has ended in stairs and public embarrassment.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Revolution identifies original release 1994, Foster, Union City and the AI premise. The card targets original PC, not the later mobile edition or Beyond a Steel Sky. Complete timing/death/hold behavior remains unverified.

Source 1: https://revolution.co.uk/games_catalog/beneath-a-steel-sky/

P029 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Kathy Rain: Director's Cut

Edition considered: PC Director's Cut

Follow Kathy's family investigation through a small town, where her grandfather's death opens secrets and the Director's Cut expands the original mystery.

What you do. Read the initial context, speak with people, and use Kathy's notebook while testing the Director's Cut's advertised single-click mouse interaction.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Family trauma and puzzle memory remain substantial; the source does not settle every late timer, chase, or held input.

Why it might click. Kathy's investigation connects her grandfather's death, family history and the secrets of a small town. The Director's Cut expands the original mystery and advertises a single-click mouse interface, making the combination of investigative conversation and a clear protagonist worth examining.

The full catch. A simpler click interface does not remove puzzle memory or emotional intensity. Family trauma and disturbing material matter here. The source does not settle every late chase, timer or held-input requirement. This is specifically Director's Cut, not an assumption that the 2016 original behaves identically.

Try this first. Read the initial context and try one conversation with Kathy's notebook close at hand. Assess both the single-click interaction and whether this family mystery feels compelling today; neither decision requires completing a case.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Motorcycle Has Entered the Hotel Complaint Log

Kathy Rain's motorcycle made me ask the valet whether we could roll mine into the ballroom for a photograph. The valet asked whether I had permission.

"Nigga, it's my party." "It's our carpet." That young man understood ownership far too well.

Mercedes wanted the family mystery on the screen left alone. Shawna wanted me to stop inventing reasons to enter buildings on vehicles. Tank wanted a picture of the inevitable argument. All three got something tonight.

I pushed the motorcycle as far as the entrance, where Rosa stood with a dessert trolley. "You block this door, I feed nobody."

A difficult choice. Motorized magnificence against cake. Tank took the handlebars from me and wheeled the bike back outside before the voters could turn violent.

We sat down with the game. I admired a protagonist investigating her history while my friends began revising mine: apparently I had personally saved dinner by agreeing not to obstruct it.

Aiden's verdict. The family investigation and distinctive lead may be worth meeting; my motorcycle remains outdoors, where its contribution to dessert service is exceptionally strong.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Director's Cut listing supports single-click interface, expanded story and family investigation. It is not a full-path accessibility audit; late required timing and holds remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1395030/>

P030 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Whispers of a Machine

Edition considered: PC release

Investigate Nordic science-fiction murders with Vera, whose responses influence abilities and connect her personality to how the investigation can be solved.

What you do. Choose conversation responses, inspect Vera's available augmentations, and use abilities or clues to pursue solutions during the unfolding murder investigation.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Abilities and alternative approaches add memory demands; every required timer or held gesture has not been verified.

Why it might click. Vera investigates murders in a Nordic science-fiction world where forbidden technology and personal history intersect. Her responses influence the augmentations available for solving problems, connecting the detective's character to the practical shape of the investigation.

The full catch. Different abilities, dialogue approaches and possible solutions create more to remember than a single straightforward clue chain. The premise includes violence and grief. The inspected listing does not establish every required timer or held gesture, so character depth should not be mistaken for a simple interface promise.

Try this first. Follow an early conversation and choose the response that feels natural, then inspect how the game explains Vera's available abilities. Write down one ability in plain language instead of trying to optimize an entire personality.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Augmentation Is a Bluetooth Earpiece

Whispers of a Machine had an augmented investigator. I put in an earpiece and asked Shawna to feed me information during conversations. "Like what?" she asked.

"Useful intelligence." "Rosa wants you to pay the extra waiter." I took the earpiece out. Nigga, technology had become nagging at a distance.

Mercedes tried it next and told me when the sound technician needed the room quieter. That worked. Tank borrowed it to report the exact moment fresh ribs arrived. That worked beautifully.

I finally sat at the game, interested in how different capacities could shape an investigation. My rented device couldn't grant insight, but it could help me hear a person doing a job.

Shawna whispered through it from across the room. "Suite. Later. No speech." I stood immediately. "Later," she repeated.

Tank watched me sit down. "That implant got a leash?" "Marriage," I said. "Premium model."

Aiden's verdict. An investigation shaped by abilities may be intriguing; our real augmentation works best when its owner listens to a complete sentence before attempting his heroic entrance.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing supports Vera, cybernetic abilities shaped by responses, voiced dialogue and multiple puzzle solutions. Memory rating is editorial; full-path timing and input requirements are unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/631570/>

P031 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Kathy Rain 2: Soothsayer

Edition considered: PC release

Rejoin Kathy as a private investigator in 1998, following a serial-killer case where a larger city brings professional ambition and financial stakes.

What you do. Follow an available lead, talk with people, and use the notebook to organize names, places, and clues in the expanded investigation.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The larger case adds tracking and dark material; control findings from Director's Cut do not automatically apply to this sequel.

Why it might click. The sequel follows Kathy in 1998 as a private investigator drawn into the Soothsayer serial-killer case. Its appeal is an established adult lead facing a larger city, new people and a case that ties professional ambition to immediate financial stakes.

The full catch. A larger investigation means more names, locations and clues, even with a notebook to organize them. Serial murder brings dark material. The inspected store page establishes the story and notebook, not a guarantee about all late timing or input sequences. Director's Cut findings do not automatically apply to this sequel.

Try this first. Read Kathy's opening situation and investigate one available lead. Use the notebook to summarize what the lead means, then judge whether the sequel's mood and interface invite another conversation rather than another obligation.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Soothsayer Says the Bar Will Close

Kathy Rain 2 brought another case, and Darnell brought news that a psychic downstairs had predicted trouble at our party. "Nigga, she seen the guest list," Tank said.

Darnell had obeyed Mercedes about his cocaine bag. Now he wanted credit for being respectful. She pointed toward the screen. "Be respectful over there, quietly."

I offered to solve the prophecy. Shawna handed me the hotel's message: last orders were approaching unless I paid to extend service. Exact date, exact consequence. Rare clarity in divination.

Porsche arrived with a tray of water and asked Mercedes whether she wanted to play another scene before soundcheck. Mercedes did. The two of them settled in while I negotiated an extension nobody had asked for.

Tank stopped me. "My nigga, we got drinks. Sit down."

I looked around. People were comfortable. My wife had saved me a chair. For once I let the approaching disaster happen somewhere outside my imagination.

Aiden's verdict. Another Kathy Rain investigation may appeal if you like her voice; the only prophecy I can verify tonight concerns a bar extension we didn't need to buy.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact 2025 sequel listing supports 1998 setting, financial premise, Soothsayer investigation and notebook. All-path timing and held inputs remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1466390/>

P032 / A PLACE TO START

Tangle Tower

Edition considered: PC release

Investigate a mansion death entangled with a painting, meeting an animated, fully voiced cast whose expressions and relationships invite another question.

What you do. Question suspects, inspect objects closely, and compare testimony or family relationships while examining the mansion's rooms and puzzle objects.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed mouse play is declared, but dragging and puzzle manipulation still need testing; relationships and testimony require attention.

Why it might click. Grimoire and Sally investigate Freya Fellow's death in a mansion where a painting appears entangled in the crime. A fully voiced, animated cast and richly drawn rooms make conversation and character observation a large part of the appeal.

The full catch. The current PC listing declares mouse-only play, play without timed input and saving at any time. Those declarations are useful but do not establish comfortable dragging or manipulation of every puzzle object. Remembering family relationships and comparing testimony still require attention; an untimed mystery can be a substantial mystery.

Try this first. Speak with one suspect and inspect one object closely enough to test selection and any manipulation. Decide whether the voices, expressions and room details make you want to ask a second question.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Two Families, One Tower, and My Terrible Seating Plan

Tangle Tower's eccentric household made me proud of my own seating chart until Mercedes found herself beside a sponsor who kept explaining how she ought to sing.

"Nigga," she told me, "move him or move my microphone to your suite."

I tried diplomacy. The sponsor wanted proximity to talent. "You've achieved it," she said. "Now demonstrate distance." Tank took his chair and carried it to another table with the man still negotiating beside it.

Shawna sat down at the game and began inspecting its strange family arrangements. I said complicated households required a firm host. Rosa handed me three place cards and asked why all the women had been seated beside people I'd wanted to impress.

I looked at the chart. Nigga, the motive was right there in my handwriting.

We let everybody choose a chair. The game kept its tangled family. Our party untangled itself in less time than my seating speech had taken.

Aiden's verdict. Explore the odd household if its people and visual puzzles catch you; our seating mystery was solved by letting grown adults place their own backsides.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing supports premise, voices and developer-declared Mouse Only, Playable without Timed Input and Save Anytime. Gesture comfort and complete-path suitability have not been independently tested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/359510/>

P033 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Detective Grimoire

Edition considered: 2014 PC commercial game; not Flash original

Explore an odd swamp attraction through a compact murder case, where interviews and visible conclusions challenge rumors about its unusual inhabitants.

What you do. Meet witnesses, select available ideas, and join them into small conclusions while following the commercial standalone game's murder investigation.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The puzzle interfaces need testing; the inspected listing does not confirm that every sequence avoids timers or held dragging.

Why it might click. The commercial 2014 Detective Grimoire builds a compact murder investigation around an odd swamp attraction and its inhabitants. Interviews and assembled conclusions give the detective's reasoning a visible role, while the creature rumors invite questions about what people assume and why.

The full catch. This is the paid standalone game, not the earlier browser title. Its mouse/touch-oriented design still involves connecting ideas and handling puzzle interfaces. The inspected listing does not explicitly verify that every sequence is untimed or that no drag-and-hold gesture is required; check the actual build before treating it as a sure fit.

Try this first. Meet an early witness and try forming one small conclusion from the available ideas. Observe whether selecting and joining those ideas feels natural, without imposing a deadline for reaching the correct answer.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Swamp Attraction Was Not Included in the Room Rate

Detective Grimoire made Tank ask whether our hotel had a swamp. I pointed at the ornamental lagoon. Shawna said we were not questioning the koi.

A party guest had dropped a bracelet near the water. I announced an investigation and stepped onto a decorative stone. It rocked. Mercedes said my name with the exhausted accuracy of someone predicting impact.

Tank caught my jacket before the fish acquired a rich new neighbor. The bracelet lay on the dry path directly beside Rosa's shoe. She picked it up and handed it back to its owner.

"Nigga, case closed," Tank said, still holding me.

At the screen, a strange tourist attraction could contain a proper mystery. At the lagoon, the main attraction was my attempt to look calm while a friend pulled me upright by the armpits.

Shawna smoothed my lapel. "Brave." "Thank you." "I meant the stitching."

Aiden's verdict. A peculiar little investigation may be a pleasing place to begin; our lagoon is now protected from further detective work by a dry path and Tank's grip.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

The 2014 commercial game's Steam listing supports the swamp case, voiced cast, conclusion system and mouse/touch design. Complete timing and held-gesture requirements are not verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/272600/>

P034 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Roottrees are Dead

Edition considered: 2025 Steam remake; not free browser original

Reconstruct a wealthy family's genealogy through a simulated 1998 internet, enjoying the moment scattered photographs and articles form a coherent family tree.

What you do. Search information, compare photographs or articles, identify a person, and place the resulting relationship into the family tree one connection at a time.

Dialogue / text choices | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Names, generations, visual identification and typing create heavy reading and memory demands; this card covers the 2025 remake.

Why it might click. The 2025 remake turns a wealthy family's genealogy into an investigation through a simulated 1998 internet. Photographs, articles and other fragments gradually identify people and their relationships, making the central reward the moment scattered information clicks into a coherent family tree.

The full catch. Names, generations, visual identification and search terms create a heavy memory and reading load. Typing and navigating the information interface matter more than reflexes in the described core activity, but that does not certify every input as effortless. This remake differs from the free 2023 browser original.

Try this first. Identify one person using one clearly connected source, then place or record that single relationship. A separate scratch note can hold a name while you test the search and family-tree interface without filling the whole chart.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Somebody Put Me in the Family Tree Twice

The Roottrees are Dead put a family investigation on the screen just as my cousin called asking why an invitation identified him as my financial adviser. I said the title sounded distinguished.

“Nigga, I borrowed twenty dollars yesterday.” “You advise me not to expect it back.”

Porsche found two separate places for me on our photo display: HOST and LEGEND. She asked whether those were brothers. Mercedes said one was adopted by the publicity department.

The game's research asked us to connect actual evidence about relationships. Our display asked everybody to accept that I personally represented two branches of excellence. Shawna removed LEGEND and put up a picture of Rosa carrying the cake.

Tank liked the correction so much he added one of the catering crew. The display filled with people who had done things besides order it.

My cousin arrived and borrowed cab fare. Family history continued expanding in an economically unfavorable direction.

Aiden's verdict. If tracing a family through documents sounds interesting, follow that curiosity; our own family tree includes one outstanding loan and absolutely no hereditary entitlement to the spotlight.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact 2025 Steam remake listing supports early-internet research, family-tree deduction and rebuilt interface. The memory assessment is editorial; no universal timing/hold guarantee is inferred from the genre.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2754380/>

P035 / A PLACE TO START

The Rise of the Golden Idol

Edition considered: PC base game

Investigate strange events in a new era of the Golden Idol format, uncovering connections between crime, belief, and institutional ambition.

What you do. Inspect crime scenes, gather useful words, and assemble explanations that connect individual incidents with broader deductions across a chapter.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Observation is described as self-paced, but names and cross-case deductions become dense; input gestures still need a trial.

Why it might click. A new era gives the Golden Idol deduction format fresh social scenery: investigators piece together strange events involving crime, belief and institutional ambition. The game invites close reading of scenes and reconstructing what happened rather than steering an action hero through them.

The full catch. The publisher explicitly describes exploring scenes at your own pace. That supports unhurried observation, not low complexity: names, collected words, connections across cases and chapter-level deductions can become dense. Input comfort and any required dragging still need a local check; dark crime scenes are central.

Try this first. Open the first case, inspect a small cluster of connected clues, and try stating aloud what seems to have happened before filling every answer. Leave the broader conspiracy for another sitting if the first scene is enough.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Idol Has a Sponsorship Deal

The Rise of the Golden Idol made the sponsor want a photograph beside our disastrous gold statue. Apparently he saw “brand energy” where Tank saw an erection with lighting.

Mercedes said neither interpretation improved the object. The sponsor asked if she'd stand beside it holding his bottle. “My contract says I sing,” she said. “Does your bottle?”

I tried to mediate by posing myself. Shawna stepped back, folded her arms, and let the photographer capture the entire mistake. That was more dangerous than an argument.

The game's modern conspiracy involved interpreting people and events. Ours involved one man trying to buy attention and another man providing it for free because a camera appeared.

Porsche showed me the photograph. The statue seemed to be pointing directly at my trousers. I offered money to delete it.

Mercedes smiled. “Look, nigga. The idol made its first profit.” The sponsor finally laughed without asking anybody to hold a product.

Aiden's verdict. The newer web of incidents may reward careful deduction; our golden idol has already exposed the connection between my vanity and Porsche's rapidly improving bargaining position.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher description supports 1970s setting, twenty cases and exploration at the player's pace. The waits label refers to scene investigation, not a tested blanket guarantee about every input or comfort need.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2716400/>

P036 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Gabriel Knight: Sins of the Fathers 20th Anniversary Edition

Edition considered: PC 20th Anniversary Edition

Follow a New Orleans writer's ritual-murder investigation into family secrets, with supernatural noir and rebuilt presentation in the twentieth-anniversary edition.

What you do. Try bookshop interactions, talk with people, and use inventory clues or remembered conversations to pursue Gabriel's developing investigation in the city.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Murder and horror are central; modern presentation does not prove that every dangerous or timed passage has been removed.

Why it might click. Gabriel's investigation of ritual murders draws a writer and bookshop owner into a family mystery in New Orleans. The twentieth-anniversary edition retells the first game with rebuilt presentation and additional material, offering a strong dose of place, conversation and supernatural noir.

The full catch. The story includes murder, horror and fictionalized religious material. Adventure puzzles can demand inventory reasoning and remembered conversations. This remake's complete path has not been checked for every dangerous or timed passage; do not assume its modern presentation removes the original design's possible pressure points.

Try this first. Try one early conversation or bookshop interaction and see whether Gabriel's personality and the setting appeal. Check the interface at the same time, keeping the first objective small rather than committing to the entire supernatural history.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Accent Has Been Banned in New Orleans

I tried a mysterious accent while introducing Gabriel Knight. Mercedes cut me off after four words. "Nigga, whatever parish that is, leave."

Tank said I sounded like a hotel answering machine drowning in butter. Shawna asked me to say the title normally, a demanding artistic limitation but one I accepted.

The game could supply its own people, setting, and darker mystery. I didn't need to pour imitation atmosphere over it. Rosa listened to the opening while Porsche turned off the novelty lamp I'd purchased because it looked vaguely occult.

My blue pocket square fell onto the table. Tank picked it up. "You planning a Crip ghost tour now?" "Historical outreach." "History declined, nigga."

Shawna tucked the square back into my jacket and straightened it. "There. Handsome without a voice lesson." I accepted the compliment and kept my mouth shut long enough for the actual story to start. Fucking brutal artistic evening.

Aiden's verdict. Meet the mystery in its own voice and check this specific edition's demands; my accent has been removed from the program by unanimous regional consent.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact twentieth-anniversary Steam edition supports Gabriel, New Orleans, murders and added remake material.

Complete timing and held-input requirements remain unverified; fictional portrayals are not presented as cultural research.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/262000/>

P037 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Still Life

Edition considered: 2005 PC original

Compare two disturbing investigations across eras, as a contemporary FBI case and a grandfather's earlier work begin to echo one another.

What you do. Examine crime scenes and connect layered puzzle information while following the contemporary investigation and its links with the earlier case.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. A documented required robot-and-laser timing puzzle conflicts with strict no-rush needs, alongside graphic crime material and complex puzzles.

Why it might click. Two related investigations in different places and eras create the appeal: a contemporary FBI case and a grandfather's earlier work gradually echo one another. This is a dark serial-crime adventure for someone specifically interested in disturbing mysteries and historical connections.

The full catch. A contemporary review describes a required robot-and-laser puzzle that depends on timing even though it is not a simple countdown. That materially conflicts with a strict no-rush preference. Graphic crime material and layered puzzle logic add further demands; this is a clearly marked detour, not an easy recommendation.

Try this first. Start by considering the subject matter and the documented later timing obstacle. If both are acceptable with a chosen helper or shared-viewing arrangement, inspect an early investigation scene without interpreting it as the whole game's control profile.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Gallery Wants Its Security Guard Back

Still Life tempted me to compare crimes like a serious investigator. The gallery guard standing beside our rented paintings tempted me to ask whether he could also watch the bar.

"No," he said. Mercedes nodded at him. "Good answer."

I explained that we were cultivating a thriller atmosphere. He explained that he was being paid to protect artwork. Rosa asked me whether I'd also like her to land a plane between courses.

Onscreen, the darker investigation had demands we needed to check, including an obstacle that wasn't merely conversation. I read that note aloud before I could sell everybody an effortless night of detective work.

Tank looked over. "Look at this nigga admitting something before it costs money."

Then I backed into a plinth. The guard caught the frame; Shawna caught my elbow. Nothing broke.

The guard asked me to move six feet away. My new security assignment was protecting the art from its renter.

Aiden's verdict. Treat this as a deliberate thriller detour with its timing catch visible; the guard and I have agreed that responsible viewing involves substantial physical distance between us.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing establishes the original game's dual-era crime premise. GameBoomers' contemporary review specifically reports timing-dependent robot/laser movement. No claim that this obstacle has an accessible skip is made.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/46480/>

Source 2: <https://www.gameboomers.com/reviews/Ss/Stilllifebynickie.htm>

P038 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Grim Fandango Remastered

Edition considered: PC Remastered edition

Travel through a distinctive land of the dead with Manny, where a compromised job expands into noir adventure, memorable characters, and music.

What you do. Explore Manny's workplace, talk with characters, and connect inventory objects while moving through the remaster's unusual world and developing story.

Mixed controls | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Indirect inventory logic can need hints; additional control schemes do not establish comfortable movement or remove every timing concern.

Why it might click. Manny's journey through a noir-inflected land of the dead combines memorable characters, an unusual visual world and a rich musical identity. The remaster refreshes presentation while preserving the adventure's central pleasure: a compromised little job opening into a much larger story.

The full catch. Traditional inventory puzzles and indirect solution logic can require considerable memory and hints. The developer confirms additional control schemes, but that alone does not establish comfortable movement or every timing requirement. Check the PC controls in practice; do not import PlayStation button instructions or assume remaster means simplified puzzles.

Try this first. Explore Manny's first available workplace interactions, compare the installed control choices, and test movement between two nearby points. Let the voice and atmosphere win your interest before agreeing to carry a long inventory of unsolved errands.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Afterlife Has an Upgrade Desk

Grim Fandango gave us travel agents for the dead. I immediately recognized the hotel manager's business model. "You'd sell a deceased nigga the premium package," I told him.

"Only if he requested a late checkout." Shawna laughed before I could defend the living.

Tank wanted to know whether the best afterlife transport included dinner. Rosa said she wasn't catering eternity without a deposit. Mercedes liked the style enough to sit closer to the screen, which seemed a more sensible response than my negotiations with death.

I offered Shawna a romantic journey beyond mortality. "Can we start with the lift upstairs?" she asked. "I have shoes to change."

I escorted her without an announcement. At the lift, the manager asked whether we needed anything else. I said no.

Nigga looked shocked. Death, rebirth, a skeleton selling journeys - none of it had prepared him for a client refusing an optional charge.

Aiden's verdict. The underworld's characters and style may make the old puzzles worthwhile to you; my romantic itinerary now begins with letting my wife take off her heels.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

PC listing supports premise and remastered presentation; Double Fine confirms additional control schemes. Full control comfort and all-path timing are unverified. No native co-op is inferred from Remote Play Together metadata.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/316790/>

Source 2: <https://www.doublefine.com/news/grim-fandango-remastered-pre-orders-now-available>

P039 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Thimbleweed Park

Edition considered: PC release

Meet five playable oddballs in an eccentric 1987 town, where ensemble comedy and strange connections reward curiosity about people and places.

What you do. Choose Casual, follow one character's objective, and try conversations or object interactions before switching characters and managing more unfinished tasks.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Casual mode reduces some demands, but five characters and inventories still require tracking; exceptional inputs remain worth checking.

Why it might click. An eccentric 1987 town ties together five playable characters and an increasingly strange mystery. The attraction is ensemble comedy, peculiar locations and the satisfaction of uncovering connections while a traditional adventure keeps revealing another layer of oddness.

The full catch. The publisher offers Casual and Hard modes and describes exploration at your own pace. Casual is the more relevant first trial, but it does not make five characters, inventories and ongoing objectives trivial. Interface gestures and any exceptional sequence still need checking; selecting a difficulty is not a universal no-hold guarantee.

Try this first. Choose Casual and follow one character's immediate objective. Try one conversation and one object interaction, noting whether the action interface is clear before switching people or collecting a large list of unfinished tasks.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Clown Is Not on My Payroll

Thimbleweed Park put strange people in a strange town. Our party put an adult clown beside the casino cashier. I hadn't booked him, which made him the cheapest entertainment I'd seen all night.

He had followed the wrong event sign. Tank invited him to eat before he left. Mercedes asked him to keep the horn away from soundcheck. He agreed more readily than most sponsors.

I watched the game's cast and said every ensemble needed one unpredictable personality. Shawna looked at the clown, then me, then back at the clown. "We already had coverage."

He asked where his actual party was. Rosa checked the booking text and sent him two floors down with a wrapped slice of cake.

At the lift he honked once at me. I honked my car key in reply. The valet alarm went off outside. The clown bowed.

Nigga knew when he'd met a professional and when to let him embarrass himself.

Aiden's verdict. A town full of odd perspectives may be entertaining if its puzzle logic appeals; our visiting clown has departed after identifying the evening's existing specialist.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing supports five playable characters, Casual/Hard modes and exploring at one's pace. Casual is an editorial first-trial choice, not proof that every interaction or entire path meets all preferences.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/569860/>

P040 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Full Throttle Remastered

Edition considered: PC Remastered edition

Follow Ben through a compact biker adventure with animated road-movie energy, distinctive characters, visual attitude, and a strong rock-music identity.

What you do. Talk with characters, investigate with inventory objects, and progress through Ben's adventure, including active road sequences beyond the quieter conversations.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Required action remains in the remaster; a complete no-reflex route or universal skip has not been verified here.

Why it might click. Ben's trouble with powerful interests unfolds through a compact biker adventure full of distinctive characters, visual attitude and rock music. The remaster restores the original game's presentation and adds archival material, preserving a very particular kind of animated road-movie energy.

The full catch. This is not solely unhurried conversation and inventory work. Its remastered road sequences retain active gameplay, and the adventure includes action demands. A complete no-reflex route or universal skip has not been verified here. Treat it as a deliberate detour if required timing is unwelcome.

Try this first. Watch or try an early quiet conversation to judge the tone, while keeping the later action warning visible. Decide separately whether someone wants to handle those sequences; shared help is an arrangement, not native cooperative play.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Biker Wants the Loading Dock Cleared

Full Throttle went onto the screen when the motorcycle performer I'd forgotten booking arrived at the loading dock. He wanted to know where the stunt area was.

"What stunt area?" Shawna asked. I suddenly remembered approving "maximum impact."

Mercedes stood beside the cable cases. "Nigga, maximum impact is what happens when that bike hits my equipment." The performer looked at the space and refused the stunt himself. Competence was everywhere except my signature.

Tank helped him park outside. Rosa offered him dinner. I paid his callout and accepted a photograph beside the stationary bike as our evening's remaining speed event.

The game's action was a real part of its appeal and its catch. We left both plainly visible instead of pretending a biker adventure could be made entirely still by enthusiasm.

Shawna mounted the parked bike behind me for the picture. "Hold on," I said. "We're not moving." "Baby, your ego corners hard."

Aiden's verdict. This belongs where deliberate action is welcome, with the reflex demands understood; our live motorcycle event has become a stationary portrait, saving both the singer and the loading dock.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Double Fine supports the remastered game's premise; the platform interview with Tim Schafer confirms the playable Mine Road sequence's preservation. No unverified skip/no-action route is claimed.

Source 1: <https://www.doublefine.com/games/full-throttle-remastered>

Source 2: <https://blog.playstation.com/archive/2017/01/13/how-double-fine-is-tuning-up-full-throttle-remastered-for-ps4/>

The Singer Got the Stage and I Got the Bill

By the time Mercedes was ready to sing, my portrait had moved, the motorcycle was outside, the fog machine had gone home unpaid in glory but paid in cash, and the mermaids were wearing shoes. Two guests were still playing in the quiet room. Nobody hauled them out for a mandatory appreciation of Aiden. I had started the evening believing a successful party required everyone looking in the same direction. Now I was pleased that the direction was only occasionally the exit. The sponsor came to me holding a revised introduction. He had restored his product name to the first sentence. I looked at it, looked at Mercedes checking her microphone, and handed it back. "Use the one she agreed to." He said this was a commercial relationship. "Then listen to the professional you hired." He waited for my usual nervous little improvement, the sentence where I'd promise him something expensive to avoid silence. I let him wait. Nigga, apparently you could do that outside a game too.

Shawna stood beside the sound desk. Tank and Rosa found chairs together. Porsche held the spare recording bag on her lap because she'd said she would. The band began. Mercedes heard the first chord, turned her head a little, and smiled at the pianist. It wasn't a smile for the sponsor or the camera. It belonged to a moment between people making something together. I put my phone away before I tried to own it.

She sang. No interruption, no surprise guest, no announcement from me about the enormous generosity involved in my silence. Halfway through, Tank leaned over and whispered, "My nigga, the bass." I nodded. I could feel it in the chair. Shawna's hand found mine. We listened. The recording light stayed on, small and red, doing a job without projecting its face onto the wall.

Afterward Mercedes wanted to hear one particular passage before promising anybody a copy. The sponsor approached with his phone ready. She held up a finger and listened. He waited. I enjoyed that so much I nearly spoiled it by congratulating her while she was still listening. Porsche caught my eye and shook her head. A whole fucking support network existed to prevent my enthusiasm from becoming a second soundtrack.

The take was good enough for Mercedes to want it. That was the decision that mattered. She put the recorder away herself, hugged Rosa, and asked Tank whether there was anything left to eat. He looked offended on a structural level. There were covered plates in the back. He had secured them hours ago. Nigga had been running a quiet, competent nation behind my collapsing empire of atmosphere.

The manager arrived with the balance. I asked whether any of the deposit was coming back. He turned two pages. Shawna made a sympathetic noise that developed, against her better judgment, into laughter. The unused fog delivery, the relocated sculpture, the additional meals, the performers, the extra hour, my inexplicable request for monogrammed ice. On paper I had entertained a small principality. In practice my friends had eaten, talked, listened, and found games that made them curious. Most of the good parts fit on the cheapest page.

Shawna took my hand and led me toward the lift. “Now,” she said. I asked whether I could make one closing remark. She squeezed my hand. “Make it upstairs.” I had never accepted a scheduling instruction more enthusiastically. Tank called after us to ask what he should do with my portrait. “Keep it safe.” “Safe from who, nigga? Recognition?” Mercedes laughed. Rosa handed him a cloth. The doors closed before I saw what they covered.

Upstairs, the strawberries were still there. So was the champagne. Shawna took off her earrings and looked at me. “No microphones.” I put my phone facedown. “No audience.” I shut the curtain. “No twelve-minute introduction.” “Baby, I can be concise.” She came over, smiling. Downstairs I had needed three rooms to impress everybody. Here the only person I needed to impress was already pulling me away from the door. I let the rest of the evening keep its own record.

Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. The Tellings Cut: original revised Panorama prose and production by ChatGPT; original game research and selection system retained. This is a separate adult comic companion to Ten Toes Down. Source novels and the first Panorama edition remain intact. All people participating in the fictional party scenes are adults; Lillian is addressed as the reader.

Voice sources sampled for this revision: the Niggatorial Tellings Book I funeral and first Vegas party, selected passages from Books II-VI, and the edition editorial record. Source repository Sodelin/Ten-Toes-Down; working base 4cdof7a6e36977ff0ac705a59ebe65407d1f2bee. Selected passages were read closely; no full reread of all six novels is claimed. The added game-night story is newly composed fiction.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

This adult comic edition includes frequent reclaimed in-group language, strong profanity, fictional cocaine and party references, sexual banter and non-graphic innuendo. Those scenes are separate from the factual game descriptions and are not descriptions of the developers or real readers.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS / THE TELLINGS CUT

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 2 OF SIX

The Emperor Has Lost His Security Deposit

Turn-based strategy, cards and role-playing

Forty real games. Aiden has made it everybody's problem.

Adult comic edition: reclaimed in-group language, profanity, fictional cocaine references and sexual innuendo.

New ChatGPT prose under Nolan's creative direction.

Tellings Cut 2.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

How to find a game in this book

Each game starts with a short pitch, what you actually do, the controls and pace, the main catch, and a first action to try. These practical sections use plain language. The longer Aiden scene comes after them.

For a fast comparison, read the pitch and main catch on two or three pages. Use the alphabetical index to jump to a title. Choose the full story only when you want the comedy; it is never a prerequisite for understanding the game.

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. The labels mean: A place to start = a promising candidate; Read the catch first = a meaningful obstacle needs checking; A more demanding detour = a narrower or harder option. They describe the game, not the reader. Check the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

Choose a game by its name

This is the quick route. Click any title, or turn to its page. Read the short pitch and main catch first; Aiden's scene follows the practical guide. The case number works across every format.

P047	Advance Wars 1+2: Re-Boot Camp	13	P051	Mario + Rabbids Sparks of Hope	18
P077	Balatro	48	P074	Monster Train	45
P060	Battle Brothers	29	P069	OCTOPATH TRAVELER II	38
P061	BATTLETECH	30	P042	Old World	8
P072	BRAVELY DEFAULT II	43	P071	Persona 5 Royal	41
P067	Chained Echoes	36	P068	Sea of Stars	37
P080	Clubhouse Games: 51 Worldwide Classics	51	P055	Shadowrun Returns	23
P078	Cobalt Core	49	P056	Shadowrun: Dragonfall - Director's Cut	24
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A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 2. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index near the front always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P041	P042	P043	P044	P045	P046	P047	P048
2. Ready for conversation	P049	P050	P051	P052	P053	P054	P055	P056
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P057	P058	P059	P060	P061	P062	P063	P064
4. Here for the atmosphere	P065	P066	P067	P068	P069	P070	P071	P072
5. Open to a wildcard	P073	P074	P075	P076	P077	P078	P079	P080

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

They Charged Extra for the Throne

“Nigga, get out of that chair.” I had returned from the suite feeling loved, handsome, and capable of running a small civilization. Tank intended to challenge two of those conclusions immediately. He stood beside a large mechanical recliner covered in white upholstery. The rental company called it a photo throne. I called it a command center. Shawna called it the reason the service corridor was blocked.

I sat anyway. It made a low electrical noise. Somewhere beneath my ass a motor woke up and reconsidered the evening. Tank took one step back. Nigga had instincts honed by years of standing near my ideas. The chair remained upright for the moment. I took this as a sign of loyalty and put my feet on the little platform.

The second game room was supposed to be quieter. People could sit with strategic choices, stories, cards, and imaginary empires. I had therefore decorated it like the headquarters of a man who planned to invade another hotel. Two flags, a projection of stars, the throne, and a velvet rope around chairs that were exactly the same as the chairs outside the rope. The hotel manager looked in, saw me seated, and wrote something down. That nigga's pen had become a predator.

Shawna came over and kissed the top of my head. “We had a nice time upstairs.” “Exceptional,” I said. “Then preserve it by not becoming an emperor.” I told her I could rule gently. She looked at the foot platform. “You can't even get down without help.” I stood to demonstrate. The platform wobbled. Tank caught my elbow with the bored competence of a man who had already budgeted for this.

Mercedes was reviewing her live recording with Porsche. She wanted to hear the quiet parts without me announcing that the quiet parts were excellent. Rosa was settling the additional staff time. She wanted numbers to arrive in the right accounts instead of merely being praised for their importance. Tank wanted to sit, eat, and beat me at something sufficiently clear that I couldn't rewrite the result afterward. Everybody had an objective. Mine required the largest piece of furniture.

Dre came in carrying his casserole dish. A grown man with a blue shirt, an easy laugh, and no interest in auditioning for my themed militia. He was a Crip; this detail did not make him responsible for my blue lighting package. “That controller's mine,” he said, pointing at the blue one. I nodded. His claim was easier to understand than the rental agreement for my throne. Tank offered him a plate. A useful alliance formed without an anthem.

Darnell followed, talking about his yacht to somebody who was not following. He had already been told where his cocaine bag wasn't welcome. Now he wanted to explain that a luxury weekend should have freedom. Mercedes looked up. “Then free me from this conversation.” He laughed as though she was flirting. She wasn't. Porsche moved a chair into the gap between them and asked Mercedes a question about the recording. That was the end of Darnell's audience. The nigga wandered toward a bartender who at least got paid to remain polite.

I wanted to announce that turn-based games meant everybody could relax. Shawna stopped me before I reached the microphone. “Say what you actually know.” I knew some actions waited. I also knew menus could pile up, systems could demand memory, and a counter could make a person feel pressed even when no seconds were ticking away. Tank nodded toward my bills. “Like that. Your debt waits. Ain't relaxing.”

So the useful notes stayed plain. What looked appealing, what a person would do, what might be a pain in the ass. Nobody had to love a heavy strategy game merely because its battles politely waited to make them miserable. Equally, nobody had to avoid a large story if learning it felt good. A grown adult could decide that for herself without me running a ceremonial checkpoint on the way to the chair.

Rosa moved a plate onto the table. Mercedes turned the speaker down enough for conversation. Shawna chose a seat that let her touch my knee without facing the throne. Tank put the first game on and looked at me. "Ready?" I reached for my commanding voice. Then I saw four people waiting for one answer and gave them one. "Yeah, my nigga." The game began. Behind us the empty throne adjusted itself with a small mechanical sigh, possibly relieved to be free of command.

P041 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Sid Meier's Civilization VI

Edition considered: PC base game, no expansion requirement

Build a civilization whose cities, discoveries, and relationships reflect your decisions, gradually creating a history with a direction of your own.

What you do. Found a city, choose its production or research, and manage units, districts, policies, and relationships with neighboring powers over successive turns.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Solo turns allow deliberation, but menus and planning are heavy; test map gestures and readability rather than assuming cognitive simplicity.

Why it might click. Build a civilization across a large sweep of history, choosing how cities grow, what people research and how to deal with neighboring powers. The appeal is seeing many small decisions create a society with a recognizable direction rather than following one prescribed storyline.

The full catch. District placement, research, policies, diplomacy and multiple units produce heavy menu and planning demands. Single-player turns permit deliberation, but this is emphatically not cognitively simple because it is turn-based. Avoid assuming online turn settings match solo play; held map gestures and interface readability still need a trial.

Try this first. Use the guided opening or a modest single-player start to found one city and make one production choice. Judge whether the explanations make that decision interesting before opening an empire's worth of additional responsibilities.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Civilization Has One City and Six Bars

I founded my first Civilization VI city and announced that everybody would prosper. Rosa asked why our real party had six drink stations and nowhere for the catering staff to sit.

“Entertainment infrastructure.” “Nigga, chairs.”

Tank looked over the map while Shawna looked over the room. Both could identify an expensive settlement without enough planning. I tried naming a district after my wife. She said the honor could begin with carrying two chairs.

Mercedes wanted to see what research changed. I wanted to explain my long-term vision. She selected the next thing while I was still describing the horizon.

The game could wait between decisions. My mouth apparently couldn't. Tank put his hand on my shoulder. “Let the nigga ruling the city think.” “That's me.” “Then let everybody else experience it for a second.”

I moved the chairs. My real civilization achieved its first measurable improvement. Nobody constructed a monument, which seemed ungrateful but affordable.

Aiden's verdict. Explore the empire if managing it sounds enjoyable; turns create thinking time, not fewer decisions, as demonstrated by my civilization's urgent and entirely avoidable chair crisis.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact base-game PC listing supports districts, research, policies and diplomacy. Waits refers to single-player turn decisions; complete input comfort and multiplayer timer/co-op configurations are not verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/289070/>

P042 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Old World

Edition considered: PC base game

Guide a historical dynasty where aging rulers, competing families, and personal events give empire management a continuing story about people.

What you do. Read a ruler's decision, consider its personal consequences, and manage cities, resources, character roles, and court relationships as the dynasty develops.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Untimed input is declared, but cities and family relationships form a dense strategy game; co-op setup needs separate checking.

Why it might click. Old World combines historical strategy with a living dynasty: rulers age, families compete, children grow and personal events affect the state. People and relationships can give empire management a more intimate story than a map of anonymous production totals.

The full catch. The developer declares play without timed input, a mouse-only option and saving at any time. That is encouraging for pacing, while court relationships, cities, resources and character roles still make this a dense strategy game. Declared co-op exists, but its setup and shared responsibilities require a separate check.

Try this first. Follow the introductory guidance until one ruler faces one clear decision. Read the affected person's name and consequence, then decide whether that personal layer makes the surrounding management enjoyable or merely adds another spreadsheet to remember.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Dynasty Has Seen My Dating History

Old World let a ruler's family complicate politics. Shawna heard that and immediately asked whether my pretend dynasty knew what I'd paid for our wedding fireworks.

"Nigga, that was romance." "One rocket spelled your name." "So you'd know who loved you."

Mercedes nearly spilled her drink. Tank asked whether a heir inherited the invoices or just the ability to explain them badly. I tried discussing succession. Rosa said the first succession should put somebody else in charge of dessert quantities.

The game's families had ambitions of their own. My friends understood that quickly. I kept acting surprised when an imaginary relation wanted something besides a framed photograph of the ruler. Shawna leaned close. "You want to build a lasting house?" I nodded. She moved the water pitcher within my reach. "Start by noticing who's thirsty."

I poured. Nigga, the great dynasty survived its first administrative reform without requiring a crown-shaped ice bucket.

Aiden's verdict. Follow the family politics if they interest you, with the management load understood; our dynasty currently measures a ruler's promise by whether he can refill glasses.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact listing supports dynasties/families and declares no timed input, Mouse Only Option, Save Anytime and co-op. Those declarations do not establish low menu load or a personally comfortable multiplayer arrangement.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/597180/>

P043 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

HUMANKIND

Edition considered: PC base game

Combine cultures across historical eras, shaping a civilization whose cities, conflicts, and achievements reflect an accumulating series of different choices.

What you do. Choose developments, manage resources and diplomacy, and make battlefield decisions while adapting the civilization to changes across successive historical eras.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Empire and battlefield systems overlap, making memory demands high; solo turns do not establish relaxed settings in every configuration.

Why it might click. Shape a civilization by combining cultures across eras rather than staying with a single identity throughout history. City growth, fame and tactical conflicts turn the map into an account of accumulated decisions, including choices about what kind of achievements matter.

The full catch. Empire management and battlefield decisions sit on top of one another. Culture transitions add systems to learn, while resources, diplomacy and competing goals make the memory load high. Turn-based battles do not establish a universally simple control scheme or relaxed multiplayer timer settings; begin with solo play and inspect menus.

Try this first. Follow the early guidance through one development choice and read what it changes. Stop to decide whether comparing those possibilities feels engaging before treating the next historical era as an obligation to keep playing.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / I Changed Cultures and Kept the Same Bar Tab

HUMANKIND let me imagine remaking a civilization across eras. I changed my jacket for the second room and called it a new cultural phase.

Tank looked at the hotel bill protruding from my pocket. “Old civilization followed you, nigga.”

Mercedes wanted to compare what a choice might change. I wanted the group to admire my new lapels. Shawna admired them, which encouraged me to turn slowly until I caught the chair with my heel.

Rosa saved the glass. Tank saved nothing; he was laughing too hard to qualify as emergency personnel.

The game offered more interesting questions than whether a man could reinvent himself by removing velvet. What should a society achieve? What did another era make possible? My wife considered my emerging era of Sitting Down a particularly promising development.

I sat. The jacket looked excellent against the chair. Mercedes made a decision on the screen and let its consequences be more interesting than the clothes I wore while watching.

Aiden’s verdict. Try shaping a civilization across changing eras if the choices appeal; my personal cultural transition has retained the debt but substantially reduced the amount of standing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing supports combining cultures, fame and turn-based tactical battles. Pacing label applies to solo strategic decisions; complete holds, map controls and multiplayer configurations remain unchecked.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1124300/>

P044 / A PLACE TO START

Into the Breach

Edition considered: PC Advanced Edition update

Solve small mech battles by reading enemy attacks in advance, finding a move that changes several threats through clever positioning.

What you do. Inspect the next announced attack, identify threatened squares, and move or act with a mech to change what will happen.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The small board still demands spatial reasoning and limited-action planning; selection controls need testing, and failure changes a run.

Why it might click. Small mech battles become visible tactical puzzles because enemy attacks are telegraphed before the next turn. The pleasure is finding an unexpected move that changes several threats at once, often by shifting positions rather than simply choosing the strongest attack.

The full catch. A compact board can still ask for demanding spatial reasoning. Protecting buildings, understanding attack direction and managing limited actions are central, and failure changes a run. The turn structure supports thought before acting; it does not prove every menu or selection gesture suits the player. Advanced Edition adds more systems.

Try this first. Try the opening guidance and inspect one announced enemy attack before choosing a move. Say which square is threatened and what one action changes; there is no need to solve the entire campaign to test that central pleasure.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Mech Cannot Save My Shrimp Tower

Into the Breach showed where an attack would land. Our waiter showed exactly where he needed to carry a towering tray of shrimp. I moved the wrong chair anyway.

“Left,” Shawna said. I moved right. Tank grabbed the chair before the waiter acquired a tactical disaster.

“Nigga, you had the whole attack preview.”

At the screen, Mercedes considered pushing an enemy instead of simply hitting it harder. I admired that. In the room she applied the same principle by moving me six feet away from the food route.

Rosa watched one careful move change several problems. “That,” she said, “is satisfying.” I offered to improve the furniture formation. “Stay pushed,” Mercedes said.

The turn waited while we talked. Nobody needed a countdown to appreciate the puzzle. My attention finally stayed on the screen long enough to see the little solution form.

Tank handed me a shrimp. A strategic reward, probably. Also a useful way of keeping my mouth occupied.

Aiden’s verdict. The small visible tactical problem may be inviting if you enjoy planning; our buffet has adopted the same principle by clearly marking where I should not stand.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes minimalistic turn-based combat with telegraphed attacks; current PC includes Advanced Edition content. Waits reflects tactical decision structure, not a complete no-hold/comfort certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/590380/>

P045 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Wargroove

Edition considered: PC base game

Lead a displaced queen's bright fantasy campaign, using distinctive commanders and varied terrain to make positioning and resource choices matter.

What you do. Follow campaign instructions, select units on the map, and choose movement or attacks while managing funds and different army roles.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Army funds and unit matchups require learning; exact co-op coverage, timing settings, and selection gestures need their own check.

Why it might click. Wargroove gives turn-based army battles a bright fantasy cast and a campaign about a displaced queen seeking allies. Commanders have distinctive special abilities, while different units and terrain make each map a problem about positioning and resource choices.

The full catch. Managing an army, its funds and its unit matchups is more involved than moving one character. The editor and multiplayer add separate layers rather than simplifying the campaign. Co-op is listed, but exact campaign coverage and setup should be checked; no untimed or hold-free claim applies automatically to every configuration.

Try this first. Start with the campaign's opening instruction and command one unit through one explained action. Test the map selection interface and the clarity of the unit information before recruiting a large army or opening the editor.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Queen Has Taken My Best Chair

Wargroove had a displaced queen seeking allies. Shawna wanted the comfortable chair I'd reserved for myself. I told her it was the command seat.

She sat down. "Command something from over there."

Tank offered to recognize her government for a plate of ribs. Mercedes demanded a competent sound system. Rosa wanted the catering balance paid. Nigga, the coalition formed in seconds and none of its terms mentioned me.

I stood beside the screen and tried to advise the campaign. Shawna chose her own move. I reached for the chair arm; she caught my hand and pulled me close enough for a kiss.

"Still allied?" she asked. "Deeply." "Then stop hovering."

The bright fantasy battles could have their own commanders and terrain. Our local conflict ended with me fetching water for the queen and taking the ordinary seat beside her.

Tank inspected it. "Nigga got diplomatic seating." I said nothing. I was still enjoying the treaty.

Aiden's verdict. Follow the colorful campaign if tactical positioning appeals; my local monarchy has been settled peacefully, with affection intact and my former command chair under new ownership.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing supports turn-based campaign, commander Grooves and native co-op categories. Co-op mode scope is not assumed to cover the whole main campaign; complete input demands are unchecked.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/607050/>

P046 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Wargroove 2

Edition considered: PC base game

Return to colorful army tactics through linked campaigns, new commanders, and a conflict over forbidden technology in an expanding fantasy world.

What you do. Read a commander's ability, move units, and use battlefield actions while learning the revised Groove system through the initial campaign.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. New abilities add knowledge to army management; extra modes and listed co-op do not automatically simplify campaign play.

Why it might click. The sequel builds a new conflict around forbidden technology and several connected campaigns, with new commanders and a revised Groove system. Its attraction is returning to colorful map tactics with fresh factions, tactical possibilities and a continuing fantasy world.

The full catch. New commander abilities and linked campaigns add knowledge to the familiar army-management demands. The separate Conquest mode and editing tools are optional avenues, not recommended first steps here. Native co-op is listed, but campaign coverage, timing settings and comfortable selection controls need their own verification.

Try this first. Take the initial campaign instruction one action at a time and read one commander's ability carefully. Compare that single mechanic with ordinary movement before exploring extra modes or designing an ambitious custom scenario for everyone else.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Forbidden Technology Is My Second Fog Machine

Wargroove 2 mentioned forbidden technology. Tank immediately pointed at a crate beside the stage. "Tell me that ain't another fog machine."

"It was a package." "Nigga, so is a box of regrets."

Mercedes read the rental label and called the technician before I could propose a controlled demonstration. He confirmed it was unused. She arranged collection. A technologically advanced civilization had apparently invented the return journey.

Onscreen, new commanders and tactical possibilities were a reason to investigate the sequel. In the room, the sequel to my first mistake needed cancellation before it developed a third act.

Shawna slipped a finger beneath my collar. "You promised less atmosphere." "I thought you meant emotional." "I meant anything that needs ventilation."

The collection crew arrived. I helped carry the crate, which Tank described as my first successful deployment of forbidden technology. Nigga filmed it like a historic disarmament agreement and sent the clip to nobody without asking.

Aiden's verdict. New campaigns may attract anyone who likes these map battles; my own sequel has been revised to remove the unnecessary machine before it acquires a plot.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Current publisher listing supports three campaigns, revised Grooves, Conquest and native co-op. Waits refers to turn-based tactics, not an all-modes or hold-free guarantee.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1346020/>

P047 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Advance Wars 1+2: Re-Boot Camp

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch compilation

Explore rebuilt Advance Wars campaigns where colorful commanding officers and land, sea, and air units turn terrain into a tactical puzzle.

What you do. Follow training, inspect a unit's information, and choose movement, capture, or attack decisions while managing different battlefield roles and funds.

Direction + buttons | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Ranges, funds, and mission conditions still demand planning; versus multiplayer does not establish a shared campaign or comfortable controls.

Why it might click. This Switch collection rebuilds the first two Advance Wars campaigns around colorful land, sea and air battles. Commanding officers bring personalities and special powers, while terrain, capture decisions and different unit roles provide a board-game-like tactical focus.

The full catch. Bright presentation does not remove the need to compare ranges, terrain, funds and matchups. It is turn-based, but particular mission conditions can still create strategic urgency. Nintendo's listed multiplayer includes versus play; do not assume a shared campaign. Hold behavior and readability require a check on the actual display.

Try this first. Follow the early training and move one unit using its displayed information. Check whether the explanation makes its purpose clear before progressing to a larger force with several different roles to remember at once.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Boot Camp Has Rejected My Dress Shoes

Advance Wars put colorful land, sea, and air units in front of us. I lined up three serving trolleys to explain combined operations. Rosa took two back immediately.

"Nigga, those got dinner on them." "Military logistics." "Catering. Older institution."

Tank climbed onto the remaining trolley. It rolled six inches, enough to make him step off with dignity he had not earned. Shawna asked whether our demonstration could now end before a hotel worker had to write about it.

At the screen, unit roles and terrain actually changed the choices. Mercedes looked at the map instead of our improvised parade. I tried to give an officer's briefing until she asked which game mode we were discussing. I had to check.

The best thing about having competent friends was the small number of ambulances required by my ideas. The worst thing was how often those friends wanted the exact answer.

Tank returned the last trolley. Boot camp released us without honors.

Aiden's verdict. The rebuilt campaigns offer clear-looking tactical maps but still require learning their rules; our trolley brigade has returned to the much more useful business of serving dinner.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo identifies the Switch remake collection and turn-based land/sea/air tactics, terrain and CO powers. Versus multiplayer is confirmed; native campaign co-op is not established. No complete no-hold guarantee.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/advance-wars-1-plus-2-re-boot-camp-switch/>

P048 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Fire Emblem: Three Houses

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

Choose a house of characters to know over a long story, where relationships develop alongside tactical battles and a continent's political crisis.

What you do. Talk with the cast, manage lessons and equipment, explore the monastery, and command units through tactical battles in the chosen house's story.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Normal/Casual reduces losses, but schedules and menus remain heavy; monastery movement adds a separate camera-control question.

Why it might click. A teacher's relationship with students develops alongside tactical battles and a continent's political crisis. Choosing a house gives the long story a particular group to know, making friendships, loyalties and changing circumstances a substantial part of the experience.

The full catch. Normal difficulty with Casual mode revives fallen allies after battles, but it does not remove lessons, schedules, equipment or tactical menus. Monastery exploration adds three-dimensional movement and camera considerations. This is a rich character game with heavy management demands, not a simple visual novel because conversations are prominent.

Try this first. Choose Normal and Casual for the first trial, then assess one introductory battle explanation and one conversation. Test monastery movement separately when available; comfort with selecting a battle square does not answer the camera question.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Three Houses and None of Them Is My Penthouse

Fire Emblem: Three Houses made me propose dividing the party into factions. Shawna asked whether mine would include people willing to hear my speeches. I said obviously.

Tank looked around. "Small house, nigga."

Mercedes wanted to choose based on the people and the story. Rosa asked how much there was to remember between battles. Both questions improved the evening more than the sashes I had already ordered.

I held up a blue one. Tank shook his head. "Don't bring the Crips into your seating chart." "It's an academy color." "Then graduate from carrying it around."

We put the sashes away. The game could offer its students, loyalties, and political troubles without turning the actual adults in our room into recruits for my organization.

Shawna kept one sash and looped it loosely around my wrist. "For identifying the man who owes me a dance."

I followed. At last, a faction with compelling membership benefits and a very short orientation.

Aiden's verdict. Let a house's people attract you, while keeping the many systems visible; our real factions have dissolved into friends who can choose their own chairs and partners.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo confirms turn-based battles, academy exploration/calendar and Normal/Casual options. Casual removes permanent allied losses in battle, not other complexity. Whole-path hold/camera comfort remains untested.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/en-gb/Games/Nintendo-Switch-games/Fire-Emblem-Three-Houses-1175482.html>

P049 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Fire Emblem Engage

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

Experiment with character and Emblem pairings in colorful tactical battles, discovering how different strengths change the options available on the grid.

What you do. Read unit matchups, select battle actions, and develop characters through weapons, rings, skills, and pairings with legendary Emblems as the campaign progresses.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Normal/Casual and other aids change punishment or support decisions; they do not establish low menu load or comfortable hub movement.

Why it might click. Engage emphasizes colorful tactical battles and the abilities gained by pairing characters with legendary Emblems. The appeal is experimenting with a cast's different strengths and seeing how a chosen pairing changes the possibilities on a grid-based battlefield.

The full catch. Weapon relationships, rings, skills and party development create many interlocking rules. Nintendo confirms Normal difficulty, Casual mode and Auto-Battle, plus a limited rewind system. Those aids change punishment or decision support; they do not prove low menu load or comfortable movement around the hub.

Try this first. Use Normal and Casual, read one unit's weapon matchup, and try its basic action before exploring every ring combination. Examine Auto-Battle as an optional tool only after seeing what it controls, keeping the choice to participate or delegate yours.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Ring Has Heard Enough About My Legendary Power

Fire Emblem Engage made me point at my wedding ring and claim I too possessed a legendary bond that improved all my abilities.

Shawna looked at the wine I'd spilled on my cuff. "Accuracy still needs work."

Tank asked whether marrying twice equipped a second power. Rosa turned toward him slowly. "You planning an experiment?" "Nigga, theoretical research." He offered her the best chair before the proposal reached peer review.

Mercedes liked looking at how different pairings changed a battle. I liked looking at my wife, which she noticed and encouraged by stretching out her hand for me to kiss. For one graceful second I had the whole room beat.

Then I caught my sleeve on her bracelet. Two legendary adults stood joined at the wrist while Porsche patiently freed the clasp.

The game could manage its own powerful combinations. Our party had identified a simpler one: jewelry, vanity, and a woman willing to laugh while helping me disentangle the evidence.

Aiden's verdict. Pairing characters and Emblems may be entertaining if the tactical systems appeal; my marital enhancement remains powerful but has not yet unlocked competent sleeve management.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo supports grid tactics, Emblem pairings, Normal/Casual, Auto-Battle and limited rewind. No full-path hold/camera assurance or shared campaign is inferred; multiplayer scope remains unverified here.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/en-gb/Games/Nintendo-Switch-games/Fire-Emblem-Engage-2267157.html>

P050 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

Join Mario characters and Rabbids in comic tactical battles, where their different roles make cover, positioning, and coordinated attacks worth learning.

What you do. Follow a solo battle explanation, compare movement with an attack, and learn exploration, equipment, and abilities as the adventure continues.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Local co-op covers separate challenges, not the full campaign; navigation and controls need checking without assuming the sequel's accommodations.

Why it might click. Mario characters and Rabbids join forces in colorful tactical battles, with each hero contributing a different role. The mismatch between earnest adventure and Rabbid behavior offers a comic frame for learning positioning, cover and coordinated attacks.

The full catch. Combat takes turns, but exploration, equipment and abilities still require learning and navigation. Nintendo describes local co-op as additional challenges, not the entire story campaign. Do not infer the sequel's hold toggles or other accommodations for this first game; exact gesture and camera comfort need checking.

Try this first. Follow an early solo battle explanation and compare one movement option with one attack. If playing together is the main attraction, inspect the separate co-op challenges and their requirements rather than promising shared control of the whole campaign.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Rabbids Did Not Order Those Suits

Mario and the Rabbids appeared just as three hired hosts arrived in matching white jackets. I had asked for “playful elegance.” They looked like a dental conference about to rob a yacht.

Mercedes stared at me. “Nigga, did you hire your own minions?” One host said he'd been promised actual duties. Rosa immediately found useful things for all three to carry.

At the screen, different characters could work together rather than merely stand around matching. Tank asked which modes let people do what together. I started answering from the picture. Shawna handed me the actual notes before I invented a feature.

We checked. I stopped trying to put every form of togetherness under the same label.

The hosts returned with fresh water and cleared plates. They had become competent members of the party by taking direction from Rosa. I asked whether they liked their jackets.

One said they were hot. Nigga, the first honest review of my elegance had arrived.

Aiden's verdict. The comic tactical mismatch may be fun if the systems suit you; check the separate co-op mode, and leave my matching-jacket theory of teamwork at the door.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo confirms turn-based combat and separate local co-op challenges. Co-op flag is restricted to those challenges; no whole-campaign co-op or Sparks of Hope control options are transferred.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/mario-plus-rabbids-kingdom-battle-switch/>

Source 2: <https://play.nintendo.com/news-tips/game-releases/mario-rabbids-kingdom-battle-release-date/>

The Emperor Required a Sewing Kit

The noise came when I bent to retrieve my phone. A small, direct sound, followed by a breeze where no breeze had been invited. Tank looked up from his plate. Shawna closed her eyes. Mercedes asked whether that was the chair. I remained bent over for one tragic second, because returning upright would mean accepting what had happened. “Tailoring,” I said. “Minor issue.” Tank stood behind me with a tablecloth. “Nigga, you got a diplomatic opening.” He wrapped the cloth around my waist while Rosa sent a hotel worker for a sewing kit. Nobody screamed. Nobody died. Several people nearly choked laughing, but they had brought that on themselves by witnessing history without adequate preparation.

Shawna took my hand and led me toward the dressing room. I tried to make the journey look sensual. She said I looked like a man escorting a banquet table into retirement. From behind us Tank called, “Keep the cloth, my nigga. We can rent it as a skirt.” Mercedes asked him not to put that idea anywhere a sponsor could hear it.

In the dressing room my wife inspected the damage. “You bought these too tight.” “For the silhouette.” “The silhouette has escaped.” She handed me a hotel robe and told me to change while she checked the seam. I said she seemed remarkably calm around a husband in his underwear. “Aiden, we just spent private time together. This isn't a press preview.” I had to sit down because laughing made the remaining seam threaten solidarity.

There was a knock. Darnell wanted to know if we needed anything to keep the party going. Shawna answered through the door. “A tailor.” He offered to call somebody from his yacht. “A tailor who's here, nigga,” she said. Silence. Then Rosa arrived with the kit, a pair of spare black trousers from the costume rack, and the news that the caterers had been paid correctly. She was having a much more successful evening than I was, and she deserved every inch of it.

The spare trousers fitted except for the length. Shawna turned the hems under while I stood still. “There's my emperor,” she said. “Finally following instructions.” I touched her shoulder. “You know I'm grateful.” “I do. You don't always have to build a stage so I can hear it.” For a moment the room got quiet in a way I liked. Then Tank called through the door to ask whether the tablecloth was formally retiring from food service. Romance requires friends with good fucking timing, and I had none.

When I came back, Mercedes had the new recording playing softly through one speaker. Porsche was listening to a passage they wanted to compare. Dre and Tank were looking at a small game together. Rosa sat with both feet under her chair instead of working on them. Nobody had needed my replacement announcement. The room had kept going while its emperor borrowed trousers.

I looked at the velvet rope, still dividing identical chairs. Unhooked it. Rolled it up. Tank watched without making a joke, which was kind until he said, “Careful bending, nigga.” I straightened my knees and coiled the rest standing up. Shawna returned to her seat beside me. The cloth went to the laundry. The throne remained empty. My dignity recovered enough to accept dinner without requesting a new title.

P051 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Mario + Rabbids Sparks of Hope

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

Travel between imaginative planets with Mario and the Rabbids, combining heroes with Sparks while their antics give each new place comic appeal.

What you do. Explore with direct movement, inspect control options, and choose hero abilities or battle actions while learning how movement-based techniques work.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Useful control options exist, but camera, direct movement, and traversal still need testing; the first game's co-op does not transfer.

Why it might click. Mario and the Rabbids travel between imaginative planets, meeting odd characters and combining heroes with helpful Sparks. Tactical battles sit inside a larger exploratory adventure, with the cast's antics providing a light comic reason to see what the next place contains.

The full catch. Ubisoft documents specific hold toggles, single-press alternatives, camera adjustments, automatic skill management and invulnerability. These are real options, not proof of a wholly no-rush path: direct movement, camera handling and airborne or traversal actions need checking. The first game's co-op challenges do not establish co-op here.

Try this first. Inspect those control options before play, then test ordinary movement and a first battle at the preferred difficulty. Check how a team jump or other moving action feels when introduced; stop there if the practical demands outweigh the appeal.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Hope Has a Settings Menu and I Don't

Sparks of Hope made me promise a trip between planets. Shawna asked whether we could first move between the ballroom and our suite without six people stopping me to discuss lighting.

Mercedes inspected the actual settings described in the notes. I watched her find practical possibilities I'd almost buried beneath a speech about cosmic wonder.

"Nigga, help looks like this," she said, pointing. Tank pointed at the chair I was blocking. "Also like moving."

I moved. Rosa tried a small bit of navigation and said exactly what she'd want to check next. Nobody answered with the phrase you'll get used to it. I had been about to, but Shawna's hand on my knee arrived before my mouth could damage the atmosphere.

"Different kind of spark," I whispered. She laughed. "Focus, husband."

We let the game keep its planets and the settings keep their real value. My contribution was finally small enough to fit the room we were actually in.

Aiden's verdict. Explore the colorful journey if its tested settings help, while checking movement for yourself; the most useful spark I supplied tonight was occasionally paying attention.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer UX interview documents listed options and time to think during turns; publisher article confirms direct real-time movement. These do not verify every traversal sequence. Single-player sequel assessed separately from Kingdom Battle.

Source 1:

<https://news.ubisoft.com/en-gb/article/3geL8IbYETmgHk6W017HpS/mario-rabbids-sparks-of-hope-accessibility-spotlight>

Source 2: <https://news.ubisoft.com/en-us/article/65J7B5ga4HkMpXtYWQ7QX5>

P052 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

XCOM: Enemy Unknown

Edition considered: PC base game; not Enemy Within expansion

Build Earth's defense against an alien invasion, growing attached to soldiers whose battlefield decisions connect to research, equipment, and headquarters planning.

What you do. Move soldiers into cover, choose explained combat actions, and manage research, budgets, equipment, and base decisions between ground missions.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Multiple soldiers and base systems add weight; casualties create pressure, and complete interception or held-input behavior is not audited.

Why it might click. Lead a defense organization against an alien invasion, growing attached to soldiers while choosing research, equipment and battlefield tactics. The appeal is the connection between a strategic headquarters and the small, consequential decisions made by a squad on the ground.

The full catch. Turn-based ground combat still involves cover, ranges, hit chances and multiple soldiers. Research, budgets and base decisions add another layer, while casualties and global threats create pressure. This card is Enemy Unknown without assuming Enemy Within additions; complete interception, timing and held-input behavior has not been audited.

Try this first. Use the opening tutorial and focus on one soldier's move into cover and one explained action. Assess whether the battlefield information feels interesting before treating the larger base-management system as part of an evening's commitment.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Aliens Want a Better Soundcheck

XCOM: Enemy Unknown gave me a defense headquarters. The hotel gave Mercedes a feedback squeal from a speaker. I announced that I would locate the hostile signal.

The sound technician reached past me and adjusted one control. Silence. Nigga, apparently Earth had hired somebody qualified.

Tank wanted to name a soldier after me. Shawna asked whether that meant the soldier would sprint ahead of the plan and demand better lighting. I said real leadership involved risk. Mercedes said real leadership could begin by letting the technician work.

The game tied people, equipment, and decisions together in a way that made consequences matter. My proposed organization had excellent uniforms and no idea what any cable did.

I carried a spare stand to the correct place. The technician thanked me. It felt disturbingly good to receive approval for doing the requested thing.

Tank still named the soldier after me. "Don't get him killed," I said. "Then stop giving him advice, nigga."

Aiden's verdict. Building a defense team can be compelling if the management appeals; my fictional namesake deserves a commander who reads the situation before volunteering somebody else's bravery.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Base-game listing supports turn-based squad combat, base/research management and interceptions. Pacing is mixed because the full strategic/interception loop is not certified wholly untimed. No expansion feature is assumed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/200510/>

P053 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

XCOM 2

Edition considered: PC base game; not War of the Chosen expansion

Lead a resistance under alien occupation, developing soldiers whose ambushes, successes, and losses become the history of a mobile organization.

What you do. Inspect cover and movement boundaries, choose soldiers' actions, and manage the base, skills, and mission objectives across the resistance campaign.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Turn limits create urgency; camera operations, held-Control waypoint paths, and permanent casualties add demands in the base game.

Why it might click. The sequel turns Earth's defenders into an insurgent force, building a mobile organization and conducting tactical missions under alien occupation. Ambushes, soldier development and the changing campaign give each squad's successes and losses a continuing personal history.

The full catch. Turn limits create strategic urgency without requiring a fast mouse click. The manual also describes many action controls, camera operations and a held Control-key gesture for waypoint paths. Base management, skill trees and permanent casualties add weight. This is the base game; expansion options for changing timers are not assumed.

Try this first. Leave the tutorial enabled and inspect one soldier's movement boundary and cover information. Read a turn-limited objective literally when it appears, then decide whether pressure measured in decisions is acceptable even when the decision itself can be considered.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P053 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

XCOM 2

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Resistance Has Lost the Hotel Wi-Fi

XCOM 2 put us under alien occupation. A login screen put us outside the hotel's internet. I described both as oppressive systems and demanded a strategic response.

Shawna entered the room number. Connected. "Liberated, nigga."

Tank liked the idea of a mobile resistance headquarters. He suggested our drinks trolley, which already carried supplies and avoided my speeches. Rosa refused to let anybody repurpose it until dinner was finished.

The game's missions had their own pressure, including objectives measured in turns. I started calling that the same as no pressure. Mercedes shook her head. "People can think slowly and still dislike a deadline."

I looked at the notes again. That was fair. My own deadline involved paying an extension before the room closed; the fact that the manager waited patiently did not make him relaxing.

We chose whether the game sounded worth that tension. I stopped comparing the Wi-Fi portal to an invasion and successfully resisted buying another router.

Aiden's verdict. The resistance story may justify the layered tactics for you; turn limits still matter, and our hotel occupation ended with a room number rather than guerrilla brilliance.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports base-game premise; official port manual documents turn-based actions, turn timers, casualties and held Control for waypoint movement. Waits concerns tactical decisions, not absence of turn pressure. No War of the Chosen options transferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/268500/>

Source 2: <https://www.feralinteractive.com/en/manuals/xcom2/latest/steam/>

P054 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Invisible, Inc.

Edition considered: PC base game

Plan corporate infiltrations where different agents and equipment make one well-chosen action open an unexpected path through security toward a valuable escape.

What you do. Inspect guards and sight lines, use agent abilities or hacking resources, and plan an extraction while choosing actions across successive turns.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The alarm rises each turn, so thinking time does not remove pressure; abilities and extraction plans require substantial tracking.

Why it might click. Corporate espionage becomes a tactical puzzle about agents, security systems and getting out with something valuable. Different operatives and equipment combinations let a plan feel clever when a small, well-chosen action opens an unexpected route through trouble.

The full catch. The designer describes an alarm that rises at the end of each turn. Thinking time is available, but escalating consequences can still feel urgent. Agent abilities, hacking resources, sight lines and extraction plans create heavy demands. Custom modes exist, yet a specific no-pressure configuration has not been established here.

Try this first. Try the introductory mission and inspect a guard's attention and one available agent action. Watch what changes when the turn ends, then judge the alarm's emotional effect rather than deciding solely from the absence of a seconds countdown.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Invisible Except for the Sequins

Invisible, Inc. inspired me to retrieve the sponsor's new introduction without him noticing. I wore a sequined jacket that threw light across the room every time I breathed.

Mercedes watched me approach. "Nigga, the chandelier can see you."

Tank volunteered to distract the sponsor by asking about his yacht. This worked immediately and catastrophically: the man began showing forty photographs. Tank looked over after the first ten with the expression of an operative whose extraction window had closed.

Shawna simply asked for the introduction. The sponsor handed it over. She returned it to Mercedes, who removed the unwanted sales pitch.

The game could make sneaking through corporate security feel clever. Our actual operation required one direct question and a friend willing to say no. I went to rescue Tank.

The sponsor showed me the yacht bathroom. Tank escaped while I looked. Nigga had used me as cover. At last somebody in our espionage unit understood his equipment.

Aiden's verdict. A careful infiltration puzzle may reward planning if its alarm pressure appeals; my sequined stealth deployment succeeded only after I was reclassified as a large reflective distraction.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports stealth systems/custom modes; first-person designer article explains alarm advancement per turn. No particular alarm-removal setting or full input accommodation is inferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/243970/>

Source 2: <https://www.gamedeveloper.com/design/game-design-deep-dive-alarm-systems-in-klei-s-i-invisible-inc-i->

P055 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Shadowrun Returns

Edition considered: PC original release

Follow a murder investigation through Seattle's mix of magic, cybernetics, and corporate power, with a team whose different abilities support the job.

What you do. Read conversations, choose a starting archetype, and direct team actions in tactical battles while managing attributes, equipment, spells, and other abilities.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Reading and character systems are substantial; turn-based fights do not certify every mission demand or held gesture on the full path.

Why it might click. A murder investigation moves through a Seattle where cybernetics, magic and corporate power collide. The story offers an adult genre mixture, while turn-based team combat lets different kinds of characters contribute practical abilities to the same job.

The full catch. Character creation, attributes, equipment, spells and tactical positioning are substantial systems. The game also relies on considerable reading, so a mystery-led premise does not make it a simple detective interface. Turn-based fights allow consideration, but the complete mission path and every held gesture have not been independently tested.

Try this first. Pick one clear starting archetype and follow the first conversation before studying every possible build. In the first instructed battle, learn one basic action and one support option rather than trying to master magic, drones and hacking together.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Mage Can't Fix the Payment Terminal

Shadowrun Returns put magic beside technology, and Rosa asked whether our hotel could adopt the combination. The card terminal had stopped responding while the manager insisted it was perfectly functional.

"Then function at it," she said.

I offered to cast something. Shawna gave me a look. Tank said, "Nigga, your last spell was asking the room to make you sexy. It opened the bill."

Mercedes wanted the murder investigation and the mixed crew, not another demonstration of my spiritual Wi-Fi. We settled around the screen while the manager fetched a different terminal.

The setting let unlike talents belong to the same job. I liked that. In our room, Rosa knew what she was owed, the technician knew the equipment, and Tank could identify food through a closed lid. I was still looking for my class.

Shawna leaned against me. "Occasionally useful husband." I chose it immediately. The advancement opportunities sounded excellent, and I already owned the necessary ring.

Aiden's verdict. The adult magic-and-corporate mystery may be worth its tactical menus; my chosen character class currently requires helping without announcing that a miracle has occurred.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes Seattle murder investigation, classless development and single-player turn-based tactical RPG. Waits refers to combat decisions; no complete no-hold or low-complexity certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/234650/>

P056 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Shadowrun: Dragonfall - Director's Cut

Edition considered: PC Director's Cut

Meet a Berlin crew with distinct histories and difficult loyalties, where relationships offer a substantial reward for learning Shadowrun's tactical systems.

What you do. Talk with the team, follow the first job, and choose tactical actions using character roles, equipment, and abilities across the campaign.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. This remains a reading-heavy tactical RPG; redesigned menus do not establish simplicity or settle every late mission's input demands.

Why it might click. Dragonfall brings Shadowrun's magic-and-technology world to Berlin and centers a crew with distinct personalities and histories. The Director's Cut expands the campaign and team material, making relationships and difficult loyalties a substantial reward for learning its tactical systems.

The full catch. This remains a reading-heavy tactical RPG with character builds, equipment and team abilities. Its redesigned interface is not evidence that menus are few or self-explanatory. The standalone Director's Cut differs from the earlier expansion; complete timing, held gestures and late mission demands have not been verified here.

Try this first. Meet the initial team and try a small portion of its first job, focusing on one character's role. Decide whether the conversations make you want to know these people before planning an optimized build or committing to every side mission.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Berlin Has Rejected My Crew Nicknames

Dragonfall gave us a crew with histories. I gave our friends new code names. Mercedes was The Voice. Tank was The Wall. Rosa was The Provider. Shawna was already leaving the conversation.

"Nigga, we got names," Tank said.

I explained that code names strengthened loyalty. Mercedes asked if The Provider had been paid. Rosa held up her phone. "She has now." That was a better origin story than mine.

The game's relationships worked because the people had reasons to remain themselves, not merely useful roles in somebody else's speech. Porsche chose a seat and asked about a character's past. We followed that instead of my naming ceremony.

Shawna returned with drinks. "What's your code name?" "The Legend." "The Leg End," Tank said, pointing at the sock exposed above my shoe. "Your trousers short, nigga."

I tugged them down and sat. The crew stayed loyal, apparently, but absolutely nobody agreed to maintain the dignity of command.

Aiden's verdict. If a developed crew and difficult loyalties appeal, Dragonfall offers reasons to learn its systems; our own crew has voted unanimously to keep its original names.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact Director's Cut page confirms standalone identity, Berlin, expanded missions/team material and revised combat/interface. No all-path timing/hold guarantee; mature themes include explicit violence and difficult backstories.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/300550/>

P057 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Shadowrun: Hong Kong - Extended Edition

Edition considered: PC Extended Edition

Explore a dense Hong Kong urban-fantasy setting with a developed crew and corporate intrigue, plus an additional campaign in the Extended Edition.

What you do. Read crew conversations, manage characters and inventory, and alternate tactical team encounters with the game's separate Matrix interactions during the campaign.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Matrix stealth and timed code or symbol elements prevent assuming the whole game waits; a comfortable complete route is unverified.

Why it might click. The third standalone Shadowrun adventure offers a dense urban fantasy setting, a developed crew and corporate intrigue in Hong Kong. Its Extended Edition includes the later bonus campaign, giving players who enjoy the characters more story beyond the original ending.

The full catch. Do not treat the whole game as unhurried because combat takes turns. Its Matrix has stealth and timed code/symbol-matching elements reported in gameplay documentation. A comfortable way through all required instances has not been verified. Text, character builds and inventory management are also heavy; this is a deliberate story-focused detour.

Try this first. Assess an early crew conversation and the character interface, then investigate the Matrix requirements before committing to the campaign. If someone offers help, agree which operations they would handle instead of quietly assuming every later obstacle will disappear.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P057 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Shadowrun: Hong Kong - Extended Edition

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Matrix Has Asked Me to Stop Guessing

Shadowrun: Hong Kong made the digital world look dangerous and complicated. My hotel television made entering a six-character access code look like a hostage negotiation.

I typed it wrong twice. Tank read the card. “That's a zero, nigga.” “Could be an O.” “Then ask it how it feels.”

Mercedes reminded us that this game's interface changes mattered; the Matrix sections weren't automatically comfortable just because other encounters used turns. I had nearly waved the distinction away with a grand statement about taking our time.

Shawna pointed at the actual catch. We left it where a reader could see it. No speech transformed it into a feature.

The television finally connected. On the screen, the crew and city still looked interesting. On my face, the expression of a man defeating a complex network concealed that he had simply copied the correct character.

Tank applauded once. “Hackerman.” Nigga made one clap sound like an entire review.

Aiden's verdict. Keep the rich setting available as a deliberate detour, with the Matrix demands clear; my own hacking career remains limited to reading the card correctly.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Extended Edition publisher page confirms revised Matrix and bonus campaign. Community gameplay documentation describes timed Matrix minigames; full-path alternatives are unverified, so no untimed completion is promised.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/346940/>

Source 2: <https://shadowrun-series.fandom.com/wiki/Matrix>

P058 / A PLACE TO START

Wildermyth

Edition considered: PC base game

Watch ordinary heroes acquire relationships, transformations, and lasting histories, creating a tactical adventure partly discovered through the consequences of your choices.

What you do. Meet the heroes, choose event responses, and direct battle actions while developing abilities and relationships; shared play can divide hero control.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Evolving characters and tactics require attention; injury and aging matter, and co-op still needs agreement about controls and decisions.

Why it might click. A band of initially ordinary heroes develops through tactical adventures, personal events and relationships. Characters can transform and carry their histories forward, giving the player a story that feels partly discovered through consequences rather than entirely delivered by a fixed cast.

The full catch. Tactical positioning, abilities, event choices and evolving characters all require attention. Injury, sacrifice and aging are part of the story. Native cooperative play can divide hero control, but setup and shared decisions still need agreement; it is not automatic simplification. Every input and late sequence has not been audited.

Try this first. Begin an introductory campaign and meet the first heroes before judging their long-term builds. Try one event choice and one battle action. If sharing play, agree who controls which hero and whether advice is invited.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Legend Came Back With a Different Haircut

Wildermyth let ordinary people acquire extraordinary histories. I said this described me perfectly. Mercedes asked which portion of my history involved ordinary behavior.

“Before fame.” “Before breakfast?” Tank offered.

Rosa liked that people could change through what happened to them. Shawna liked relationships carrying forward. I liked any system that might remember my achievements without needing me to announce them at dinner.

Porsche found a photograph from an earlier party where I had the same confident pose and an appalling haircut. She put it beside the screen. “Your legacy.”

“Nigga, that was a transition.” “Into what?” I had no response strong enough for the fringe.

The game could turn consequences into a shared story. Our group had been doing that for years, usually against my preferred version. Shawna kissed the side of my head and said the current haircut was much better.

Tank asked if we could recruit the old one as a monster. History is fucking cruel.

Aiden’s verdict. A company whose people change may be appealing, especially if shared play interests you; my personal legacy has survived everything except an accurately dated photograph.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports evolving heroes, tactical battles, difficulty choices and cooperative campaign play with separately controlled heroes. Memory rating is editorial; co-op does not guarantee reduced burden or complete input comfort.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/763890/>

P059 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Wartales

Edition considered: PC base game

Build a medieval company's survival story through contracts, camp life, skills, and equipment, with native co-op offering a way to share it.

What you do. Inspect party and camp menus, choose contracts, manage supplies and equipment, and use professions alongside tactical battles and world exploration.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Some professions use timed minigames; avoiding them throughout a chosen route is unverified, and party management is extensive.

Why it might click. Lead a band through a harsh medieval world, choosing contracts and gradually shaping its camp, skills and equipment. The appeal is the practical, emergent story of a company surviving together rather than fulfilling a single hero's destiny; native co-op can share that company.

The full catch. Food, money, gear, professions and tactical battles create extensive management. Some profession activities use timing-based minigames, so turn-based combat does not mean a completely untimed game. A whole-route way around those activities is unverified. Exploration and party maintenance add further demands; this is a marked detour.

Try this first. Inspect an opening party and camp menu before pursuing contracts. Check the specific profession interactions a chosen plan would need, and only then consider a short shared outing with clear agreement about who handles each operation.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Mercenaries Want Their Overtime

Wartales made running a company look like a story about food, equipment, and getting paid. Rosa pointed toward the catering crew. "Look, Aiden. Fantasy."

I tried to make a joke about loyal retainers. She gave me the shift schedule. The hired hosts needed an answer about overtime. They had been carrying things in my ridiculous jackets for hours.

I approved the time before asking for another favor. Tank nodded. "Nigga learning the order."

The game's mercenary life had appeal precisely because survival came through practical choices. It also had activities we couldn't pretend were all leisurely just because the battles used turns. Mercedes read the catch aloud while I finished the hotel adjustment.

One of the hosts took off his hot jacket with visible relief. Shawna said the crew looked better comfortable anyway. I agreed and resisted explaining how this supported my original vision.

Nigga, sometimes your finest command is letting people remove the thing you bought them.

Aiden's verdict. Company life may be compelling if its demands suit you, but the timing catches keep this a detour; our own mercenaries have secured overtime and breathable clothing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher confirms open-world company management, turn-based combat and up-to-four-player co-op. Gamepressure's profession guide describes timing minigames. Their complete avoidability has not been established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1527950/>

Source 2: <https://www.gamepressure.com/newsroom/professions-in-wartales-explained-list-and-description/zd543a>

P060 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Battle Brothers

Edition considered: PC base game

Lead a mercenary company through a harsh, unscripted world where recruitment, contracts, equipment, and battlefield outcomes create a history you can recognize.

What you do. Inspect recruits and gear, read contracts, travel across the world, and direct turn-based battles while paying wages and managing injuries.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. World travel is real-time while battles use turns; pause behavior needs checking, and harsh consequences accompany extensive management.

Why it might click. A mercenary company develops its own history through recruits, contracts, equipment and battles in a changing world. The appeal is a tough, unscripted campaign where decisions leave marks and a modest success can feel earned because failure remains possible.

The full catch. The publisher explicitly separates real-time world travel from turn-based battles. Roster management, wages, equipment, injuries and risk assessment are substantial. Harsh consequences can produce pressure even when battle decisions wait. Pause behavior during travel and every held-input requirement need checking; this is not a low-management fantasy adventure.

Try this first. Inspect a starting company's people and equipment, then read one contract's terms before accepting anything. Test travel controls and pausing deliberately. If the administrative burden already dominates the fun, another entry deserves the evening instead.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Battle Brothers and the Dinner They Deserve

Battle Brothers offered a mercenary company whose history could get ugly. Tank immediately asked whether I intended to name everybody after our friends and then get offended by consequences.

“Of course not.” Shawna looked at the recruit I'd named AIDEN THE EXCEPTIONAL. “Nigga, we haven't even started.”

I considered the equipment costs. Rosa smiled at the sudden respect entering my face. “Amazing what paying people yourself does for attention.”

The hard campaign interested Mercedes as a place where a little success might matter. It didn't interest everyone equally, and nobody had to join my imaginary battalion to remain welcome at dinner.

Tank renamed one recruit Tank. I asked whether that was vanity. “No. That's somebody who expects armor before a speech.”

I gave him decent gear and a sensible job. Then I moved my own recruit out of the most heroic-looking danger. Shawna squeezed my arm. “Exceptional decision, baby.” For once I accepted a compliment without enlarging it.

Aiden's verdict. Choose this harsh company story only if its complexity and losses sound enjoyable; my recruiting office has finally discovered that adequate equipment outranks an inspiring adjective.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes real-time travel, turn-based combat and mercenary contract/equipment management. Travel pause/hold details are not established here; strategic pressure is an editorial warning, not a seconds-timer claim.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/365360/>

P061 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

BATTLETECH

Edition considered: PC base game

Command giant combat machines in a mercenary company where personalities, damage, and tactical outcomes continue to matter after the battle ends.

What you do. Inspect a machine's movement and weapons, make battlefield choices, and manage loadouts, repairs, contracts, and the company's equipment between engagements.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Technical menus and economic consequences are substantial; listed competitive multiplayer does not establish a cooperative story campaign.

Why it might click. Command enormous combat machines while managing the mercenary company behind them. The attraction is the connection between personalities, damaged equipment and tactical decisions: a battle's outcome follows the crew back to a traveling base rather than vanishing at a results screen.

The full catch. Weapon loadouts, heat, armor, positioning, repairs and contracts create substantial technical and menu demands. Battles take turns, yet long engagements and economic consequences can still feel taxing. The publisher lists competitive multiplayer and solo skirmishes; do not infer cooperative campaign play from sharing a screen or discussing tactics.

Try this first. Try the opening instruction or a solo skirmish and inspect one machine's movement and weapon choices. Before accepting a company-wide campaign, decide whether reading its equipment information is an enjoyable part of the experience or simply too much administration.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The BattleMech Has a Massage Setting

BATTLETECH's huge machines made me proud of the mechanical throne I'd rented for photographs. Then the chair reclined with me in it and refused to come back up.

Tank bent over my face. "Nigga, your mech got defeated by leisure."

Shawna stood at my feet looking amused enough to end a marriage and attractive enough to restart it. "You comfortable?" "I could use assistance." "You've been asking for that position all evening."

Mercedes turned away laughing while I defended the honor of my upholstery.

The rental man found the control. The chair rose slowly, forcing everyone to watch me return to authority at the speed of an elderly drawbridge.

Onscreen, damaged machines came back with costs that affected their company. Mine came with a technician's fee and a recording Tank promised not to share unless I lied about it.

I immediately decided truth was a valuable principle. Nigga, operational expenses can make a philosopher out of anybody.

Aiden's verdict. The mercenary machines offer a compelling link between people, tactics, and repair bills; my prototype has demonstrated the risks of purchasing command furniture before checking reverse.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports turn-based mech combat, contracts, repairs, company management and solo skirmish/PvP modes. Complete held/camera interactions are not tested; no native co-op inferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/637090/>

P062 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

TRIANGLE STRATEGY

Edition considered: PC release

Explore political conflict where allies vote on major choices, making persuasion, scarce resources, and competing principles matter alongside tactical battles.

What you do. Read conversations, consider political choices, and direct units through positional battles while learning their abilities at a comfortable difficulty.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed input and adjustable difficulty support pacing, but dialogue, political names, tactics, and menus still demand substantial attention.

Why it might click. Political conflict, scarce resources and competing principles shape a story in which allies can vote on major choices. Tactical battles and conversations both matter, making the central attraction the tension between personal conviction, persuasion and the needs of a group.

The full catch. The PC listing declares play without timed input, adjustable difficulty and saving at any time. Those features help pacing but do not shrink the dialogue, political names, unit abilities or positional tactics. Expect a heavy reading and menu load; the story's moral weight may itself feel demanding.

Try this first. Choose a comfortable difficulty and follow an early conversation before testing one explained battle action. Pay attention to whether the political questions interest you enough to learn the surrounding systems; no vote of the Bureau can supply that interest.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Vote Says Pay Rosa First

TRIANGLE STRATEGY had people voting over consequential choices. I called a party vote on extending the room, funding the extra performance, or paying the remaining catering adjustment.

Rosa raised her hand. "One of those is already owed." Tank raised both hands. Mercedes asked why my debts had entered an election.

Shawna took the microphone. "We pay Rosa. Then we ask what people actually want." The room approved before I'd explained the voting procedure. Nigga, democracy was happening at an irresponsible speed.

In the game, competing convictions could make persuasion interesting. In our room, I had tried to disguise arithmetic as a moral dilemma because a ballot felt more impressive than opening my bank app.

I paid. Rosa checked. Then she voted to keep a quieter room available for whoever still wanted games. Mercedes seconded it. Tank promised to move the remaining food.

The plan passed without my dramatic tie-breaking intervention. I carried two chairs to feel connected to the constitutional process.

Aiden's verdict. The political decisions may be a strong attraction if the tactical load appeals; our local voting system excludes whether I should pay a bill I've already incurred.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports conviction/voting and tactical systems; current PC metadata declares no timed input, adjustable difficulty and Save Anytime. These are declarations, not independent full-path control validation.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1850510/>

P063 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Tactics Ogre: Reborn

Edition considered: PC Reborn edition

Follow Denam through factional conflict, where branching decisions connect personal loyalties with public consequences in a sustained tactical political fantasy.

What you do. Read the political situation, direct units through battle turns, and manage a roster's equipment, classes, and abilities as choices branch.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Reborn declares untimed input, but rosters and political names require learning; selection and camera comfort still need testing.

Why it might click. Denam's decisions unfold amid factional conflict in a kingdom shaped by past rule and renewed war. Branching story choices and tactical battles make the appeal a sustained political fantasy in which personal loyalties and public consequences rarely stay neatly separate.

The full catch. The current Reborn PC listing declares no timed input, mouse-only and keyboard-only options, and saving at any time. Even so, a large roster, equipment, classes, battle rules and political names demand substantial learning. Reborn's revised systems differ from earlier releases; comfortable selection and camera use still need testing.

Try this first. Read the opening situation and try one unit's basic turn without planning an entire army. Keep a small character note if useful, then decide whether the political intrigue makes the menus feel worthwhile rather than automatically accepting them as a toll.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Rebellion Has My Room Key

Tactics Ogre offered branching loyalties in a kingdom full of conflict. At the hotel, Shawna and Mercedes took our room key and declared the dressing room a territory free of my surprise announcements.

“Nigga, I'm being deposed.” “You're being given a chair,” Rosa said.

Tank considered both sides. My faction had promises. Theirs had dinner and a clear exit route. He crossed over without even pretending to negotiate. An ugly day for hereditary charm.

The game's political choices deserved more attention than my little domestic melodrama. I sat beside Rosa and listened while she considered a character's position. People could want different things without waiting for a hero to assign their motives.

When Shawna returned, she'd changed into shoes she could enjoy. “Miss me?” “Painfully.” “Good. You can dance without conducting a territorial survey.”

She led me out. The rebellion had secured comfortable footwear, privacy, and a husband who finally followed somebody else's route across the floor.

Aiden's verdict. A branching political fantasy may reward sustained attention, with its systems fully acknowledged; our palace revolt has achieved shoes, privacy, and an unexpectedly pleasant peace treaty.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Reborn listing supports branching story, revised tactical systems and developer-declared no timed input/Mouse Only/Keyboard Only/Save Anytime. Complexity assessment is editorial, not a clinical rating.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1451090/>

P064 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

FINAL FANTASY TACTICS - The Ivalice Chronicles

Edition considered: PC Enhanced version proposed for later assessment

Follow Ramza and Delita through Ivalice's struggle over class, power, and loyalty, with fully voiced dialogue in this edition's Enhanced version.

What you do. Choose Enhanced and Squire, then move characters and select battle actions while gradually learning jobs, equipment, and positioning during the story.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Squire lowers a barrier without removing tactical systems; Classic differs, and held-input or camera comfort has not been verified.

Why it might click. Ramza and Delita are drawn through a struggle over power, class and competing loyalties in Ivalice. This edition's Enhanced version adds fully voiced dialogue and refinements, offering a specific modern route into a substantial tactical story rather than an unspecified nostalgic recommendation.

The full catch. Use Enhanced with Squire difficulty for the proposed trial. That lowers a barrier but does not remove job systems, equipment, positioning or a large cast of names. The Classic version has different features. Complete held-input and camera comfort remain unverified, and a gentler setting does not make every battle simple.

Try this first. Select Enhanced and Squire, then follow the opening explanation through one character's movement and action. Read only the abilities immediately available before considering future job combinations; the first question is whether this turn feels understandable and interesting.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Ivalice Has No Place for My Platinum Package

FINAL FANTASY TACTICS brought class, loyalty, and power into our conversation. I had just offered three guests access to my “platinum” area, which was the same room behind a more expensive rope. Mercedes looked at it. “Nigga, the chairs identical.” “The exclusivity isn't.” “Neither is the bullshit.” Tank unhooked the rope because it obstructed Rosa's trolley. An entire social order collapsed under the practical requirements of potato service.

We checked the Enhanced version and the chosen difficulty before starting. Shawna wanted the voiced scenes heard properly. I stopped trying to narrate over them. The game's people had enough to argue about without a hotel aristocrat contributing from the sofa.

The sponsor asked what had happened to the platinum area. Rosa invited him to sit wherever there was space. He did, apparently surviving equality without an ambulance.

I coiled the rope and put it away. Nigga, even my velvet oppression had a restocking fee.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the specified Enhanced edition for this route into the political story; our own class system has been dismantled because its only distinctive feature blocked dinner.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Square Enix's current official page confirms exact title, Enhanced/Classic distinction, voiced Enhanced dialogue and Squire difficulty. Job/ability complexity is documented; complete no-hold/camera comfort is not.

Source 1: <https://final-fantasy-tactics-the-ivalice-chronicles.square-enix-games.com/en-us>

P065 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Disgaea 5 Complete

Edition considered: PC Complete edition

Enjoy an extravagant demonic rebellion where huge numbers and unusual combinations make increasingly elaborate systems part of the comedy and attraction.

What you do. Try the opening move-and-act battle loop, then gradually explore jobs, items, special mechanics, and customization if those systems become enjoyable.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The Complete edition adds extensive material and deep systems; turn-based decisions do not make its menu or memory burden light.

Why it might click. Disgaea 5 turns tactical role-playing into an extravagant comic machine of demons, rebellion, huge numbers and unusual combinations. Its appeal is enjoying systems that become increasingly ridiculous, with a cast and world equally happy to push beyond ordinary fantasy restraint.

The full catch. The Complete edition contains extensive added material and many deep systems: jobs, items, special battle mechanics and customization. That is a major menu and memory burden, not a promise of more effortless entertainment. Turn-based decisions help pacing, but the publisher's abundance is exactly the catch for someone wanting few systems.

Try this first. Try only the opening explanation and a basic battle action. Leave bonus scenarios and long-term optimization alone until the fundamental move-and-act loop feels enjoyable; there is no requirement to consume everything included in the word Complete.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Netherworld Has a Two-Drink Minimum

Disgaea 5 made extravagant demonic power look almost modest beside the invoice from my party decorator. I showed Tank the total. He whistled. "Nigga, you unlocked the final boss."

Darnell arrived boasting that his yacht parties used bigger numbers. Mercedes asked whether those numbers came with guests who let other people finish a sentence. He began explaining his premium cocaine. "Still the same sentence," she said, and turned back to the game.

I liked the ridiculous scale until the menus made it clear the systems also expected attention. Shawna read a choice twice. I wisely refrained from saying it was simple.

Tank wanted a demon powerful enough to negotiate the catering minimum. Rosa said her minimum was already reasonable and had survived stronger demons than him.

The game could keep its enormous combinations. We kept one manageable question on the screen. Darnell went to tell the bartender about his yacht, and the bartender charged him for the privilege of remaining nearby.

Aiden's verdict. Embrace this excess if elaborate systems themselves sound fun; our party has confirmed that large numbers are entertaining right up until they appear beside my signature.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Complete listing documents included scenarios, jobs, customization and multiple strategic systems. Waits is tactical decision pacing; no full-path no-hold or low-menu claim is made.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/803600/>

P066 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Disgaea 7: Vows of the Virtueless

Edition considered: PC base game

Follow a reluctant fighter and enthusiastic client through demonic comic excess, where oversized transformations turn tactical possibilities into increasingly unreasonable spectacle.

What you do. Learn movement and attacks, select targets through PC menus, and explore character classes, items, and special battle mechanics as interest grows.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Systems remain dense, and auto-battle unlocks only after completing each stage; it is not a verified first-pass story bypass.

Why it might click. A reluctant fighter and an enthusiastic client anchor a demonic tactical adventure with exaggerated powers and comic excess. New systems such as oversized combat transformations fit a series whose appeal includes seeing a seemingly sensible strategy become gloriously unreasonable.

The full catch. The PC publisher specifically supports keyboard/mouse menu and target selection, but the many classes, items and mechanics remain dense. Auto-battle unlocks after successfully completing each stage; it is not a verified first-pass story bypass. Turn-based structure does not settle every held-input requirement or make the management light.

Try this first. Learn the first battle's ordinary movement and attack before opening every customization possibility. Test whether the PC menu and target controls feel clear, and judge the cast's humor separately from the attraction of increasingly elaborate numerical combinations.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Giant Demon Cannot Fit Through the Ballroom Door

Disgaea 7's oversized transformations reminded me of the inflatable mascot waiting in its crate. I told the operator to bring it in. He asked about the door width.

"It's a large door." "How large?" Nigga, professionals kept ruining imagination with measurements.

Tank found the dimensions on the label. The thing wouldn't fit. Mercedes asked whether I'd planned to demolish a wall before or after her set. Shawna touched my arm. "Baby, keep one huge thing about yourself imaginary."

I opened my mouth. She smiled. "Choose your response carefully." I closed it. Tank had to leave the room to laugh properly.

The game could make excess part of a complicated tactical playground. My mascot could remain deflated without sacrificing anyone's evening. Rosa used the cleared space for a serving table.

The operator thanked us for canceling before inflation. I paid him and accepted that, in this particular story, refusing to become enormous was my most impressive transformation.

Aiden's verdict. The demonic spectacle belongs with an appetite for its layered systems; my own giant transformation has been canceled because the door and my wife presented persuasive objections.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Base PC listing supports Fuji/Pirilika, Jumbification, keyboard/mouse menu controls and auto-battle unlocked by completed stages. No complete-edition extras, unconditional autoplay or hold-free guarantee is inferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2250600/>

P067 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Chained Echoes

Edition considered: PC release

Travel with an ensemble across a war-torn world of dragons and machines, with political trouble and personal stories sustaining the journey.

What you do. Move through the world, read the cast's story, and select turn-based battle actions while learning skills and managing equipment along the way.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The publisher describes complex skills and equipment; directional movement may require holds, and every potential timing question is not settled.

Why it might click. An ensemble crosses a war-torn continent in a fantasy world that mixes dragons and machines with a deliberate older-RPG visual style. The appeal is a long journey through varied places, with character stories and political trouble giving the travels a continuing purpose.

The full catch. The publisher explicitly describes a complex skill and equipment system. Turn-based battles permit choosing actions, while exploration still requires directional movement and may involve sustained inputs. Visible enemies replace random encounters, but that does not eliminate combat, navigation demands or every potential timing question across the whole story.

Try this first. Follow the opening until you can test one movement segment and one explained battle choice. Read the currently useful skill information, then decide whether the cast and world make further systems learning attractive rather than assuming retro-looking graphics mean retro-sized complexity.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Airship Is a Minibus With a Deposit

Chained Echoes mixed dragons and machines, so I asked whether our shuttle could be decorated as an airship. The driver said decoration was extra and wings couldn't extend over the mirrors.

Tank looked at me. "Nigga, people just need a ride home."

Mercedes wanted to follow the ensemble across its world. I wanted our transport to support the theme. Rosa wanted the driver to know who actually needed a ride and when. She made a list while I negotiated imaginary aviation.

Shawna slipped the brochure out of my hand. "Want to take me somewhere?" I said absolutely. She pointed at the dance floor, six steps away and entirely without fuel requirements.

We danced while the driver confirmed the actual route with Rosa. The game kept its large journey. Our party secured the modest miracle of people going where they'd asked to go.

Tank watched us pass. "Look at this nigga finally transporting somebody." I spun my wife gently and let him have the line.

Aiden's verdict. The ensemble journey may justify learning the battles if its world appeals; our local transport now promises correct destinations, which has outperformed the proposed dragon decal.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports story-driven ensemble journey, visible enemies, turn-based battles and complex equipment/skills. Held movement and complete path comfort are unverified; no all-game no-timer claim.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1229240/>

P068 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Sea of Stars

Edition considered: PC base game

Join companions in a colorful sun-and-moon fantasy adventure, with local cooperative story play available through the Dawn of Equinox update.

What you do. Move through the world, inspect difficulty and relic options, and choose battle actions that include timed hits during the companions' journey.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Timed hits are real, including in co-op; a complete route avoiding every timed or held action has not been established.

Why it might click. A colorful, classically inspired role-playing journey follows Solstice Warriors through a world of sun-and-moon magic. The combination of scenery, companions and adventure is the attraction; the Dawn of Equinox update also makes the story available in local cooperative play.

The full catch. Timed hits are a real combat mechanic, including in co-op. The developer documents difficulty presets and relic adjustments, but this research does not establish a complete path avoiding every timed or held action. Movement and traversal require separate checks. Treat it as a deliberate detour rather than assuming turn-based means entirely unrushed.

Try this first. Inspect the installed version's difficulty and relic explanations, then test movement and one early battle with no expectation of perfect timing. If the required operations already conflict with preferences, enjoy the premise and choose another route without a mastery assignment.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Moon Has No Interest in My Pool Speech

Sea of Stars made me suggest moving everyone beside the rooftop pool for celestial atmosphere. Shawna looked at the stairs. Mercedes looked at her equipment. Rosa looked at the food.

“Nigga,” Tank said, “you move the sun.”

We stayed where we were. The screen could provide its scenery without making seven adults carry dinner through a lift. I checked the updated shared-play information and the timing catches before proposing who might join whom.

Dre, our new grown guest in a blue shirt, raised his controller. “This one's still mine.” I respected the claim. He had also brought a casserole, which gave him more material authority than my rented sky projector.

Shawna leaned against me as the game's companions began their journey. “There,” she said. “Stars without moving the room.”

I looked up at my projector, switched off and unnecessary. Nigga, it had cost money to learn that a screen could already display a sky.

Aiden's verdict. The journey may be appealing, including its supported shared play, but timed inputs still need attention; our celestial outing has wisely remained beside the existing chairs.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer describes original story with Dawn of Equinox's up-to-three-player local co-op, timed hits and difficulty presets. This assesses that updated base adventure, not the OST or unverified Sunset Edition changes. Complete no-timed/hold path unknown.

Source 1: <https://sabotagestudio.com/press-release/sabotage-studio-announces-free-sea-of-stars-update-dawn-of-equinox-bringing-top-fan-requested-additions-to-pc-and-consoles-gains-november-release-date/>

P069 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

OCTOPATH TRAVELER II

Edition considered: PC release

Choose among eight protagonists with distinct motives, then discover how their different beginnings and an expanding cast relate within one shared world.

What you do. Follow a chosen traveler's opening, select battle actions, and manage jobs, equipment, movement, and character abilities as the wider journey develops.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed input is declared, but eight stories and battle systems add memory load; comfortable directional holds remain a separate question.

Why it might click. Eight protagonists bring separate motivations and talents to a shared world, with stories that can be approached through different beginnings. The attraction is choosing a person who catches your interest, then discovering how an expanding cast and their journeys relate.

The full catch. The PC listing declares play without timed input, but battles still use several interacting systems and the wider journey includes movement, jobs, equipment and distinct character abilities. Remembering eight stories can become substantial. Directional hold comfort remains a separate question even when battle selections wait.

Try this first. Choose one traveler because the premise appeals, read that opening, and learn one ordinary battle action. Keep the next step attached to that character before treating the whole ensemble as a single large list of unfinished obligations.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Eight Travelers and One Nigga Blocking the Door

OCTOPATH TRAVELER II offered eight different beginnings. I offered our guests eight suggested itineraries for the rest of the evening. Mercedes chose a ninth: ignoring mine.

Rosa wanted to finish dinner. Tank wanted another look at a battle. Shawna wanted music. Porsche wanted five quiet minutes. Dre wanted to find the lid for his casserole. Darnell wanted an audience. The bartender wanted Darnell to order something.

Nigga, my room had become an ensemble without consulting its narrator.

I watched the game's distinct people make separate reasons for beginning. Then I stepped out of the actual doorway so my own people could do the same. Nobody needed to form a party behind me whenever I moved.

Shawna came back for my hand. "You coming?" "Where?" "With me, if you want."

A whole night of selling routes, and the best invitation had eight words and no package price. I took her hand. Tank found the casserole lid and achieved a different happy ending.

Aiden's verdict. Pick a protagonist whose motives interest you and let the systems follow at a tolerable pace; our guests have already demonstrated the advantages of choosing their own beginnings.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing supports eight travelers, Path Actions, jobs and Break/Boost; developer declares no timed input. Mixed label reflects active exploration alongside waiting battle decisions, not a contradicted timer claim. Hold comfort unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1971650/>

P070 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

DRAGON QUEST XI S: Echoes of an Elusive Age - Definitive Edition

Edition considered: PC Definitive Edition

Join an accused hero and growing band of companions in a colorful identity-searching adventure, with both personal backstories and traditional turn-based battles.

What you do. Inspect presentation choices, move through the world, and choose party actions while managing equipment and abilities across a long companion-filled story.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The 3D camera, directional holds, and optional minigames need checking; the 2D option is not an instant universal solution.

Why it might click. A young hero accused of being a threat gathers companions and searches for the truth of his identity. The appeal is a substantial, colorful adventure with personal backstories and a traditional turn-based battle structure; this edition also includes a two-dimensional presentation option.

The full catch. Party equipment, abilities, navigation and a long story create a meaningful memory load. The 3D presentation brings camera demands; trying 2D may change that burden but is not a universal solution or instant switch at every moment. Directional holds and optional minigame timing remain separate checks.

Try this first. Inspect the Definitive Edition's presentation choices and begin without extra Draconian challenge settings. Try ordinary movement and one early turn-based battle, judging both the immediate controls and whether the companions' tone makes a long adventure sound inviting.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P070 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

DRAGON QUEST XI S: Echoes of an Elusive Age - Definitive Edition

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Chosen One Has Been Asked to Validate Parking

DRAGON QUEST XI S introduced a hero whose identity brought trouble. The hotel manager introduced me to three guests whose parking needed validating. Recognition had consequences everywhere.

“Nigga, I thought you wanted your name known,” Tank said.

I validated the tickets and came back to a world colorful enough to make my decorations look needlessly literal. Shawna wanted to meet the companions. Rosa asked which presentation we were actually considering. We checked instead of pretending every version worked the same way.

I said I identified with a misunderstood chosen one. Mercedes looked at the tickets in my hand. “Chosen by the valet. Important calling.”

Tank gave me one more. His car had been outside since lunch. I considered protesting, then remembered he'd caught me near a pond, moved three pieces of furniture, and saved my shrimp tower.

The grand adventure could wait while I performed one small quest for my friend. Nigga even gave me directions to the desk.

Aiden's verdict. A long companion-filled adventure may be worth exploring in the specified edition; my chosen-one duties currently include appreciating the friends who keep my evening upright.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact XI S Definitive page confirms 2D/3D modes, companions, turn-based combat and optional Draconian challenges. Mode-switch limits and full input/timing comfort are not fully verified; no original-XI assumptions.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1295510/>

P071 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Persona 5 Royal

Edition considered: PC Royal edition

Spend time with a stylish ensemble whose daily relationships connect to a supernatural struggle against abusive power, supported by striking music and presentation.

What you do. Read conversations, plan calendar choices and relationships, explore dungeons, and select combat actions while following the ensemble's long character story.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Required later countdowns and timed traversal conflict with strict no-rush needs; menus, calendar planning, and camera handling add complexity.

Why it might click. A stylish ensemble of students balances daily relationships with a supernatural campaign against abusive power. Royal offers an extensive character story with striking music and presentation, making the desire to spend time with its cast entirely understandable even when its systems are demanding.

The full catch. This is a detour for a strict no-rush preference. Royal walkthroughs document a required later boss with a thirty-minute countdown, alongside timed traversal elsewhere. Ordinary turn-based combat does not erase those exceptions. Calendar choices, relationship planning, combat menus, dungeon movement and camera handling create additional complexity.

Try this first. Judge the opening conversations and presentation, but keep the late countdown warning in the decision from the start. Establish a deliberate shared-viewing or help arrangement before investing in a long campaign if those required operations are unacceptable alone.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P071 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Persona 5 Royal

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Phantom Thief Stole My Schedule

Persona 5 Royal had a stylish group navigating relationships and a packed calendar. I held up our party schedule. Mercedes took it and tore off the section marked UNEXPECTED AIDEN MOMENT.

“How it unexpected if you wrote it down, nigga?” Tank asked.

Shawna wanted the story considered honestly, including the bits that actually used a timer. I read the warning before praising the turn-based combat as though that described every second of the game. The music was attractive enough without me selling away the catch.

Rosa put my remaining schedule beside the plates. “People will do what they want.” “There was a closing toast.” “There was a man who promised to sit down.”

I sat. The calendar in the game could create pressure and possibility. Ours no longer had to.

Mercedes pocketed the torn strip. I asked if she was stealing my moment. “Saving it from you,” she said. Nigga, very efficient phantom work in a visible red dress.

Aiden’s verdict. Keep the characters available as a deliberate detour, with the required timed encounter plainly stated; our real calendar has lost one oppressive event and gained breathing room.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Royal PC listing supports premise. Royal-specific walkthroughs corroborate required Okumura time limits; no PC option removing them was verified. Story interest is separated from full-route suitability.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1687950/>

Source 2: <https://gamefaqs.gamespot.com/ps4/260936-persona-5-royal/faqs/78256/week-24-october-1st-october-9th-okumuras-palace>

Source 3: https://www.neoseeker.com/persona-5-royal/Okumura%27s_Space_Station

P072 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

BRAVELY DEFAULT II

Edition considered: PC release

Travel with four heroes through a crystal-centered fantasy, using a battle rhythm that asks when to save actions and when to commit them.

What you do. Learn an ordinary attack and Default, observe the next turn, and combine jobs, abilities, and equipment as the adventure develops.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed input is declared, but Brave Points and jobs create heavy tactics; directional control may still require uncomfortable holds.

Why it might click. Four heroes undertake a crystal-centered fantasy journey with jobs and abilities that can be combined in different ways. The signature battle idea is deciding when to store action capacity and when to spend it, creating a recognizable rhythm of preparation and commitment.

The full catch. The PC publisher declares play without timed input and adjustable difficulty. That helps pace, while Brave Points, primary and secondary jobs, equipment and enemy behavior still create a heavy tactical load. Exploration requires directional control; a no-timed-input declaration does not establish that movement is comfortable without holds.

Try this first. Choose a comfortable difficulty and learn one ordinary attack and one Default action in the early guidance. Observe what changes on the next turn before planning elaborate job combinations or trying to bank an entire party's future at once.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / I Saved Three Speeches and Spent Them All at Dinner

BRAVELY DEFAULT II made saving and spending actions sound strategic. I told Shawna I'd saved up three compliments for her and planned to deploy them together.

"Try one that isn't about how lucky I am." Nigga, she had seen my opening hand.

Tank liked the idea of storing something now for a bigger move later. He had done it with dinner rolls and was prepared to demonstrate. Rosa removed the bread basket from his reach before theory became a siege.

At the screen, committing actions involved a real choice rather than simply doing the biggest thing available. I considered that while my wife waited for the first compliment.

"You look like you chose tonight for yourself," I said. "And I'm glad I get to be here." She softened. No joke for a second. Then she kissed me and said the other two could remain in reserve.

Tank whispered, "Nigga finally learned economy." I let him keep his roll.

Aiden's verdict. The store-and-spend rhythm may make battles interesting if you enjoy job systems; my own resources improved dramatically when I stopped spending three sentences on one feeling.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing explains Brave/Default, jobs and four heroes; developer declares no timed input and adjustable difficulty. Mixed pace distinguishes exploration from waiting decisions, not a claim of required timers. Holds untested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1446650/>

P073 / A PLACE TO START

Slay the Spire

Edition considered: PC original game

Build a deck from limited choices, enjoying the moment a useful card-and-relic combination gives the next encounter a different shape.

What you do. Read attack and defensive cards, spend available energy, and choose cards or relics that develop a plan across the climb's encounters.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Card effects and energy require reading and planning; test targeting gestures, and expect losing runs as part of the structure.

Why it might click. Build a deck while climbing a changing sequence of encounters, choosing cards and relics that make the next fight play differently. The appeal is recognizing a useful combination and gradually shaping a plan from imperfect, limited choices rather than executing a fixed routine.

The full catch. The developer declares play without timed input, mouse-only play and saving at any time. Card text, energy, status effects and deck interactions still demand reading and planning. Test card selection and targeting for drag or hold comfort; losing a run is part of the structure, not evidence that the trial was wasted.

Try this first. Begin with the first available character and examine one attack card and one defensive card before playing either. Try one encounter and judge whether the tradeoff is satisfying without aiming to finish the entire climb on the first visit.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Spire Doesn't Accept My Guest List

Slay the Spire offered me cards and imperfect choices. I asked Tank whether we could improve my opening selection. He said we could improve many things if I stopped assuming the best option was owed to me.

“Nigga, is this advice or cards?” “Two services. Same friend.”

Mercedes noticed a combination I had missed while admiring the name of a card. Rosa wanted to know what an effect actually did before choosing it. Shawna leaned close enough to distract me and then enjoyed watching me pretend the distraction was tactical.

I built toward one idea instead of taking everything that looked impressive. The deck became more coherent. My party, by comparison, still contained an unemployed fog machine and a gold statue nobody would stand beside voluntarily.

Tank tapped the screen. “You learning.” I started describing my instinct for restraint. He pointed at the next choice.

Nigga had found the perfect counter to my speech: another decision worth thinking about.

Aiden's verdict. Try building combinations if that kind of thinking feels rewarding; my deck may achieve the focused identity that our party lost when I approved decorative marine life.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Original PC game listing supports deckbuilding/roguelike structure and declares Mouse Only, no timed input and Save Anytime. Card manipulation comfort and full-path suitability are not independently verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/646570/>

P074 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Monster Train

Edition considered: PC original game

Defend a train through stacked battle spaces, where choosing a creature's floor can matter as much as choosing the next card.

What you do. Place units on floors, play spells, and develop the deck through upgrades while defending the train across an ordinary solo run.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Exclude clock-driven Hell Rush from this trial; floor placement and card effects remain complex, with drag comfort unverified.

Why it might click. Defend a train across stacked battle spaces by combining units, spells and upgrades into a developing deck. The vertical layout changes the familiar card-battle question: where a creature stands can matter as much as which card is played next.

The full catch. Use an ordinary solo run for this proposal. The publisher explicitly describes Hell Rush multiplayer as a real-time, clock-driven competition, so exclude it from a no-rush trial. Multiple floors, unit placement, card upgrades and interacting effects still create a substantial mental load; dragging and held-input behavior require checking.

Try this first. Open a solo run and inspect one unit's placement and one spell before advancing the fight. Keep attention on the immediate floor arrangement; there is no need to plan a perfect deck or enter any competitive challenge to understand the attraction.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Train Has Three Floors and No VIP Rope

Monster Train's stacked battle spaces made me propose a hierarchy for our hotel rooms. Tank asked whether the top floor had better food. Rosa said all the food was downstairs with her.

“Then that's the top, nigga.”

Mercedes considered where a unit belonged rather than merely how impressive it looked. I had put a decorative throne beside the narrowest doorway for exactly the opposite reason. Shawna pointed this out without even leaving her chair.

We checked that we were considering the ordinary solo route rather than the special timed mode. The train had enough to think about without borrowing pressure from somewhere else.

I moved the throne out of the doorway. Two guests passed comfortably, which Tank described as an unprecedented transit victory for my administration. Rosa brought drinks through without turning sideways.

Onscreen, a placement made the next encounter work better. In the room, another placement did the same. Nigga, transportation theory had finally reached my rented furniture.

Aiden's verdict. The vertical card battles may offer satisfying choices; stay clear of the timed mode for this trial, and place the attractive furniture where people can pass it.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Original-game publisher page supports three vertical fields/deckbuilding and explicitly identifies Hell Rush as timed real-time multiplayer. Waits applies to the proposed ordinary solo mode, not all modes; holds remain unchecked.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1102190/>

P075 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Griftlands

Edition considered: PC release

Navigate a rough science-fiction world where separate conversation and combat decks make negotiations, alliances, and grudges matter mechanically as well as narratively.

What you do. Read negotiation or combat cards, choose them in encounters, and manage relationships whose effects can follow the protagonist into later situations.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Two decks and relationship consequences require substantial text and tracking; every gesture or possible timing exception has not been audited.

Why it might click. Three separate protagonists navigate a rough science-fiction world through fights, negotiations and relationships. Maintaining different decks for talking and combat makes social encounters mechanically substantial, while choices about allies and enemies can follow the character into later situations.

The full catch. Two decks, relationship effects, faction loyalties and run-based consequences make this more demanding than a small casual card game. Considerable text explains abilities and social stakes. Turn-based card decisions support deliberation, but no full-path guarantee about every gesture or timing exception has been independently established.

Try this first. Start the opening character's story and read one negotiation card in context before building a grand strategy. Try one exchange, observing both what the card does and why the other person cares, then decide whether managing conversation this way is enjoyable.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Negotiation Deck Is All Apologies

Griftlands made talking and fighting separate kinds of encounters. I asked Shawna which deck I was best at. She said neither and suggested a third deck labeled LISTEN.

The sponsor wanted one more photograph. Mercedes wanted to leave the stage without selling a drink. I offered a compromise in which he stood beside me instead. He looked disappointed. Nigga, I discovered my market value in real time.

Tank watched us negotiate. "Play the card where you stop making promises." I did. The sponsor took a photograph of the room and moved on. Everybody survived the absence of my brilliant settlement.

The game could make relationships and chosen approaches matter in a satisfying way. Our party had done the same with less visible machinery and more snacks.

Shawna took my hand. "Good talk." "I barely spoke." "Exactly." She kissed me before I could spoil my winning play by explaining it. Nigga, the LISTEN deck had excellent rewards.

Aiden's verdict. If relationships changing both conversations and conflicts appeal, investigate this layered card game; my strongest negotiation now consists of an accurate promise followed by a closed mouth.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports three campaigns, separate negotiation/combat decks and persistent social consequences. Waits describes core card decisions; held gestures and complete-path exceptions have not been tested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/601840/>

P076 / A PLACE TO START

Dicey Dungeons

Edition considered: PC release

Enter an absurd dungeon game show as walking dice, turning rolled numbers into equipment effects and small tactical puzzles with lively presentation.

What you do. Read an equipment requirement, assign a rolled die, and observe its effect before choosing another placement or continuing through the dungeon.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Arithmetic and equipment conditions require thought; test placement gestures, and begin with the initial character before learning different rule sets.

Why it might click. Walking dice face a peculiar dungeon game show, turning rolled numbers into attacks and other equipment effects. Different characters change the rules enough to make a familiar-looking die produce very different little tactical problems, with lively art and music supporting the absurdity.

The full catch. Equipment conditions, arithmetic and random outcomes require thought; later characters change the rules substantially. Turn-based play is the core, but placing dice may involve dragging or other gestures worth testing. Begin with the initial character rather than treating every class or bonus episode as equally simple.

Try this first. Use the first available character and try assigning one die to one piece of equipment. Read the requirement, observe the result, and judge the placement gesture before considering a whole dungeon or a different character with an entirely new rule system.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Dice Have Better Contracts Than the Host

Dicey Dungeons put walking dice inside a peculiar game show. I immediately offered to host one in the ballroom. Mercedes asked what the contestants won.

“An unforgettable experience.” “Cash value, nigga.”

Tank held up a bread roll as his buzzer. Rosa refused to let me turn dinner into a compulsory contest. Shawna asked whether the contestants could simply play the actual game while I remained seated. A severe format revision, but the audience seemed enthusiastic.

We looked at what the dice could do in the available equipment. The ordinary act of choosing where a number belonged became more interesting than my proposed theme tune.

I rolled a hotel mint between my fingers. Tank caught it when I dropped it and said I'd lost the appetizer round. Rosa awarded him nothing because he already had dinner.

The actual dungeon show continued without any need for a rented spotlight. My contract was canceled after a pilot episode consisting entirely of people refusing the premise.

Aiden's verdict. The absurd dice-and-equipment puzzle may be a cheerful trial if the handling suits you; our live game show has failed its audience test before anybody lost dinner.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer store supports characters/equipment; official project wiki describes turn-based dice allocation. Drag/hold alternatives and every episode are not verified; recommendation targets the initial character's basic loop.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/861540/>

Source 2: https://wiki.diceydungeons.com/doku.php?id=dicey_dungeons

P077 / A PLACE TO START

Balatro

Edition considered: PC base game

Turn familiar-looking poker hands into a changing score puzzle, where Jokers and modifiers can make a modest combination unexpectedly powerful.

What you do. Build a recognizable hand, read Joker effects, and select or arrange cards to improve the combination for the next scoring target.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed mouse play is declared, but scoring modifiers and boss rules add memory demands; selection and rearrangement gestures need testing.

Why it might click. Poker-like hands become ingredients in a single-player score-building puzzle, transformed by Jokers and other modifiers. The attraction is watching a modest combination become unexpectedly powerful and deciding how each new card changes the plan for the next target.

The full catch. The developer declares play without timed input and mouse-only play. Hand recognition, scoring modifiers, changing boss rules and reading several effects at once still take attention. Card rearrangement and selection need a gesture check; a familiar deck does not mean all the surrounding rules are familiar or memory-light.

Try this first. Try the opening explanation and build one clearly recognized hand. Read one Joker's effect in plain language before buying or arranging a complicated combination, then decide whether discovering the score interaction feels satisfying rather than like unwanted arithmetic homework.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Joker Knows My Entire Financial History

Balatro reached the screen while we were still inside a casino hotel, which made Darnell announce that he'd teach us all how to win money. Mercedes pointed at the game. "Different thing."

"Same instinct." "Your instinct just paid eighteen dollars for water, nigga."

I admired a Joker that changed how a familiar hand mattered. Tank admired the possibility of me finally reading the explanation instead of gambling on my personality. Shawna asked what one modifier did. We checked it together before adding another.

The pleasure was in building a score-making idea, not inviting Darnell to become our investment adviser. He attempted one more yacht comparison. Rosa asked him to carry an empty tray. He discovered an urgent call elsewhere.

I played a hand and watched the result. A small combination had become interesting through its actual effects. Behind us the casino flashed and chimed. For once I didn't need to make either kind of noise myself.

Aiden's verdict. Explore the changing combinations if score puzzles appeal; this game does not appoint the loudest yacht owner as a financial adviser, despite his persistent application.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact base listing supports poker-inspired deckbuilding, Jokers and developer-declared no timed input/Mouse Only. No real-money gambling claim or guaranteed hold-free card manipulation is made.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2379780/>

P078 / A PLACE TO START

Cobalt Core

Edition considered: PC release

Meet a small spaceship crew caught in a time-loop mystery, using card choices to reposition the ship as well as attack.

What you do. Inspect incoming fire, play movement or attack cards, and shift along one line to avoid shots or align weapons during encounters.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Crew decks, ship layout, and incoming fire interact; gesture comfort and the full sequence of encounters remain untested.

Why it might click. A small crew's personalities and a time-loop mystery sit inside spaceship card battles. Moving along a single line makes positioning part of the card choice: avoiding a shot or lining up a weapon can matter as much as adding more damage.

The full catch. Crew decks, ship layout, incoming fire and upgrades create interacting information to track. The publisher invites play at one's own pace, but gesture comfort and the complete sequence of encounters are not independently tested. This is a card-driven tactical game, not a reflex flying game, yet it still requires attentive planning.

Try this first. Inspect one incoming attack and one movement card during the opening guidance. See what shifting the ship changes before building a multi-card sequence, then decide whether the crew's banter gives you a reason to explore another encounter.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Our Time Loop Ends When Tank Finishes the Story

Cobalt Core had a crew caught in a time-loop mystery. Tank had a story about me losing my hotel key that he kept beginning again whenever someone new arrived.

"Nigga, they heard it." "Not from the part where you accused your own pocket."

Mercedes wanted to know how a card changed the ship's position. We watched one move and understood why location mattered. I wanted to know how to move Tank into a different conversation without wasting a friendship.

Shawna supplied the answer by asking him about his own locked-car incident. Rosa smiled immediately. The timeline developed fresh material. Tank pointed at me. "That nigga wasn't even there."

"Neither were half the people hearing my key story."

At the screen, small shifts changed what could hit whom. Around the table, one well-placed question accomplished the same thing. We laughed, then returned to the crew and its problem. My keys remained visible on the table, where history could no longer frame my trousers.

Aiden's verdict. The crew and positioning cards may make a focused, interesting combination; our local time loop has been interrupted by allowing more than one friend to be embarrassing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports card-driven single-axis combat, crew stories and playing at one's pace. No continuous-action flight claim; complete hold/gesture comfort remains unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2179850/>

P079 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Wildfrost

Edition considered: PC release

Build a companion-card group in a frozen world, enjoying how a carefully chosen move can change attacks several turns into the future.

What you do. Read friendly and enemy counters, place companion cards, and choose moves that alter positioning, effects, and the order of upcoming actions.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Counters measure turns rather than seconds, but attack order and survival demand planning; card-placement comfort still needs checking.

Why it might click. Build a traveling group of companion cards in a frozen world, arranging their effects and attacks to work together. The distinctive pleasure is planning around visible action counters, so that a carefully chosen move changes what happens several turns later.

The full catch. The counters measure turns until actions, not a requirement to click within seconds. Even so, attack order, positioning, status effects and companion survival can be demanding, and a cute appearance does not predict an easy run. Card placement gestures and all-path input comfort remain checks rather than verified assurances.

Try this first. Read one friendly counter and one enemy counter, then use the opening guidance to observe what advances them. Try predicting only the next action before attempting a long chain of effects or comparing every possible leader and deck.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Frozen World Has My Ice Sculpture

Wildfrost appeared beside a melting ice sculpture I had ordered before asking what anybody wanted to look at. It was supposed to be an eagle. By dinner it looked like a wet chicken accusing me.

Tank read the delivery tag. “Nigga, you paid extra for wings.”

Rosa put a tray underneath while Mercedes studied the game's counters. Those numbers measured moves, not seconds; I didn't get to flatten every kind of pressure into the same claim. The ice, meanwhile, had a genuine relationship with real time and my carpet deposit.

Shawna asked the hotel to remove it. I tried to save the head. It detached in my hand. My wife stared at me holding a bird's slippery face in evening clothes.

“Still majestic?” she asked. “From this angle.”

Tank took one photograph before helping carry the tray. Onscreen, planning several actions ahead looked valuable. Beside it, the consequences of planning none at all dripped steadily onto my shoe.

Aiden's verdict. The companion combinations may reward planning around turn counters; the only unavoidable countdown in our immediate surroundings belonged to my increasingly liquid attempt at grandeur.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher explicitly explains turn-based battles and counters measured in turns. This distinguishes counters from real-time deadlines; no low-difficulty or hold-free promise is inferred from visual style.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1811990/>

P080 / A PLACE TO START

Clubhouse Games: 51 Worldwide Classics

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch; individual games must be assessed separately

Find one enjoyable little ritual within a collection of distinct board, card, and other games, each offering its own in-game explanation.

What you do. Start with Four in a Row, read that game's instructions, and test selecting and placing a piece in the chosen player setup.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Assess each game separately: the collection includes reflex games, and multiplayer, touch, motion, and undo options vary by title.

Why it might click. The collection offers many small, distinct games with in-game explanations, from familiar boards to cards and more active diversions. Its useful promise is variety within one package: it may be possible to find one pleasing little ritual without adopting a long campaign.

The full catch. Assess individual games, not the collection as one control profile. Nintendo explicitly distinguishes strategic choices such as Four-in-a-row from reflex games such as Slot Cars and Toy Boxing. Multiplayer, motion, touch and undo availability vary by game. Shared competitive play is not automatically cooperative play.

Try this first. Open Four-in-a-row and read its own instructions, then test selecting and placing a piece in a local or solo arrangement without an added household timer. Check that game's controls and player setup before trying a second title.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Fifty-One Games and I Pick the One With Four Pieces

Clubhouse Games gave us a whole collection. I started explaining that our first trial concerned one specific game within it. Shawna nodded. "Four in a Row." I was almost disappointed she'd read the note before my performance.

Tank sat opposite me. Rosa put a small plate between us. Mercedes asked whether the rest of the collection would remain available later. Of course. Nobody had to swallow the whole menu to enjoy one thing.

Dre set his blue controller down and watched my first move. "You sure?" "Completely." "All right, my nigga." A deeply unhelpful tone from a man holding the correct casserole lid.

A few moves later Tank won. I requested an explanation. He pointed at four pieces. I requested a rematch. Shawna offered me a choice: another game or a dance.

I stood. Tank smiled. "Tactical withdrawal."

"Romance," I said. My wife pulled me toward the music before the losing commander could hold a press conference.

Aiden's verdict. Start with the named Four in a Row trial rather than treating all fifty-one games alike; my first defeat has produced a perfectly respectable alternative evening activity.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo confirms collection/tutorials and explicitly separates strategic/reflex games; proposed trial is Four-in-a-row only. Collection-level mixed pace/input must not certify every included game. Native co-op scope and game-specific holds are unverified.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/clubhouse-games-51-worldwide-classics-switch/>

Four in a Row and One Dance Owed

Tank beat me at Four in a Row and waited for the appeal. I inspected the pieces. Four of his, visibly together, with no constitutional ambiguity I could exploit. Dre leaned over and counted them aloud. Slowly. “Nigga, I can count,” I said. “Then this will be quick.” It was. I had lost a game, which appeared to be survivable despite the enthusiastic audience.

Shawna offered me a dance instead of a rematch. I took it before my mouth found a reason to summon a tournament committee. The music came from Mercedes's chosen playlist now. She had finished checking the recording and wanted to eat, laugh, and hear somebody else for a while. We gave her that. Porsche tucked the equipment bag beside her own chair. Darnell asked whether he could play one track from his yacht. Every woman within hearing distance said no at a slightly different pitch. Briefly, the room became a choir.

My wife moved close. “How are the trousers?” “Diplomatically sound.” “Good. I was worried about a border incident.” I laughed against her hair. We danced without a camera crew clearing space, without a special introduction, without the throne identifying who was important. Tank filmed three seconds, saw Shawna shake her head, and put his phone down. Some moments were better when everybody in them could remain there.

The hotel manager waited until the song ended before handing me the final additions. A considerate executioner. I read them properly this time. Asked about one duplicated charge. He checked and removed it. Paid the rest. No empire collapsed; no bank sent a helicopter. It was just money leaving because I had agreed to spend it. Mercedes watched from her chair. “Look at this nigga learning a plot with consequences.” I bowed. The new trousers held. We took that as a second victory.

Rosa gave the remaining staff food to take home. She checked who wanted what instead of packaging everybody the same meal. Tank carried the boxes to the back, returned with the empty trolley, and asked whether we were done moving things. I looked at the mechanical throne. He followed my gaze. “No.” “The crew will collect it.” “Correct answer, my nigga.” We left the enormous chair where the rental company could reclaim both its motors and my ambitions.

Dre found the lid for his casserole and offered the last portion around before closing it. Darnell had finally stopped talking about the yacht because the bartender had gone on break. The sponsor sat with a small game open, quietly reading a choice instead of trying to become part of Mercedes's recording. I considered this proof that everyone had grown. Shawna said it might only prove we were tired. Both explanations allowed sitting down, so I accepted the more modest one without a fight.

There were games people wanted to revisit and games nobody wanted to touch. Nobody owed the room a reason that satisfied me. Heavy systems could be the pleasure, or they could be an obstacle. A little card puzzle could catch somebody completely. A huge famous story could leave them cold. The important answer was the one they actually felt while playing, not the answer that made my purchase sound wise. Tank pointed at the throne. “Same with chairs.” I told him he'd made the point. He said the chair had helped.

Mercedes stood and hugged me. “Good night, Aiden.” I asked whether she'd enjoyed herself. “Parts.” “Which parts?” She looked toward the screen, the food, Shawna, and the friends still talking. Then she looked at me. “You were in some of them.” Nigga, I nearly ruined that by asking for a percentage. Instead I hugged her back and thanked her for singing. No sponsor language. No review. Just what I meant.

When we left, I carried Shawna's shoes. Tank carried Rosa's bag. Porsche carried the recording because Mercedes had asked her to. Dre carried the casserole. Everybody had something whose destination they understood. The throne stayed behind. So did the statue, the unused light, and the face on the board, which the hotel had turned gently toward the wall. My wife leaned against me in the lift. “What did we learn?” she asked. I looked at her shoes in my hand. “I should buy looser trousers.” She laughed and kissed me. For tonight, nigga, that answer was enough.

Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. The Tellings Cut: original revised Panorama prose and production by ChatGPT; original game research and selection system retained. This is a separate adult comic companion to Ten Toes Down. Source novels and the first Panorama edition remain intact. All people participating in the fictional party scenes are adults; Lillian is addressed as the reader.

Voice sources sampled for this revision: the Niggatorial Tellings Book I funeral and first Vegas party, selected passages from Books II-VI, and the edition editorial record. Source repository Sodelin/Ten-Toes-Down; working base 4cdof7a6e36977ff0ac705a59ebe65407d1f2bee. Selected passages were read closely; no full reread of all six novels is claimed. The added game-night story is newly composed fiction.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

This adult comic edition includes frequent reclaimed in-group language, strong profanity, fictional cocaine and party references, sexual banter and non-graphic innuendo. Those scenes are separate from the factual game descriptions and are not descriptions of the developers or real readers.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS / THE TELLINGS CUT

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 3 OF SIX

My Nigga, the View Costs Extra

Forty places, small worlds and scenic arguments about what counts as progress.

Forty real games. Aiden has made it everybody's problem.

Adult comic edition: reclaimed in-group language, profanity, fictional cocaine references and sexual innuendo.

New ChatGPT prose under Nolan's creative direction.

Tellings Cut 2.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

How to find a game in this book

Each game starts with a short pitch, what you actually do, the controls and pace, the main catch, and a first action to try. These practical sections use plain language. The longer Aiden scene comes after them.

For a fast comparison, read the pitch and main catch on two or three pages. Use the alphabetical index to jump to a title. Choose the full story only when you want the comedy; it is never a prerequisite for understanding the game.

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. The labels mean: A place to start = a promising candidate; Read the catch first = a meaningful obstacle needs checking; A more demanding detour = a narrower or harder option. They describe the game, not the reader. Check the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

Choose a game by its name

This is the quick route. Click any title, or turn to its page. Read the short pitch and main catch first; Aiden's scene follows the practical guide. The case number works across every format.

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P101	AER Memories of Old	28	P102	Proteus	29
P088	Alba: A Wildlife Adventure	13	P114	Riven	45
P103	Dear Esther: Landmark Edition	30	P096	Sable	22
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P087	Eastshade	12	P091	Smushi Come Home	17
P104	Everybody's Gone to the Rapture	31	P109	The Beginner's Guide	38
P100	Feather	26	P119	The Looker	51
P107	Firewatch	36	P099	The Pathless	25
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A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 3. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index near the front always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P081	P082	P083	P084	P085	P086	P087	P088
2. Ready for conversation	P089	P090	P091	P092	P093	P094	P095	P096
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P097	P098	P099	P100	P101	P102	P103	P104
4. Here for the atmosphere	P105	P106	P107	P108	P109	P110	P111	P112
5. Open to a wildcard	P113	P114	P115	P116	P117	P118	P119	P120

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

The Penthouse Had No Fucking View

'Nigga, I paid for the horizon.' The manager pointed at the curtains. Behind them stood another wall. I opened the curtains farther, giving the wall every opportunity to explain itself. Tank walked in carrying a covered casserole. He looked at the wall, looked at me, and put dinner down before the situation got worse. 'Beautiful brickwork,' he said.

The manager explained that the panoramic suite came with the panoramic package. I had purchased the suite. The package was separate. Shawna sat on the bed and crossed her legs. 'Baby, you bought a room with ambition.' I asked the manager what the package did. He pressed a button. The wall lit up with a projected beach. A recorded seagull screamed directly into my ear. Tank nodded. 'Nigga got robbed by a television.'

We had booked the entire floor for a game night. All adults, all dressed like the casino might promote us if we stood correctly. Rosa had a paid performance slot downstairs. Mercedes had brought music she wanted people to hear without some rich fool talking over it. Porsche had the room keys and enough knowledge of the hotel's actual layout to become more powerful than me before dinner. Shawna had brought a red dress and made no promise to spend the evening watching her husband argue with a wall.

Dre arrived next, carrying the casserole Tank had offered to help transport. Tank had removed the cover to inspect its emotional condition. Dre took it back. 'Nigga, that's for everybody.' He wore a blue jacket, reached for the blue controller on the game table, and said, 'Crip's got first choice.' Tank asked if the casserole was similarly affiliated. 'That casserole belongs to whoever washes the dish.' Tank put his plate down. Suddenly neutral as hell.

Darnell came through the door announcing a yacht nobody had asked about. He had white powder on one lapel and a little bag he kept mentioning like a postgraduate credential. Mercedes looked up once. 'Cocaine didn't make that boat story shorter, huh?' He began explaining the boat's third deck. She put her headphones back on. Nigga had found a chemical route to being ignored at greater speed.

I took Shawna's hand and promised the real terrace would compensate for the false ocean. She let me pull her close. 'You can compensate later. First find somewhere Rosa can sing without that bird screaming.' The projection squawked again. Tank told it to get a plate or get the fuck out. I found the remote under the manager's folder and silenced the only guest who had not pretended to recognize me.

Downstairs, the casino had put our games beside a velvet rope and a sign that said THE GRAND PANORAMA. Forty destinations in this part of the night. Little towns. Islands. Strange houses. Skies large enough for my ego to get lost in. The useful descriptions were there for anybody who wanted to choose directly. My elaborate entertainment was optional, a fact Mercedes announced over my microphone before I could attach a cover charge to curiosity.

We found the actual terrace behind an ordinary door. City lights. Warm air. A perfectly good view that had cost nothing extra. Shawna stood beside the railing and smiled at me. I put one hand at her waist and started a sentence about what I intended to do upstairs. Rosa tested her microphone behind us. The entire sentence entered the speakers. Tank lifted his casserole plate. 'Nigga, at least the sound works.'

P081 / A PLACE TO START

Unpacking

Edition considered: PC current release

Discover a person's changing life through the belongings they keep, arrange and carry into new homes over the years.

What you do. Open boxes, examine everyday objects and place them in rooms, noticing what each move reveals about their owner.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Small objects and visual searching still need checking, despite documented alternatives to holds, dragging and time limits.

Why it might click. Unpacking tells a life through belongings and the rooms they enter. The pleasure is partly arranging a space and partly noticing what survives each move. A familiar object can carry more character information than a long conversation. This is a worthwhile route for curiosity about people expressed through ordinary things.

The full catch. The developer documents no time limits, mouse-only PC play and alternatives to dragging or holding. Those specific provisions make it a stronger starting candidate. Visual searching, small objects and deciding where things belong can still take effort. Check the Allow Items Anywhere option if placement rules interfere with the pleasure.

Try this first. Open one box in the first room and place an object. Test the click-based interaction and whether the objects are comfortably visible before organizing everything.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Wife Unpacked the Evidence

I had booked the penthouse for one night. Shawna opened my suitcase and found three watches, a velvet jacket, and enough cologne to announce a second building.

'Nigga, where are your clothes?' 'You wearing most of my plans.' She held up one clean sock. 'Your plans going barefoot?'

Tank arrived with somebody else's luggage and a sandwich balanced on it. I asked how he knew it was somebody else's. 'This nigga packed vegetables. Ain't ours.' He left the case and kept the sandwich.

We spread our things across the bed. A cracked little souvenir fell from Shawna's bag. She caught it before I could offer to replace it. First trip together. Cheap as hell. She still carried it.

I stopped arranging my watches and found a safe place for her souvenir. Shawna watched, then tossed me the missing sock. 'There. Now you can seduce me with a complete inventory.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose this when somebody's belongings sound more interesting than their résumé. My wife learned everything she needed from one suitcase, including why I was not dressing myself.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Steam supports belongings-as-story and no timers. Official developer accessibility page previously inspected supports mouse-only PC, no required holds drags/simultaneous buttons and Allow Items Anywhere. Actual comfort remains individual.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1135690/>

Source 2: <https://www.unpackinggame.com/>

P082 / A PLACE TO START

Townscaper

Edition considered: PC release

Make a small waterfront town simply because you like its shapes and colors, without managing residents or a budget.

What you do. Place or remove building pieces and watch the town's architecture change, experimenting with the arrangement of your own little place.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Check camera movement, pointer control and any sustained input; a simple building idea does not guarantee comfortable controls.

Why it might click. Townscaper is a construction toy in which clicks generate buildings and pleasing architectural connections. You can follow a small visual idea, such as a street over water or a cluster of towers, without first learning a production economy. Its interest is shape, color and the surprise of what the building system produces.

The full catch. The small tool set does not remove every physical task. Moving the view, zooming and placing a precise block may involve a different input pattern from selecting a menu. Preview those actions on the chosen device. This is a place-making activity with little authored character story, so the appeal must come from making rather than following a plot.

Try this first. Make a three-house waterfront, change one color and turn the view once. Keep building only if those ordinary actions feel satisfying.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / I Built a Waterfront Nobody Could Afford to Leave

The hotel had given us a shallow decorative pool. I arranged champagne corks in it and called the result Aiden Harbor. Mercedes looked down. 'Nigga, that's the bar's trash.'

'Waterfront property.' 'Then why your tallest building says Brut?'

Tank brought bread from the buffet. One cork leaned against another. I moved a third. Suddenly the little mess looked like a place. Shawna sat beside me and added a pink drinks umbrella without requesting planning permission.

I objected to the color. She moved her chair away. I immediately discovered a deep appreciation for pink coastal architecture.

A manager came over about the corks. Mercedes pointed at the enormous model resort in his lobby. 'Yours got mortgages. His got bubbles.' He looked at mine again. I offered him the mayoral suite. Nigga asked if breakfast was included.

I said yes. Tank ate the remaining bread.

Aiden's verdict. Take the little town if making a pleasing place is enough. The harbor's mayor has eaten breakfast, the building material, and any chance of a second term.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1291340/>

P083 / A PLACE TO START

Dorfromantik

Edition considered: PC release; Creative mode is a separate assessment target

Arrange a pleasing countryside of villages, forests and waterways, using Creative mode when unrestricted landscape-making is the main attraction.

What you do. Choose Creative mode, place landscape tiles and experiment with how fields, woods, water and settlements fit together.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Creative mode is the intended scope; camera controls and exact placement actions still need checking on your device.

Why it might click. Dorfromantik assembles a landscape from hexagonal tiles. Fields, settlements, forests and waterways make the next placement visually meaningful. The attraction is a small repeated action that grows into a countryside you can inspect and enjoy. It can suit someone who likes arranging a world more than managing its inhabitants.

The full catch. Choose the mode deliberately. Standard play involves tile supply, objectives and scoring; Creative mode is a separate assessment target, not a label for every session. Rotation, camera movement, small connection details and interpreting the interface still need checking. The sources support the game's building premise, not a universal promise that every control is hold-free.

Try this first. Open Creative mode with setup help if needed. Place one village tile, one field and one stretch of water, then examine the connections without chasing a score.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Tank Put the Buffet on the Wrong Side of the River

I turned the casino's banquet floor plan into a countryside. Trees here. Water there. Private retreat for me and my wife where the stage used to be.

Rosa put her microphone down. 'Nigga, my deposit says stage.'

I drew a footbridge. She drew a fee. Tank leaned over us with a plate and accidentally connected the river to the shrimp station. Now my elegant village had a seafood delta.

Shawna moved three table cards and gave everybody a route that made sense. Mercedes found a little corner with no speakers pointed at it. She sat there before I could name it after myself.

The arrangements felt good when they belonged together. I moved one more piece purely because I liked how it looked. No speech. No grand objective. Tank said he could feel the room getting cheaper.

Then the manager saw my private retreat. 'Sir, that's a fire exit.' My wife patted the little bridge. 'Guess we taking the scenic route to the bedroom.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose a landscape you want to arrange, with Creative mode explicitly selected. My romantic village has failed fire inspection, but the river does reach the buffet.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1455840/>

P084 / A PLACE TO START

Hidden Folks

Edition considered: PC release

Explore crowded illustrated scenes full of small jokes and hidden people, with the search itself supplying the main pleasure.

What you do. Inspect a detailed scene, follow the target hints, interact with objects and look for the people or things described.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Dense drawings, tiny targets, zooming and scene navigation may be demanding; test any required dragging.

Why it might click. Hidden Folks turns searching into a lively illustrated scene. The hand-drawn crowds and interactive details reward looking closely, while target clues give a concrete reason to investigate. A companion can help spot possibilities without taking over a character or handling an inventory. The pleasure is noticing, testing and finally recognizing the right little detail.

The full catch. A static-looking scene can still demand visual scanning. Small targets, dense drawings, zooming and panning may be the main obstacles. Check whether navigation requires an uncomfortable drag on the selected device. The absence of an avatar does not itself establish every accessibility property, and this card does not certify the complete game as hold-free.

Try this first. Choose one target from an early scene. Read its clue, enlarge the view if useful and search together for that one person before opening a longer list.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Find the Nigga Who Has My Room Key

The casino photographer promised one elegant group picture. We gave him nineteen adults, a feathered dancer, two champagne carts, and Tank trying to conceal a whole dessert behind another dessert.

My room key disappeared during the arrangement. 'Nobody move,' I said. Every nigga moved.

Mercedes spotted my watch in the piano player's pocket. He had been holding it for me. Rosa found my jacket under a chair. Shawna located the key inside the jacket while I was still accusing the fountain of acting suspicious.

'You welcome,' she said. 'Baby, I was narrowing the field.'

The photographer showed us the picture. Little stories everywhere. Porsche laughing at somebody behind a plant. Tank staring at a waiter with fresh pie. My wife holding up the key like the tiny piece of freedom it was.

I asked him to enlarge me. 'You already taking up most of the situation,' he said.

Aiden's verdict. Pick this if searching a crowded picture sounds pleasurable. Nobody owes the tiny scene a speed record, and the hotel has already charged me for enlarging myself.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/435400/>

P085 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

A Short Hike

Edition considered: PC release

Take a small island outing where conversations, discoveries and the route itself can be more appealing than reaching the summit.

What you do. Walk around the island, meet characters and explore paths, trying climbing and gliding only after checking basic movement.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Climbing, gliding, jumping and held movement make this conditional, even though the overall outing can feel gentle.

Why it might click. A Short Hike offers a compact island, a climb toward a destination and small encounters along the way. Its warmth comes from the people you meet and the freedom to let one nearby curiosity become the next activity. It is a smaller, more legible exploration proposition than a vast map filled with competing objectives.

The full catch. The developer describes an unhurried journey, but the controls still ask for movement. Climbing and gliding use held input; gliding also requires steering. Those demands matter even when the mood is gentle. Side activities need their own check, and there is no native simultaneous local co-op in the assessed version.

Try this first. Walk along an early shoreline or marked trail and speak to one character. Introduce climbing and gliding only after ordinary movement has become comfortable.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Penthouse Was One Flight Higher Than My Confidence

I told Shawna the rooftop was a short walk. She looked at my shoes. Patent leather. Beautiful. Completely uninterested in stairs.

'Nigga, you dressed like the elevator owes you money.'

Tank took the first landing carrying Rosa's speaker. I took it carrying a promise about the view. By the second landing, the promise weighed more.

Shawna stopped at a little window. The city looked unexpectedly good from there. Mercedes joined her and took a picture without me in it. I demanded an explanation. 'The city got dressed too.'

We stayed a while. Nobody was awarding the roof to the first arrival. My wife loosened my tie, kissed me, and said the room downstairs had a perfectly respectable view of her.

I considered both destinations with mature seriousness. Tank called down that the rooftop bar was closed. 'Nigga, romance wins again,' I said, turning around before somebody reopened it.

Aiden's verdict. Try the small journey if wandering itself appeals, after checking jumps and held movement. My shoes endorse all destinations reachable before the next flight of stairs.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer Steam description supports unhurried summit exploration; named hands-on review supports held climb/glide and steering. No blanket statement about every optional activity.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1055540/>

Source 2: <https://saveorquit.com/2021/01/16/review-a-short-hike/>

P086 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Yonder: The Cloud Catcher Chronicles

Edition considered: PC release

Explore a colorful open world where helping communities, gathering materials and tending projects provide reasons to keep visiting new places.

What you do. Travel between settlements and natural areas, talk to residents, collect resources and take on the activities that interest you.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Crafting, gathering and navigation can add complexity; third-person movement and camera coordination still need a direct check.

Why it might click. Yonder provides an open island with several environments and a broad set of activities, including gathering, farming, crafting and helping residents. Its appeal is the possibility of choosing a direction and making a small life within a landscape. The central restoration premise gives exploration a purpose without making every interest identical.

The full catch. This is a conditional open-world candidate. Third-person navigation brings movement and camera control, while professions, inventory, trading and quests can accumulate into a substantial interface. The developer's own-pace language does not erase the changing day, seasons or the work of remembering goals. It is single-player, even when a friend helps.

Try this first. Have a helper find an uncomplicated nearby route. Walk to one visible destination and try one gathering action before enrolling in every available profession.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Somebody Sold Me a Vacation with a Livestock Budget

The concierge said our party package included a pastoral experience. I pictured a private garden, my wife, and enough privacy to become the subject of a very small scandal.

A grown man in overalls arrived with an invoice for the petting lawn. Tank read it. 'Nigga, you renting goats by the opinion?'

One goat had already taken an interest in the ribbon on my presentation table. Rosa pulled her performance contract away. Mercedes protected her jacket. I announced I could manage a peaceful environment.

The goat looked at me and kept chewing.

Shawna turned the invoice over. Watering, feeding, transport, cleanup. 'Peaceful got chores, baby.'

I moved the party away from the lawn and watched the animal finish dismantling my ribbon. No enemy. No boss fight. Just a living world with more needs than the brochure had mentioned.

Tank offered me his pen. 'Sign here, Farmer Nigga. Your goat wants overtime.'

Aiden's verdict. Visit if a world of errands and discovery sounds rewarding. Lack of combat does not cancel the work, as the goat's impressive billing department has demonstrated.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/580200/>

P087 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Eastshade

Edition considered: PC release

Explore an island through painting and conversations, letting attractive places and the people who live there guide your curiosity.

What you do. Walk through the island, meet residents, gather what you need and make paintings of views that interest you.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. First-person movement, camera control, travel and resource tasks remain part of the experience; no-combat does not mean low-demand.

Why it might click. Eastshade makes a traveling painter the center of an island adventure. Meeting residents, discovering places and making paintings give curiosity a tangible role in the world. The atmosphere and local stories may appeal to someone seeking a grown-up journey that does not revolve around fighting.

The full catch. The no-combat design is not the same as simple physical input. First-person walking and looking typically use separate controls, and crafting, canvases and quests add interface work. The developer's design essay is older than release; the final storefront supports the painting and exploration premise, not a guarantee about every environmental rule or input.

Try this first. Try a short village walk and one conversation. Test turning the view while standing still before deciding whether to learn the painting and crafting systems.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Painter Refused to Fix My Face

I hired a portrait painter for the terrace. First instruction: make me look like the kind of nigga who owned the sunset. She looked at my invoice and painted the sunset.

'Where am I?' 'You haven't paid for a person.'

Shawna laughed into her drink. Mercedes asked the painter about the colors across the buildings. Rosa watched a patch of light on the pool and suggested we move her performance there before it disappeared.

I wanted everybody looking at me. Instead I found myself looking where they were looking. The wall had gone orange. A waiter paused with an empty tray. Even Tank set down his fork.

Somebody inside started bragging about cocaine in the VIP bathroom. Nobody on the terrace turned around. For once the cheaper light outside was winning.

I paid for the landscape. My wife leaned against me. The painter asked whether I still wanted a portrait. 'Later,' I said. 'Nigga finally found something worth the frame.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose the painting journey if a place can hold your attention. The terrace has survived without my portrait, and the sunset has refused to negotiate ownership.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Steam supports painter, relationships and exploration. Developer no-combat essay is pre-release (2015); it does not establish all final environmental or input rules.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/715560/>

Source 2: <https://eastshade.com/without-combat/>

P088 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Alba: A Wildlife Adventure

Edition considered: PC release

Get to know a small island by noticing wildlife, taking photographs and helping with a community effort to protect it.

What you do. Walk around the island, look for animals, photograph discoveries and speak with residents involved in its conservation story.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Camera use, small targets, navigation and any scene-specific timing need checking before calling the whole journey comfortable.

Why it might click. Alba places wildlife discovery and care for an island at the center of a bright adventure. Looking for animals and recording what you find supplies a recognizable activity within a place that also has residents and a conservation story. It offers a possible bridge from noticing details to moving around a small world.

The full catch. The gentle premise should not be mistaken for a verified control profile. Check movement, camera adjustment, aiming the camera, target recognition and the way objectives accumulate. Any required timing or unusual interaction remains an open question until the exact version is inspected. The child protagonist does not by itself determine whether the subject will interest an adult.

Try this first. In an early accessible area, find one animal and try one photograph. Assess the ordinary move-look-photograph sequence before making a collecting plan.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Bird Ruined My Promotional Shoot

I opened the terrace doors wearing a suit worth photographing. A small bird landed on the rail directly behind me. Every phone in the room turned toward the bird.

'Nigga, I'm in focus over here.' Mercedes lifted one finger. 'Don't scare the talent.'

Rosa wanted to know what kind it was. Tank wanted to know whether the hotel had charged us for it. Shawna lowered my elbow so the bird could keep its patch of railing.

The photographer crouched. I crouched too, unwilling to lose an entire production to somebody with free feathers. Then I saw its reflection in the pool. Tiny feet. Ridiculous confidence. It looked like it owned the place more naturally than I did.

I stayed still for the picture. Shawna squeezed my shoulder. 'Look at you, supporting another star.'

The bird flew off before the manager arrived with his event forms. Tank nodded after it. 'Smart nigga. Didn't sign shit.'

Aiden's verdict. Follow the wildlife if noticing and photographing it sounds worthwhile. The unpaid guest has departed with top billing and left me responsible for the entire venue.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1337010/>

P089 / A PLACE TO START

TOEM

Edition considered: PC release

Explore a quirky illustrated world through photography, meeting people whose requests give you reasons to look at the surroundings closely.

What you do. Move between places, talk with characters and use the camera to photograph details connected to their small requests.

Mixed controls | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Camera aiming, zooming and any required holds remain input checks; the photographic premise alone does not settle them.

Why it might click. TOEM uses photography to turn exploration into observation. Its illustrated world and small requests give a reason to look at a place carefully, then try a picture that connects what you saw with what someone needs. The changing camera view can make an ordinary corner feel like a little discovery.

The full catch. Movement and photography are distinct tasks, so check both rather than assuming a small-looking world has one-button play. Camera aiming, view changes, object size and remembering several requests may matter. The store's photographic-adventure premise does not establish that every task is untimed or that every input avoids holding.

Try this first. Take one request, locate its subject and make one photograph. Keep the current request visible or write a short reminder if that makes the next action clearer.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Photographer Got My Good Side and the Fire Exit

I announced a photographic tour of the hotel. Shawna asked whether this meant I would stop demanding everyone photograph me. 'Let's not make wild promises, baby.'

Mercedes gave Tank the camera. He immediately photographed the buffet label that said UNLIMITED. 'Evidence,' he said.

Rosa wanted a picture of the pianist's hands after her rehearsal. The man straightened his cuffs. A tiny quiet transaction happened: she had noticed his work, and he let the picture matter.

I tried to join the frame. Mercedes caught my belt. 'Nigga, let somebody else have ten seconds.'

We found strange corners I'd missed while announcing my arrival. A mural beside the service lift. An old chandelier. Porsche laughing so hard against a vending machine that the picture blurred.

Back upstairs, Shawna showed me one she'd taken when I wasn't looking. Me holding Rosa's coat while she sang. 'That one's your good side,' she said. I saved it before the niggas saw me get sentimental.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the camera outing when looking for pictures is the pleasure. My best photograph required neither a pose nor the photographer agreeing that I owned the building.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam app 1307580, TOEM: A Photo Adventure (2021). The automated TOEM 2 match was rejected. Source supports photography, conversations and puzzles, not universal no-timing or no-hold claims.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1307580/>

P090 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Lil Gator Game

Edition considered: PC release

Turn a friendly island into a make-believe adventure, meeting characters and enjoying the playful possibilities of its ordinary spaces.

What you do. Explore the island, talk with characters and take part in activities involving movement, climbing and improvised adventure.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Jumping, climbing, gliding and camera coordination are meaningful demands; the friendly tone does not remove them.

Why it might click. Lil Gator Game builds an island adventure around play, make-believe and meeting people who can become part of it. Exploration and small activities offer a lighthearted sense of progress. The emotional question of sharing an enthusiasm may resonate even when the visual style is deliberately playful.

The full catch. This remains a movement-based adventure. Check camera control, climbing, gliding, jumping and the frequency of held or combined inputs in the chosen version. A playful tone does not make those demands disappear. Someone who wants a darker mystery or dense adult dialogue may simply prefer another shelf, which is a matter of taste.

Try this first. Explore one nearby patch of the opening area and talk to a character. Try the basic movement and camera separately before committing to traversal challenges.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Cardboard Sword Cost Less Than the Damage Deposit

Porsche found a cardboard crown in the event supplies and put it on my head. I accepted with the dignity of a king whose elastic strap had caught his ear.

Tank handed me a foam sword. 'There, nigga. Hotel finally insured your ass.'

The adult party guests started building a ridiculous kingdom from sofa cushions. Mercedes claimed the good chair. Rosa demanded a stage with a stable floor. Shawna drew a moat around the snack table using blue ribbon, then charged me a kiss to cross.

I paid twice and called it infrastructure investment.

The fun was in deciding that an ordinary room could become an adventure because we agreed to treat it that way. I did not need to win the kingdom. My wife had the bridge.

Then I jumped onto the wrong cushion and spilled a bowl of wrapped mints. The manager appeared. Tank raised the foam sword. 'No violence, my nigga. We doing damage emotionally and through upholstery.'

Aiden's verdict. Try the playful island if its movement suits you and make-believe sounds fun. The cardboard king accepts that a charming costume does not remove the jumping requirement.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1586800/>

The Blue Controller Did Not Come with Ownership of the Television

Dre had the blue controller, which he considered a settled matter. I had paid for the television, which I considered an ongoing constitutional advantage. We looked at each other across the game table. Tank slid a plate between us. 'Before either nigga declares a country, taste this.' The casserole interrupted our founding documents.

Shawna picked a game because its ordinary actions sounded pleasant. Not because it had won a debate. Not because its cover looked expensive. She tried the movement, stopped, and asked whether that particular camera could behave differently. I immediately offered to become her personal cameraman. She kissed my cheek. 'Baby, I need the game to turn, not another man with opinions.'

Mercedes wanted a story. Rosa wanted a place she could look around between songs without feeling chased. Tank wanted to build something attractive and also eat with the hand he was not using. Dre wanted to know whether the promised shared activity actually supported another player. Four different questions reached the table before my grand ranking system could put on its shoes.

We checked what the page actually said. Unknown stayed unknown. A conditional choice kept its condition. Somebody could like the idea and dislike the action; the room did not collapse. I found that reassuring until Mercedes pointed out that the same principle applied to my party. 'Love the idea,' she said. 'The host still needs settings.'

Dre handed Shawna the blue controller to try. I raised an eyebrow. He shrugged. 'Nigga, preference ain't a hostage situation.' Tank gave him more casserole. The evening's first successful negotiation ended without my involvement, though I stood nearby looking sufficiently official to be blamed later.

P091 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Smushi Come Home

Edition considered: PC release

Help a tiny mushroom find a way home through a forest whose scale makes ordinary places feel like an adventure.

What you do. Explore the forest, meet characters and try traversal activities while following the mushroom's journey toward a familiar home.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Movement holds, jumps and camera control need checking, especially before relying on its small scale as evidence of simplicity.

Why it might click. Smushi Come Home follows a tiny mushroom trying to return home through a forest. New tools, helpful creatures and light puzzles give the trip a clear purpose. The small scale can make familiar natural objects feel surprising, and the mycology journal supplies another kind of curiosity beyond simply reaching the next place.

The full catch. The primary description explicitly includes running, gliding, climbing, swimming and light platforming. Those are real control demands despite the cozy presentation. Assess held movement, steering and transitions between abilities. An own-pace exploration claim does not demonstrate that every jump or required action will be comfortable.

Try this first. Try a small stretch of walking and one conversation. Then inspect the earliest necessary traversal action before deciding whether the homeward journey feels inviting.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Mushroom Had a Better Sense of Direction Than the Host

I lost the private lounge between the elevator and the corridor. Five-star hotel. Eleven identical plants. Somebody had designed the floor specifically to humble a nigga in expensive shoes.

Porsche came around the corner wearing a mushroom-shaped promotional hat. 'Follow me.' 'Why you dressed like that?' 'Because the staff recognize me, motherfucker.'

She led us through a little side passage I had walked past three times. Rosa followed with her music. Tank carried the last tray as if abandoning it would violate his religion.

Shawna asked what I had learned. 'The mushroom got connections.'

We reached a snug room with low lights and a balcony. Mercedes opened the curtains. I liked the feeling of finding a little home inside the enormous building. My wife put her bag down and stole the best seat.

I offered to lead the return trip. Every nigga looked at the hat. Porsche put it on me. 'Now somebody might rescue your ass.'

Aiden's verdict. Visit the small forest if finding a way home appeals, after testing movement and jumps. The hotel recognizes the mushroom hat as a more reliable guide than me.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1740300/>

P092 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Haven Park

Edition considered: PC release

Make a small park more welcoming by exploring it, meeting visitors and improving the places where they can stay.

What you do. Walk around the park, talk with visitors, gather materials and make small improvements to its camping areas.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Building and gathering add tasks to remember, while movement and camera control still require a practical trial.

Why it might click. Haven Park combines a small explorable park with campsite improvements and conversations. Taking care of a place gives wandering a practical rhythm: find something, learn what a visitor needs and make the park more welcoming. Its family connection and local stories provide a modest narrative thread around that activity.

The full catch. The developer presents a peaceful open world, but building and gathering still introduce resources, quests and navigation. Check camera behavior, interaction distance, held movement and how many unfinished tasks the interface expects you to track. The advertised mood should not stand in for an edition-specific input assessment.

Try this first. Explore one nearby campsite and identify a single useful improvement. Complete that little loop before accepting a broad program of park redevelopment.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Rosa Asked for a Campsite and I Ordered Valet Parking

The casino wanted a little outdoor lounge for the event. I ordered rugs, chandeliers and a valet. Rosa looked at the terrace. 'Nigga, the chairs already outside.'

'Luxury camping.' 'Where the tent?' I pointed at the hotel. She put her drink down very carefully.

Tank arranged two chairs where the breeze actually reached them. Mercedes moved a lamp so people could see each other's faces. Shawna put a blanket on the seat beside hers. Three small changes. Suddenly the place looked like somewhere to stay.

I tried adding a velvet rope. Nobody got up to let me attach it. The rope hung from one hand like I'd brought a leash for my own importance.

A waiter asked what we wanted. Rosa ordered water. Tank ordered food. My wife patted the blanket.

I sent the valet home and sat down. Nigga left with my tip, which was more camping profit than anybody else had made.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the park if making a place welcoming sounds satisfying. Start with one useful improvement; the valet has already earned enough from my misunderstanding of nature.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1549550/>

P093 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Mail Time

Edition considered: PC release

Make little deliveries through a storybook forest, with meeting people along the route providing much of the charm and interest.

What you do. Travel through the forest, speak with characters and carry letters or requests between the people you encounter there.

Movement + camera | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Platforming, jumping, gliding and remembering destinations can complicate the otherwise gentle delivery premise.

Why it might click. Mail Time turns deliveries into a forest adventure with distinct characters and places. Letters provide a clear reason to visit someone, while the world makes the route part of the attraction. It is a potential option for enjoying small social encounters without needing a dense mystery or a complicated economic simulation.

The full catch. The developer explicitly states no time limits or fall damage, which supports the pace side of this candidate. It also explicitly includes running, jumping and gliding. These physical demands must be assessed separately. Check camera movement, held glide input and remembering delivery destinations; do not assume the listed accessibility options solve every concern.

Try this first. Follow one early delivery from address to recipient. Test the first necessary jump or glide at a comfortable moment before planning a full mail route.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Love Note Went to the Entire Banquet Staff

I wrote Shawna a note promising the kind of evening a hotel charges extra to clean up after. Nothing detailed. A gentleman leaves room for anticipation and plausible housekeeping estimates.

Tank took the envelope. 'Room number?' I told him. He nodded with a mouth full of pastry, which should have ended my confidence right there.

The note reached Rosa. Rosa passed it to Mercedes. Mercedes read the first line aloud. Every nigga at the table turned toward me.

'Wrong room,' Tank said. 'Wrong fucking postal service,' I said.

Shawna took the envelope before the second line acquired an audience. She smiled, folded it, and put it in her purse. 'Delivery accepted. Your courier fired.'

I liked the final few feet of that journey considerably more than the middle. Tank asked whether the position included severance. My wife handed him a mint. Nigga checked whether it was wrapped before accepting the settlement.

Aiden's verdict. Take the little delivery route if meeting people between addresses sounds fun. My romantic correspondence has demonstrated why a short journey can still contain several complications.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1607240/>

P094 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Lake

Edition considered: PC base game

Follow a familiar delivery route through a lakeside community, getting to know people through workday conversations and personal choices.

What you do. Drive the mail truck, make deliveries and talk with residents, deciding how you want to spend time with them.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Driving and walking controls are central; camera coordination, menus and particular sequences still need checking.

Why it might click. Lake follows Meredith during a return to her hometown and a temporary job delivering mail. Adult relationships, ordinary decisions and the question of what kind of life to choose are the main attractions. The setting offers a slower social story rather than a grand fantasy quest.

The full catch. Driving and walking are real activities, not just scenery between dialogue screens. The developer mentions an autopilot option for the mail truck, which is worth checking, but it does not establish that all navigation becomes automatic. Verify camera control, interaction and the extent of that feature in the exact release before relying on it.

Try this first. Try one nearby delivery and conversation. Examine the driving assistance option, then decide whether the route itself adds pleasure or merely gets between the conversations.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Driver's Uniform Came with Somebody Else's Problems

I borrowed the hotel's delivery cart because carrying my own jacket seemed beneath the evening's production values. Shawna put three parcels beside me. 'Since you driving.'

'Baby, this is a leisure vehicle.' 'Then leisurely take those downstairs.'

Rosa needed a cable from reception. Mercedes wanted her forgotten earrings. Tank handed me an empty plate and asked if I could do anything with it. Nigga understood the route better than I did.

I stopped at each familiar face. The concierge had a joke. The pianist had an opinion about our room. A woman I'd ignored earlier remembered exactly where the earrings had been left.

By the time I returned, the hotel felt less like a backdrop and more like people sharing a shift. Shawna took her parcel and kissed me.

'Good service.' 'You should see the premium package.'

She looked at the empty plate. 'You haven't completed the standard one. Tank still hungry.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose the delivery story if a familiar route and recurring conversations appeal. The truck is part of the job; my premium service remains delayed by a plate.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1118240/>

P095 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

SEASON: A letter to the future

Edition considered: PC release

Record a world through photographs, sounds and conversations, building a personal account of places and people before they change.

What you do. Travel through the world, stop to meet people and collect impressions in a journal using photographs and recordings.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Cycling, walking, camera use, menus and journal organization can all add effort despite the reflective subject.

Why it might click. SEASON centers a bicycle journey, a customizable journal and the effort to preserve memories of a changing world. Photography, recordings and conversations make observation the substance of the story. It offers a more reflective reason to explore: choosing what deserves attention and how to remember it.

The full catch. A reflective premise does not establish an easy physical route. Cycling, walking, camera use and arranging journal material are different interactions to check. The story's impending change may also feel emotionally urgent even without a verified real-time deadline. Record the exact controls and pause behavior rather than inferring them from the mood.

Try this first. In the first available quiet area, collect one image or sound and place it in the journal. Decide whether the recording and arranging process itself is enjoyable.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Night Wanted a Witness and I Kept Offering a Photographer

Mercedes asked for a recording of the terrace before the party got loud. I offered to stand in front of it. She stared. 'Nigga, I said the terrace.'

Rosa was warming up inside. A waiter rolled glasses past. Somewhere below, a couple argued, laughed, then argued again about the parking ticket. The city had a whole sound without my announcement over it.

Shawna handed me a little notebook. 'Write something you'll actually want to remember.'

I wrote what she wore. She leaned over my shoulder. 'Besides your plans for taking it off.'

I crossed out half a sentence and kept the color. Wrote the song Rosa was trying. The warm railing. Tank carrying two chairs because he thought we looked comfortable enough to need dinner.

Later somebody showed me a spectacular photograph of the party. It left out almost everything I'd written. I kept both. Nigga can enjoy a picture without asking it to hold the whole night.

Aiden's verdict. Take this route if collecting impressions sounds meaningful. Its travel controls still matter; the notebook merely preserves the parts of the evening my publicity photographs keep missing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/695330/>

P096 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Sable

Edition considered: PC release

Explore striking desert ruins and meet nomads while considering which path to take and what kind of life might fit the traveler.

What you do. Walk or ride through the landscape, meet people and investigate places, trying climbing separately from ordinary travel.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Navigation, held movement, climbing and gliding need testing; route-finding, puzzles and the distinctive visual style can still demand attention.

Why it might click. Sable offers a rite of passage across a striking desert landscape. Exploring ruins, meeting nomads and collecting possibilities for an identity give its open world a personal theme. Its appeal lies in choosing a path and considering where the traveler belongs, rather than following a crowded list of victories.

The full catch. The developer's description includes a hoverbike, climbing, jumping and gliding. Navigation and held movement therefore deserve a practical trial. The distinctive art may be beautiful without automatically making landmarks or depth easy to read. Menus, route-finding and puzzle difficulty should be checked before presenting it as a simple wandering game.

Try this first. Explore one nearby stretch on foot, then test the first vehicle or climbing interaction separately. Follow one visible curiosity instead of committing to a complete map.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / I Found Myself in a Suit I Hadn't Paid For

The hotel stylist brought three jackets and asked what sort of man I wanted to be tonight. 'Rich,' I said. She pointed to the invoice. 'Start here.'

Shawna chose a plain one with a beautiful cut. I chose the one that could be seen from a helicopter. Mercedes asked which jacket belonged to the man inside it.

'Nigga, all three if this negotiation goes well.'

Porsche took us through a quiet service courtyard to escape the mirrors. Warm walls. Big sky. Nobody telling me what my silhouette meant. I walked beside my wife and let the ridiculous question settle.

Not every journey needed an enemy. Sometimes the difficult thing was deciding which life felt like yours when nobody clapped.

I went back for the plain jacket. Tank examined it. 'Where all the shiny shit?' 'On the invoice.'

Shawna slipped her hand inside my arm. The stylist said I looked comfortable. For once that sounded more expensive than the other option.

Aiden's verdict. Try the desert journey if discovering a direction sounds better than defeating an opponent. Clothing, beauty and freedom still leave navigation and held movement to assess.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/757310/>

P097 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

ABZU

Edition considered: PC release

Move through an underwater world for the pleasure of its creatures, spaces, music and the feeling of being among them.

What you do. Swim through three-dimensional environments, steer around sea life and explore the spaces and discoveries along the route.

Movement + camera | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Swimming and camera coordination need checking, along with any scene-specific demands; beautiful motion can still require complex input.

Why it might click. ABZU makes underwater movement and marine life the center of a largely visual journey. Swimming among schools of creatures and discovering changing seascapes can be absorbing without a dialogue-heavy plot. Its attraction is the feeling of entering a place that moves around you.

The full catch. Swimming in three dimensions can require substantial steering and camera coordination. The official description also warns of dangers in the depths, so a peaceful visual style is not proof of uniformly pressure-free play. Check whether turning, ascending, descending and stopping are comfortable before committing to the wider journey.

Try this first. Use the first suitable open-water area to practice a short forward swim and a gentle turn. Let a companion observe the controls rather than immediately taking over.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / I Promised a Private Ocean and Delivered a Hotel Pool

I told Shawna the pool would feel like the whole ocean belonged to us. Tank arrived wearing inflatable armbands. 'Nigga, your ocean got a lifeguard named Kevin.'

Blue light moved across the ceiling. Mercedes put on something slow. For a few minutes the water did make the room feel larger than the building.

Then a drunk adult guest stood beside the diving sign and announced that cocaine had made him an excellent swimmer. Kevin told him to take a seat. The nigga sat down with the offended dignity of an admiral relieved of command.

Rosa watched the light instead. Shawna leaned her head against my shoulder. I stopped describing ownership and listened to water moving against the edge.

Tank asked Kevin whether floating counted as exercise. 'Depends what you're carrying.' Tank looked down at his covered snack bowl.

'Nigga, this is resistance training.'

My wife laughed. There was my ocean. Not the pool. The laugh travelling across it.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the underwater atmosphere if swimming and camera control feel comfortable. Beauty can be a whole reason to visit; Kevin still refuses to certify anybody's aquatic boasting.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/384190/>

P098 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Journey

Edition considered: PC release

Travel through a landscape whose mood comes from movement, music, ruins and the possibility of meeting an unfamiliar companion.

What you do. Move through the world, explore its spaces and experience the journey's changing terrain and possible encounters with another traveler.

Movement + camera | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Gliding, movement and camera control remain necessary checks; companionship is not a promise of conventional controllable co-op.

Why it might click. Journey builds meaning through landscape, movement, music and the possibility of encountering another traveler. Its sparse presentation leaves room for the player to interpret the trip. This may appeal when the desired story is a feeling of passage or companionship rather than detailed dialogue and inventory puzzles.

The full catch. The experience still involves steering, gliding and moving through a three-dimensional environment. The possibility of another traveler is online companionship, not a promise of local couch co-op or a reliably present helper. Check camera comfort and later pressure before treating its quiet opening as representative of every scene.

Try this first. Cross one early area and notice whether movement and the visual direction feel natural. Decide whether the atmosphere is engaging before worrying about reaching the destination.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Stranger Helped Me Without Asking for a Photograph

I dropped the last chair cushion on the way to the rooftop lounge. A stranger caught it before it landed in a wet planter and handed it back.

'You know who I am?' I asked. 'Nigga with no cushion if I hadn't.'

Fair. We carried the chairs together. He pointed out a better patch of shade. I pointed out the table where Tank was defending a plate against the wind.

No introductions. No long explanation. Just a little shared movement toward somewhere pleasant. I found myself relaxing because the man did not seem interested in proving anything about either of us.

Shawna met us at the doors. I turned to thank him again, but he was already helping another couple with their bag.

'Get his name?' she asked. I shook my head.

Tank sat on the recovered cushion. 'Good nigga.'

I let that be the whole speech. The rooftop had enough air in it without me filling every inch.

Aiden's verdict. Take the journey if movement and its meeting-a-stranger mood appeal. Any companionship remains the game's actual design, not a promise of a fully controllable shared campaign.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/638230/>

P099 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

The Pathless

Edition considered: PC release

Explore a striking landscape with an archer and an eagle, if fluid movement and action are part of the desired attraction.

What you do. Travel across the world using the game's movement and archery systems, following a journey built around speed and motion.

Movement + camera | Action continues while you think | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Aiming, timing and traversal make this an action detour, rather than a dependable choice for avoiding reflex demands.

Why it might click. The Pathless combines a hunter, an eagle companion and a large mythic landscape. Movement and archery are part of its identity, alongside exploration of ruins and the story of a curse. It belongs here as a visually appealing action detour for someone specifically curious about that kind of movement.

The full catch. The primary description explicitly includes high-speed archery, acrobatics and boss battles. This is not an ordinary no-rush recommendation. The developer's forgiving treatment of permanent damage or death does not remove required reactions. Camera, aiming and combined inputs are central checks, and a strict no-reaction preference should send the reader elsewhere.

Try this first. Watch a short official gameplay sequence together, then test basic traversal only if that motion looks appealing. There is no obligation to turn admiration into play.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Eagle Declined My Invitation to Perform Indoors

The entertainment consultant offered a bird display. I imagined an eagle landing on my wrist while Shawna looked at me like a man whose problems were finally majestic.

Tank looked at the ballroom ceiling. 'Nigga, that bird got about three flaps before it owns the chandelier.'

The trainer said outdoors only. I said the doors were large. The eagle stared past me with the expression of somebody whose contract contained real boundaries.

Porsche moved the demonstration to the courtyard. Suddenly the trainer's precision made sense. Distance. Timing. Attention. This was not a quiet ornament that happened to have wings.

Shawna asked if I still wanted the dramatic landing. I watched the trainer work and handed back the glove. 'I want to keep these fingers available for married activities.'

The eagle settled exactly where it meant to. Tank applauded. 'First professional to visit this party.'

I joined in. Some spectacular things were worth watching without volunteering my wrist as the landing site.

Aiden's verdict. Keep this as an action detour if its demands genuinely appeal. Admiring a beautiful movement does not oblige anybody to perform it or lend the eagle a hand.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1492680/>

P100 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Feather

Edition considered: PC release

Fly through an island environment for the feeling of movement itself, without needing a conventional chain of quests to motivate you.

What you do. Steer a bird through the landscape, explore the airspace and enjoy the changing views and ambient surroundings.

Movement + camera | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Continuous steering and camera-related motion may be uncomfortable; open-ended flight does not establish hold-free or effortless play.

Why it might click. Feather offers bird flight around an island, with music and changing scenery as the reward. The developer explicitly describes a world without enemies, combat or threats and supports flying alone or with online players. Its appeal is movement for its own sake, rather than collecting equipment or following a character drama.

The full catch. The absence of threats does not make flight effortless. Continuous steering, orientation, camera motion and any held controls need a practical check. Online multiplayer is different from native local co-op. Someone who wants a substantial mystery or a clear sequence of tasks may find the open-ended flight less satisfying than the premise suggests.

Try this first. Try one broad circle above an open area. Check turning and camera comfort before exploring narrow passages or inviting another online flyer.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Feathered Man Had Misread the Dress Code

The invitation said FEATHER LIGHT EVENING. A grown man arrived in a cape wide enough to require its own revolving door. Tank backed away. 'Nigga, you migrating?'

He spread both arms. The cape knocked a champagne flute off a tray. Porsche caught it. Mercedes moved her dress clear before the bird could take another victim.

I took him to the terrace where there was space. A breeze lifted the fabric. For one beautiful second the ridiculous man looked exactly as grand as he thought he did.

Shawna watched him turn. 'That's the part he came for.'

I understood. Sometimes you wanted motion without an assignment. A room large enough to let a stupid lovely thing happen.

Then the cape caught my cufflink. We shuffled together toward the railing like two expensive pigeons sharing a criminal record.

'Let go, nigga.' 'You let go.'

Tank photographed the rescue. My wife called it our first successful joint flight.

Aiden's verdict. Visit for free flight if steering and camera movement feel good. The pleasure may be motion itself; my cufflink does not qualify as a multiplayer feature.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam app 545040, Feather; rejected Feather Land match. Developer explicitly describes no enemies/combat/threats and online multiplayer. Flight comfort remains untested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/545040/>

Darnell Tried to Sell the Sunset

Darnell caught me by the terrace door and offered access to an exclusive boat gathering. 'You mean your yacht?' I asked. He nodded like he had just unveiled a new continent. Mercedes, passing behind him, said, 'Nigga been describing the same railing since seven.'

He wanted the party to move. Rosa had a stage here. Shawna had a room here. Tank had food here and had already formed a committed relationship with the waiter bringing more. Darnell's proposal consisted of leaving all that to admire a possession while he supplied commentary. Even I could see the weakness, and my entire wardrobe was built on similar arguments.

He tapped his lapel and mentioned cocaine again. Porsche handed him a napkin for the stain, then pointed him toward a chair. 'Sit down, Captain Powder. The sunset doesn't need a promoter.' Nobody volunteered for the boat. Darnell finally looked beyond the railing and found the sky doing something worth shutting up for.

Mercedes put on the song she'd wanted us to hear. Rosa listened. Shawna slipped her hand into mine. For a whole chorus nobody asked what the moment would earn or prove. I could feel my next boast waiting behind my teeth, offended by the lack of employment.

Then Tank whispered that the warm bread had arrived. We carried the quiet back inside with us rather than pretending it would last forever. Darnell stayed at the rail. When we returned, he was taking a photograph of the sky with no yacht in it. Mercedes looked over his shoulder. 'There you go, nigga. Finally a subject with range.'

P101 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

AER Memories of Old

Edition considered: PC release

Explore floating islands and old ruins through a journey that changes between walking and bird flight, with mystery in its setting.

What you do. Travel on foot and in bird form, visit islands and investigate ruins or temples along the wider journey.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Switching movement modes, flying and camera coordination need checking; atmospheric exploration is not automatically a simple control task.

Why it might click. AER combines bird transformation, floating islands and the investigation of an old, broken world. Flying between places and entering temples gives its mystery a distinctive rhythm. The visual simplicity may make the landscape inviting, while the pilgrimage provides more direction than an entirely open-ended flight toy.

The full catch. Changing between flight and on-foot exploration means learning more than one movement pattern. Check steering, landing, camera behavior and the controls used inside temples. Puzzles and route-finding add another layer. The official atmospheric description does not establish an absence of all timing demands or a hold-free route through the complete game.

Try this first. Try one short flight and a controlled landing, then explore a small nearby space. Decide whether the transformation feels pleasurable before following the wider pilgrimage.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Rooftop Tour Acquired Wings and a Liability Waiver

The hotel advertised a transformation experience. I expected a new suit. A performer stepped out wearing a bird mask and asked whether I was ready to discover my freedom.

Tank looked at the mask. 'Nigga, he better discover where he parked first.'

We followed him onto the roof. Floating lights made the separate terraces look like islands. Mercedes stopped teasing long enough to watch the spaces between them.

I spread my jacket and told Shawna I could fly. 'You can flirt,' she said. 'Stay in your qualification.'

That settled it. I leaned against the rail with both feet on the ground while the performer moved between the lights. Strange shapes, old stone, a little mystery in the distance.

Porsche handed me the waiver. I read the part about physical participation and passed. Tank applauded my restraint with one hand because the other held a plate.

Dre touched his blue lapel. 'Even the Crip keeping both feet down tonight.'

My wife tucked herself under my arm. Ground had its advantages.

Aiden's verdict. Try the changing forms and floating ruins if flight controls feel pleasant. The scenery can earn your attention without my jacket receiving official recognition as wings.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/331870/>

P102 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Proteus

Edition considered: PC release

Wander through a changing island whose sounds, colors and atmosphere provide the experience, without a conventional story directing every step.

What you do. Walk around the island, look at its surroundings and listen to how the place responds and changes.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The lack of a conventional objective may not appeal, and walking plus camera movement still need checking.

Why it might click. Proteus is an exploratory island experience in which the surroundings respond musically to where you go. It has little conventional instruction, text or plot. The pleasure comes from observation and the changing relationship between sound, color and place, rather than solving a case or completing a set of chores.

The full catch. Its minimal goals can be either freeing or frustrating. First-person movement and camera control remain necessary even when there are few menus. The lack of hints is a documented design choice, so someone who wants a clear next action should treat that as a meaningful catch. There is no basis here for promising that an unstructured world will feel easy.

Try this first. Walk toward one visible landmark and listen to what changes. If the absence of a stated objective feels empty rather than inviting, choose a more directed game.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Garden Refused to Tell Me What the Fuck It Wanted

I asked the concierge what we were supposed to do in the night garden. 'Enjoy it, sir.' Nigga had offered me an activity without a competitive structure.

I found this suspicious.

Tank went straight to a bench. Rosa listened to the insects beyond the lights. Mercedes walked until the music from the casino became a soft pulse behind the trees.

Shawna took my hand and moved me away from the sign announcing the garden's opening hours. I had been reading it like there might be a hidden mission.

'Baby, you can just be here.' 'I'm exceptionally good at being here.' 'Then shut up and demonstrate.'

The air smelled different beside the water. Lights changed when the breeze moved the leaves. No big speech from the garden. No appointment with its king.

I stood there with my wife until Tank called that the bench had begun charging him in mosquito bites. We went back because we wanted to, not because I'd finished nature.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the atmospheric wander if noticing a place is enough. Direction and camera comfort still matter; the garden will not provide a plot to justify the visit.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/219680/>

P103 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Dear Esther: Landmark Edition

Edition considered: PC Landmark Edition

Follow a voice through an atmospheric island, if fragments, uncertainty and the feeling of a place are more appealing than clear tasks.

What you do. Walk through the island while listening to narration and taking in the surroundings as the account gradually develops.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. First-person walking and camera use remain, and the fragmentary narrative may not satisfy a wish for clear resolution.

Why it might click. Dear Esther: Landmark Edition presents a remote island through walking, spoken fragments and music. Its story turns around loss, memory and interpretation. This is a route for someone interested in literary atmosphere and adult emotional material, with relatively little conventional inventory or puzzle activity described by the developer.

The full catch. The physical task is still first-person navigation. Check turning, walking holds, audio clarity, subtitles and how narration behaves when you stop or revisit a place. The fragmented telling may demand attention even without complex controls. Its bleak tone is central, and the Landmark Edition should not inherit unverified technical details from another release.

Try this first. Walk to the first narration trigger and listen to one passage. Consider both the movement and the form of storytelling before treating the island as a longer commitment.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Letter Wasn't a Love Letter and I Had Already Taken Credit

Mercedes read one line aloud from a strange letter somebody had left near the terrace. I immediately said it sounded like something I would write to Shawna.

My wife took it. 'Nigga, this man seems troubled.' 'Love is complicated.' 'You wrote bring the room key and wear that again.'

Tank said both authors had communicated a need.

The letter made the empty terrace feel different. A place could acquire a voice without the person standing there. Rosa wanted to hear the next line; Porsche wanted to know who had left it.

I wanted it to become a neatly solved little story. Mercedes folded the page halfway and said uncertainty could be the reason to keep listening.

Shawna returned my actual note, which she'd saved. Four lines. Terrible handwriting. She kissed me anyway.

I stopped competing with the mysterious writer. Nigga had an entire island of sorrow. I had a wife smiling beside the elevator.

Aiden's verdict. Take the narrated island if atmosphere and an unresolved voice appeal. It offers a particular listening mood; my four-line romance is neither a clue nor a walkthrough.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/520720/>

P104 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Everybody's Gone to the Rapture

Edition considered: PC release

Investigate an empty village by following traces of its people, piecing together a community's relationships and the mystery of their disappearance.

What you do. Explore village spaces and follow the story encounters, listening to conversations that reveal what happened to the community.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. First-person navigation and looking around are central, while unfolding encounters and their comfort need a practical check.

Why it might click. Everybody's Gone to the Rapture explores the vanished community of an English village through traces of conversations and events. Its mystery is inseparable from relationships, resentments and ordinary lives. The attraction is piecing together what happened to people rather than mastering combat or a large equipment system.

The full catch. The open environment requires first-person movement, orientation and finding the next useful trace. Spoken scenes and nonlinear order may create memory demands. Check interaction with the light phenomena, text support and walking controls in the PC version. A contemplative story still can be emotionally unsettling, and the source does not certify every interaction as untimed.

Try this first. Explore one small village area and follow one conversation fragment. Note a single person or question worth returning to, rather than attempting to map the entire community.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P104 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Everybody's Gone to the Rapture

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Everybody Left the Reception and the Band Kept Playing

I stepped out to answer a call. When I returned, the terrace chairs were empty and somebody's drink was still cold on the table.

'Nigga?'

No answer. Music drifted from the speakers. A shawl on a chair. Tank's abandoned fork, which suggested circumstances beyond ordinary human understanding.

I walked through the quiet space noticing traces I'd ignored while the room was full. A pair of glasses. A folded message. Somebody had moved two chairs close together.

Then a door opened below. The entire party was at the late buffet. Shawna called up, 'You finished your important call?'

I had spent three minutes constructing a theory about absence. Tank held up a fresh plate. 'The chicken came out.'

Mercedes looked at the empty chairs from downstairs. 'Still a good picture.'

It was. The place held the shape of people after they'd gone. I joined them before the picture included me as the last nigga to miss dinner.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the village mystery if piecing together an absent community sounds compelling. Camera and walking remain practical checks; the abandoned fork is evidence only in our hotel.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/417880/>

P105 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

What Remains of Edith Finch

Edition considered: PC release

Discover a family's strange and moving history through the rooms and stories left behind in an unusually detailed house.

What you do. Explore the house and enter its different narrative episodes, following the changing interactions used to tell each story.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Episode controls vary and the material is emotionally intense; a compelling premise does not establish physically simple play.

Why it might click. What Remains of Edith Finch uses a remarkable family home to connect a series of short, varied stories. The attraction is the inventive relationship between each person's life and the way their story is presented. It offers rich emotional material without requiring the player to manage a conventional role-playing character sheet.

The full catch. Variation is also the principal control catch. The developer explicitly says the gameplay changes between family stories, so learning the opening does not establish a stable interaction pattern for the whole game. First-person navigation and later combinations need checking. Death is central throughout; this is a content preference to consider, not a surprise to conceal behind the attractive house.

Try this first. Explore an early room and assess the first change of interaction. Continue because that style of storytelling interests you, not because the opening seemed mechanically simple.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Family Portrait Fell Off the Wall During My Speech

The hotel put me beneath a wall of old family photographs and handed me a microphone. I announced that every great man deserved a dynasty.

A portrait behind me slipped off its hook. Tank caught it against his chest. 'Nigga, yours trying to leave.'

The photograph showed an old couple by the same pool before the building had become enormous. Shawna asked who they were. The manager knew a little. His grandmother had worked there.

He told us one story. Then another. The woman in the picture stopped being decoration. Rosa pulled a chair close. Mercedes lowered her phone instead of turning the moment into content.

I looked at the microphone in my hand. My speech had been mostly about future statues. The manager was talking about somebody's favorite song.

We put the portrait somewhere safe. Tank asked if I still wanted to address the room.

'Later,' I said. 'Nigga might need a better definition of dynasty.'

Aiden's verdict. Visit the family's strange stories if their form and darker subject matter appeal. Varied first-person interactions need checking; being moved by a premise does not settle controls.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/501300/>

P106 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Gone Home

Edition considered: PC release

Learn about a family by exploring their house and noticing personal traces, letting ordinary objects reveal relationships and hidden stories.

What you do. Walk through the house, inspect belongings and follow the information they reveal about the people who lived there.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. First-person navigation, searching and remembering locations remain demands, and the atmosphere can feel tense despite its domestic setting.

Why it might click. Gone Home invites the player to understand a family by exploring its house and examining the things left behind. The personal story grows through rooms, possessions and written material. The developer explicitly describes no combat and no conventional puzzles, making investigation itself the central activity.

The full catch. First-person camera control, walking and inspecting objects still require comfort with navigation. Reading and keeping track of rooms may be more demanding than the mechanical premise suggests. The stormy, empty-house atmosphere can feel suspenseful even though the developer rules out attacks. Check text size and object manipulation instead of assuming the story's pace settles every concern.

Try this first. Investigate one room and choose one object or note that changes your understanding of the family. Test returning it and moving to the next doorway.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P106 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Gone Home

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Wife's Empty Room Had Too Much Evidence

I opened the suite and found Shawna gone. Her shoes were by the chair. A note lay on the bed. I immediately prepared to be a man discovering a devastating secret.

The note said POOL.

Tank read it over my shoulder. 'Nigga, case closed.'

But I had already started looking. Her little souvenir on the dresser. The book she'd brought and actually read. A photograph tucked into the mirror. Ordinary things made the room feel occupied even with nobody there.

Mercedes appeared in the doorway and caught me holding the photograph. 'You investigating or missing your wife?'

I put it back exactly where she'd left it. 'Both.'

At the pool Shawna asked why I'd taken so long. I told her I'd been following the evidence. She pulled me down beside her chair.

'What did you discover?'

'That you look better in person.' She smiled. Tank arrived behind me. 'And that the nigga needs help with a four-letter clue.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose the house if learning about people through their rooms sounds interesting. First-person movement remains part of the visit, however inviting the personal traces may be.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/232430/>

P107 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Firewatch

Edition considered: PC release

Follow a relationship built through radio conversations while exploring a wilderness setting whose isolation gives the story its particular mood.

What you do. Walk through outdoor areas, investigate the surroundings and speak by radio as the narrative and relationship develop.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Camera control, navigation and dialogue-response behavior need checking, particularly if any sense of urgency is unwelcome.

Why it might click. Firewatch combines an adult relationship over a handheld radio with exploration of the Wyoming wilderness. Its appeal is the interplay between place, conversation and a developing mystery. The characters have histories and imperfect motives, so the emotional complexity comes from people rather than elaborate combat systems.

The full catch. First-person movement, map use and terrain navigation are substantial checks. Dialogue response behavior also needs direct inspection: a conversation-driven game should not receive an unlimited-waiting claim without testing it. The developer describes suspense and adult themes. This is a conditional story candidate, especially if any feeling of urgency is unwelcome.

Try this first. Try the earliest ordinary radio exchange and a short walk. Check whether response choices allow the desired pace before investing in the relationship or mystery.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Walkie-Talkie Knew Too Much About My Marriage

I took the event radio so I could manage the roof like a man with tactical range. Shawna's voice came through it. 'Where are you?'

'On patrol.' 'You said that twenty minutes ago. I can see your reflection in the bar.'

Tank pressed his own radio. 'Suspect ordered another drink.'

I walked onto the quiet terrace. Now my wife's voice arrived from somewhere I couldn't see. The distance made me listen instead of trying to look impressive at the same time.

She asked what the city looked like. I described it badly. She corrected the detail she could see from her window. We laughed. A small conversation held the whole roof together.

Then Rosa came over the shared channel. 'Who got the cocaine nigga out of my dressing room?' Porsche answered that she'd done it and kept the room key.

Shawna paused. 'Come back, Captain.'

I returned the radio to Tank. Some towers were best reached by elevator.

Aiden's verdict. Try the wilderness conversation if that relationship interests you and first-person travel is comfortable. A voice can make a place intimate without removing the navigation demands.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/383870/>

P108 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Stanley Parable: Ultra Deluxe

Edition considered: PC Ultra Deluxe

Explore a comic argument between a narrator, a player and a game, where choosing a route changes the experience's direction.

What you do. Walk through the environment, make route choices and listen to how the narrator responds to what happens next.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. First-person movement, repeated passages and some darker content remain; inspect individual branches rather than assuming one uniform mood.

Why it might click. The Stanley Parable: Ultra Deluxe is a comic exploration of choices, narration and the rules games pretend to enforce. An office becomes the starting point for branches, contradictions and jokes that respond to what the player does. Its appeal is especially strong if arguing with an overconfident narrator sounds like entertainment.

The full catch. It uses first-person movement and contains many different branches. A simple corridor is not evidence that every ending has the same input or emotional demands. The developer lists added accessibility features, including content warnings, but their presence does not certify a no-hold or no-timing route. Check camera comfort and preview the relevant settings.

Try this first. Reach the first meaningful choice and follow the route you actually find amusing. Test pausing and leaving without treating every possible ending as an assignment.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Announcer Told Me to Take the Left Elevator

The casino voice told us the private party was through the left doors. I took the right ones. 'Nigga, I refuse to be predictable.'

We entered the linen room.

Tank picked up a towel. 'You have defied the system and discovered laundry.'

The voice continued outside, cheerful as hell, describing the marvelous evening awaiting its guests. I tried the next door. Kitchen. A cook handed me a tray because confidence apparently resembles employment.

Shawna found me carrying bread. 'How your rebellion going?' 'Feeding people.'

Mercedes leaned into the doorway and listened to the announcement. 'The voice doesn't know you wrong.'

That pleased me more than it should have. I considered making the detour into a philosophy. The cook asked whether my philosophy included taking the tray to table twelve.

I delivered the bread. Then I took the left elevator. Tank watched me press the button. 'Nigga discovered free will and chose the correct floor.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose the narrator's game if arguing with a designed situation sounds amusing. Its camera and particular darker or repetitive branches still need their own honest checks.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1703340/>

P109 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Beginner's Guide

Edition considered: PC release

Take a guided journey through game spaces that raises questions about creators, interpretation and what an observer can really know.

What you do. Move through the presented environments and listen to the narrator's account of the places and their possible meaning.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. First-person movement and camera control remain relevant, while detailed comfort and timing information are limited in the primary source.

Why it might click. The Beginner's Guide uses a sequence of game spaces and a narrator to tell a story about interpretation, creativity and a relationship to another person's work. It is a compact narrative experiment rather than a conventional quest or collection of systems. Its adult interest lies in the questions it raises about understanding and ownership.

The full catch. The primary description offers very little detailed control information. Do not turn its lack of traditional goals into a guarantee that every scene uses one simple input. First-person movement and changes between spaces should be checked directly. The story may also be emotionally uncomfortable rather than merely clever or relaxing.

Try this first. Experience the first short space and narration, then assess whether the combination feels compelling. Check movement and stopping behavior before following the entire sequence.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Tour Guide Was Talking About Me Again

I gave Mercedes a tour of the party and explained what every detail said about my inner life. She stopped at the first centerpiece.

'Nigga, this is rented.' 'The feeling is mine.'

Rosa asked whether the pianist wanted my interpretation of his arrangement. I said I could provide one. The pianist kept playing, which I chose to consider consent until Shawna elbowed me.

A room could mean something without needing its host to translate every object. I knew this in theory. In practice I had purchased a microphone.

Mercedes turned it off. We walked to a quiet corner. She pointed to a light somebody had put behind a curtain. Beautiful. Nobody offered a thesis. We let it stay beautiful for almost twelve seconds.

Then I asked if they wanted to know why I'd chosen that particular shade. Porsche said the rental company had one left.

Tank applauded from the buffet. 'Nigga's subconscious comes with next-day pickup.'

Aiden's verdict. Take the guided reflection if questions about creators and interpretation sound compelling. First-person travel still needs checking; the host's explanation is not automatically the room's truth.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/303210/>

P110 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Vanishing of Ethan Carter Redux

Edition considered: PC Redux edition

Explore an atmospheric valley through an occult investigation and a dark family mystery, if unsettling discovery is part of the appeal.

What you do. Move through the valley, examine traces and reconstruct events connected to the investigator's search and the family's story.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Horror, violence, first-person controls and scene-specific interactions remain catches; keep Redux edition and installation details straight.

Why it might click. The Vanishing of Ethan Carter follows an occult-minded investigator through a detailed valley and a dark family mystery. Observation and reconstructing events give the landscape narrative purpose. It may appeal to someone who wants grown-up detective atmosphere with supernatural unease rather than a large combat system.

The full catch. The developer describes no combat, but that does not erase horror, violence or first-person navigation. Check scene-specific interaction, camera use and any unsettling sequences before promising a relaxed route. This card targets Redux; the inspected store treats it as content associated with the original product, so edition and installation details must be kept straight.

Try this first. Explore an early outdoor area and inspect one trace. Decide whether the visual atmosphere feels intriguing rather than oppressive before advancing into the darker investigation.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Beautiful Valley Had Not Agreed to Be My Holiday Advertisement

I told the photographer our event needed a mysterious atmosphere. He dimmed the corridor and aimed the lights toward an old portrait. Suddenly the hotel looked like somewhere a rich man might vanish.

Tank took one look. 'Nigga, put the cheerful lights back. I ain't paying to become evidence.'

Mercedes stayed at the doorway. The place was beautiful in a way that made her want to ask what had happened there. Rosa said curiosity did not mean she wanted to be frightened all evening.

Shawna listened to both and moved the party room lamps closer. A boundary appeared without an argument. Mystery over there. Warm chairs here.

I had been ready to sell everybody the same mood because I'd paid for it. My wife handed me the unused lighting invoice.

'You can like a thing without dragging every nigga into it.'

I folded the invoice. The corridor kept its secrets. The buffet kept its customers.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the dark investigation only if its unease is welcome. Lovely scenery does not cancel horror, camera movement or the need to inspect scene-specific demands.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Redux store entry and linked base-game store. Redux is described as associated content; base page supports the remaster relationship, mystery and no combat. Exact Redux input behavior remains untested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/400430/>

Source 2: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/258520/>

The Hotel Map Had a Better Night Than I Did

Porsche spread the hotel map across a clean table. A route to Rosa's stage. Another to the quiet lounge. The terrace, the buffet, the suite. I drew a line connecting all of them and called it the optimum evening. Shawna erased three stops. 'My evening got fewer errands.'

Tank drew a loop around the food. Mercedes drew no line at all. She knew where she wanted to sit and did not need a journey to make the choice respectable. Dre asked which tables had two genuine player positions. The map got useful the moment the niggas stopped pretending we all wanted the same night.

I tried explaining that forty games could become an adventure through forty possible moods. Rosa touched my arm. 'Aiden, they can also pick one.' I understood the sentence. Accepting it required another sip of water.

We kept the useful routes short. A scenic idea came with its actual movement demands. A strange mystery carried its dark content. A game that expected quick action stayed marked that way even if the view looked like heaven with a marketing budget. Nothing got promoted merely because I had written a good joke beside it.

Shawna folded the map until only our route upstairs remained visible. 'This one,' she said. I lowered my voice before making another romantic claim, remembering the microphone. Tank watched us leave the table. 'Nigga learned from consequences.' I offered him a dignified nod. He pointed at my jacket caught on the chair. 'Not all of them. Turn around, Romeo.'

P111 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

INFRA

Edition considered: PC complete game

Investigate the workings and failures of a detailed built environment, if infrastructure and noticing how places function sound intriguing.

What you do. Explore industrial spaces, examine structures and machinery, and follow the problems revealed by the environment as you investigate.

Movement + camera | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Hazards, navigation and camera demands keep this a conditional action-oriented detour, despite its unusual non-soldier premise.

Why it might click. INFRA makes structural inspection into a detailed environmental puzzle adventure. Photographing damage, tracing routes and uncovering how a city's systems failed can appeal to someone fascinated by real places and hidden institutional stories. The mystery grows from infrastructure rather than fantasy combat equipment.

The full catch. The developer explicitly describes hazards and a fight for survival despite the absence of guns. This is therefore an investigative detour, not an automatic calm-walking recommendation. First-person navigation, environmental puzzles, resource handling and dangerous situations need direct checks. A camera as the main tool does not mean the game behaves like a leisurely photo album.

Try this first. Inspect a short, ordinary early area and try documenting one defect. Assess movement and the first hazard warning before deciding whether this kind of investigation is enjoyable.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P111 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

INFRA

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Champagne Fountain Was a Plumbing Problem in Formal Wear

The fountain stopped halfway through my toast. Champagne crawled down the outside instead of staying in the expensive part. Tank moved his plate under it.

'Nigga, don't assist the leak.' 'I'm containing losses.'

A maintenance woman knelt beside the base. I asked how long the repair would take. She asked which idiot had moved the unit onto an uneven carpet.

Shawna pointed at me without looking up.

I followed the woman into the service passage. Pipes, switches, little warnings I had walked past all night because they didn't have my name on them. Every grand room upstairs depended on this plain machinery working.

She found the problem. I offered a theory. She handed me a towel.

By the time we returned, Mercedes had moved the toast to the bar. Rosa had started singing. Nobody missed the fountain.

The repair woman wrote the charge. Tank peered over my shoulder. 'Nigga, infrastructure has met your ass personally.'

Aiden's verdict. Try the infrastructure investigation if noticing how places work is the attraction. Its hazards and camera demands keep this out of any automatic easy-evening promise.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/251110/>

P112 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Obduction

Edition considered: PC release

Enter an unfamiliar world assembled from strangely recognizable pieces, with exploration and mechanisms giving its mystery something concrete to investigate.

What you do. Move through the environment, inspect structures and work out relationships between mechanisms and the spaces they affect.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Free camera control, navigation and linked puzzles can be demanding; the mysterious premise does not establish comfortable operation.

Why it might click. Obduction places fragments of familiar life inside an alien setting and asks the player to investigate how its worlds work. Environmental puzzles and the desire to understand the place provide the story's momentum. Its appeal is the patient discovery of connections that initially seem unrelated.

The full catch. The game is visually and spatially elaborate. Walking, looking, operating devices and remembering how places connect can be substantial demands. This card proposes the ordinary screen version, not VR. The primary description establishes an exploration puzzle adventure with consequential choices, not a blanket absence of timing, holds or difficult navigation.

Try this first. Inspect one nearby structure and test a single interaction. Keep a brief note or image of the immediate question before exploring several routes at once.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Elevator Opened onto Somebody Else's Theme Night

I pressed the button for the lounge and stepped into a desert wedding. Plastic cactus. Purple lights. A man in silver boots asking whether I was the groom.

'Nigga, my wife better not hear that.'

Shawna stepped out behind me. 'Too late.'

The whole floor looked familiar in pieces and wrong as a whole. Hotel carpet under desert scenery. Ordinary doors hidden inside impossible rockwork. Mercedes touched a wall and laughed at how quickly the room had changed her bearings.

Tank asked the groom where the food was. The actual groom, fortunately, found this reassuring. Somebody still recognized the basic purpose of a party.

I tried to trace our route back. Porsche found the elevator behind an enormous fake moon. We returned with two wedding favors and no useful understanding of the floor plan.

Shawna squeezed my hand. 'Strange world, baby.'

I checked the next floor number twice. One marriage was already giving me enough adventure.

Aiden's verdict. Visit the displaced-world mystery if strange surroundings invite you in. Navigation and linked mechanisms are part of the work, even when the opening is wonderfully bewildering.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/306760/>

P113 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Myst

Edition considered: 2021 PC remake; not the 1993 original

Explore an enigmatic island of structures and mechanisms, if a place that gradually reveals its logic sounds like a compelling destination.

What you do. Visit parts of the island, inspect objects and solve mechanisms to uncover routes and more of its mystery.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. This is the 2021 remake: free movement, camera use, device manipulation and clue memory still need checking.

Why it might click. Myst combines a mysterious island, linked worlds and a story of family betrayal with environmental puzzles. The attraction is learning how a place works through observation and inference. This entry targets the 2021 remake, whose presentation and controls differ from the original screen-by-screen game.

The full catch. Do not assume the old game's navigation applies to the remake. Free movement, camera control, device manipulation and remembering clues all require checking. The developer documents an in-game photo feature that may help preserve clues, but VR comfort features should not be misrepresented as ordinary-screen settings. Puzzle difficulty can remain considerable regardless of input comfort.

Try this first. Explore one small area, photograph one useful-looking clue and test one mechanism. Use that concrete question to decide whether the island's style of reasoning is appealing.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Book Had Better Travel Arrangements Than My Concierge

The hotel left a glossy book about its properties on our table. I opened to a private island and told Shawna we should go there immediately.

'Nigga, you can't book a honeymoon every time you turn a page.'

'Watch me.'

Mercedes tapped a photograph of a stone building. What was inside? Why that doorway? The picture made the destination feel like a question instead of a list of amenities.

Tank opened to the restaurant pages. His questions were more direct.

I wanted an island with secrets because the hotel's secrets had mostly become additional charges.

Shawna wanted to inspect how we would move around before I announced ownership of the horizon.

Porsche held up my phone. The concierge had replied to my message with a booking link. No magical transport. Just a deposit big enough to alter my posture.

I closed the brochure. My wife reopened the interesting page. 'Looking is still free, nigga.' We stayed there a while.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the island puzzle if exploring a mysterious place appeals. Match controls to the exact edition; my brochure's gorgeous photographs do not settle how the journey works.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1255560/>

P114 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Riven

Edition considered: 2024 PC remake; not the 1997 original

Explore a densely designed island world in its modern remake, where careful attention to the place supports solving its mysteries.

What you do. Move through the rebuilt world, investigate its structures and work out how its mechanisms and locations relate.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The remake's free three-dimensional movement differs from the older edition, and its interlinked puzzles can create substantial remembering work.

Why it might click. Riven asks the player to understand a richly connected world and the power shaping it. Observation of the environment supplies information that later becomes meaningful, making discovery feel like learning a place rather than completing disconnected puzzles. The 2024 remake expands and reimagines the original game's world.

The full catch. The remake explicitly uses free movement in a three-dimensional environment. That matters for camera comfort and must not be confused with the 1997 original's screen navigation. Its interlocking clues also make memory and note-taking significant. This is a deliberate reasoning stretch, not an easy label earned by the absence of a weapon.

Try this first. Observe one small area and record a single pattern or symbol without demanding an immediate solution. Test movement and view control before building a large notebook.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Sequel Had Rebuilt the Entire Island and Kept the Confusion

I returned to a themed suite I swore I remembered. Somebody had changed the doors, the lights and the corridor. I led everyone confidently into the closet.

Tank stepped around a robe. 'Nigga, your nostalgia got shelves.'

The manager explained the renovation. Same property. Different layout. Shawna asked which route actually reached the balcony. I said I was refreshing my knowledge. Mercedes said I was standing inside a wardrobe.

We started again. This time I looked. The rebuilt space was beautiful, but the relationships between its parts needed learning. A familiar name on the key did not make every action familiar.

Porsche found the balcony mechanism. Rosa opened the curtains. The view finally arrived with all of us facing the right direction.

I leaned against the rail and told Shawna I'd known where we were going.

She kissed me, then tucked the closet key into my pocket. 'Keep a little piece of your homeland.'

Aiden's verdict. Take the remade island if its dense place-making interests you. Familiarity with an older version does not guarantee the same camera, movement or interaction demands.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1712350/>

P115 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Firmament

Edition considered: PC non-VR mode proposed for assessment

Explore strange machinery and environments with an unusual assistant, if figuring out how a constructed world works sounds rewarding to you.

What you do. Travel through mechanical environments, operate the Adjunct device and interpret machinery while following the mystery and a speaking companion.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Assess desktop separately from VR; moving, looking, targeting devices and sequencing puzzles still need practical checks.

Why it might click. Firmament offers a puzzle adventure through large mechanical environments, using a device called the Adjunct to interact with their systems. The mystery concerns the purpose of the realms and the companion who speaks to you. It may appeal to someone who enjoys machinery as part of a world's history.

The full catch. The imposing spaces require navigation and camera control, while device puzzles add interpretation and sequencing. Assess the ordinary-screen version separately from VR; the developer's VR comfort list does not automatically describe a desktop control solution. A recurring tool can simplify the vocabulary without making all its uses physically or mentally simple.

Try this first. Try the first device interaction and identify exactly what changed. Check moving, looking and targeting the mechanism before deciding whether the broader machine world is inviting.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Mechanical Assistant Had a Better Union Than Tank

I ordered a little motorized trolley to carry our drinks. Tank watched it roll across the floor and asked what benefits it had.

'Nigga, it's a machine.' 'So no health plan. Same as me.'

The trolley stopped beside a decorative mechanism and refused to move farther. I pressed a button. Nothing. Shawna pointed to a different control on its handle.

I liked the idea of working with something that changed what the environment would let us do. I liked it less when it waited for me to understand the arrangement.

Mercedes placed one glass on it and watched the route. Rosa moved a chair out of the way. A tiny bit of cooperation made the whole setup useful.

Then Tank put the entire dessert tray on top. The trolley beeped.

'Weight limit,' the manager said.

Tank took the tray back. 'Nigga, I respect a professional boundary.'

I could not get him to extend that policy to my ego.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the mechanical world if its assistant-and-environment relationship appeals. First-person camera and navigation remain significant checks; a useful companion does not operate the whole game for you.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/754890/>

P116 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Witness

Edition considered: PC release

Explore an island of line puzzles that gradually teach their own rules, with discovering connections providing the main sense of progress.

What you do. Walk between puzzle panels, study their patterns and draw solutions as new relationships emerge across the island.

Mixed controls | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Camera movement, precise line drawing and demanding reasoning remain important; its understated presentation does not mean effortless play.

Why it might click. The Witness develops a large collection of line puzzles across an explorable island. Its particular pleasure is discovering what a visual rule means through examples, then recognizing a new twist. The environment becomes part of the thinking, so looking carefully can matter as much as manipulating the panel.

The full catch. First-person walking and camera control separate one puzzle from another. Drawing lines may involve precision or held input, and the reasoning becomes demanding. The presence of many apparently static panels does not prove the entire game has no timed or pressure-based content. Check the chosen route and ordinary panel interaction rather than offering a universal calm-game guarantee.

Try this first. Try a few introductory panels and stop when a new rule becomes interesting. Assess the drawing action itself and avoid treating the full island as a completion obligation.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P116 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The Witness

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Line Went Somewhere and I Wasn't Invited

Shawna traced a route across the casino floor plan with one finger. I watched it bend around the bar and end at our suite.

'Baby, is this a proposition?' 'It's how you stop getting lost.'

Mercedes found the little pattern satisfying. Tank asked why my route included three buffet passes. I said those were landmarks. He said they were ambitions.

The pleasure was in noticing that a line could obey a rule and suddenly explain a space. I tried another route. It failed. Nobody fell over. Nobody needed a speech about it.

Then I began adding my initials to the pattern. Shawna took the pen away.

'Nigga, solve what's there.'

I looked again. The answer had been under my hand. Tank watched my face change and pushed his plate toward the newly correct line.

'Good. Now witness this shortcut to dinner.'

My wife kept the route to the suite for later. I took that as a better prize.

Aiden's verdict. Try the island's line puzzles if discovering rules sounds enjoyable. Walking, camera movement and precise drawing are separate demands from the satisfaction of seeing a pattern.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/210970/>

P117 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Talos Principle

Edition considered: PC original release; not Reawakened

Work through spatial puzzles while encountering philosophical questions about purpose and existence, if thinking about both systems and ideas sounds appealing.

What you do. Explore puzzle spaces, move through their mechanisms and read or encounter the material that develops the philosophical story.

Movement + camera | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The original PC game includes drones and time-related puzzle mechanics; camera movement, object handling and spatial planning need checking.

Why it might click. The Talos Principle combines environmental puzzles with questions about personhood, authority and the remains of human civilization. Devices, beams and other mechanisms create practical problems, while texts and choices add an adult philosophical story. It offers both a place to think and something specific to manipulate.

The full catch. This entry targets the original PC game, not Reawakened. Movement, camera control, object handling and spatial planning all require assessment. The developer explicitly includes drones and time-related puzzle mechanics, so a turn-like appearance in some rooms should not become a claim of universal waiting. Reading and remembering relationships can also be substantial.

Try this first. Attempt one introductory device puzzle and read one optional piece of story material. Decide whether both halves are enjoyable before pursuing a larger sequence of rooms.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Robot Asked Whether I Was Qualified to Be Human

The casino hired a silver-painted performer to welcome guests. I told him I was the most important human in the room. He tilted his head.

'On what evidence?'

Tank nearly swallowed a mint. 'Nigga, the robot got questions.'

I listed my achievements. Shawna asked if any included remembering her dinner order. The performer kept his beautiful metal face perfectly still, which made the silence expensive.

We fell into an argument about intelligence, purpose and whether a man who could rent a ballroom should automatically be allowed to arrange it. Mercedes took the machine's side. Rosa asked whether it could help with the sound check.

I enjoyed the questions once I stopped treating them as an attack on my species. A puzzle with an idea behind it might keep me interested longer than a room full of applause.

Then the performer removed his helmet to drink water.

'Nigga,' Tank said. 'It got thirsty before Aiden got humble.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose the philosophical puzzles if the questions themselves attract you. Their intellectual invitation comes with spatial machinery and camera demands, which still deserve a practical trial.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/257510/>

P118 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Talos Principle 2

Edition considered: PC base game

Enter a larger philosophical puzzle journey where a society's choices and ambitions give new meaning to the machinery and places explored.

What you do. Travel through puzzle environments, investigate mechanisms and follow conversations or discoveries about the society and its possible future.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The larger world and more machinery increase navigation and reasoning demands; its ideas do not simplify the controls.

Why it might click. The Talos Principle 2 develops its puzzle world into a more populated, character-driven discussion of civilization and its future. New devices and abilities accompany conversations and choices. It may appeal when philosophical ideas become more engaging through people who disagree about them.

The full catch. The large environments retain movement and camera demands, and new mechanics increase the amount to learn. The developer says the game can be finished without solving every puzzle, which may help set expectations, but that does not establish a low-input route. Check device manipulation, navigation and the difficulty of ordinary required puzzles.

Try this first. Try an introductory puzzle and one conversation. Use those two activities to judge the balance of physical interaction, reasoning and story, rather than aiming to master every optional challenge.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Robots Built a City and Asked Me Not to Name It

I proposed calling the new hotel annex Aidenopolis. Mercedes said the people who would use it might have ideas. I said those ideas could be considered after the sign.

Shawna put the model building in front of her. 'Nigga, who lives here?'

'Important people.' 'Doing what?'

Tank placed a tiny chair beside it. Rosa moved a miniature stage away from the imaginary bedrooms. Suddenly we were discussing a place instead of my lettering.

A society had choices to make. Space. Comfort. What it valued enough to build. I found that more interesting than I expected, particularly once Mercedes stopped every sentence that began with my name.

Then Porsche added a little library. I asked where the statue went. She pointed to the storage box.

'Future generations can discover you when they need spare parts.'

Tank leaned down to the tiny city. 'Congratulations, my niggas. You have survived the founding father.'

Aiden's verdict. Take the larger philosophical journey if a society's choices interest you. Its scale and machinery also expand the demands; grand ideas are not a shortcut around navigation.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/835960/>

P119 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Looker

Edition considered: PC release

Explore a comic response to familiar puzzle-game conventions, if playful surprises and jokes about apparent profundity sound like a good evening.

What you do. Move through the island, inspect puzzle situations and try the interactions that reveal the jokes within their setup.

Mixed controls | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. First-person camera use and drawing or other puzzle actions still need checking despite the comic tone.

Why it might click. The Looker uses an island of puzzles to make jokes about a familiar style of serious puzzle adventure. The attraction is the combination of solving something and recognizing the absurdity around it. A little familiarity with the genre may make the satire richer, but curiosity about the joke can be enough to begin.

The full catch. Its compact comic premise does not certify easy controls or uniformly untimed play. First-person movement, drawing interactions and changing puzzle expectations should be checked directly. Humor also depends on taste; someone who wants an absorbing character story may prefer a different route. This is an editorial puzzle-comedy candidate, not a guarantee based on its brevity.

Try this first. Try the first small cluster of puzzles and see whether the jokes make the thinking more enjoyable. Stop freely if the parody feels like commentary on a party you did not attend.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P119 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The Looker

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Puzzle Had Been Laughing at Me for Ten Minutes

I stood in front of a decorative maze on the wall and delivered an explanation of its deeper meaning. Mercedes listened with a straight face, which should have frightened me.

Tank waited until I mentioned the relationship between man and destiny. Then he turned the sign around.

EXIT.

'Nigga,' he said. 'You have interpreted a door.'

I laughed despite myself. The room had set up an expectation and let my confidence fall through it. Shawna kissed my cheek. 'You looked very thoughtful.'

'I am thoughtful.' 'You trying to draw a solution on the emergency plan.'

Porsche brought me another little visual joke from the party favors. This time I let the joke arrive before I built a monument over it.

It felt good. Being surprised without having to defend my first impression.

Mercedes took the marker away anyway. 'For the hotel's protection.' The niggas let me keep my dignity, mostly because it was already too damaged to fit in the deposit.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the parody if being teased by puzzle conventions sounds entertaining. Check its camera and interaction demands separately; a funny idea still needs a workable way to play.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1985690/>

P120 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Outer Wilds

Edition considered: PC base game; expansion assessed separately

Investigate a small solar system whose discoveries build on one another, if exploration and understanding are worth accepting a demanding structure.

What you do. Travel between locations, investigate discoveries and connect information gathered during repeated journeys through the solar system.

Movement + camera | Action continues while you think | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. A repeating time loop, flight and other action demands make this a clearly marked detour for a no-rush preference.

Why it might click. Outer Wilds builds a remarkable mystery around a small, changing solar system. Exploration and accumulated understanding reveal how its worlds connect. It belongs in the panorama because curiosity, discovery and a sense of place are central to its appeal, even though its demands differ sharply from the opening route.

The full catch. The official description explicitly identifies a time loop, environments that change with time, hazards and oxygen management. Flight and first-person navigation add major control demands. A strict no-rush preference makes this a detour, not a match. Do not imply that a companion, pause setting or familiarity removes those systems without evidence.

Try this first. Look at the premise or share a brief, spoiler-light official gameplay preview. Consider direct play only if timed exploration and flight are appealing rather than merely tolerable.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Sun Went Out and Tank Asked for a Refund

The rooftop party package included an artificial sunrise. I had paid extra for this because actual sunrise kept inconvenient hours. The lights began their grand sequence and then went dark.

Tank raised his glass. 'Nigga, you broke tomorrow.'

The technician restarted the program. Same glow. Same music. Same hopeful little horizon. Then darkness again. Mercedes asked whether we were learning anything between attempts.

Shawna found the technician instead of accusing the sky. Rosa moved the performance indoors. Porsche located the faulty connection while I considered a lawsuit against dawn.

Every repetition made the room more familiar, but familiarity did not mean everybody wanted the cycle. Tank wanted breakfast. My wife wanted the real balcony.

I followed her outside. The actual sky was changing without my package.

'Beautiful,' I said.

'And it won't wait because you rented a better suit.'

Behind us the fake sun failed a third time. Tank applauded. 'Encore, motherfucker. Same disappointment, excellent consistency.'

Aiden's verdict. Keep the time-loop exploration as a clearly marked detour. Curiosity can be powerful, but repeated timed cycles and flight demands remain real reasons to choose another page.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Primary storefront inspected for this game's premise and described mechanics. Input, pace and memory labels are editorial route aids; the card names unresolved control or whole-game checks. No hands-on completion audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/753640/>

The Real View Had Been There the Whole Time

Rosa finished her song with the terrace doors open. The last note carried into the warm air and stopped people without asking permission. Mercedes sat close to the speaker, hearing the work instead of monitoring who was impressed by it. Tank had finally put the fork down. Dre stood at the back with his empty casserole dish. Darnell was quiet enough to suggest either personal growth or a missing audience.

I looked around the room I'd tried so hard to turn into proof of myself. It was better while everybody was doing something I had not specified. Somebody compared two game pages. Somebody watched a friend play. Somebody had closed the book and gone out to see the city. No crisis. No failed evening. Just adults knowing when they liked a thing.

The manager arrived with the bill. I recognized the panoramic charge and pointed toward the real terrace. 'Nigga, that view was already outside.' He looked at the line, then at the wall upstairs visible through our open suite door. The projected beach was still frozen on an ocean that had never once managed to get wet.

Shawna took the bill, crossed out the package, and handed it back. 'He'll pay for the room. The horizon belongs to itself.' The manager considered arguing. Mercedes looked up. Tank stood. Not threatening. Just enormous and interested. The manager corrected the charge. A beautiful little sunset occurred over the invoice.

Dre gave Rosa the casserole dish to return later and took his jacket. Darnell started to describe the boat again. Porsche opened the elevator. 'Tell it to the lobby, nigga. They got fresh ears.' We all laughed, including him this time.

My wife led me upstairs. At the suite door she took the remote from my pocket and switched off the fake ocean. 'Now,' she said, 'about all that shit you announced over the speakers.' I loosened my tie. 'Baby, I believe in completing the promised experience.' She pulled me inside. The door closed before I could add a speech. Downstairs, Tank asked whether our package included breakfast.

Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. The Tellings Cut: original revised Panorama prose and production by ChatGPT; original game research and selection system retained. This is a separate adult comic companion to Ten Toes Down. Source novels and the first Panorama edition remain intact. All people participating in the fictional party scenes are adults; Lillian is addressed as the reader.

Voice sources sampled for this revision: the Niggatorial Tellings Book I funeral and first Vegas party, selected passages from Books II-VI, and the edition editorial record. Source repository Sodelin/Ten-Toes-Down; working base 4cdof7a6e36977ff0ac705a59ebe65407d1f2bee. Selected passages were read closely; no full reread of all six novels is claimed. The added game-night story is newly composed fiction.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

This adult comic edition includes frequent reclaimed in-group language, strong profanity, fictional cocaine and party references, sexual banter and non-graphic innuendo. Those scenes are separate from the factual game descriptions and are not descriptions of the developers or real readers.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS / THE TELLINGS CUT

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 4 OF SIX

The Casino Locked My Champagne in a Puzzle

Puzzles, mechanisms, creative toys and retro desktop diversions

Forty real games. Aiden has made it everybody's problem.

Adult comic edition: reclaimed in-group language, profanity, fictional cocaine references and sexual innuendo.

New ChatGPT prose under Nolan's creative direction.

Tellings Cut 2.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

How to find a game in this book

Each game starts with a short pitch, what you actually do, the controls and pace, the main catch, and a first action to try. These practical sections use plain language. The longer Aiden scene comes after them.

For a fast comparison, read the pitch and main catch on two or three pages. Use the alphabetical index to jump to a title. Choose the full story only when you want the comedy; it is never a prerequisite for understanding the game.

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. The labels mean: A place to start = a promising candidate; Read the catch first = a meaningful obstacle needs checking; A more demanding detour = a narrower or harder option. They describe the game, not the reader. Check the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspectiously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

Choose a game by its name

This is the quick route. Click any title, or turn to its page. Read the short pitch and main catch first; Aiden's scene follows the practical guide. The case number works across every format.

P126	A Good Snowman Is Hard To Build	12	P149	Return of the Obra Dinn	51
P128	A Monster's Expedition	15	P158	RollerCoaster Tycoon Deluxe	69
P121	Baba Is You	6	P157	SimCity 2000 Special Edition	67
P129	Bonfire Peaks	16	P124	Snakebird	10
P131	Braid, Anniversary Edition	20	P125	Snakebird Primer	11
P130	Can of Wormholes	17	P151	Sokobond	56
P146	Carto	45	P123	Stephen's Sausage Roll	8
P147	Chants of Sennaar	47	P153	Tametsi	60
P135	COCOON	26	P143	The House of Da Vinci	39
P155	Color a Dinosaur	64	P144	The House of Da Vinci 2	41
P127	Cosmic Express	14	P145	The House of Da Vinci 3	43
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P134	HUMANITY	25	P141	The Room Three	36
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P138	Monument Valley 2: Panoramic Edition	30	P159	Theme Hospital	71
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A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 4. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index near the front always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P121	P122	P123	P124	P125	P126	P127	P128
2. Ready for conversation	P129	P130	P131	P132	P133	P134	P135	P136
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P137	P138	P139	P140	P141	P142	P143	P144
4. Here for the atmosphere	P145	P146	P147	P148	P149	P150	P151	P152
5. Open to a wildcard	P153	P154	P155	P156	P157	P158	P159	P160

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

The Box Cost More Than What Was Inside It

'Nigga, open my champagne.' The host smiled and touched a brass dial. Nothing opened. I touched the invoice. The amount had opened parts of my nervous system I preferred to keep private. Tank walked around the carved box, looked for a hinge and asked whether the bottle knew it was in prison. The host said we were about to embark on an unforgettable journey. Shawna said the journey had already missed its dinner reservation.

The casino's lower lounge had been transformed for our second set of games. Not a paper office in sight. Marble tables. Velvet chairs. A chandelier so low Dre had ducked once and then taken personal offense. Little machines, strange pictures, locked compartments and an entire miniature city that somebody thought I could be trusted to govern. Mercedes read the sign over the door: THE INTELLECTUAL EXPERIENCE. 'Nigga,' she said, 'that phrase never comes before a reasonable bill.'

Rosa had just finished singing. She wanted food, a chair and a game she could choose without attending a lecture. Tank could supply advice about the first two. Shawna wanted to know what each game actually asked a person to do. Porsche had the hotel manager's number and was prepared to use it against anything that interfered with these modest ambitions. I wanted the locked bottle to open in a way that made the room applaud. Four separate projects had arrived in one suit.

Dre placed his casserole beside the miniature city and claimed a blue chair. 'Crip zoning,' he said. Mercedes moved the chair out of the walking route. 'Crip still gotta leave a path to the bathroom.' He looked at the space, nodded and moved his dish with him. The city's first planning dispute ended with everybody able to reach the toilet. I considered borrowing the technique for the actual hotel.

Darnell had found a new audience near the mechanical box. He mentioned cocaine, then the yacht, then a woman who had allegedly said the yacht was the best part of knowing him. 'Nigga, you telling that like a compliment?' Tank asked. Darnell clarified that she had admired its size. Shawna touched my arm before I could contribute. 'Don't.' The restraint nearly injured me. Mercedes moved Rosa's chair away from the story and toward the game she wanted to try.

The host finally explained the box. Look closely. Notice the moving part. Follow what changed. We could do that. Then he added a dramatic flourish about genius. Shawna held up a hand. 'Leave that bit out.' I objected because genius had been the part I intended to supply. She kissed me and said I could be sexy without turning every hinge into an intelligence contest. Tank asked whether that offer extended to all the niggas or whether marriage provided exclusive licensing. We began with one object. Mercedes found a detail. Rosa moved the lamp. Dre kept Darnell from balancing a drink on the mechanism. I followed a connection and heard a clean little click. Something opened. The satisfaction hit before I could market it. For a second I was simply glad to understand what the thing wanted from my hands.

Inside sat another box. Tank stared at it. 'Nigga, the champagne has a gated community.' The host smiled. Shawna laughed and pulled me into the chair beside hers. We had plenty of other choices on the tables. Nobody had to finish the box to earn a pleasant evening. I accepted that principle with considerable maturity, then asked the waiter to bring an ordinary bottle with an ordinary fucking cork.

P121 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Baba Is You

Edition considered: PC release

Discover puzzles where moving the words changes the rules, if a small action leading to a big conceptual surprise appeals.

What you do. Move around compact boards, push rule words into new arrangements and observe how the changed rules affect the puzzle.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The simple movement system supports difficult reasoning; verify movement repeat, undo and exact controls before choosing it.

Why it might click. Baba Is You turns the rules of a puzzle into objects you can move. A short arrangement of words can transform what a wall, flag or character does. The appeal is the surprise of realizing that the rule you assumed was fixed is actually the thing to manipulate.

The full catch. The small number of movement actions should not be confused with easy reasoning. The developer describes a large collection of increasingly inventive rule interactions. Reading the words, predicting consequences and revising a plan can become demanding. Check the exact movement, undo and restart controls rather than assuming they are comfortable because the board is compact.

Try this first. Try an introductory level and deliberately move one rule word. Observe what changes before attempting a long solution or consulting an entire set of hints.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Sign Said Aiden Is King Until My Wife Moved a Word

I hired a light-up sign for the casino lounge. AIDEN IS KING. Three separate panels, because even my modesty required modular construction.

Shawna moved one. KING IS AIDEN became AIDEN IS EXTRA when Mercedes found the rental company's spare lettering.

Tank laughed so hard he put his plate down. Nigga made room for the joke.

I tried to restore order. Porsche moved the KING panel over the buffet. Suddenly every adult in the room agreed with the new constitution.

The funny part was how little had changed physically. Same pieces. Different rule. My magnificent authority had become something anybody could push around.

'That's dangerous,' I said. 'For who?' my wife asked.

I kissed her and offered to negotiate a private monarchy upstairs. She turned the EXTRA panel toward me.

'Room service extra. Champagne extra. You? Nigga, consistently extra.'

I left the sign alone. For once the room's rules described its actual government.

Aiden's verdict. Pick the rule-changing puzzle if rearranging an idea sounds exciting. The controls can be small while the reasoning grows enormous, as my dismantled monarchy demonstrates.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/736260/>

P122 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Patrick's Parabox

Edition considered: PC release

Explore boxes within boxes, if discovering how nested spaces fit together sounds more interesting than following a conventional character story.

What you do. Move pieces through recursive box arrangements, reconsider the spatial relationships and try new paths through the compact puzzle.

Direction + buttons | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The developer declares untimed input, but nested relationships can create substantial reasoning and memory demands.

Why it might click. Patrick's Parabox explores boxes that contain other boxes, including recursive arrangements. The repeated act of pushing gains new meaning as the space folds into itself. Its interest is in discovering how a small set of relationships can support surprisingly rich puzzles.

The full catch. The current Steam listing declares play without timed input and keyboard-only support. Spatial nesting can still require holding several relationships in mind even when the controls are limited. Verify key repeat, undo and any zoom behavior in the actual version. There is little conventional character story to carry the experience if the recursive logic itself does not appeal.

Try this first. Play the earliest introduction to entering and leaving a box. Explain one relationship aloud if useful, then try a move that tests that explanation.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The VIP Room Was Inside Another VIP Room I Wasn't Allowed In

The casino sold me a private room inside a private room. I assumed this was the highest level of importance a man could rent without purchasing a small country.

At the inner door, the attendant asked for another wristband.

'Nigga, I'm the reason the outer room exists.' 'This is the inner experience, sir.'

Tank looked through the glass. 'They got the same shrimp.'

Shawna took the floor plan. Rooms inside rooms, each apparently promising to make the last one feel ordinary. Mercedes asked where the nesting stopped. The attendant smiled with the confidence of a man paid by the boundary.

I imagined pushing the whole inner room into the outer one. A satisfying little rearrangement. The hierarchy might fit differently.

Porsche opened a side door and found the two rooms shared a kitchen. Tank walked straight through it.

'Nigga, recursion has a buffet entrance.'

I followed my wife. We reached the center without upgrading our identities.

Aiden's verdict. Choose recursive box puzzles if nested spaces make you curious. The developer declares untimed input, but remembering how the layers relate remains the central challenge.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Steam developer description supports premise. Current developer declarations include Playable without Timed Input and Keyboard Only Option. Physical comfort, held inputs and reasoning load still need their stated checks; this is not a hands-on completion test.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1260520/>

P123 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Stephen's Sausage Roll

Edition considered: PC release

Work through compact spatial puzzles built around a comic cooking premise, if figuring out a demanding arrangement sounds satisfying.

What you do. Inspect the puzzle space, move through its arrangement and test how your actions change the problem in front of you.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The primary description is brief; controls and full-game timing remain unresolved, and the reasoning can be demanding.

Why it might click. Stephen's Sausage Roll is a compact three-dimensional puzzle game built around unusually exact spatial problems. Its appeal is the satisfaction of understanding a small arrangement deeply enough to make it work. It belongs on the reasoning shelf for someone who enjoys a stubborn little mechanism more than an expansive story.

The full catch. The inspected primary storefront supplies very little detailed control information, so this card does not certify timing, holds or the full interaction set. The title's cheerful food premise should not imply easy puzzles. Treat both input comfort and the amount of planning as questions for an early trial, with no expectation of quick completion.

Try this first. Inspect the first small puzzle and test a single movement. If the rules interest you, try one hypothesis; if they merely irritate, leave the plate unfinished.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P123 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Stephen's Sausage Roll

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Sausage Chef Asked Me to Stop Talking About My Equipment

The late buffet included a man grilling elaborate sausages. I watched him turn one and told Shawna he reminded me of a certain gifted husband.

She looked at the grill. 'Nigga, that one's burnt.'

Tank choked on a laugh. The chef kept working with the concentration of somebody who had heard every version of my joke and preferred his tongs.

I tried to recover by discussing technique. Mercedes asked what qualified me. 'Natural understanding of impressive meat.'

The chef handed me a plate. Empty. 'Hold this.'

I stood there while a small cooking problem received actual attention. Placement. Turning. The consequence of a careless move. Simple objects could create a serious puzzle without accepting my commentary.

Shawna finally took the plate from me. 'Good job, baby. You kept that part level.'

Dre applauded beside Tank. 'My Crip casserole got more experience than this nigga.'

The chef served my wife first. I respected the man's survival instinct.

Aiden's verdict. Try the compact puzzle if demanding spatial logic appeals. The brief source description leaves control details unresolved; the sausage jokes provide no evidence of mechanical simplicity.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-game Steam description is very brief ('A simple 3d puzzle game'); source supports identity and basic genre, not detailed control or difficulty certification. Scene is original fiction. Specific input and full-game timing remain to be checked.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/353540/>

P124 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Snakebird

Edition considered: PC original game

Guide an awkward growing creature through spatial puzzles, if planning around its shape sounds like an enjoyable challenge to explore.

What you do. Move the creature through a puzzle arrangement and account for how its changing shape affects the possible route.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The developer calls the puzzles challenging; colorful creatures and limited controls do not establish easy reasoning.

Why it might click. Snakebird makes the length and shape of its fruit-eating creatures central to spatial puzzles. What looks like a small comic animal becomes a tool for crossing, supporting and arranging a route. The attraction is the way a simple change in body length changes the whole problem.

The full catch. The developer explicitly calls the game deceptively challenging. A friendly drawing and a small board should not be sold as easy reasoning. Check directional input, switching between creatures and recovery from mistakes. The card does not establish universal no-timing behavior from genre alone; its strongest case is for a player who enjoys concentrated spatial experimentation.

Try this first. Try the earliest fruit-and-exit arrangement. Notice what the new length permits before attempting to plan several moves ahead.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Feather Boa Ate the Whole Dance Floor

Porsche's costume started as a feather collar. Every time somebody complimented it, she added another length. By midnight it stretched across two chairs and one unfortunate man's drink.

I told her more was always better. Shawna looked at my event invoice and declined to endorse the theory.

Tank tried to pass behind the boa. It followed him. 'Nigga, this bird got a trailer.'

We worked out how to move the ridiculous growing shape around the furniture. One turn solved a problem and created another. Mercedes lifted the end while Rosa rescued the drink.

I liked watching the room become a spatial question. I liked it less when the boa wrapped around my ankle.

'Don't panic,' Porsche said. 'I'm expensive,' I replied. 'That's not the same thing.'

Shawna freed me and kissed the top of my head. Tank told everybody the king had been defeated by accessories.

Porsche added another feather. Nigga, the creature was still feeding.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the bird puzzle if planning around an awkward growing shape sounds satisfying. Its bright appearance does not cancel the developer's warning about serious difficulty.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/357300/>

P125 / A PLACE TO START

Snakebird Primer

Edition considered: PC separate prequel game

Try a gentler introduction to Snakebird's spatial idea, if a clearer opening challenge makes discovering its rules more appealing.

What you do. Work through the separate Primer game's introductory puzzles, moving the creature and learning how its shape affects each route.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. This is the easier separate game, not a guarantee of effortless puzzles; movement and undo still need checking.

Why it might click. Snakebird Primer is a separate set of puzzles designed as a more approachable introduction to Snakebird's spatial ideas. The developer explicitly contrasts its easier island with the original game's serious challenges. It can be a useful place to discover whether moving and shaping these creatures is pleasurable before choosing the harder title.

The full catch. Easier is a comparison, not a personal guarantee. Directional movement, visual planning and keeping track of a changing shape still matter. Check undo, restart and control repetition in the exact release. The appeal remains puzzle logic rather than rich character dialogue, and a player need not graduate to the original game to justify enjoying this one.

Try this first. Complete or explore one introductory arrangement, focusing on how fruit changes the creature. Let curiosity about the next idea decide whether to continue.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Small Feather Boa Was Allowed to Attend Orientation

After the full feather disaster, Rosa cut a short strip from the costume supplies and put it on the table. 'Start with this.'

I objected to the reduced spectacle. Tank held up his stained sleeve. 'Nigga, spectacle already had a turn.'

Shawna arranged three glasses around the small boa. We worked out a route through them. Mercedes changed one thing and asked whether the same idea still worked.

It did not. Good. We could see why without losing the entire dance floor.

I stopped insisting that the first exercise resemble the grand finale. There was pleasure in recognizing a rule clearly enough to use it somewhere new.

Porsche watched us, then placed one extra glass in the way. 'Now do it while your reputation watching.'

Tank moved his chair closer. 'I'm his reputation. I ain't been impressed in years.'

My wife solved the little arrangement and slid it toward me. 'Your turn, big nigga. No cape required.'

Aiden's verdict. Start with Primer if the spatial idea appeals and a gentler introduction is wanted. A smaller opening challenge can still lead to worthwhile thinking without demanding spectacle.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1014140/>

P126 / A PLACE TO START

A Good Snowman Is Hard To Build

Edition considered: PC release

Make charming snowmen through compact spatial puzzles, if arranging a small scene is enough motivation to think through a problem.

What you do. Move around each small space and manipulate snowballs to find an arrangement that makes the intended snowman work.

Direction + buttons | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed and keyboard-only declarations help, but exact movement, holding and planning demands remain worth checking.

Why it might click. A Good Snowman Is Hard To Build makes a small, affectionate premise into a spatial puzzle: a monster creating snowmen. The compact scenes invite attention to a few objects and how their positions relate. It can offer a satisfying repeated activity without needing a sprawling world or a dense inventory story.

The full catch. The current developer listing declares play without timed input and keyboard-only support. Check movement, undo and snowball manipulation on the chosen device; those declarations do not establish that every action avoids holding. The puzzles still require planning and trial, so the gentle presentation should not become a promise of effortless solutions. Narrative is limited to the charm of the activity.

Try this first. Try making one snowman and notice where your first plan changes. Learn the recovery control before treating a mistaken move as a reason to restart everything.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P126 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

A Good Snowman Is Hard To Build

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Snowman Got Better Treatment Than the Guest of Honor

The casino installed an ice sculpture beside the bar. Three round sections. A charming face. I asked whether it could be made to resemble me.

The sculptor looked at the middle section. Tank said, 'Nigga, careful how you answer.'

Shawna adjusted its scarf. Rosa moved the spotlight so the face looked warm instead of interrogated. Mercedes put a little flower beside it. Suddenly everybody liked the snowman.

I asked what I had to do to receive this level of care. 'Stand still and stop narrating yourself,' my wife said.

The sculptor showed us how one small adjustment changed the whole figure. Not more ornament. Better arrangement.

I tried a dignified silence. Tank timed it with a sip of water. I lasted until somebody called the sculpture handsome.

'Nigga, we share a jawline.'

Shawna kissed my cheek. 'There he is. Couldn't let frozen water have one compliment.'

The snowman kept smiling. Tough competition.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the snowman puzzles if making a compact arrangement work sounds charming. Untimed-input support helps, while planning and exact movement still deserve a practical check.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Steam developer description supports premise. Current developer declarations include Playable without Timed Input and Keyboard Only Option. Physical comfort, held inputs and reasoning load still need their stated checks; this is not a hands-on completion test.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/316610/>

P127 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Cosmic Express

Edition considered: PC release

Design a tiny railway for unusual passengers, if finding a route within tight space and capacity limits sounds satisfying.

What you do. Draw or arrange tracks through the station so the train can collect and deliver its passengers in a workable order.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The puzzles are explicitly difficult; test track input despite declared untimed play and keyboard-only or mouse-only options.

Why it might click. Cosmic Express asks you to lay railway routes through small space stations and deliver their residents. The one-passenger constraint makes the order of visits important. Its appeal is the clean relationship between a visible route and the consequences that follow from it.

The full catch. The developer describes the puzzles as difficult and separately declares play without timed input, with keyboard-only and mouse-only options. Drawing tracks may still involve sustained pointer actions, so test the intended input method. Cute passengers do not reduce the planning burden: a compact station can hold a demanding puzzle. The declared input options do not certify hold-free interaction.

Try this first. Draw a route in an early station and watch one passenger's trip. Test editing or resetting the route before trying to optimize a complicated arrangement.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Private Train Had Room for One Nigga and His Confidence

I rented a novelty train to carry guests across the casino terrace. The carriage seated one adult. Tank read the sign and looked at me.

'Nigga, that's a chair with a railway problem.'

I volunteered to demonstrate. Shawna asked where the train would put everybody else while I enjoyed transportation. I pointed to the route. Mercedes pointed to the queue forming beside it.

The little system had a real constraint. One passenger. A path. Somebody waiting at the next stop. My desire to be admired did not create another seat.

Rosa moved a table so the train could reach the far side. Porsche adjusted the order of stops. The ridiculous thing began to make sense.

I offered Shawna the first ride. She sat, crossed her legs, and waved like royalty.

Tank leaned toward me. 'See? Nigga finally built public transport for the public.'

I walked alongside. She took my hand when the train stopped, which improved its passenger capacity emotionally.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the railway puzzle if routing within tight limits sounds satisfying. It can wait for thought, but the track controls and difficult planning still need checking.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Steam developer description supports premise. Current developer declarations include Playable without Timed Input and Keyboard Only Option plus Mouse Only Option. Physical comfort, held inputs and reasoning load still need their stated checks; this is not a hands-on completion test.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/583270/>

P128 / A PLACE TO START

A Monster's Expedition

Edition considered: PC release

Explore a playful museum of human oddities through spatial puzzles, with discoveries and jokes giving the journey a welcoming purpose.

What you do. Explore the islands, solve environmental arrangements and investigate exhibits that offer an unusual outside view of human habits.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The charm accompanies real spatial reasoning, while movement, undo and object manipulation still need checking.

Why it might click. A Monster's Expedition combines tree-pushing spatial puzzles with comic museum observations about humanity. Small islands form a larger exploratory structure, so solving a route can lead to both a new place and a new joke. It offers a particular mix of thoughtful manipulation and dry amusement.

The full catch. The developer describes simple mechanics with substantial depth. That depth can mean difficult planning even when the action vocabulary is small. Check movement, undo, reset and the readability of the islands and exhibits. Its open structure should not be treated as proof that every puzzle is optional or that every route remains easy.

Try this first. Solve or experiment with one early crossing, then read the nearby exhibit. Judge whether the combination of puzzle and joke makes you want another island.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Museum Called My Underwear a Ceremonial Flag

The hotel displayed old celebrity belongings near the lounge. Porsche slipped one of my spare silk boxers into an empty frame and wrote ROYAL BATTLE STANDARD beneath it.

Tank bent over laughing. 'Nigga fought bravely in these.'

Shawna read the label. 'Short campaign.'

I demanded historical accuracy. Mercedes asked whether I wanted the underwear returned or the explanation corrected. Important distinction. I wanted both and a more flattering font.

A small crowd of adult guests gathered. Nobody knew exactly what they were looking at, but the confident label had done impressive work. Rosa said museums could make ordinary things wonderfully strange.

I admitted that an outside view of our habits might be funny as hell. Then a guest offered to buy the frame.

I considered the offer. My wife removed the garment before I could turn married life into a collectible. 'Private collection, nigga.'

Tank asked whether the museum gift shop sold the longer campaign.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the exploratory puzzles if a funny outside view of human habits appeals. The museum's charm supports the journey, while the physical puzzle controls still need testing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1052990/>

P129 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Bonfire Peaks

Edition considered: PC release

Work through spatial puzzles with a reflective theme of carrying and letting go, if that combination feels intriguing to you.

What you do. Move through puzzle spaces, arrange what you carry and examine how the next position changes the problem's possibilities.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Its voxel spaces can be demanding to reason about; exact controls and full-game timing still need checking.

Why it might click. Bonfire Peaks presents a spatial puzzle journey organized around closure and moving onward. Its compact, sculptural environments make objects and their placement visually central. It may appeal when the satisfaction of an exact arrangement is strengthened by a quiet theme about what people carry.

The full catch. The primary description promises rewarding challenges and evolving mechanics, not low difficulty. Manipulating objects in three-dimensional puzzle spaces may require careful orientation and planning. Check the actual movement and object controls before assuming the fixed-looking presentation eliminates physical demands. The emotional theme is suggestive rather than a richly voiced character drama.

Try this first. Inspect an early puzzle, learn one object interaction and test how to recover from a mistake. Continue only if the precise arrangement feels absorbing rather than burdensome.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Bonfire Was Supposed to Burn My Old Speeches

The hotel offered a ceremonial fire bowl. I brought a stack of unused speeches. Shawna looked impressed until she saw I'd printed replacements.

'Nigga, that ain't letting go. That's inventory rotation.'

Tank brought a broken party sign. Mercedes brought nothing and said she didn't owe the evening a symbolic sacrifice. Rosa wanted the flame kept away from her dress. All sensible agendas except mine.

I held one speech over the bowl and recognized an entire paragraph about how humble I had become. The paper deserved better than another audience.

I let it go.

Nobody applauded. That helped. The small act stayed mine instead of becoming a performance I'd need to preserve.

Then the manager asked who had ordered the fire feature. Tank pointed at me.

'Additional charge, sir.' I looked at the remaining speeches. 'Nigga, letting go expensive.'

Shawna took my hand. 'Still cheaper than making us hear them.'

Aiden's verdict. Try the spatial puzzle if its idea of carrying and relinquishing things appeals. The reflective mood accompanies demanding arrangements; it does not make every solution easy.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1147890/>

P130 / A PLACE TO START

Can of Wormholes

Edition considered: PC release

Explore a deep puzzle world with hints you can play, if learning through a smaller demonstration sounds more enjoyable than reading explanations.

What you do. Move through the puzzle situations, experiment with solutions and use playable hints to discover the underlying ideas when needed.

Direction + buttons | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Explicit untimed input and unlimited undo are helpful; deeper reasoning and device-specific control comfort still matter.

Why it might click. Can of Wormholes develops many interactions from a small collection of puzzle objects. Its distinctive strength for this catalogue is a documented playable hint system: a smaller related stage can suggest the insight needed for the larger one. Experimentation and discovery are the main rewards.

The full catch. The developer explicitly states that no time-critical inputs or simultaneous key presses are required, and documents unlimited undo and restart. Those are unusually useful concrete claims. Keyboard or gamepad play is supported, with a Mac gamepad limitation noted by the developer. Spatial reasoning and learning new interactions can still be demanding; hold behavior should be checked separately.

Try this first. Try an introductory stage, use undo once and inspect a playable hint if curiosity stalls. Learn how the support works before a difficult puzzle makes it feel urgent.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P130 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Can of Wormholes

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Hint Was a Smaller Disaster I Could Actually Understand

I asked the cocktail-table puzzle host for help. He began a lecture. Tank stopped him. 'Nigga, show him one thing before his ego orders another drink.'

The host made a tiny version of the arrangement. One moving part. One consequence. I tried it and immediately saw what I'd been missing.

Shawna watched my face. 'There. You don't need to be embarrassed every time learning happens.'

I said I had never been embarrassed. Mercedes pointed to the jacket I was wearing indoors because I'd spilled champagne down the shirt.

The little demonstration did not solve the whole problem for me. It gave me a useful idea. I went back to the larger arrangement and changed one thing.

It worked. Tank lifted his glass. 'My nigga discovered assistance.'

I prepared to explain the significance of this breakthrough. Rosa slid the small puzzle back in front of me.

'Try the version with fewer words.'

My wife laughed. Excellent hint system. Brutal delivery.

Aiden's verdict. Start here if learning through playable hints sounds appealing. Explicitly untimed inputs and unrestricted undo are useful evidence, while the puzzle's deeper reasoning remains the attraction.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer Steam description explicitly says no time-critical input or simultaneous key presses, unlimited undo/restart and playable hints; gamepad on Mac is not currently supported in that description. This supports the stated narrow timing claims, not universal hold-free operation.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1295320/>

The Cocktail Did Not Need an Optimization Score

The mechanical drinks display completed a full cycle without colliding with itself. The bartender tasted the result and nodded. I asked whether it could be done faster. Mercedes said, 'Nigga, taste the drink before you improve its employment conditions.'

I tasted it. Good. The little arms moved again. That steady repeat had a pleasure of its own. I wanted to enjoy it and also wanted a plaque declaring that nobody had ever arranged a better beverage. Shawna could see both ambitions fighting across my face. She moved the imaginary plaque off the table before it became another actual expense.

Darnell leaned over and said his yacht had a faster system. Rosa asked him what music he liked. He returned to the yacht. Mercedes took his empty glass. 'You need a second subject, nigga. Cocaine already used up the first one's vocabulary.' Dre offered him casserole. For several blessed seconds chewing slowed the marine infrastructure report.

A working solution could be enough. A clever arrangement could be satisfying before comparison turned it into labor. That did not mean every puzzle was easy, or that a quiet screen asked little from a person. The point was to want the thing being asked. A small move. A difficult inference. A story clue. Whatever sounded good when nobody was announcing your performance.

I took Shawna's hand and asked whether my romantic technique required optimization. She looked at the untouched ordinary champagne. 'Start with being here.' Tank raised his glass. 'Best feedback the nigga got all night.' I remained present with a degree of concentration that would have impressed any machine on the table.

P131 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Braid, Anniversary Edition

Edition considered: PC Anniversary Edition

Explore platform puzzles that manipulate time, if clever movement challenges are appealing enough to accept their physical and timing demands.

What you do. Move through platforming spaces and use the game's time-manipulation ideas to reconsider routes, mistakes and puzzle solutions.

Direction + buttons | Action continues while you think | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Rewinding does not remove timed jumps or other platforming demands, so this remains an action detour.

Why it might click. Braid, Anniversary Edition combines platform movement with puzzles built around unusual behavior of time. Its story and images concern memory, desire and regret. The new edition also includes extensive creator commentary, offering another route into the design for someone interested in how a game thinks.

The full catch. Rewinding does not remove jumping, hazards or required movement timing. The developer explicitly describes platforming and changing time mechanics. This is a conditional action-puzzle detour, not a standard no-rush fit. Check movement, jump combinations and rewind holds separately; a forgiving recovery system can reduce failure cost without reducing the action itself.

Try this first. Try one introductory movement puzzle and the rewind control. If the physical action is unwelcome, consider the design commentary as an interest to investigate rather than forcing play.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P131 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Braid, Anniversary Edition

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / I Wanted to Rewind the Part Where I Said Watch This

I told the room I could step from the low platform to the velvet bench without spilling my drink. Shawna said the sentence already contained too many projects.

'Watch this, baby.' Tank watched. Mercedes watched. Rosa moved her microphone away from the likely splash zone.

I reached the bench. My drink reached the carpet. My dignity stayed somewhere between them asking for a return ticket.

Somebody played the security camera clip backward on a phone. Champagne leapt into the glass. I floated gracefully back to the platform. Every nigga cheered.

'See?' I said. 'Beautiful movement.'

Shawna took the phone. 'Rewinding doesn't mean you didn't need to land.'

I could appreciate a clever relationship with time without volunteering to repeat the physical demand. I sat beside her and let the clip finish.

Tank watched it forward once more. 'Nigga invented regret with a replay function.'

My wife put a dry drink in my hand. Ground level. Very advanced.

Aiden's verdict. Keep the time-manipulation platformer as a deliberate action detour. Rewinding a mistake can be clever without removing the timed movement that caused it in the first place.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/499180/>

P132 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

World of Goo

Edition considered: PC original game

Build unusual structures from connected creatures, if watching a physical construction succeed or wobble sounds like the pleasure you want.

What you do. Place and connect the available pieces, observe how the structure behaves and revise the arrangement when it fails.

Mouse / pointer | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Physics, precision and dragging can add pressure or sustained input; inspect the chosen level and controls directly.

Why it might click. World of Goo turns drag-and-drop construction into a physics puzzle with a comic corporate world around it. Structures bend, balance and fail in visible ways, so a small design change can be satisfying to test. Its personality comes from the creatures, signs and increasingly strange purposes of the construction work.

The full catch. The primary description explicitly says drag and drop. Holding and positioning the pointer may therefore be a central barrier. Physics unfolds while structures are running, and hazards vary by level, so do not assume an unlimited-waiting solution from the word puzzle. Check the ordinary building loop before becoming invested in the larger campaign.

Try this first. Build the smallest useful connection in an early level and watch it behave. Test selecting, dragging and releasing one piece before attempting an elaborate tower.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Bridge Was Made of Candy and My Reputation

The dessert chef built a little bridge from sticky sweets. I announced that it could support a champagne flute. He said it was decoration. I heard opportunity.

Tank looked at the span. 'Nigga, even the candy scared.'

Mercedes held the glass while Shawna moved the supports. We could see the problem shift when one piece changed. That was interesting. My original demonstration plan was mostly expensive gravity.

A man from the VIP room offered engineering advice at extraordinary speed. Porsche asked if the cocaine had issued him a degree. He stopped pointing and sat down.

The chef added one sensible connection. The bridge steadied. I wanted to take credit, but my wife still had the glass and therefore controlled the evidence.

She put it safely on the table instead.

'We learned enough,' she said.

Tank ate one unused sweet. 'Bridge closed for consumption.'

I watched the structure lean. Nigga had found an entirely different failure mode.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the construction puzzle if experimenting with a wobbling structure sounds fun. Physics and dragging remain real demands, whatever impressive theory the party invents around them.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/22000/>

P133 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

World of Goo 2

Edition considered: PC sequel

Try new construction and liquid puzzles within World of Goo's satirical world, if experimenting with physical systems sounds entertaining.

What you do. Arrange the available elements, observe their physical behavior and revise the construction to make the current situation work.

Mouse / pointer | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. New physical systems can increase demands; check pointer precision, dragging and scene-specific timing before treating it as relaxed.

Why it might click. World of Goo 2 expands the construction idea with flowing liquid, new material behaviors and another satirical corporate story. The attraction is watching a designed structure interact with a physical process, then discovering a better arrangement. It is a distinct sequel with new puzzles rather than an alternative edition of the first game.

The full catch. The developer describes a dangerous world and varied material mechanics. Pointer precision, holding or dragging, moving liquid and level-specific hazards need assessment. Do not assume that familiarity with one type of goo makes the complete game mechanically simple. This is most plausible when hands-on construction is itself enjoyable, not merely a route to the jokes.

Try this first. Try one early construction problem and observe how one material behaves. Check whether editing the structure feels comfortable before attempting to manage several interactions at once.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P133 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

World of Goo 2

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Green Company Had Painted the Spill Green

The event sponsor called its new drinks fountain sustainable. A leak spread under the sign while the representative explained the future of responsible luxury.

Tank looked down. 'Nigga, the future wet.'

I asked what made the system green. The representative pointed at the green lights. Mercedes laughed so suddenly she startled him.

Shawna moved the power lead clear. Rosa rescued her shoes. Porsche brought towels. While the speech continued, the people without microphones solved the practical problem.

The mess did have an intriguing shape. Liquid taking the route the room gave it. A system behaving honestly beneath a dishonest advertisement.

I stopped the representative long enough to ask where the drain went. He looked offended by the question's lack of vision.

Tank handed him a towel. 'Here, my nigga. Participate in the circular economy.'

The man knelt. The speech ended. The floor began improving.

I considered hiring him for every future announcement, provided the towel remained part of the uniform.

Aiden's verdict. Try the sequel if its new construction and liquid ideas appeal. More physical systems can also mean more control demands; a green label does not simplify them.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/3385670/>

P134 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

HUMANITY

Edition considered: PC non-VR mode proposed for assessment

Direct striking crowds through puzzle spaces as a dog, if the unusual spectacle appeals alongside more active stages and challenges.

What you do. Guide crowds through environments, place or use directions and respond to the puzzle and action situations along the route.

Mixed controls | Action continues while you think | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Action, platforming and bosses are documented, so the crowd-routing premise does not make the whole game untimed.

Why it might click. HUMANITY turns crowd direction into a striking puzzle-action spectacle. A dog places commands that shape the movement of many people, making routes and group behavior visible at a large scale. Its visual ideas may appeal to someone who enjoys watching a small instruction transform a complex scene.

The full catch. The developer explicitly includes action-focused stages, platform-like elements and boss battles. This prevents an unqualified no-rush recommendation. Navigation, command placement and the behavior of moving crowds need checking, and the ordinary-screen version should be assessed separately from VR. A clever planning premise does not remove required reactions elsewhere.

Try this first. Inspect an introductory routing stage and test one command. Treat later action sections as a real selection barrier, not a detail to discover after making a commitment.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Dog Took Over the Dance Floor

I spent fifteen minutes arranging the guests for a photograph. A little dog walked through the open door and solved crowd movement in six seconds.

Every adult followed it. 'Niggas, I'm the host.'

The dog stopped by Tank. Tank had chicken. The political situation was immediately clear.

Mercedes watched the crowd curve around tables. Shawna moved a chair before somebody tripped. Rosa laughed and asked why my seating plan had never inspired that kind of obedience.

I tried holding up a piece of bread. Nobody came. My campaign lacked protein.

Watching a crowd respond to simple direction was fascinating. Controlling the whole procession would be another matter, especially if the furniture changed while it moved.

The dog's owner collected it, thanked Tank and left. Everyone drifted back to their seats.

I stepped onto the platform. Shawna raised one finger. 'Before you speak, baby, ask whether the dog available for management consulting.'

Tank barked once. Traitor.

Aiden's verdict. Keep the crowd puzzle as an action detour. Its striking premise includes platforming and bosses, so a clever-looking procession is not evidence of fully relaxed play.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1581480/>

P135 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

COCOON

Edition considered: PC release

Explore worlds nested inside portable worlds, if that spatial invention is compelling enough to consider a game with guardian encounters.

What you do. Carry and use world-orbs, move between their environments and work out how the nested spaces relate to each other.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Guardian battles are a concrete action barrier; also check movement and world-handling controls before committing to the journey.

Why it might click. COCOON builds an alien puzzle adventure around worlds contained within portable orbs. Carrying a world into another world changes what can be done, creating a strong visual form of discovery. The appeal is the elegant connection between an object, a place and a new possibility.

The full catch. The official description explicitly includes guardian battles with new mechanics. A small-looking action vocabulary therefore does not prove a no-reaction experience. Check movement, aiming or triggering abilities, required timing and the effect of failure. This is a narrow puzzle-adventure detour for someone interested in those interactions, not a default quiet-game recommendation.

Try this first. Try the first world-and-orb interaction to see whether its logic feels satisfying. Preview a representative guardian encounter before assuming that the opening describes the full game.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P135 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

COCOON

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Party Was Inside a Ball Inside Another Party

The designer hung mirrored spheres over the tables. Each one reflected the party differently. I looked into the nearest and found a tiny magnificent version of myself.

Tank leaned beside me. 'Nigga, even little you taking up space.'

Porsche opened one sphere to reveal a smaller lit room inside. A miniature lounge, a miniature bar, a miniature man who looked suspiciously overdressed.

Mercedes said the nesting was the interesting part. What happened in one space might change the way another space made sense. I said the tiny man needed a better suit.

Shawna put the sphere back before I could renovate him.

A sponsor in the next room started shouting about the evening's big challenge. Rosa rolled her eyes. 'Every pretty thing got somebody trying to turn it into a contest.'

I liked the tiny worlds. I did not need to pretend their beauty erased every hard encounter around them.

Tank tapped the outer sphere. 'Nigga in there probably wants a quiet table too.'

Aiden's verdict. Consider the nested-world puzzle for its spatial invention, with guardian battles explicitly in view. Beautiful miniature worlds do not cancel the action demands between them.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1497440/>

P136 / A PLACE TO START

Gorogoa

Edition considered: PC release

Discover surprising connections between illustrated panels, if rearranging pictures into something newly meaningful sounds like a satisfying kind of puzzle.

What you do. Move or arrange illustrated panels, inspect their details and follow the relationships that emerge when images connect differently.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Panel dragging and exact pointer control need checking; visual calm does not establish hold-free interaction.

Why it might click. Gorogoa tells its story through illustrated panels that the player arranges and combines. Its puzzles depend on visual relationships, scale and the possibility that one image can become part of another. The result can feel like discovering how a picture thinks rather than manipulating a conventional inventory.

The full catch. Panel movement and visual precision are the main checks. The store supports arranging and combining images, but not a complete hold-free control claim. Inspect whether dragging, zooming or small targets are comfortable on the chosen device. The story is largely visual and interpretive, which may be appealing or may feel less concrete than dialogue-led mysteries.

Try this first. Move or inspect one panel in the opening arrangement and watch for a new relationship. Focus on that single change before trying to explain the whole story.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Wedding Picture Opened onto the Wrong Reception

I ordered four large photographs for the lounge wall. The installers swapped two, and suddenly a doorway in one picture seemed to open into another.

Mercedes stopped them before they corrected it. 'Leave that a second.'

Shawna tilted a frame. A line connected. The room inside one image seemed to continue somewhere impossible. Tank leaned close enough to leave a nose print.

'Nigga, I can see a buffet through the marriage.'

The pleasure arrived before anybody explained it. One arrangement changed what the pictures could suggest. I moved the frame slightly, and the little illusion vanished. Moved it back. There.

Porsche asked whether I'd planned the effect. I opened my mouth. My wife pinched my sleeve.

'Tell the truth, baby. It's attractive.' I admitted the accident. Mercedes smiled and adjusted the final frame.

Tank studied the completed wall. 'Beautiful. Now put the real reception where that imaginary food is.'

Some niggas respect art most when it points toward dinner.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the image puzzle if discovering relationships between pictures sounds delightful. Check panel manipulation and dragging first; the visual revelation should be the pleasure, not the pointer struggle.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/557600/>

P137 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Monument Valley: Panoramic Edition

Edition considered: PC Panoramic Edition

Explore impossible-looking architecture through a visual puzzle journey, if changing perspective and opening a path sounds appealing to you.

What you do. Inspect each architectural scene and manipulate its structures to create a route through the changing arrangement of shapes.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Pushing, pulling and clicking need a hold-and-drag check on this PC edition, despite its approachable presentation.

Why it might click. Monument Valley guides Ida through compact architectural illusions. Manipulating parts of the monuments changes which paths connect, giving visual discovery a clear purpose. The Panoramic PC presentation can suit someone drawn to beautiful, contained spaces rather than a freely steered open world.

The full catch. The developer describes pushing, pulling, clicking, raising and lowering parts of the scenery. Those operations need a hold-and-drag check; the game's approachable marketing is not a control guarantee. The current Steam header uses Monument Valley, while its description explicitly identifies the Panoramic edition. Keep that edition scope when checking settings and input.

Try this first. Complete one early architectural transformation and send Ida along the new path. Test the manipulation itself before deciding that the quiet presentation matches the desired physical comfort.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Staircase Had Been Designed by a Nigga Who Hated Feet

The hotel art director built a staircase backdrop that appeared to lead in three directions at once. I stood beneath it and announced that our event had transcended ordinary architecture.

Shawna looked around. 'Where the actual stairs?'

Tank pointed at the service door. 'Architecture over there. Bullshit here.'

Mercedes shifted her viewpoint and watched the impossible shape become convincing. I liked the trick: a little change in how you looked could make a path appear.

Then I tried posing as if I were climbing it. My foot hit painted canvas. Porsche caught my sleeve before transcendence became a dental claim.

'Nigga, use your eyes first.'

I did. From the correct place, the picture worked beautifully. My body did not need to enter every beautiful idea.

Shawna took the photograph. In it I looked like I owned a palace that had defeated gravity.

Out of frame, Tank held me steady and asked what architectural consultants earned.

Aiden's verdict. Try the architectural illusion if changing a view sounds satisfying. Its pushing and pulling need a hold-and-drag check before the peaceful appearance earns your trust.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually inspected correct Steam app 1927720. Current header shortens the name, but detailed description explicitly identifies Panoramic Edition and manipulation actions. Wrong or unresolved automatic cache excluded. Holds/timing not certified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1927720/>

P138 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Monument Valley 2: Panoramic Edition

Edition considered: PC Panoramic Edition

Follow a story of care and independence through architectural puzzles, if the relationship gives the changing spaces a stronger reason to explore.

What you do. Guide the journey through changing structures and manipulate the architecture as the relationship between the two travelers develops.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The PC description explicitly calls for clicking and dragging; check held movement, targets and recovery from mistakes.

Why it might click. Monument Valley 2 connects architectural illusion with a story of Ro and her child. The changing paths give its themes of care and independence a visual form. The developer describes it as a standalone adventure, so interest in this relationship does not require finishing the first game.

The full catch. The PC description explicitly calls for clicking and dragging to reshape the world. That is a concrete conditional barrier, even though the presentation is calm. Check how long manipulations must be held, target size and recovery from an unintended movement. The current storefront's shorter title still identifies the Panoramic edition in its detailed description.

Try this first. Try one early interaction involving the two travelers and the structure around them. Assess the drag action before assuming that a gentle story means physically effortless play.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P138 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Monument Valley 2: Panoramic Edition

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Wife Didn't Need the Staircase I Had Built for Her

I arranged two matching chairs beneath the impossible staircase backdrop. Same angle. Same view. A fair and loving gesture from a nigga who had neglected to ask.

Shawna moved hers.

'Baby, I made them match.' 'I know. Mine was facing the speaker.'

Mercedes adjusted the lights for Rosa's height instead of mine. Tank pulled a chair away from the draft. Little differences kept improving the room while I stood there mourning symmetry.

The backdrop's second figure seemed to be heading somewhere different from the first. I liked that once my wife pointed it out. A shared journey could include separate positions.

Porsche took a picture of us in our mismatched chairs. Shawna reached across the gap and held my hand.

'See? Still married.'

I asked whether the bedroom arrangements were similarly negotiable. She smiled. 'You can start by letting me choose the music.'

Tank turned the speaker down. 'Look at that. Nigga discovered cooperation without matching furniture.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose the second architectural story if care and growing independence appeal. The PC version explicitly involves dragging, so that physical condition belongs before the invitation.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually inspected correct Steam app 1927740. Detailed text identifies Panoramic Edition and explicitly describes clicking and dragging. Wrong or unresolved automatic cache excluded. Calm presentation is not a hold-free guarantee.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1927740/>

P139 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Room

Edition considered: PC original game

Investigate an elaborate puzzle box, if noticing small details and uncovering a mechanism feels more inviting than navigating a large world.

What you do. Inspect the box closely, examine its details and manipulate mechanisms to discover what the object is concealing.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Turning, zooming and dragging remain unresolved comfort checks; the primary premise does not certify a fully untimed route.

Why it might click. The Room offers close inspection of elaborate mechanical objects within an atmospheric mystery. Cryptic letters and unusual devices give each discovered mechanism a little narrative weight. Its concentrated setting may appeal more than walking through a large world, especially when the desired activity is examining something with a purpose.

The full catch. Close-up object puzzles can demand rotation, zooming, sliding and held pointer movement. The primary PC description calls the experience tactile but does not certify click-only controls. Check a representative latch or dial and the readability of details. The eerie tone may also matter even if the player is not controlling a combat character.

Try this first. Inspect the first object, identify one movable part and test the exact interaction. Learn how to leave a close-up before proceeding through several layers.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P139 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The Room

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Box Had No Respect for How Much I Paid

The casino delivered our centerpiece in a carved wooden box. I expected champagne. The box had a dial, a hidden latch, and the attitude of a motherfucker who knew I had an audience.

I tried opening it with confidence. Nothing. Tank offered his hands. Shawna caught his wrist. 'It's rented.'

Mercedes noticed a small mark near the hinge. Rosa turned the box toward the light. Suddenly the object became worth examining instead of merely defeating.

I followed one detail to another. A little movement produced a satisfying click. The lid still stayed shut.

'Foreplay,' I announced.

My wife looked at the box. 'At least somebody here knows how to build anticipation.'

Every nigga at the table made the same noise. I kept my attention on the latch because it was the only relationship in the room I could currently improve.

Inside was a smaller compartment.

Tank sat down. 'That box getting its money's worth out of you.'

Aiden's verdict. Try the mechanical mystery if close inspection feels inviting. Test turning, zooming and dragging directly; the box's excellent dramatic timing is not proof of comfortable controls.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/288160/>

P140 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Room Two

Edition considered: PC release

Continue The Room's mechanical mystery in broader spaces, if examining objects remains enjoyable and a larger investigation sounds welcome.

What you do. Investigate objects and mechanisms, follow the scientist's letters and connect discoveries across the spaces presented by the game.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Expanded environments add location and object memory, while turning, zooming and dragging still need a PC-specific check.

Why it might click. The Room Two continues the series' mechanical mystery while expanding the spaces and objects to investigate. Following an enigmatic scientist's letters gives the tactile puzzle work a thread to pursue. It may suit someone who liked the first game's close observation and wants a broader version of that activity.

The full catch. An expanded environment can add object and location memory to the familiar manipulation demands. Check turning, zooming, dragging and moving between viewpoints in the PC release rather than carrying over assumptions from a mobile version. The primary source establishes a rebuilt PC edition, not universal comfort or a completely untimed completion path.

Try this first. Investigate one object in the opening area and complete a single interaction chain. Notice whether finding the next relevant object feels inviting or starts to become visual clutter.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Second Box Had Brought Friends

I solved the first ornamental latch and announced that the evening's intellectual work was complete. The host rolled out another table.

Three boxes. Tank looked at me. 'Nigga, your success has reproduced.'

Shawna picked one object to examine. Mercedes stayed with a letter beside it. Rosa moved the lamp rather than letting us crowd around the shadow.

I wanted to touch everything because expansion felt like a challenge to my status. Porsche handed me one small piece and pointed to the place it belonged. A useful job. Humiliatingly effective.

The objects began suggesting relationships. Not every surface needed my attention at once. I could stay with a thread until it actually led somewhere.

Then the host offered a premium package with still more boxes.

'Nigga, no,' I said.

My wife leaned against me. 'Listen to you, setting a boundary.'

Tank applauded. 'Somebody record this. He just turned down extra.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose the expanded room if following one mechanical thread still feels enjoyable. More locations add remembering and manipulation demands, so let curiosity set the size of the visit.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/425580/>

The Velvet Rope Could Not Tell Who Was Grown

I found a coloring toy beside a severe-looking logic puzzle and suggested putting the childish things at the far end of the lounge. Mercedes turned slowly. This is a useful warning sign if a nigga values the next five minutes of his life.

'Childish-looking,' she said. 'And some people might want it. Other people might want a serious story. You could ask instead of standing there ranking their childhoods.' Tank moved the velvet rope away from both tables. Dre picked a ridiculous blue dinosaur. Rosa chose a mechanical mystery. Nobody's adulthood changed at the door.

Then the logic puzzle defeated my first three ideas. Its little creature looked friendly as hell while declining to cooperate. Shawna pointed out that cute and easy had never signed a joint contract. I tried to blame the lighting. Porsche moved the lamp. Now I could see myself being wrong with excellent clarity.

The room improved when we described the actual activity. Drawing a route. Dragging a part. Remembering a clue. Waiting for an opening. Comparing several ideas. Some of these were welcome tonight; some were not. The costume around them did not get the final vote.

Dre showed me his dinosaur. 'My nigga got taste.' It was blue, purple and completely free of narrative ambition. He enjoyed it and handed the controller onward. Mercedes returned to her mystery. I sat with my wife and tried the little logic problem again. She asked whether I wanted a hint. 'Yes,' I said. Tank nearly dropped his glass. Nigga acted like I had confessed to another marriage.

P141 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Room Three

Edition considered: PC release

Investigate a mysterious island and its intricate mechanisms, if a larger setting makes the invitation to examine objects more compelling.

What you do. Explore the presented spaces, inspect mechanisms and follow clues through the trials associated with the elusive Craftsman.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. More navigation and location memory join close manipulation; dragging, holds and full-game timing remain to be checked.

Why it might click. The Room Three expands mechanical puzzle investigation into a mysterious island and the trials of an elusive Craftsman. Its rebuilt PC presentation offers richly detailed objects and spaces. This is a candidate for someone who enjoys handling intricate mysteries and wants a broader setting around the mechanisms.

The full catch. Broader spaces can increase navigation and remembered-location demands. Close manipulation still needs an exact-device check for turning, dragging and zooming; a mouse interface does not establish that everything is click-only. The inspected description does not certify every later interaction as untimed. Eerie isolation is part of the appeal, so choose it for that mood rather than assuming the title means a quiet decorating game.

Try this first. Inspect the first available mechanism and follow one clue to its consequence. Check manipulation comfort before treating the island's larger mysteries as a commitment.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P141 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The Room Three

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Private Island Was a Locked Room with Better Marketing

The invitation promised an island experience. I followed the host into a dark lounge with a painted ocean and a cabinet that refused to open.

Tank read the brochure. 'Nigga, they put us on shore leave from the buffet.'

I asked for the Craftsman. A man in a velvet waistcoat bowed. Mercedes asked whether the cabinet had a real maker or just a branding department.

He showed us one beautifully made joint. Shawna touched the edge and found a seam I'd missed. The object had more thought in it than the invitation.

Rosa sat near the lamp. She wanted to follow the mystery. Tank wanted to know whether the island served food after ten. Different questions. Both deserved an answer.

I turned a little mechanism and heard something move farther inside.

'There,' my wife said. 'Better than kicking it.'

I had not mentioned kicking it. Marriage gives a woman dangerous access to a nigga's unpublished methods.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the broader mechanical mystery if the setting deepens your curiosity. More space and object relationships add demands; the beautiful cabinet still needs a direct input check.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/456750/>

P142 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Room 4: Old Sins

Edition considered: PC release

Explore a dollhouse concealing a darker domestic mystery, if detailed rooms and their connections make you want to understand what happened.

What you do. Investigate the dollhouse's rooms, manipulate tactile contraptions and follow the disappearance story through objects and their relationships.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Room switching and object uses add memory work; turning, dragging and complete-path timing remain unverified.

Why it might click. Old Sins frames its mechanical puzzles around an unusual dollhouse and a disappearance at Waldegrave Manor. An engineer, his wife and a sought-after artifact give the investigation a darker domestic story. The PC edition rebuilds the visual presentation around detailed rooms and their interconnections.

The full catch. The dollhouse is a mysterious adult setting, not evidence of simple mechanics. Moving among rooms and tracking object uses can add memory demands; rotating and manipulating mechanisms may involve sustained pointer actions. Check the PC controls directly. The reviewed source establishes the premise and tactile puzzles, but leaves full-game timing and hold requirements unresolved.

Try this first. Explore one dollhouse area and identify what changed after a single mechanism. Continue if the relationship between the small room and the larger mystery feels satisfying.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Dollhouse Had a Better Sex Life Than the Hotel

The centerpiece turned out to be a miniature mansion with lights in every room. I leaned close and announced that the tiny master suite seemed underused.

Shawna folded her arms. 'Nigga, you criticizing their marriage before ours has had dessert?'

Mercedes opened a little door. Behind it sat an object that changed the story she'd imagined about the house. Rosa noticed something in another room. Their attention grew serious while I was still inspecting miniature curtains.

A small domestic space could hold a large secret. I liked that. The little furniture stopped looking like decoration and started looking like evidence.

Tank peered through a tiny window. 'They got a kitchen?'

Porsche turned the house toward him. He nodded with deep professional approval.

I suggested putting our own suite into miniature. My wife touched my tie. 'Let's see what you do with the full-size one first.'

Every nigga pretended not to hear. Every nigga heard.

Aiden's verdict. Take the dollhouse mystery if rooms full of human secrets appeal. Small scale does not guarantee simple controls, and its darker domestic story deserves a taste check.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1361320/>

P143 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The House of Da Vinci

Edition considered: PC release

Investigate Leonardo's disappearance through Renaissance machinery, if a fictional historical mystery gives mechanical puzzles a more compelling reason to solve them.

What you do. Inspect the workshop's objects, solve mechanical puzzles and use unusual devices to examine the environment in different ways.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Small details, object memory, viewpoint changes and tactile manipulation need checking; a point-and-click label does not eliminate holds.

Why it might click. As Leonardo's apprentice, investigate his disappearance through mechanical puzzles and hidden objects in a Renaissance setting. Special devices add unusual ways to inspect the environment. The appeal is fictional intrigue joined to elaborate machinery, with an atmosphere inspired by historical inventions rather than a plain sequence of abstract boards.

The full catch. Inspecting objects can involve viewpoint changes and tactile manipulation; do not assume that a point-and-click label eliminates dragging or holds. Puzzles may require noticing small details and remembering where a device belongs. The source describes a fictional adventure, not a history lesson or a verified fully untimed control path. Test the intended PC input arrangement.

Try this first. Examine one early device and identify its moving parts before trying to solve everything nearby. Check whether manipulating it feels pleasant enough to support a longer mystery.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P143 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The House of Da Vinci

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Leonardo Would Have Asked Me to Leave the Workshop

The casino's Renaissance host called me apprentice. I corrected him. 'Nigga, I arrive at master level.'
He handed me a mechanism. It remained closed.

Tank leaned over the table. 'Master of holding that shit.'

Shawna noticed a moving part. Mercedes asked where its motion led. Rosa watched the host's demonstration instead of my face, which robbed the evening of some excellent expressions.

I wanted the pleasure of a machine revealing its logic. I did not particularly want the preliminary period in which the machine ignored my reputation. Apparently the two came together.

The host said Leonardo's workshop required patience. I said he should have met my accountant.

My wife placed my hand beside the correct part. 'There. Start by looking.'

I did. Something connected. The mechanism opened. Tank clapped. 'Nigga invented listening.'

I considered putting that on a plaque, but Shawna had already found the next interesting thing and I wanted to see it too.

Aiden's verdict. Try the Renaissance mystery if its machinery and missing-master story appeal. Manipulation and small details remain practical checks; a historical atmosphere does not certify simple actions.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/522470/>

P144 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The House of Da Vinci 2

Edition considered: PC release

Follow a narrated Renaissance mystery where actions connect past and present, if discovering consequences across time sounds interesting to you.

What you do. Investigate mechanisms, listen to the story and use the time-related device to understand connections between earlier and present conditions.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Redesigned controls are not proof of low demand, and multiple time relationships can add substantial remembering work.

Why it might click. The second House of Da Vinci combines Renaissance mystery, mechanical puzzles and a device that connects past actions with present conditions. The developer describes a fully narrated story and redesigned controls. Those are useful distinctions to check when choosing this installment, particularly if hearing the narrative is part of its appeal.

The full catch. Redesigned controls are not proof of low physical demand. Test the actual manipulation, viewpoint changes and dragging on the PC version. Time travel can increase the number of relationships to remember, and narration does not guarantee that every clue is spoken. The reviewed source does not settle all later timed interactions or the option to avoid sustained input.

Try this first. Try one narrated scene and one mechanical interaction. Notice separately whether the voices help the story and whether the device controls feel comfortable.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P144 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The House of Da Vinci 2

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Time Travel Was Going to Fix My Drink Bill

The second Renaissance room offered a device that connected past and present. I immediately asked whether it could reach the moment before I ordered the premium champagne.

Tank shook his head. 'Nigga trying to erase the only decision I enjoyed.'

Shawna turned one part and watched another change. Mercedes followed the narrated explanation. Cause and effect made the room feel larger than the table in front of us.

I imagined repairing my earlier mistakes. Wrong corridor. Extra fountain. The speech with a second ending. My wife asked why my first thought about time travel wasn't meeting her sooner.

I stopped. 'Baby, that was obviously implied.'

Rosa laughed without looking away from the device. Tank said history should keep the receipts.

I watched the little change happen again and found it satisfying enough without rewriting my life. Then Shawna kissed me.

'You can improve the next ten minutes,' she said.

Finally. A manageable timeline with excellent incentives.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the time-linked mystery if following consequences sounds rewarding. Narration may help the story, but revised controls still need checking and multiple periods add relationships to remember.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1259840/>

P145 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The House of Da Vinci 3

Edition considered: PC release

Continue Giacomo's Renaissance adventure through conspiracies and machinery, if the series' characters and atmosphere already make its conclusion appealing to you.

What you do. Follow the concluding story, inspect mechanical puzzles and investigate the time-related mysteries surrounding Giacomo and Leonardo's journey together.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Finale context, manipulation and viewpoint controls make this conditional; full-route timing is not verified by the reviewed source.

Why it might click. The third game concludes Giacomo's adventure with Leonardo, combining mechanical puzzles, time-related mysteries and conspiracies across Italian settings. The developer advertises voiced historical figures within the fictional story. It is most appealing as a continuation for someone already enjoying the series' machinery and atmosphere.

The full catch. A finale can carry more narrative context than a first encounter needs. Its polished presentation and claims of intuitive interaction do not verify click-only play or absence of required holds. Check the PC manipulation and camera behavior, and establish whether prior story knowledge matters to the intended experience. Full-route timing remains unverified in this source pass.

Try this first. Watch or inspect the opening premise without racing onward. If the characters and controls are already familiar, try one mechanism; otherwise consider starting with the first installment.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P145 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The House of Da Vinci 3

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Finale Arrived Before I Understood the First Affair

The host announced the final chapter of the Renaissance entertainment. I applauded as if I had followed every conspiracy. Mercedes asked me who the missing man was.

'Nigga with enemies.' 'Specific.'

Shawna knew. Rosa remembered the earlier conversation. Tank remembered who had brought the appetizers and was willing to build his entire theory from that.

The finale offered a bigger reason for the machinery, but it also asked us to bring something from what came before. I could enjoy the beautiful room without pretending context was an optional accessory.

Porsche offered a quick recap. I accepted before my pride ordered another explanation from the wrong person.

Then I heard a character's name and genuinely knew why it mattered.

'Look at you,' my wife said. 'I been following.'

Tank raised a finger. 'Nigga, we watched you arrive.'

I let him have it. Knowing the story felt better than winning the argument about when I started listening.

Aiden's verdict. Continue the trilogy when its people and mechanisms already matter to you. A finale's context can enrich it, while also making it a less convenient first visit.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1603640/>

P146 / A PLACE TO START

Carto

Edition considered: PC release

Help Carto find her grandmother by rearranging the map itself, if changing geography sounds like a playful way to solve a journey.

What you do. Rearrange map pieces to create paths, then move through the changed world and meet people along the route.

Mixed controls | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Map manipulation and character movement are separate activities; check dragging, rotation and held movement before settling in.

Why it might click. Carto combines a journey to reunite with Granny with puzzles that rearrange the map itself. Changing the arrangement creates new paths and possibilities in the world. Friendly encounters and varied communities give the spatial puzzle a human thread, offering more story context than an isolated logic board.

The full catch. There are two activities to learn: moving the character and manipulating map pieces. Check rotation, placement, any dragging and the amount of direction holding needed for walking. The peaceful presentation is encouraging, but it does not establish every interaction as untimed or effortless. Later map relationships may demand more spatial reasoning than the first examples suggest.

Try this first. Complete one map change, then walk the resulting route and notice what it changed. Judge whether switching between map thinking and character movement feels natural.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P146 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Carto

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / I Moved the Bedroom on the Map and Expected the Hotel to Cooperate

Shawna pointed out that our suite was a long walk from the lounge. I moved its room card beside the elevator on the floor plan.

'Fixed it, baby.' She looked at me. 'Nigga, the room still upstairs.'

Mercedes rearranged the event cards beside mine. One move made the terrace connect neatly to the dining area. Another gave Rosa a quieter route to the stage. The paper version of the party improved fast.

I loved the fantasy of geography listening to a hand. Put two places together and discover a new way through them.

Tank moved the buffet card onto his chair. 'I'm ready for the technology.'

Porsche took the practical changes to the manager. A few were possible. My relocated suite was not.

Shawna slipped the original room key into my palm. 'Old-fashioned travel tonight.'

I offered her my arm. The walk suddenly looked manageable.

Tank kept his card. Nigga believed in a better future.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the map-changing journey if rearranging space sounds delightful. You still alternate between map work and character movement, so try that switch before assuming the whole route feels easy.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1172450/>

P147 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Chants of Sennaar

Edition considered: PC release

Decode languages and discover a divided tower's peoples, if understanding symbols is appealing enough to consider the adventure's separate stealth demands.

What you do. Observe conversations and scenes, record meanings in the notebook and revise symbol interpretations while traveling through the tower.

Mouse / pointer | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Developer-confirmed guard timing conflicts with a strict no-rush route, despite useful mouse-only and camera-comfort declarations.

Why it might click. Chants of Sennaar builds a tower journey around interpreting several interconnected languages. Observation, conversations and a notebook of symbols support the process of finding meaning. Its distinctive appeal is the moment when a scene becomes understandable, with communication across separated peoples supplying a larger purpose.

The full catch. The developer explicitly confirms stealth sections that require choosing a path and timing movement around guard patterns. This conflicts with a strict no-rush route. The Steam listing's mouse-only and camera-comfort declarations do not remove that demand, and the developer says the gamepad cover/free toggle does not apply to mouse-and-keyboard play. Language deduction also adds substantial memory work.

Try this first. Explore the early language puzzle only if that bounded visit is wanted. Preview the stealth requirements before committing; do not promise that enjoying the opening makes the full game suitable.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P147 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Chants of Sennaar

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Sign Could Mean Welcome or Get Your Ass Out

I greeted the foreign-language sign outside the themed lounge as if confidence could translate it. Mercedes asked what it said.

'Important guests this way.' Porsche checked the staff placard. 'Service entrance, nigga.'

Inside, symbols repeated across menus and decorations. Rosa noticed one beside a drink. Shawna found it again near a doorway. Meaning started to gather from use instead of my optimism.

I enjoyed that little discovery. Then the entertainment host announced a sneaking challenge across the next room. Tank looked at the moving staff silhouettes and sat down.

'Nigga, I came to understand the sign, not time my ass between security.'

Fair. One appealing activity did not oblige us to accept another. Mercedes kept studying the symbols at our table. Rosa ordered a drink she now recognized.

I finally made a correct translation.

Shawna smiled. 'What does it say?' 'Stay here with my wife.'

'That's not on the sign.' 'Working theory, baby.'

Aiden's verdict. Keep the language mystery as a conditional detour for its verified stealth timing. Enjoying a thoughtful opening does not make the later moving-guard requirement disappear.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Steam premise and declared input categories; developer Rundisc replies of December 4, 2023 and March 23, 2024 explicitly confirm stealth timing and distinguish gamepad from mouse/keyboard. No whole-game no-rush claim.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1931770/>

Source 2: <https://steamcommunity.com/app/1931770/discussions/0/4040354734349221032/>

P148 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Heaven's Vault

Edition considered: PC release

Explore archaeology through an evolving character story, if translations that remain uncertain make discovery more interesting than simply finding a correct answer.

What you do. Talk with characters, examine inscriptions and explore the world while developing and revising theories about its ancient language.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Exploration includes sailing and navigation; camera or held travel input and heavy interpretation memory need checking.

Why it might click. Heaven's Vault follows archaeologist Aliya and her robot companion Six through a network of places and histories. Translating an ancient language is woven into an adaptive story, where discoveries and interpretations affect the journey. It offers grown-up curiosity, character exchanges and the possibility of forming a theory that later evidence complicates.

The full catch. This is more than a static translation screen: exploration includes navigation and sailing, and the source describes fast-flowing space rivers. Check camera movement, sustained travel input and the handling of those sequences. Tracking inscriptions, earlier interpretations and story choices can be demanding. Do not read its reflective subject matter as proof that every physical action waits comfortably.

Try this first. Try one conversation and one inscription before evaluating a travel sequence separately. Keep a translation provisional and notice whether uncertainty feels intriguing or merely burdensome.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P148 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Heaven's Vault

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Ancient Inscription Was Probably Somebody's Bar Tab

The antiquities display included a stone covered in symbols. I announced it recorded the arrival of a legendary king. Tank asked whether the king had settled his room charges.

Mercedes studied a repeated mark. Shawna found a related shape on another object. Their guesses changed as more details appeared.

I liked the uncertainty until my own theory lost support. Then I considered declaring the stone damaged.

'Nigga, evidence ain't broken because you wrong,' Rosa said.

An adult collector beside us launched into a speech about his yacht and the cocaine party he'd hosted on it. Mercedes turned the display lamp away from his reflection.

The old writing was more interesting. Somebody had meant something. We could approach it without owning it immediately.

I crossed out KING and wrote MAYBE.

Shawna rested her chin on my shoulder. 'Sexy word on you.'

Tank looked at my page. 'Nigga discovered doubt and got flirted with. Research paying off.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose the archaeological story if uncertain translations and evolving relationships appeal. Exploration and sailing add movement demands, while keeping interpretations provisional can become substantial mental work.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/774201/>

P149 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Return of the Obra Dinn

Edition considered: PC release

Reconstruct the mystery of a merchant ship that returned without its crew, if a large network of human clues sounds compelling.

What you do. Explore the ship, inspect details and use logical deduction to work out the events connected to its missing crew.

Movement + camera | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. First-person controls, many identities and disturbing death-related material make this a substantial conditional mystery.

Why it might click. Return of the Obra Dinn casts the player as an insurance investigator examining a merchant ship that has returned without its crew. The developer emphasizes first-person exploration and logical deduction. Its appeal is reconstructing a complicated human mystery through observation, making it a strong story-and-evidence candidate for the right input setup.

The full catch. First-person navigation brings camera coordination and movement holds into the assessment. Connecting many identities and events can also impose a large memory burden, while the ship's fate involves death and disturbing material. The inspected primary description is brief; it does not establish every timing or interaction requirement. Choose it for substantial deduction, not as a low-effort introduction to mysteries.

Try this first. Inspect the opening environment and the investigation interface. Check visual comfort and navigation before deciding whether maintaining a larger network of people and clues sounds enjoyable.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P149 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Return of the Obra Dinn

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Insurance Man Wanted to Know What Happened to the Buffet Ship

I rented a decorative ship for the seafood table. By midnight its sails leaned, the shrimp were gone, and one tiny sailor had vanished inside Tank's napkin.

The insurer asked what had happened. Every nigga looked at Tank.

'Circumstantial,' he said.

Shawna examined the little deck. Mercedes reconstructed who had moved the tray. Rosa remembered the waiter carrying the broken mast. Suddenly a ridiculous object held a sequence of human decisions.

I found the logic absorbing. A detail made another detail matter. A missing piece changed the account. My original answer, GREAT PARTY, was not adequate documentation.

Tank produced the sailor from his pocket. 'He survived.' The insurer wrote something.

'Nigga, don't put that on my premium,' I said.

Shawna handed over the broken sail and told the truth. It was less flattering than my version and considerably more useful.

Tank asked whether the survivors were entitled to dessert. The insurer finally laughed.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the ship's deduction if reconstructing human events sounds compelling. Its large identity puzzle, death-related content and first-person navigation keep this a substantial, conditional undertaking.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/653530/>

P150 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Opus Magnum

Edition considered: PC release

Build working alchemical machines within a story of ambition, if arranging a mechanism and watching it succeed sounds like the central pleasure.

What you do. Place equipment, sequence its instructions and revise the arrangement until the machine performs the required transformation successfully on its own.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The editor, component placement and sequencing are complex, and optimization comparisons can add unnecessary self-imposed pressure.

Why it might click. Opus Magnum is an open-ended machine-building puzzle about arranging and programming alchemical equipment. Several solutions can work, with optional interest in making them cheaper, smaller or faster. A story of ambition and intrigue surrounds the workshop, while watching a successful mechanism repeat its work provides a distinctive reward.

The full catch. The editor, component placement and instruction sequencing create substantial interface and reasoning demands. Optimization comparisons can introduce self-imposed pressure even when a solution already works. Machine execution speed is not the same thing as required human reaction speed, but exact editing holds and all control requirements still need checking. The narrative is woven around construction rather than replacing it.

Try this first. Follow one introductory construction and make a single operation work. Ignore efficiency comparisons while deciding whether arranging and revising a machine is enjoyable in itself.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P150 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Opus Magnum

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Machine Could Pour Drinks but Couldn't Take a Compliment

I commissioned a mechanical cocktail display. An arm moved a glass, another turned a bottle, and the whole thing made me want to announce the future before it had served anybody.

Tank waited with an empty cup. 'Nigga, future thirsty.'

Shawna changed one part of the sequence. The arms stopped colliding. Mercedes watched the repeated movement settle into something elegant.

I immediately asked whether it could go faster. Rosa asked whether the drink tasted good. Better question. Irritating timing.

The first successful cycle was enough to enjoy. Parts doing what they were supposed to do, without a man shouting instructions over them.

Then I requested an extra arm that would point toward me after each pour.

Shawna unplugged my proposal verbally. 'No.'

Tank accepted the drink. 'Machine working. Nigga still under development.'

I took the next cup and watched the mechanism run. The steady little rhythm was more convincing than another speech about my role in creating it.

Aiden's verdict. Try the alchemical construction if arranging a working mechanism sounds satisfying. Its editor and sequencing are demanding; comparisons about speed and size need not become the evening's purpose.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/558990/>

Darnell Tried to Put Cocaine in the Escape-Room Budget

Darnell announced that the puzzle lounge needed more energy. He patted the pocket containing his little cocaine bag. Porsche looked at the untouched games, the available food and the six separate adults who had already moved away from his boat speech. 'Nigga, the room got energy. Your conversation got a leak.'

He said he could make the night unforgettable. Rosa said her song had already done that for the people listening. Mercedes asked whether anybody wanted to continue the picture puzzle. Three hands went up. Darnell's did not. He wanted spectators, not partners, which was a distinction I recognized with uncomfortable speed.

I almost defended him on behalf of every man who had ever mistaken a large announcement for an experience. Shawna caught the thought before it left my mouth. 'You can enjoy being here too, baby. You don't have to keep producing us.' She pulled a chair beside her. I sat.

Dre moved his casserole away from Darnell's pocket and told him to choose a game or help carry dishes. No sermon. Just an actual job available in the room. Darnell picked up a tray. Tank showed him where it went. For the first time all evening he completed a route without explaining how it compared to his yacht.

When he returned, Mercedes asked whether he wanted to try one panel of the picture puzzle. He said yes. They looked at it together. A minute passed without an audience. I leaned toward Shawna and whispered that personal growth appeared possible even at our event. She kissed me. 'Careful, nigga. Don't turn his minute into your speech.'

P151 / A PLACE TO START

Sokobond

Edition considered: PC release

Make molecular connections into compact logic puzzles, if discovering spatial relationships appeals without needing prior knowledge of chemistry to begin.

What you do. Move through introductory molecular arrangements, observe the result of each action and revise the spatial idea when needed.

Direction + buttons | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed-input support is declared, but key behavior, undo comfort and reasoning demands still need a practical check.

Why it might click. Sokobond turns molecular connections into compact logic puzzles with a minimalist presentation. The developer explicitly says chemistry knowledge is not required. Its current Steam declarations include keyboard-only play and play without timed input, making this a useful candidate when deliberate problem-solving is welcome but reaction pressure is not.

The full catch. A small control vocabulary can still support difficult spatial reasoning. Confirm comfortable key presses, any repeat behavior and how undo works on the actual device. The developer's no-timed-input declaration is useful evidence, not a hands-on comfort guarantee. This is mainly abstract puzzle pleasure; it will not supply the character-rich narrative that motivates some other choices in the catalog.

Try this first. Try one introductory molecular puzzle and learn the result of a single movement. Continue only if revising a spatial idea feels satisfying, without requiring prior chemistry expertise.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P151 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Sokobond

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Atoms Refused to Respect My Social Status

I arranged cocktail olives into what I called a powerful molecular formation. Shawna asked which molecule. 'Rich nigga.'

Mercedes moved one olive. 'Now it's humble nigga.' Tank ate another. The chemistry became urgent.

The real attraction was simpler than my performance: a few connected pieces could obey rules worth discovering. Nobody had to arrive wearing a laboratory coat and pretending to remember school.

Rosa tried one arrangement, then another. Porsche watched how the connection changed the possible next move. Their attention made the little problem feel more interesting than my invented scientific reputation.

I asked if our formation could produce a particularly romantic reaction upstairs. My wife took the cocktail pick out of my hand.

'Start with not putting olives on the bed.'

Tank finished the remaining sample. 'Experiment complete.'

I protested the loss of data. He patted his stomach. 'Still preserved, nigga. Different research facility.'

Mercedes ordered a fresh bowl and assigned him a chair farther from the laboratory.

Aiden's verdict. Try the molecule puzzles if discovering spatial rules sounds satisfying. No chemistry background is required, and declared untimed input helps; exact movement comfort still needs checking.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Steam source supports chemistry-themed puzzles without required chemistry knowledge. Current developer declarations include Keyboard Only Option and Playable without Timed Input. Those declarations are not a hands-on test of sustained keys or individual comfort. Remote Play Together is not treated as native co-op.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/290260/>

P152 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Hexcells

Edition considered: PC original game

Try an ambient cell-based logic puzzle, if studying a compact board and finding a justified next move sounds enjoyable to you.

What you do. Read the board's instructions, inspect its cells and make selections based on the relationships you can establish from the clues.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The primary description is brief; exact input, readability, holding and full timing requirements remain unresolved.

Why it might click. Hexcells is presented by its developer as an ambient logic puzzle. Its compact cell-based format offers a different kind of interest from walking through a world: inspect the board, understand its rules and look for a reasoned next step. It is a candidate for someone who likes deliberate abstract deduction.

The full catch. The inspected primary description is unusually brief, so it does not substantiate a full no-timer or hold-free claim. Check the game's instructions, cell readability and the distinction between its input actions before relying on it. A sparse screen does not guarantee an easy deduction. This original Hexcells entry should not inherit features or extra modes from the separate Plus and Infinite games.

Try this first. Read the opening board instructions and make one move whose reason is clear. Check whether selecting and distinguishing cells feels comfortable before increasing the puzzle size.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P152 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Hexcells

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Six Sides and Not One of Them Agreed with Me

The casino put hexagonal tiles beneath the drinks. I moved them into a pattern and told Tank the arrangement had six different ways to prove I was right.

He looked down. 'Nigga, I only need one where your glass stops wobbling.'

Shawna rotated a tile. Mercedes noticed a relationship between two marks. A quiet problem formed in the middle of the noisy room.

Rosa lowered the music near us without turning the moment into a ceremony. We could look. Make one careful choice. See whether the next choice became clearer.

I tried pointing dramatically. It added nothing. Porsche slid my finger aside so everybody could read the mark underneath.

Then the arrangement made sense. Small satisfaction. No fireworks. I liked it.

Tank put his drink down. Steady.

'Good work, my nigga. Your theory finally supporting something.'

I raised my glass and nearly forgot why it had been steady. Shawna caught the loose tile before I could reinvent the entire problem.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the compact logic format if a carefully justified move sounds pleasurable. Its brief primary description leaves full timing and control details unresolved, so begin with a small board.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

The exact-game Steam page describes an ambient logic puzzle; its short primary text does not establish full controls or timing. The separate sequels' features were not imported. Detailed input verification remains outstanding.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/265890/>

P153 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Tametsi

Edition considered: PC release

Work through demanding tile logic with drawing tools and saved progress, if making a supported deduction is itself a satisfying reward.

What you do. Inspect tile relationships, reason about hidden mines and use the drawing tools to keep notes while developing a solution.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The developer explicitly calls it difficult; large clue relationships, tile visibility and exact controls still need checking.

Why it might click. Tametsi offers demanding logic puzzles about finding hidden mines among tiles. The developer says solutions do not require guessing, provides on-screen drawing tools for notes, and saves progress even within a level. For someone who enjoys careful deduction, those features can support a substantial problem without requiring an immediate answer.

The full catch. The developer also explicitly describes the game as difficult. Large patterns, written notes and relationships between clues can become mentally busy even when the physical action is modest. Verify the click controls, tile visibility and stopping behavior on the device. The inspected text supports automatic progress saving, but it does not explicitly certify every input as hold-free or every activity as untimed.

Try this first. Try an early board and write down one deduction with the available note tools. Decide whether the reasoning itself is enjoyable before treating more difficult boards as an objective.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P153 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Tametsi

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Tile Needed Evidence and Tank Was Offering Vibes

Tank pointed at one square on the party's puzzle mat. 'That one.' Shawna asked why. He considered the question.

'Energy.' Mercedes put his hand back beside his plate. 'Nigga, eat. We need evidence.'

I almost defended intuition until Rosa asked me to explain my own choice. The explanation began confidently and ended in a vague circle over the table.

We tried writing the reasons down. One clue limited another. A mark ruled out a possibility. The problem did not get smaller, but it got less mysterious in the unhelpful way.

Porsche left the unfinished arrangement alone when the music changed. We could come back to it. Nobody needed to solve everything before dancing.

I asked Shawna whether she found logical certainty attractive. 'Sometimes. Right now I'm attracted to that song.'

We went.

Tank stayed with the mat until Mercedes called him. Then he pointed once more. 'Still that one.'

Nigga had a theory. It remained unsupported.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the difficult tile logic if proof itself is enjoyable. Saving progress supports returning later, while large clue relationships and exact input still deserve an honest trial.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/709920/>

P154 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Mario Paint

Edition considered: 1992 SNES original; SNES Mouse input

Make a playful picture in the original SNES creative toy, using stamps and fills as a narrow first activity to enjoy.

What you do. Choose a stamp and a fill color, place a few elements and experiment with a small picture using the mouse.

Mouse / pointer | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Original hardware needs the SNES Mouse; other tools involve dragging, many icons add clutter, and Gnat Attack requires reactions.

Why it might click. The original SNES Mario Paint is a creative toy for pictures, music and animation, built around the SNES Mouse. Stamping and filling areas offer a narrower first activity than exploring the entire toolbox. Its appeal is making something playful, with nostalgia as an optional bonus rather than a requirement.

The full catch. The original hardware needs the mouse peripheral. Manual instructions distinguish simple selections from held-button dragging used by other tools, so the whole program is not hold-free. Many icons and palette choices can create menu clutter. The separate Gnat Attack activity adds reaction demands and is outside this suggested stamp-and-fill trial. This is creation, not a character-story adventure.

Try this first. Choose one stamp and one fill color, then make a small picture. Leave freehand dragging, animation and the reaction minigame aside while checking mouse comfort.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P154 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Mario Paint

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Hotel Let Me Design the Welcome Screen Once

They gave me a drawing station for the party's welcome display. I selected a stamp, filled a color, and discovered a level of creative power the hotel had foolishly left unsupervised.

Shawna watched my first design. 'Nigga, why your name on it fourteen times?'

'Visual rhythm.'

Mercedes removed thirteen. Suddenly the picture looked better. I called this collaboration and kept my original invoice.

Dre chose a blue background and said his casserole deserved equal billing. Tank stamped a little shape near the buffet arrow. Rosa wanted a flower, not another slogan.

We made something ridiculous together. Nobody asked whether it belonged in a gallery. The small act was enough.

Then I found the separate reaction game and started boasting. Shawna turned back to the picture.

'Different activity, baby. You were enjoying this one.'

I stayed with the stamps.

Tank nodded at the finished screen. 'Nigga finally left a little space for the guests.'

Aiden's verdict. Try stamps and fills if playful creation appeals. The original mouse setup and other tools' dragging remain distinct from this narrow invitation, which excludes the reaction minigame.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo announcement confirms the 1992 original; original Nintendo manual transcription, hosted by a third party, distinguishes stamps/fills from held dragging and the separate Gnat Attack activity. Card scope is original SNES Mouse play, not an automatic claim about modern ports.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/whatsnew/mario-paint-scribbles-into-the-super-nes-collection/>

Source 2: <https://manualzz.com/doc/26101036/nintendo-mario-paint-family-user-manual>

P155 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Color a Dinosaur

Edition considered: 1993 NES original

Revisit an unusual NES coloring toy if choosing colors for simple pictures is exactly the small retro activity you want.

What you do. Select a picture, choose colors and fill a few regions, trying the manual's narrow point-to-point coloring arrangement first.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Its child-oriented style and limited variety may rule it out; full timing and modern-device behavior remain untested.

Why it might click. Color a Dinosaur is an original NES coloring toy with a deliberately small activity loop. Its manual describes selecting pictures and filling regions with colors, including a point-to-point control arrangement. It belongs here as a specific retro curiosity for someone who wants that simple action, not as a substitute for adult narrative.

The full catch. The presentation is aimed at young children and the variety is limited. That may be a taste veto regardless of how few controls are needed. The original manual supports the coloring controls, while full-play timing and modern-device behavior have not been tested here. Mode changes can affect the drawing; check the intended setup rather than assuming an emulator reproduces every behavior conveniently.

Try this first. If the retro coloring idea itself appeals, fill a few regions in one picture. Stop the trial once its narrow appeal is clear; completing a picture is optional.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Dinosaur Wasn't Applying for an Adult Drama Award

The retro table had a dinosaur picture waiting for color. I announced that we could reframe it as a sophisticated meditation on extinction.

Mercedes looked at the picture. 'Nigga, it wants green.'

Dre chose blue. Tank said the dinosaur now owed the casserole table a visit. Shawna filled another region because she liked the color, not because I had finally explained art.

It was a small old toy. That could be fun for the person who wanted a small old toy. I did not need to dress it in a tuxedo and promise a complicated love affair.

Rosa tried one region, smiled, then went back to her song. Nobody made her stay.

I prepared another ambitious interpretation. My wife handed me the controller.

'Pick a color, baby.' I picked an outrageous one.

Tank leaned over. 'There. Nigga discovered taste without writing a grant.'

The dinosaur remained exactly as simple as it had been. The evening survived this honest description.

Aiden's verdict. Visit only if the retro coloring toy itself appeals. Its narrow loop and child-oriented presentation are real limits, regardless of how grandly I introduce the dinosaur.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Original manual scan, hosted by a third party, was visually examined in the earlier project research (work/retro-games.json); current reopen yielded no searchable text. Manual-supported point-to-point coloring is a narrow option, not a tested whole-game or emulator guarantee. Wrong Steam coloring-game match excluded.

Source 1: <https://www.digitpress.com/library/manuals/nes/Color%20a%20Dinosaur.pdf>

P156 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Incredible Machine 3

Edition considered: 1995 Windows original

Revisit a historical contraption puzzle if making an unlikely chain of cause and effect succeed is the attraction you remember.

What you do. On an existing working setup, inspect an introductory contraption and change one component to observe the resulting chain of effects.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Primary mechanics verification, exact controls, current availability and compatibility remain unresolved; setup could overwhelm the intended evening.

Why it might click. The Incredible Machine 3 is a historical contraption-building puzzle candidate: arrange parts into chains of cause and effect to achieve an objective. Its appeal is seeing an unlikely mechanism succeed after a useful adjustment. This 1995 Windows entry is included for a revisit if an existing copy and workable setup are available.

The full catch. Evidence is weaker here than for the modern store entries. A Sierra historical archive identifies the game, but its descriptive text credits a secondary database; the linked scanned manual was located without usable text verification. Exact mouse actions, timers, compatibility and present availability remain unresolved. Do not mistake this historical candidate for a certified easy-to-run or hold-free recommendation.

Try this first. On a working existing setup, inspect one introductory contraption and its controls before changing a single component. Avoid turning software setup into the evening's main activity.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P156 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The Incredible Machine 3

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Machine Rang a Bell to Tell Me I Was an Idiot

I built a table arrangement intended to ring a bell when the first guest sat down. The manager asked why I couldn't greet the guest normally.

'Nigga, scale.'

Tank inspected the ball, the little track, and the expensive object I'd used as a support. 'Your scale has my dessert plate.'

Shawna moved one part. Nothing happened. Mercedes moved another. The ball finally travelled, nudged the next piece, and produced a tiny bright ring.

I grinned before I could announce what the grin meant. Ridiculous chain. Real result. That was the pleasure.

Then Rosa sat down and the whole thing rang again. Tank sat. Again. Every arriving adult received the same stupid welcome.

By the sixth ring, even I understood the manager's question.

Shawna took the ball away. 'Successful experiment, baby.' 'Why stop it?' 'Because we learned what it does.'

Tank reclaimed his plate. 'Nigga invented a bell and then discovered dinner needed silence.'

Aiden's verdict. Keep the historical contraption builder for a working existing setup. Its mechanical idea is attractive, but control details and current compatibility remain explicitly unverified in this research.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Explicit source gap: historical Sierra archive page inspected, but its descriptive prose credits MobyGames. Original scanned manual located, not successfully read for mechanics in this pass. Primary identity locator is available; detailed controls, timing, current availability and compatibility remain unverified.

Source 1: <https://www.sierragamers.com/tim-3/>

Source 2: https://www.sierragamers.com/wp-content/uploads/2019/12/TIM_3_Manual.pdf

P157 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

SimCity 2000 Special Edition

Edition considered: PC Special Edition

Build and manage a classic city if planning how its parts support one another sounds as interesting as watching the skyline grow.

What you do. Inspect a city, use its building and service tools and respond to the relationships between the settlement's needs.

Mouse / pointer | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Budgets, services, simulation behavior and old menus add substantial complexity; pause behavior and no-pressure modes were not verified.

Why it might click. SimCity 2000 Special Edition offers the classic city-building and management fantasy, with the ability to design a settlement and respond to its needs. The current exact-edition store description includes additional cities and scenarios. It may appeal through nostalgia, long-term planning and the satisfaction of a place taking shape.

The full catch. Management brings budgets, services, tools and simulation behavior into the same interface. This is a meaningful increase in menu and system complexity, not a default low-demand choice. Check speed controls, pausing, the ability to inspect while paused and the readability of the old interface on the intended setup. The reviewed sources do not establish a special no-pressure mode or hold-free operation.

Try this first. Inspect an existing city or an introductory situation and identify one service before building extensively. Decide whether managing relationships between systems sounds enjoyable, rather than merely liking the skyline.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P157 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

SimCity 2000 Special Edition

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Mayor Put the Strip Club Where the Water Should Go

I arranged the casino's miniature city display into what I called a vision of prosperity. Nightlife first. Magnificent skyline. A private road to my house.

Shawna looked at the empty corner. 'Where the water?' 'In the champagne.'

Tank stopped me. 'Nigga, the citizens need to wash.'

Mercedes moved a model building and asked where ordinary people would live. Rosa wanted a neighborhood that didn't hear my opening ceremony every night. Dre put his tiny blue car somewhere with parking.

The city became interesting when it had needs beyond admiring me. A system could answer a foolish choice with a problem I had to understand.

I liked that possibility. I also saw how much attention it could demand. A whole city would not become simple because its buildings looked cute from above.

My wife moved the private road out of the way.

'There,' she said. 'Now your constituents can reach something useful.'

Tank pointed at the water. 'Democracy got a shower, nigga.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose the city only if managing linked systems is appealing. Budgets, menus and simulation behavior are central; the attractive skyline does not turn it into a simple decorating toy.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Special Edition GOG listing and official EA title page inspected. Supports city design/management and edition identity; pause behavior, no-pressure modes and present-device control comfort were not verified.

Source 1: https://www.gog.com/en/game/simcity_2000_special_edition

Source 2: <https://www.ea.com/games/simcity/simcity-2000>

P158 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

RollerCoaster Tycoon Deluxe

Edition considered: PC Deluxe edition

Design a familiar little amusement park if caring about its visitors and finances is part of the attraction alongside building rides.

What you do. Place or inspect attractions, arrange the park and manage the guest needs and finances surrounding its operation over time.

Mouse / pointer | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Menus, money and scenario demands can create pressure; prebuilt rides do not remove the wider management system.

Why it might click. RollerCoaster Tycoon Deluxe combines the original park-management game with its two expansion packs. It offers both custom coaster construction and prebuilt rides, alongside the business of keeping guests and finances in order. The pleasure can be a recognizable little park evolving through practical and creative decisions.

The full catch. Designing rides is only part of the game: management menus, guest needs, money and scenario demands can create pressure. Check simulation speed and pause behavior, exact mouse operations and interface size. The presence of prebuilt rides does not remove the rest of the management system, and this edition should not be credited with modes from later RollerCoaster Tycoon releases.

Try this first. Inspect an opening park or scenario and locate one prebuilt attraction in the interface. Evaluate whether the management surrounding construction feels interesting before committing to a large custom coaster.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P158 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

RollerCoaster Tycoon Deluxe

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Queue for My Grand Opening Had Formed Outside the Wrong Ride

I opened the party's miniature amusement area with a speech long enough to create its own waiting line. Tank stood at the back eating popcorn.

'Nigga, the ride is leaving before you finish.'

Shawna pointed at a perfectly good prebuilt attraction. Mercedes wanted to try it. Rosa wanted the music turned down near the seating. The guests kept having actual preferences while I described my vision.

I looked across the little park layout. Paths mattered. Where something sat mattered. A beautiful idea could still send everybody to the same cramped corner.

Porsche moved a sign, and the queue split sensibly. More practical improvement than my last three paragraphs combined.

I handed the microphone to the attendant.

Tank applauded immediately. 'Best opening you ever done.'

My wife took my hand and led me toward the ride. 'You coming?'

I went. A man could enjoy his own party once he stopped trying to stand in front of every fucking entrance.

Aiden's verdict. Try the park if design and management both sound enjoyable. Prebuilt rides ease one task, while guest needs, money and scenario pressure remain part of the game.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/285310/>

P159 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Theme Hospital

Edition considered: 1997 PC original

Run a satirical institution if exaggerated operational problems and resource management sound entertaining, rather than looking for a personal character adventure.

What you do. Design and maintain the hospital, manage its staff and rooms and balance the resources needed to keep it operating.

Mouse / pointer | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Busy menus and simulation pressure need checking, while fictional illnesses and death may make the subject unwelcome.

Why it might click. Bullfrog's original Theme Hospital is a comic management game about designing and running an institution with limited resources. The official EA page emphasizes building, maintaining and managing the hospital while balancing cash and its exaggerated fictional problems. Its appeal is institutional satire and operational tinkering, rather than a rich personal adventure.

The full catch. Staff, rooms, resources and developing demands can make this a busy management choice. Its comic visual style does not remove time pressure or menu work. Check pausing, speed behavior, readable text and the exact mouse controls before assuming a relaxed setup is possible. The humor includes exaggerated illnesses and death, which may simply be the wrong subject for an enjoyable evening.

Try this first. Inspect the early building and management interface without committing to an elaborate plan. Decide whether its subject and overlapping responsibilities are appealing before taking on the continuing simulation.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P159 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Theme Hospital

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Administrator Bought Marble Before Buying Chairs

I spent the lounge's comfort budget on a marble reception desk. It looked magnificent. Every guest then had to stand while admiring it.

Rosa put her bag down. 'Nigga, where do people sit?'

I gestured toward the desk as if beauty might support a human ass. Shawna gave me the look she reserved for expensive ideas with missing middle steps.

Tank brought chairs from the adjoining room. Mercedes put the service menu where people could read it. Porsche found the attendant I'd stationed behind a decorative curtain.

Within five minutes the place worked better and looked less like my fantasy of institutional power.

The hospital-management satire on the game table suddenly seemed to have me in its sights. Rooms. Staff. Money. Consequences. A building did not run on the administrator's posture.

I offered to help move another chair.

Dre watched me carry it. 'Look at this nigga. Community service with cufflinks.'

Shawna kissed my cheek. I made a note to invest in more useful furniture.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the institutional satire only if its subject and management workload appeal. Busy systems and potentially pressuring simulation remain real catches beneath the exaggerated comic presentation.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Official EA page identifies Bullfrog's original 1997 Theme Hospital and building/management with limited resources. The automatic Steam hit was unrelated DLC and is excluded. Exact pause/hold behavior remains to be checked.

Source 1: <https://www.ea.com/games/theme/theme-hospital>

P160 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Zoombinis

Edition considered: 2015 PC remake of Logical Journey of the Zoombinis

Guide familiar blue travelers through a cartoon logic journey if its particular nostalgia and pattern-discovery charm are what you want tonight.

What you do. Try the remake's puzzle types, notice patterns and make choices that help the travelers continue toward their new home.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The child-oriented style is a real taste limit; difficulty, dragging, penalties and timing require puzzle-specific checks.

Why it might click. This is the 2015 remake of Logical Journey of the Zoombinis, a cartoon adventure built around pattern and logic puzzles. The developer describes twelve puzzle types with several difficulty levels as the travellers seek a new home. It may appeal through nostalgic character, rule discovery and a sequence of distinct reasoning tasks.

The full catch. The child-oriented presentation is a real taste consideration, especially when the desired experience is a grown-up character story. Logic difficulty can increase independently of that appearance. Check the specific puzzle's clicking, dragging, penalties and timing; the store description does not establish a universally untimed or hold-free route. This entry refers to the remake, not every older edition or platform version.

Try this first. Try one early puzzle and explain the pattern you think matters. Check whether helping these characters feels charming before investing in harder levels or the larger journey.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P160 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Zoombinis

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Travellers Did Not Need My Nightclub Dress Code

I arranged the little blue figures on the retro table into a VIP line. Tank looked at the shapes. 'Nigga, you denying entry to a cartoon?'

I said a journey required standards. Shawna moved the velvet ribbon I'd borrowed and let everybody see the actual puzzle.

Dre pointed at the blue group. 'These my cousins now. Treat them right.'

Mercedes asked what pattern mattered. Rosa noticed a difference between two figures. The conversation became useful once I stopped inventing social status for the pieces.

The old cartoon adventure had its own charm. Somebody could enjoy that without being talked down to, or decline it without having to prove adulthood to me.

I tried the next choice and watched what changed.

Shawna smiled. 'There you go.' 'Natural leadership.'

Tank shook his head. 'Nigga, you just stopped blocking the road.'

We let the travellers continue. I kept the ribbon for a more appropriate purpose: stopping Darnell from pitching his yacht to the band again.

Aiden's verdict. Try the remake if its particular cartoon logic journey appeals. Pattern difficulty and puzzle-specific controls still need checking; nostalgia should invite a visit rather than demand one.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact-title developer/publisher Steam description inspected for premise and edition. Fit and first trial are editorial suggestions. Controls, timing and comfort remain bounded by the explicit checks in the card; no complete playthrough performed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/397430/>

The Cork Had Been Available Separately

The ordinary bottle opened with one clean sound. Every head turned, including the host's. Tank lifted his glass toward the elaborate locked box. 'Hear that, motherfucker? Your competition.' The host laughed, finally abandoning the expensive solemnity he'd been issued with his waistcoat.

We had solved some things and left other things alone. A few games had become more inviting when their actions were stated plainly. Others had revealed a catch that settled the matter just as usefully. Nobody earned extra status by choosing the hardest board. Nobody had to accept dragging, camera movement or timed action because the room liked the joke printed beside it. The games kept their real demands. We kept the right to choose.

Mercedes and Darnell finished the little picture arrangement. He smiled without looking around to see who had noticed. Rosa tried another mechanical detail before putting it down. Dre retrieved the blue controller from under a napkin and asked who wanted it next. Tank collected the empty plates with an efficiency that suggested we had been wasting a talented nigga on speeches.

The host offered us a final attempt at the carved box. I looked at Shawna. She looked at the ordinary champagne, then at the suite key in my hand. 'What do you actually want to do?' The question had become dangerously effective.

I wanted to understand the box eventually. Tonight I wanted to leave with my wife while she was still smiling at the man inside the ridiculous suit. I told the host we would let the mechanism retain its dignity until another visit. He handed me a small card describing its maker. A good invitation. No challenge attached.

At the elevator, Tank asked whether I'd enjoyed the intellectual experience. 'Nigga, I learned plenty.' Shawna pressed our floor. 'He learned the cork was available separately.' Mercedes laughed from the table. Dre raised the casserole dish in farewell. Darnell opened his mouth, saw the closing doors, and mercifully saved the yacht for somebody else's tomorrow.

Upstairs my wife took the key, opened the room in one uncomplicated movement and looked back at me. 'See? This one works.' I followed her inside with the bottle. Whatever happened after that required no narrator, no leaderboard, and absolutely no motherfucking puzzle box.

Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. The Tellings Cut: original revised Panorama prose and production by ChatGPT; original game research and selection system retained. This is a separate adult comic companion to Ten Toes Down. Source novels and the first Panorama edition remain intact. All people participating in the fictional party scenes are adults; Lillian is addressed as the reader.

Voice sources sampled for this revision: the Niggatorial Tellings Book I funeral and first Vegas party, selected passages from Books II-VI, and the edition editorial record. Source repository Sodelin/Ten-Toes-Down; working base 4cdof7a6e36977ff0ac705a59ebe65407d1f2bee. Selected passages were read closely; no full reread of all six novels is claimed. The added game-night story is newly composed fiction.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

This adult comic edition includes frequent reclaimed in-group language, strong profanity, fictional cocaine and party references, sexual banter and non-graphic innuendo. Those scenes are separate from the factual game descriptions and are not descriptions of the developers or real readers.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS / THE TELLINGS CUT

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 5 OF SIX

The Penthouse Where Everybody Had a Story

Character stories, dialogue and consequential choices

Forty real games. Aiden has made it everybody's problem.

Adult comic edition: reclaimed in-group language, profanity, fictional cocaine references and sexual innuendo.

New ChatGPT prose under Nolan's creative direction.

Tellings Cut 2.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

How to find a game in this book

Each game starts with a short pitch, what you actually do, the controls and pace, the main catch, and a first action to try. These practical sections use plain language. The longer Aiden scene comes after them.

For a fast comparison, read the pitch and main catch on two or three pages. Use the alphabetical index to jump to a title. Choose the full story only when you want the comedy; it is never a prerequisite for understanding the game.

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. The labels mean: A place to start = a promising candidate; Read the catch first = a meaningful obstacle needs checking; A more demanding detour = a narrower or harder option. They describe the game, not the reader. Check the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

Choose a game by its name

This is the quick route. Click any title, or turn to its page. Read the short pitch and main catch first; Aiden's scene follows the practical guide. The case number works across every format.

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P197	A Normal Lost Phone	49	P170	NORCO	17
P198	Another Lost Phone: Laura's Story	50	P184	OPUS: Echo of Starsong - Full Bloom Edition	34
P173	Beacon Pines	23	P183	OPUS: Rocket of Whispers	33
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A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 5. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index near the front always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P161	P162	P163	P164	P165	P166	P167	P168
2. Ready for conversation	P169	P170	P171	P172	P173	P174	P175	P176
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P177	P178	P179	P180	P181	P182	P183	P184
4. Here for the atmosphere	P185	P186	P187	P188	P189	P190	P191	P192
5. Open to a wildcard	P193	P194	P195	P196	P197	P198	P199	P200

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

The Hotel Charged Me for My Own Entrance

The hotel had put my face on the elevator doors. Nigga, every time somebody wanted the thirty-second floor, they had to split my head down the middle.

I stood in front of it with Tank. Two tourists waited behind us. One had a camera. The other had the expression of a woman who had already heard why her husband needed the camera.

'Who approved that?' I asked. Tank looked at the doors. 'You. You said larger than life.' 'Nigga, I meant the photograph. Not the forehead.'

The doors opened through my nose. Shawna stood inside wearing a blue dress that had ended three conversations on the way upstairs. Mine nearly became the fourth.

'Baby. You coming?' 'Depends what happens when I arrive.' 'You help Rosa move the food.'

Tank got in first. Nigga moved fast when somebody gave romance a practical ending.

The penthouse was supposed to hold a game night. I had rented the whole floor, hired a singer, ordered a champagne fountain and told the hotel I wanted the room to feel intimate. They had installed enough speakers to introduce intimacy to the surrounding county.

Mercedes was at the piano with the singer. She wanted one clean run through her new arrangement before anybody started talking over it. Porsche had both phones out and was threatening the lighting technician with a photograph of what his amber setting did to her shoes.

Rosa wanted dinner hot. Tank wanted to sit beside Rosa. Shawna wanted the bedroom key I had somehow given to the man tuning the piano. Everybody had a clear objective. Mine was to make this look intentional.

'Nigga, why the piano man got our room?' 'He asked for a key.' 'He meant a musical key.'

My wife held out her hand. I went and fetched the other kind.

By the windows, a casino host was showing a guest the private bar. The guest had brought cocaine and an opinion about every business in Nevada. His opinion arrived first. His jacket followed on a waiter's arm after Porsche decided both needed to leave her piano alone.

'He said he's an investor,' I told her. 'Then he can invest in the fucking elevator.'

Porsche handed the jacket to the host. Tank held the door. The guest kept explaining his idea while the lift carried him and his belongings toward a different audience.

I liked Porsche. She could remove a whole subplot without explaining symbolism.

Mercedes tried the first line. Conversation dropped away in pieces. Shawna leaned against me. I slid a hand to her waist. She let it stay there, which immediately improved my opinion of the architecture.

'We could go upstairs,' I whispered. 'This is the top floor.' 'Nigga, emotionally.' 'Emotionally, you still owe Rosa two trays.'

I carried the trays.

On the long low table, the games were ready. Stories about bartenders, drivers, detectives, families and people whose decisions refused to stay simple. The hotel had supplied a second sofa so somebody could watch without being assigned a controller. It was a small miracle. Usually a hotel charges extra for understanding a sentence.

Tank dropped onto it and patted the place beside him. Rosa put down the last dish and sat. My brother's whole face changed. Same nigga who could make a doorway look nervous, looking at her like the night had finally started.

'You feeding me?' he asked. 'You got hands.' 'I'm being romantic.' 'Then use both and pass the plate.'

He passed it. Romance survived the adjustment.

I stood in front of the screen. The hotel lights caught my blue jacket. A guest by the bar raised his glass and said I had turned a Crip colour into a room service surcharge.

'Nigga, this is tailored.' 'So is the bill,' Tank said.

I had prepared a speech. Mercedes looked up from the piano and shook her head once. Not angry. Busy. She wanted her music, and the room was finally giving it to her.

I folded the speech without opening it.

These were separate invitations. Somebody could want a game. Somebody could want a song. Somebody could want to hear what a character meant without racing an answer. Nobody had to join the noise because I had paid to make it loud.

Shawna pulled me down beside her. 'Pick something with people in it.' 'Baby, people love me.' 'I want to hear them finish a sentence.'

Tank laughed hard enough to lose a shrimp. Rosa caught it on his plate. That nigga had married well.

I opened the first story. The door to the hallway stayed shut, the bedroom key stayed in my wife's hand, and for one promising moment the most interesting voice in the penthouse did not belong to me.

P161 / A PLACE TO START

Coffee Talk

Edition considered: PC first game

Listen to customers in a late-night café, where preparing a drink creates space for intimate conversations and gradually unfolding personal stories.

What you do. Read conversations, prepare requested drinks and follow the people who return to the counter with different concerns.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Choose Main Story with manual text advance; timed Challenge Mode is a different experience, and ingredient selection still needs attention.

Why it might click. Coffee Talk makes a café counter into a place to get to know recurring people. The fantasy setting puts a fresh surface on work, romance, identity, and belonging. Serving drinks influences story branches; the appeal is noticing a person's request and watching relationships develop.

The full catch. Use the main story with manual text advance; avoid timed Challenge mode. Expect substantial reading and ingredient selection. Drink choices can change story branches. Check the brewing interface and text controls; any decorative latte work is a separate hold/drag question.

Try this first. Choose the main Story mode and manual text advance. Serve one early request, then stay for the conversation it supports. Notice whether ingredients add pleasure or interrupt listening; check the exact edition's controls before settling in.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Barista Knows Why My Wife Is Smiling

I leaned over the penthouse coffee counter and told Shawna I knew exactly what she needed. Nigga, I had been married long enough to understand why she enjoyed hearing me say that.

'Go on,' she said. I reached for a cup. 'Something hot. Complicated. Worth staying up for.' 'Coffee, Aiden.'

Tank laughed into his saucer. The bartender waited with the patience of a man being paid hourly for my courtship.

Coffee Talk had people arriving with more on their minds than the drink. Mercedes wanted to hear one finish. I started predicting the problem. She turned the little screen toward herself.

'Nigga, let the customer speak.' 'I'm establishing rapport.' 'You're establishing noise.'

I made Shawna's coffee while she listened. Put the cup down without an introduction. She took a sip and caught my sleeve before I could walk away.

'That,' she said, 'was what I needed.' Tank lifted his saucer. 'Write it down, my nigga. You solved one.'

Aiden's verdict. Bring this to a night that wants conversation over spectacle. My wife got her coffee; the nigga advertising himself as a beverage remains under review.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Steam supports the first game's premise and drink-driven story. The identified secondary walkthrough separates the main story from timed Challenge objectives; this is a mode-specific recommendation. Manual advance, brewing and hold comfort still need checking in the chosen edition. The whole-game pace field remains unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/914800/>

Source 2: <https://www.trueachievements.com/game/Coffee-Talk/walkthrough>

P162 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Coffee Talk Episode 2: Hibiscus & Butterfly

Edition considered: PC sequel

Return to familiar café company for new conversations and drink-making, with another set of relationships to follow across the nights together.

What you do. Prepare drinks, follow customer conversations and explore the latte-art interface if its particular form of interaction interests you.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Returning relationships and recipes add tracking; fluid latte-art controls may require drawing, dragging or sustained pointer movement.

Why it might click. The second Coffee Talk offers more café conversations with returning and new fantasy customers, additional drink ingredients, and latte-art play. It suits an appetite for spending more time with this particular world rather than racing through a chain of dramatic reveals.

The full catch. Recipes and returning relationships can increase the things to remember. The official description includes fluid-simulation latte art, so drawing or held-pointer demands need checking separately. Nothing about the calm presentation establishes a complete absence of fiddly inputs.

Try this first. Make an early drink and follow one customer's situation. Try the art interface only if it interests you; inspect how to proceed if it does not. Decide whether the return feels welcoming or depends too much on previous familiarity.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P162 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Coffee Talk Episode 2: Hibiscus & Butterfly

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Butterfly Looks Like It Owes Child Support

I told the bartender I could draw a butterfly in the milk. Shawna watched me take possession of the cup with the confidence that usually preceded a hotel damage charge.

The result had one enormous wing and a body shaped like a threat. Tank looked down. 'Nigga, that butterfly got warrants.'

Mercedes wanted hibiscus. Porsche wanted to show her something on the game screen. Neither had requested an exhibition of my dairy talents, but success rarely waits for permission to announce itself. 'It's abstract,' I said. Shawna turned the cup. 'Now it's fleeing.'

The second Coffee Talk brought another night of people carrying stories into a familiar place. Porsche leaned closer when a conversation caught her. Mercedes stopped checking her phone.

I almost explained how I had created the atmosphere. The bartender slid a proper drink in front of me and quietly took away my brush.

Shawna tasted the tea. 'Lovely.' 'You mean my butterfly?' 'Baby, I mean the thing somebody else finished.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose another evening at the counter if the people still interest you. My butterfly has been denied entry, but its fleeing silhouette remains emotionally convincing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC sequel. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1663220/>

P163 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

VA-11 Hall-A: Cyberpunk Bartender Action

Edition considered: PC release

Work behind a cyberpunk bar where mixing drinks gives you time with distinctive customers, their problems and the life outside the counter.

What you do. Read customer exchanges, follow drink recipes and serve mixtures while learning more about the people who visit the bar.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Reading, recipes and customer preferences need attention, alongside sexual conversation and alcohol themes; test the actual mixing controls.

Why it might click. The game uses bartending to frame a series of conversations about life in a high-tech, unequal city. Drinks influence which stories unfold. Its attraction is the contrast between large political systems and the specific people living, working, joking, and struggling inside them.

The full catch. Reading, recipe selection, and remembering customer preferences are real parts of the experience. Sexual conversation, alcohol, and adult subject matter belong to its tone. Check ingredient operations and any mixing or waiting controls rather than inferring simplicity from the visual-novel label.

Try this first. Complete one customer order with the recipe information available on screen. Then judge the conversation itself: are these people enjoyable company, and is the bar routine a satisfying rhythm rather than unwanted clerical work?

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Cocktail Was Named After Me and Nobody Wanted Two

The bartender asked what I wanted to call my signature drink. I said Aiden After Midnight. Tank asked whether it came with an apology in the morning.

'Nigga, it comes with confidence.' 'That's the ingredient I'm worried about.'

VA-11 Hall-A put a different kind of bar in front of us. Neon, people with difficult lives, drinks that gave them somewhere to start talking. Mercedes pulled up a chair.

I tried to make our actual bartender explain my creation to a woman waiting for water. Shawna caught my eye across the counter.

'She asked for water.' 'I heard her.' 'Then why are you naming yourself at her?'

I passed the water. The woman thanked me and returned to her own conversation. Astonishingly, the room survived without learning what my cocktail meant.

Tank tasted my drink and set it down. 'Nigga, this tastes like you had an argument with a lemon.' Shawna slid it toward me. 'Good. You two can resolve it privately.'

Aiden's verdict. Take the neon bar for its people and their messy nights. The actual bartender may confiscate my lemon argument without compromising anybody's fictional drinking order.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/447530/>

P164 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Red Strings Club

Edition considered: PC release

Explore a cyberpunk story about emotion and influence through unusual work, conversations and choices that question what helping another person means.

What you do. Shape objects, prepare drinks, use telephone conversations and make choices while following the story's questions about emotional influence.

Mixed controls | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Object shaping can require precision; several interaction types and morally difficult themes need checking beyond the point-and-click label.

Why it might click. This cyberpunk conspiracy story asks what happiness and emotional freedom mean. Its unusual sequence of bartending, implant pottery, and phone impersonation gives those arguments different forms; you manipulate both objects and conversations while learning what a corporation intends.

The full catch. The store explicitly describes a lathe and cocktail manipulation, which makes pointer precision and held movement significant checks. This is not safely described as dialogue-only. Its emotional manipulation and corporate-control themes may also feel sharper than a relaxed conversation game.

Try this first. Inspect the first hands-on task as soon as it appears. Determine whether its movement is enjoyable and whether the offered controls work for you. A compelling ethical question is not an obligation to tolerate an irritating interface.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Clay Knows My Hands Better Than My Alibi

I said the pot I had made looked like a heart. Shawna said it looked like a heart after I explained my expenses. Tank turned it over and asked where the other half went.

The Red Strings Club had us talking about emotion, influence and the difference between helping somebody and deciding what they should feel. I was strongly in favour of people feeling impressed.

Mercedes wanted to turn the object herself. I kept pointing at the screen. She held out her hand until I remembered the mouse belonged in it.

'Nigga, move.' 'I'm assisting.' 'Then assist yourself out of my light.'

At the real bar, a guest was promising Porsche he could change her entire career. Porsche asked whether he could change his seat instead.

Shawna watched me watching. 'You hearing the theme?' 'Baby, I've been hearing themes all night.'

She put my crooked clay heart beside my drink. 'Then hear this one. I like you better when you ask.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose the strange club when influence itself sounds worth questioning. My clay heart may attend, provided the nigga holding it stops diagnosing everybody else's feelings.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/589780/>

P165 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Neo Cab

Edition considered: PC release

Meet passengers whose conversations reveal a troubled city, while a driver's relationships, money and emotional state complicate the choices ahead.

What you do. Read passenger exchanges, choose responses and consider the relationships, ratings and resources affected by the driver's decisions.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Money, ratings and emotion restrictions create pressure; check text flow and map/menu operations despite the declared mouse-only option.

Why it might click. Neo Cab is a visual novel about Lina, a human driver in an increasingly automated city. Passengers become sources of stories and possible leads in her search. Her emotional state affects available responses, giving conversations a connection to the strain of working and surviving.

The full catch. Do not confuse its driving premise with a promise about vehicle controls: the inspected listing calls it a visual novel and declares a mouse-only option. Money, ratings, and emotion restrictions can still create pressure. Check reading flow and map/menu operations.

Try this first. Follow an early passenger conversation through to its outcome. Look at how a mood change affects the next available response. Decide whether that constraint deepens the character or makes the conversation feel less enjoyable.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Driver Has Heard My Seduction Speech Before

I put on driving gloves inside the suite. Tank looked at the carpet. 'Nigga, where you taking us? The lamp?'

Neo Cab's conversations began with somebody needing a ride. Mine began with Shawna needing me to stop pretending the sofa was a luxury vehicle. I offered her the front seat anyway.

'What's the fare?' she asked. 'A kiss.' 'Hotel already charged me for the room. I'm negotiating.'

Mercedes sat with the game and read the passenger's reply. A person could want a destination and still bring a whole different problem into the car. She wanted to hear it.

I started a story about the last woman who admired my driving. Shawna looked at me. 'That was me.' 'Baby, I remember my best reviews.'

Tank produced the actual car keys. 'You left these in the champagne bucket.'

I removed the gloves. My wife moved closer on the sofa. Apparently the driver could have a pleasant evening after admitting he was parked.

Aiden's verdict. Invite the passenger stories when conversation and compromise appeal. My driving gloves stay on the table until the nigga wearing them identifies an actual vehicle.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/794540/>

P166 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Eliza

Edition considered: PC release

Follow a story about scripted emotional support, work and listening, where the gap between a helpful conversation and a performance becomes interesting.

What you do. Read conversations, choose responses and follow the character's work and relationships as the story questions how support is delivered.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Substantial dialogue explores personal distress and counselling technology; check text pacing and whether the subject feels welcome tonight.

Why it might click. Eliza follows Evelyn as she works as a human proxy for an AI counseling program and reconnects with people from her past. Fully voiced characters and a contemporary setting carry questions about work, responsibility, technical power, and whether simulated care meets real needs.

The full catch. The subject includes personal distress and the limits of counseling technology. Consider whether that is welcome material tonight. Expect substantial dialogue and choices; verify text pacing and navigation. This is a fictional story, not an instruction manual for supporting another person.

Try this first. Read an early work scene and a conversation outside it. Compare the constrained professional role with Evelyn's own voice. Continue if the contrast makes you curious, rather than because the subject seems worthy enough to require homework.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Earpiece Told Me to Shut the Fuck Up

Shawna stood behind the casino's decorative screen and fed me reassuring sentences through an earpiece. I delivered the first one to Tank with my hand over my heart.

'I hear the weight of your concern.' Tank looked at his plate. 'Nigga, I asked where the sauce was.'

Eliza had started an argument about scripted empathy. I intended to prove that warmth could make any line convincing. Shawna sent the next instruction.

'Ask a follow-up.' I leaned closer. 'How long have you wanted the sauce?'

Mercedes laughed so hard she put the controller down. Rosa walked past me, gave Tank the sauce and kissed his head. The entire therapeutic performance lost to a small bowl.

I took out the earpiece. 'Baby, you were setting me up.' 'You volunteered to demonstrate understanding.'

She came around the screen and sat beside me. I asked whether she wanted anything. She said a quiet minute. Nigga, the first unscripted request was the hardest one.

Aiden's verdict. Try this when the distance between listening and performing concern feels interesting. The sauce arrived without an earpiece, which has complicated my theory of professional warmth.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/716500/>

P167 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Citizen Sleeper

Edition considered: PC first game

Build a precarious life through dice and daily choices, with relationships and meaningful opportunities competing for the resources available each cycle.

What you do. Allocate dice, choose tasks, manage resources and follow relationships while deciding what can be done during each cycle.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. No timed input is declared, but resource shortages, cycle clocks and interconnected choices create substantial planning pressure.

Why it might click. Citizen Sleeper turns life on a crowded station into choices about work, friendships, resources, and survival. Assigning dice creates a clear connection between what you can do this cycle and what you care about. Its characters make those allocations feel personal rather than merely numerical.

The full catch. Steam declares playable without timed input, but the story uses resource pressure and advancing clocks. Several systems and ongoing relationships need attention. That declaration does not verify hold-free controls; inspect dice placement, text size, and the station interface.

Try this first. Spend one cycle slowly, explaining to yourself what each chosen action will cost or advance. Meet somebody whose situation interests you. Notice whether the limited opportunities feel engaging or like a second schedule to manage.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / I Rolled Four Problems and Called Them Opportunity

I shook the dice beside the penthouse window like I was about to win the hotel. Tank watched them land. 'Nigga, those numbers don't even buy breakfast.'

Citizen Sleeper gave us a life built from limited chances. I looked at the available choices and promised Mercedes I could arrange everything. She asked which thing I would leave undone.

'Nothing.' 'Then read it again.'

Porsche wanted to follow one person. Tank wanted to keep enough resources for what came next. Nobody was wrong, which was inconvenient for my preferred method of settling an argument loudly.

A casino host drifted over to admire my confidence. Shawna sent him away before he could convert it into a credit line.

I chose one modest action. The rest waited, still wanting something. Mercedes nodded at the consequence instead of congratulating me.

'Damn,' I said. 'It keeps the bill.' Tank leaned back. 'Welcome, my nigga, to the part of gambling they don't put on the chandelier.'

Aiden's verdict. Sit with these choices if limited resources make a story richer. My casino confidence cannot pay a space-station bill, despite the jacket suggesting otherwise.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC first game. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1578650/>

P168 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Citizen Sleeper 2: Starward Vector

Edition considered: PC sequel

Travel with a crew through uncertain contracts, where imperfect dice and limited resources make shared needs and consequences part of the story.

What you do. Choose contracts, allocate dice, manage crew concerns and resources, and respond to stress and damaged dice as journeys develop.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Crew systems, stress, contracts and damaged dice add heavy tracking despite declared untimed play and adjustable difficulty.

Why it might click. The sequel expands the dice-driven roleplaying into travel, crew-building, and contracts across an asteroid belt. A battered ship can become a home, while temporary jobs bring distinct characters and risks. The appeal is making a future through relationships as well as careful decisions.

The full catch. The current Steam record declares adjustable difficulty and play without timed input. It also describes stress, damaged dice, and multi-cycle contracts: waiting for you is not the same as removing consequences. Inspect the actual difficulty choices before relying on them.

Try this first. Learn one contract's objective, available dice, and stress consequences before committing actions. Try a manageable early job and ask whether preparing with a crew adds pleasure or too many interconnected things to track.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Ship Has Rejected My Penthouse Upgrade

I tried to name our imaginary ship The Aiden Experience. Tank asked whether passengers could request a refund before takeoff.

Citizen Sleeper 2 made the crew and the next contract feel connected in ways my grand name did not cover. Mercedes wanted to know who was coming aboard. Porsche wanted to know whether the job was worth the trouble.

'Nigga, we can do it.' 'That's not the question,' Shawna said.

I moved a champagne crate to demonstrate cargo capacity and discovered it was empty. The actual bottles were behind Rosa, who had correctly anticipated that my demonstration would become a voyage.

The game's damaged dice looked less like bad luck once somebody depended on the plan. I stopped talking long enough to read the options.

Tank tapped the empty crate. 'Captain, your luxury fleet got no engine.'

I sat on it. Shawna came over and fixed my collar. 'At least the seating works.' The Aiden Experience opened as a bench and received its first favourable review.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the crew story when imperfect tools and uncertain jobs sound compelling. My ship remains available as a bench until somebody supplies more than the captain's name.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC sequel. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2442460/>

P169 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Disco Elysium - The Final Cut

Edition considered: PC Final Cut

Investigate through conversations and competing inner voices, with unusual characters, roleplaying choices and a darkly funny world giving the detective story depth.

What you do. Explore scenes, question people, read or hear dialogue and make choices shaped by the detective's different skills and impulses.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Extensive dialogue, skill checks and inventory/character menus add substantial work; not every interaction is verified as untimed or hold-free.

Why it might click. The Final Cut presents a dense, voiced detective roleplaying story about a damaged investigator and a politically complicated city. Skills become argumentative inner voices, making character-building part of the writing. Conversations can be funny, cruel, revealing, and unexpectedly tender.

The full catch. Expect extensive dialogue, skill checks, inventory and character menus, and mature material including addiction and violence. A failed choice can have consequences. The manually checked source confirms the Final Cut edition, but does not certify all interactions as untimed or hold-free.

Try this first. Follow an early conversation and inspect one relevant skill explanation. Decide whether the competing voices delight you or interrupt the person you want to hear. Treat the opening as a test of tone as much as controls.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Necktie Has Demanded Its Own Room

I loosened my tie and told the room it had seen things. Tank said the room had seen me miss the same trouser pocket twice and could therefore confirm part of the testimony.

Disco Elysium put a detective's competing impulses in front of us. I recognised the sensation of several confident voices suggesting terrible plans. Shawna said those were usually just my friends warning me.

'Nigga, this tie understands complexity.' Mercedes lifted it off the table. 'This tie understands spilled rum.'

At the far bar, the cocaine guest had returned long enough to announce another business revelation. Porsche pointed him back toward the host. We already had enough unreliable narrators indoors.

I read the next exchange. Funny, ugly, human. My own joke went quiet halfway out.

Shawna touched my wrist. 'You want to keep going?' I nodded.

Tank took the tie before I could put it back on. 'Detective, evidence says this motherfucker needs laundry, not a promotion.'

Aiden's verdict. Enter for the voices, contradictions and difficult people if that darkness appeals. My necktie may testify, but its room-service charges remain entirely my responsibility.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually inspected Steam app632470 on 2026-09-20, exact title Disco Elysium - The Final Cut. Source supports full English voice acting, skills, roleplaying choices, and mature content. Control and workload judgments remain editorial.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/632470/>

P170 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

NORCO

Edition considered: PC release

Investigate a family mystery in a distinctive industrial landscape, where conversations, local detail and strange events make the place itself compelling to explore.

What you do. Explore scenes, talk to characters, inspect clues and work through the story's puzzles and other interactive sequences.

Mouse / pointer | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Dense themes and puzzles add work, and the source mentions fights; do not assume it is exclusively quiet dialogue.

Why it might click. NORCO combines a missing-person search with family history, industrial landscapes, and increasingly strange science fiction in South Louisiana. Its dialogue-focused point-and-click structure invites attention to both particular characters and the forces shaping their world.

The full catch. The official description also mentions puzzles and fights; do not treat dialogue-focused as proof that every sequence is mechanically quiet. Expect dense imagery, unfamiliar connections, and bereavement. Check each new interaction type and the text/interface size.

Try this first. Explore an early location and follow one clue about the missing brother. Pause to decide whether the place feels intriguing in its own right. Inspect the first unfamiliar mechanical sequence before assuming later play matches the opening.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P170 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

NORCO

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The South Has Sent My Mood Board Back

I had arranged a tray of objects to explain NORCO's atmosphere: a motel key, a plastic monkey, a broken sign and my most thoughtful sunglasses. Mercedes picked up the monkey.

'Nigga, did you read anything before decorating?' 'I communicate visually.' 'You communicate expensively.'

The game's family mystery and industrial landscape wanted attention more serious than my styling. Shawna read the first exchange without supplying a mood. I sat beside her.

Downstairs, the casino's enormous neon crown kept buzzing. Tank pulled our curtain halfway closed. The room looked better with less of my chosen view in it.

I tried to put the sunglasses on the monkey. Rosa took both and set down the food. 'Let something in here be useful.'

A detail on the screen caught Mercedes. She asked us to wait. We did.

The tray remained on the floor by my shoes, all its objects looking suddenly ordinary. Nigga, the actual place had arrived, and my expensive explanation had nothing left to say.

Aiden's verdict. Visit for a particular family and place, if their unease draws you in. My decorative monkey is not qualified to brief anyone on the American South.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected public Steam primary description and category declarations for PC release. Premise and listed features are source-supported; control workload, memory and mood routing are editorial judgments, not completion testing. Absent co-op or timed-input declarations remain unknown.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1221250/>

My Wife Paused Me Without Touching the Controller

I had developed a theory about every person on the screen. This surprised nobody. I had also developed a theory about the waiter, the piano tuner and the woman who had asked whether the ice machine was down the hall.

Shawna waited until I finished explaining a character's entire life from one line of dialogue. Then she picked up the controller.

'Nigga, you want to know what she says next?' 'I know what she means.' 'You know what you mean. You've been telling the room for six minutes.'

Tank glanced over from the bar. 'That's the short version.'

I reached for my drink and discovered Rosa had moved it away from the electronics. She had left it within reach of my actual hand. A considerate correction, which is the most difficult kind to turn into an argument.

On the screen, a conversation waited. Across the room, Mercedes and Porsche were having one that did not.

'You told him I was performing again?' Mercedes asked. Porsche lowered a phone. 'He said the casino wanted an encore.' 'The casino got the song. I wanted the rest of the night.'

I started to step in. Shawna put her hand on my knee.

'Don't.' 'Baby, I can smooth this out.' 'You can make it about your ability to smooth things out. Different service.'

I stayed.

Porsche looked at the little stage. She had arranged the lights herself, argued the sound into behaving and thought an encore would be a compliment. Mercedes had spent the evening making sure the room heard the song instead of a story about the song. They wanted different endings to the same successful thing.

'I should've asked,' Porsche said. Mercedes nodded. 'Yeah.'

No smashed glass. No elaborate punishment. Two grown women adjusting a plan while I sat there with an entire unused entrance.

Tank came over carrying the microphone. 'They handed this to me.' 'What for?' 'To announce you were about to say something.' 'Nigga, I wasn't.'

He looked at Shawna. She shook her head. He put the microphone down so carefully it might have been a sleeping animal.

'Damn,' he said. 'Almost had an event.'

The screen conversation was still there. I read the next line. My magnificent interpretation developed a hole.

Shawna watched my face. 'What?' 'Nothing.' 'That was an expensive-looking nothing.'

The character had wanted something simpler than my theory allowed. I had supplied a motive, a secret and a childhood grievance where the actual words supplied one disappointed friend.

Nigga, I had furnished a whole house nobody asked to live in.

I let Shawna answer. She did not pick the line I would have picked. The story went somewhere interesting. I managed not to announce that this too had been contained within my analysis.

Rosa sat on the arm of Tank's chair. 'You two enjoying yourselves?' 'I am,' Shawna said. 'He's adjusting.'

My brother lifted his glass. 'To adjustment.' 'Nigga, don't toast my correction.'

Everybody drank anyway.

The piano tuner returned the spare key at last. He apologised for the confusion. Shawna took it and slipped it into her bag. I said our bedroom was now available for its intended purpose.

'Sleep?' Tank asked. 'Nigga, mind your marriage.'

Rosa smiled at him. 'You should.'

He stood so fast I thought the couch had caught fire.

They did not leave immediately. Rosa still wanted dessert. Tank sat back down, accepted a plate and looked at her with the patience of a man who understood that the evening was not improved by hurrying the part she was enjoying.

I took the lesson without volunteering that I had taken it.

On the screen, somebody started another difficult sentence. I kept my mouth shut long enough to hear the end.

P171 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Kentucky Route Zero

Edition considered: PC complete five-act edition

Follow an unusual theatrical journey where conversations, working lives and strange places matter as much as finding out what happens next.

What you do. Explore scenes, choose conversation responses and follow the people met along a mysterious delivery route.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Expect substantial reading and ambiguity; the existing source does not certify every timing or held-input demand.

Why it might click. This five-act magical-realist adventure follows a delivery into a world of strange roads, precarious work, debts, and fragile communities. Its pleasure lies in language, staging, music, and atmosphere. Choices can feel like shaping a performance rather than selecting the correct solution to a puzzle.

The full catch. Expect substantial reading, ambiguity, and a pace that may feel deliberately indirect. The PC Edition has been manually matched to the assigned complete game. Check movement and text advance; no inspected source establishes every scene as free of held or timed input.

Try this first. Stay with one early encounter rather than trying to solve the whole world's meaning. Notice whether choosing a line makes you feel involved. If the theatrical distance leaves you cold, that is useful taste information, not a reading failure.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Highway Leads to a Room I Didn't Book

I asked the concierge for directions to somewhere impossible. He checked my room bill and said I had already arrived.

Kentucky Route Zero had made the familiar feel strange without raising its voice. Mercedes wanted to follow the conversation. I wanted to explain what everything represented. Shawna gave me a look that could close a conference.

'Nigga, it can mean something before you name it.'

Tank pushed aside the curtain. From our floor, the casino road disappeared underneath the hotel and came out somewhere else. Rosa said that was where the valet had taken her car three hours ago.

The game's delivery felt like a journey with people who had their own reasons to keep moving. I stopped trying to make a map of everybody's meaning.

Mercedes read another line. The piano below us answered with a chord somebody was testing. For once, two unrelated things were allowed to sound good together.

I rang the concierge. 'Forget the directions.' 'Which ones, sir?' Nigga had a fair question.

Aiden's verdict. Take this road for its people, theatre and strange atmosphere. The concierge cannot guarantee a destination, especially when the nigga requesting directions is asking metaphorically.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually inspected Steam app231200, Kentucky Route Zero: PC Edition; the five-act PC edition matches this assigned game despite title-review flag. Other control and mood judgments remain provisional.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/231200/>

P172 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Night in the Woods

Edition considered: PC release

Revisit friendships in a changing hometown, where funny conversations and ordinary outings lead into a more unsettling story about belonging.

What you do. Move through town, talk with friends, explore familiar places and take part in activities along the story.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Movement includes platforming and other active sequences; a strong character story does not remove those control demands.

Why it might click. Night in the Woods offers the company of young adults negotiating friendship, disappointment, work, and changes in their hometown. Its animal characters carry recognizably human conversations, with a mystery growing around the edges of daily wandering.

The full catch. Movement and platforming are part of its adventure structure, and additional activity types require checking. Do not file it as a static visual novel. Its themes can be bleak, including economic decline and emotional distress, despite the bright designs and frequent jokes.

Try this first. Walk through an early stretch of town and talk to somebody who knows Mae. Test the movement before investing in the story. Decide whether the everyday conversations are reward enough for the amount of traversal between them.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / I Came Home with a Band and Nobody Rehearsed

I told the hotel pianist we were starting a band. Tank said he had come upstairs to eat. I said every great drummer began with objections.

Night in the Woods brought us back to old friends and a place that had kept changing without permission. I began listing everybody who had missed me last time I left Vegas.

'Nigga, the valet missed your tip,' Porsche said. 'That's affection with an invoice.'

Mercedes picked up a spare guitar and tested one string. She wanted a song. Shawna wanted me to hear the awkward conversation on the screen before I made the homecoming about applause.

I sat down. Somebody in the game said something that sounded funny until it didn't. Tank quit tapping his fork against the glass.

'That's your part,' Mercedes told him. 'The silence.'

He nodded. I reached for the microphone. Five people looked at me at once. Nigga, the band had found unity before we had found a name.

Aiden's verdict. Come for the friendships and the uneasy business of returning home. My new band accepts silence as a contribution and has therefore become dangerously good.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/481510/>

P173 / A PLACE TO START

Beacon Pines

Edition considered: PC release

Explore a branching storybook mystery where discovering and choosing particular words can change what happens to its characters in meaningful ways.

What you do. Move through the setting, talk to characters, collect useful words and try them at branching moments.

Direction + buttons | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Branch tracking and creepy events remain despite untimed-play declarations; test walking and menu selection for held-input demands.

Why it might click. Beacon Pines combines exploring a small town with collecting word charms and revisiting branches through a story tree. New words can transform a moment and open different events. Curiosity about how a sentence changes the world becomes part of solving its mystery.

The full catch. The Steam record declares play without timed input and keyboard-only operation. Branch tracking still adds a memory burden, and the cute art accompanies creepy events. Those declarations do not establish that every control avoids holds; test ordinary walking and menu selection.

Try this first. Collect an early charm and use it at a turning point. Then inspect how the story tree represents the route. Continue if comparing possibilities feels like discovery rather than keeping several unfinished stories in your head.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Word Was Charming Until I Put Myself in It

I wrote AIDEN beside three words on a hotel napkin: AVAILABLE, SPECTACULAR and LATE. Shawna slid the first two away.

Beacon Pines let words change the direction of a story. I appreciated that. I had spent years trying to make late sound like an entrance.

Tank read the napkin. 'Nigga, available to who?' 'The evening.' 'The evening already ate.'

Mercedes wanted to try a different branch. Porsche leaned across her shoulder and pointed at one word. They argued about what it might do, then Mercedes chose for herself.

I added MISUNDERSTOOD to my little autobiography. Rosa put a plate on top of it. The word disappeared beneath potatoes, a development I considered hostile to literature.

The game showed us a new possibility. Shawna smiled at the sentence rather than at me. I found I wanted to see the next one too.

I left the napkin under the plate. My wife touched my knee. 'Look at you, baby. Finally on time for something.'

Aiden's verdict. Open it when a single word changing a story sounds inviting. My napkin autobiography remains available, although the potatoes have won editorial control of the ending.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1269640/>

P174 / A PLACE TO START

Mutazione

Edition considered: PC release

Spend time in an unusual community through conversations and gardening, with music helping give the people and their surroundings a distinctive mood.

What you do. Explore the community, speak with residents and tend gardens as their interconnected stories develop around you.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Illness, family secrets and community conflict matter; verify the declared untimed, input and saving options on the installed version.

Why it might click. Mutazione follows Kai visiting her grandfather in an unusual island community. Conversations, old tensions, and musical gardens sit alongside the supernatural plot. Its attraction is spending enough time with a place that the relationships begin to matter.

The full catch. Illness, family secrets, and community conflict are central; gentle presentation is not a promise of emotionally light material. Steam declares no timed input, mouse-only and keyboard-only options, and save-anytime. Verify those options on the installed version and inspect ordinary navigation.

Try this first. Meet one resident and spend time with an early garden interaction. Judge the balance between conversation and moving through the community. If you like it, a note of the next person to visit may make returning easier.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Garden Grows Better When I Stop Singing at It

I stood over a hotel fern and sang what I considered a nourishing note. Tank watched one leaf sag. 'Nigga, that plant just requested checkout.'

Mutazione had gardens, music and people whose lives were tangled together. Mercedes listened to the sound while Rosa leaned closer to a conversation. Neither wanted my botanical solo.

Shawna took the watering jug from me. 'It's artificial.' 'Then explain the attitude.'

At the bar, Porsche was refusing another guest's request for Mercedes to perform. Mercedes heard the refusal and kept playing. A small kindness, delivered without making her turn around.

I sat beside Rosa and asked what the character had said. She repeated it. I listened instead of looking for an entrance.

The fern remained fake. The little world on the screen felt considerably less so.

Tank put the plant on the far side of the room. 'Better acoustics over there.' 'For who?' 'Nigga, everybody still alive enough to object.'

Aiden's verdict. Visit for community, conversation and the pleasure of growing a garden. The hotel fern has relocated permanently, citing unresolved artistic differences with my voice.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1080750/>

P175 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Wytchwood

Edition considered: PC release

Gather strange ingredients and craft useful things while a witch's errands lead through an illustrated world of stories, creatures and connected tasks.

What you do. Explore locations, collect ingredients, follow recipes and return with crafted items to advance different characters' requests.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Nested recipes, repeated travel and monsters add work; keeping several ingredient chains in mind can become demanding.

Why it might click. Wytchwood turns gothic fairy-tale errands into gathering and crafting. The witch's judgments give the recipes personality: ingredients are steps toward changing a troublesome situation, not simply collecting for its own sake. The illustrated world helps make each place distinctive.

The full catch. Expect repeated travel, nested recipes, and remembering where resources come from. The official description includes monsters and overcoming them through tools and spells; do not assume that crafting removes all hazards or movement demands. Check inventory and held movement.

Try this first. Follow one early recipe from request to ingredients to use. Notice whether retracing a route is satisfying familiarity or unwanted repetition. The useful trial is the whole small crafting loop, not just admiring the art.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Recipe Needs One Ingredient I Have Never Heard Of

I promised Rosa I could improve the party punch with something from the hotel garden. She caught my wrist before my confidence became a beverage.

'Nigga, that is landscaping.' 'It's fragrant.' 'So is floor cleaner.'

Wytchwood had a better reason to gather odd ingredients: a whole chain of tasks leading into stories. I liked the witch's authority. Tank liked watching me discover that authority still had errands.

Mercedes read a recipe and asked where the next item might be. I pointed at a distant place with the certainty of a man who had not checked his pockets.

Shawna opened the inventory. The item was already there.

'Baby,' she said, 'you just sent everybody across the room for your own hand.'

Rosa took the punch bowl away from me. I followed the actual game instead. It turned out that remembering what I had was an excellent first step toward finding what I needed. Nigga, several hotel purchases could have benefited from that discovery.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the witch's errands if gathering and making things sound satisfying. My punch improvement has been cancelled until I can distinguish a recipe from landscaping.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/729000/>

P176 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Wandersong

Edition considered: PC release

Meet a colourful world through a bard's singing, with music and character encounters giving an active adventure its playful and emotional shape.

What you do. Move through scenes, sing to interact with the world and handle platforming as the adventure continues.

Mixed controls | Action continues while you think | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. This is an active platforming detour; warm music and artwork do not remove real-time movement and reaction demands.

Why it might click. Wandersong builds a characterful adventure around a bard who changes things through music. Its humor, unusual interactions, and emotional story can make singing feel like a way of meeting the world. The official pitch also explicitly calls it a platforming adventure.

The full catch. Directional movement, platforming, and selecting musical responses are meaningful demands. The developer's broad accessibility language about color and sound does not answer every motor-input question. This is a contrasting option for someone who wants those active elements, not a guaranteed quiet story.

Try this first. Try an early singing interaction and a small piece of traversal. Check whether choosing the notes and moving through the space are enjoyable. If either feels like an obstacle, keep the musical premise separate from the actual fit.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Karaoke Machine Has Requested a Better Singer

I announced that the power of song could solve anything. Mercedes looked at the karaoke machine. 'Start with whatever the fuck you did to its settings.'

Wandersong gave a bard a world to meet through music. I gave the penthouse one long note that made Tank inspect the ceiling.

'Nigga, is that you or the fire system?' 'That's range.' 'Then leave it at a distance.'

Shawna wanted to hear the actual song. Porsche lowered my microphone until it pointed at my shoes, which were better at keeping rhythm than the rest of me.

The game kept moving. Singing belonged to an active adventure, and I watched the little character negotiate what my grand theory had treated as automatic.

Mercedes sang a phrase softly from her seat. The room listened. I knew when to join her this time.

I didn't. She finished, smiled, and handed me a glass. Nigga, supporting a performance could feel surprisingly good when I stopped trying to stand in its middle.

Aiden's verdict. Take the musical adventure when singing and active movement both appeal. My microphone faces the carpet until the hotel confirms which sound triggered its concern.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/530320/>

P177 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Chicory: A Colorful Tale

Edition considered: PC release

Paint and explore a world where colour, creativity and a character's personal story develop together, with an optional second person helping paint.

What you do. Move through the world, colour scenes, solve obstacles and try the different available painting roles with a companion.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Painting, movement and active sequences need checking, and the two cooperative roles do not offer identical control.

Why it might click. Chicory is a coloring-book adventure about taking up an artist's brush. Painting changes the environment and supports puzzles, while the story explores creativity and the people around it. The official listing explicitly includes local cooperative painting.

The full catch. Painting, directional movement, and more active sequences need separate checks. Local co-op does not necessarily give both people identical roles. Inspect brush behavior and the game's actual options before deciding whether the action is welcome; no assumed setting is required by this card.

Try this first. Color one small area and use paint for an early puzzle. If playing together, establish who controls movement and who paints. The point is to discover whether making marks feels playful without turning the result into an art assessment.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / She Painted Over My Name and Improved the Landscape

I painted AIDEN across the hotel's practice canvas. Mercedes looked at the size of it. 'Nigga, what happened to the picture?' 'It acquired a subject.'

Chicory gave us a world to colour. Shawna wanted a patch of blue. I said I could supply a particularly distinguished shade. Tank told me the Crips had survived this long without my paint consultancy.

My wife took the brush. I kept pointing to places that needed my initials. She painted a beautiful little shape straight over the largest one.

'Baby.' 'Yes?' 'That was my signature.' 'Now it's a pond.'

Porsche moved closer to see. Rosa said she liked the pond. The room had reached a consensus with insulting speed.

We tried the game's different jobs together. I asked what Shawna wanted me to do before announcing what I intended.

She smiled. 'There. That colour.' I followed her lead. Nigga, somehow the world got brighter while my name got smaller.

Aiden's verdict. Bring it when making colour together sounds joyful and the actions suit both players. The pond remains unsigned, which has improved its reputation among actual visitors.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1123450/>

P178 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Rakuen

Edition considered: PC release

A hospital story opens into a fantastical world, connecting exploration and puzzles with the lives and feelings of people encountered along the way.

What you do. Guide the character through scenes, speak with people, explore the storybook world and solve puzzles that connect their stories.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Illness and grief are central, while non-combat play still includes movement, navigation and puzzle demands that need checking.

Why it might click. Rakuen follows a boy and his mother as helping people in a fantasy world reveals the lives of people around him. Music and character stories connect the two settings. The developer explicitly describes a non-combat adventure with puzzles and dialogue-based mysteries.

The full catch. Hospital life, illness, grief, and unfinished relationships are central themes. Non-combat does not mean no navigation or difficult puzzle. Check walking, object interaction, text advance, and any eerie sections; decide separately whether the emotional subject is welcome.

Try this first. Explore a small early area and speak with one person. Test the ordinary movement and the way information is presented. Continue for interest in the people, with permission to stop before an emotional scene feels like an obligation.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Hospital Story Made Me Put Down the Microphone

I tried to introduce Rakuen like a headline attraction. Shawna took the microphone out of my hand before I found a voice large enough to spoil it.

A child in a hospital and a storybook world deserved more than my best impression of importance. Rosa settled on the sofa. Tank sat beside her without bringing the joke he had been carrying from the bar.

I lowered the room's music. Mercedes noticed and nodded once. No applause. Nigga, apparently a useful action could arrive without an audience.

The game let another kind of place open beside a difficult one. Porsche wanted to follow the people. Shawna kept her hand in mine.

I almost said something reassuring I had no right to promise. My wife squeezed my fingers, and the sentence stayed where it belonged.

We watched a little longer. When Rosa asked to stop, Tank reached for the water before anyone asked why.

I put the microphone in its case. This story could speak without me turning up the volume.

Aiden's verdict. Visit the storybook only if its hospital setting and grief are welcome tonight. The microphone stays closed; this invitation does not require an uplifting speech.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/559210/>

P179 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

To the Moon

Edition considered: PC original release

Follow a person's memories toward a final wish, discovering how small details change the meaning of an emotionally focused story over time.

What you do. Explore scenes from a life, examine important objects and follow conversations that gradually connect the memories.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Bereavement and emotional revelations matter; non-combat storytelling still leaves movement and particular interaction sequences to check.

Why it might click. To the Moon follows two doctors working backward through a dying man's memories to understand and fulfill his final wish. Its compact story links small details across a life. Music and changing context supply much of the emotional effect.

The full catch. The developer describes a non-combat experience, but movement, searching for objects, and puzzle interfaces remain. Bereavement and questions about memory and relationships carry significant emotional weight. Verify text advance and the particular PC version rather than assuming all ports behave alike.

Try this first. Play through an early memory investigation, noticing whether gathering its clues supports your curiosity. There is no need to solve the eventual meaning in advance. Check whether the dialogue rhythm and movement let the story land comfortably.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Moon Has Declined to Explain My Marriage

I said that if somebody walked through my memories, they would find romance, courage and exceptional tailoring. Shawna said they would also find the afternoon I locked both keys in the car. To the Moon asked us to follow a life toward a wish. Tank wanted to know why the wish mattered. I wanted to claim I already understood.

'Nigga, you barely understand why Rosa moved the chairs,' Mercedes said.

Rosa looked up. 'People wanted to sit together.' The explanation was so simple I briefly resented it. On the screen, an ordinary detail changed the shape of what came before. Shawna leaned forward. I let her finish reading before talking.

'Would you change anything?' I whispered. 'About you?' 'About us.'

She looked at the room, then at my hand around hers. 'I'd keep the spare key.' I laughed quietly. The moon could keep its grand answer. Nigga, my wife had found a small one with evidence.

Aiden's verdict. Choose this memory story when the reason behind a wish sounds compelling. My marriage retains its mysteries, but the spare car key has solved one.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC original release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/206440/>

P180 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Finding Paradise

Edition considered: PC release

Discover a life through memories and conflicting wishes, with a standalone story that gives its character's contradictions room to matter and develop.

What you do. Explore remembered scenes, examine significant objects and follow conversations that reveal the circumstances behind a difficult wish.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Reading, walking and details that matter later require attention, while end-of-life material remains central to the story.

Why it might click. Finding Paradise is a standalone follow-up in the memory-traversing series. The doctors investigate Colin's life and a wish whose apparent contradictions invite a closer look. It offers another character-centered story about how a life can mean more than its neatest explanation.

The full catch. Expect reading, walking, and attention to details that gain significance later. End-of-life material remains central. The publisher says previous games are not required, but that does not establish identical controls or a complete absence of unusual sequences.

Try this first. Follow the first substantial memory scene and identify one question you want answered. Check ordinary movement and dialogue handling. Let the uncertainty be part of the pleasure rather than trying to create a complete timeline immediately.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Perfect Life Has Two Mutually Exclusive Endings

I told Shawna my perfect life involved excitement, peace, endless travel and never having to pack. Tank looked at me. 'Nigga, you want a hotel to follow you.'

Finding Paradise put a complicated wish in front of us. Mercedes wanted to know how the pieces fitted. I announced that people simply needed to decide what they wanted.

My wife raised one eyebrow. It was the expensive eyebrow. The one that knew where all my contradictory promises were buried.

'You wanted a quiet night,' she said. 'And a band.' 'A small band.' 'Nigga, there's a trumpet in our bathroom.'

I went and let the musician out. He had only been looking for somewhere to practise, which somehow made my life less defensible.

The game kept its person's contradictions. They made him more interesting than my tidy explanation would have.

I sat beside Shawna and stopped trying to repair the premise. Peace arrived for almost a whole conversation. The trumpet respected the closed door.

Aiden's verdict. Visit when a life that refuses a tidy explanation sounds worth hearing. My travelling hotel remains unbuilt, and the bathroom has been returned to civilian use.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; input workload and preference routing are editorial judgments. No full-playthrough, no-hold, or universal no-timer certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/337340/>

P181 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Impostor Factory

Edition considered: PC release

Follow a strange murder-and-memory story in which familiar situations twist into something unexpected, with a standalone narrative and unsettling comic touches throughout.

What you do. Explore scenes, examine objects and follow conversations as the story rearranges what familiar events appear to mean.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Its time-loop premise does not establish actual timer behavior; movement, interaction sequences and disturbing material still need checking.

Why it might click. Impostor Factory begins with a strange party and a time-loop murder mystery, then develops into a broader narrative. Its mixture of absurd comedy and emotional storytelling makes it a candidate for someone who enjoys being led somewhere they did not initially expect.

The full catch. The publisher permits independent play but notes that series order affects the experience. Expect reading, walking, deaths, and disturbing imagery within the mystery. The time-loop premise does not itself verify the absence of timed tasks or unfamiliar input sequences.

Try this first. Follow the opening invitation and inspect an early area without looking up the eventual explanation. Check movement and dialogue handling. Decide whether the strange humor earns your trust before committing to the story's later changes of direction.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Bathroom Has Seen Me Before

I came out of the bathroom and found Tank holding the same shrimp I had watched him eat a minute earlier. I pointed at it. 'Nigga, explain time.'

He held up the plate. 'They brought more.'

Impostor Factory had made me suspicious of an ordinary room. Shawna asked whether I was ready to continue. I told her we needed to establish that the bathroom was not repeating itself.

'You left your phone in there twice,' she said. 'That's you repeating yourself.'

Mercedes followed the strange story while I inspected the door. Porsche walked past me, retrieved my phone and handed it over without slowing down.

The game turned the familiar wrong in a way my little investigation had not managed. I sat down before the next surprise.

Tank offered me a shrimp. I took it. Same taste, new shrimp. Nigga, science was willing to proceed. Shawna kept the phone, which solved the part of the mystery we actually controlled.

Aiden's verdict. Enter when a familiar room becoming deeply strange sounds entertaining. My bathroom investigation is closed, and the shrimp supply has been cleared of temporal misconduct.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1182620/>

P182 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

A Bird Story

Edition considered: PC release

A short, largely wordless story uses animation and small interactions to follow a boy and a bird through an imaginative, emotional experience.

What you do. Guide the character through brief scenes and follow the changing relationship through gestures, movement and visual events.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Little reading does not remove movement or input checks; this is a compact interactive story rather than a complex mystery.

Why it might click. A Bird Story is a short, wordless interactive animation about a boy and an injured bird. Its small scale and reliance on images make it distinct from the more dialogue-heavy games nearby. The developer explicitly presents it as an experiment, not To the Moon's sequel.

The full catch. Fewer words do not eliminate movement, interaction, or waiting through a deliberately authored sequence. The child-and-bird story still has emotional stakes. Check the ordinary controls and whether the amount of interaction matches what you want from a game tonight.

Try this first. Follow the first simple routine and observe how images communicate the relationship. Let the initial section show you its rhythm. If you want many decisions or extensive dialogue, use that preference to choose another page rather than forcing this one.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Bird Was Not Booked to Sing Backup

A little bird landed on the penthouse balcony. I approached with the kind of smile I usually reserved for photographers. Tank watched from the sofa. 'Nigga, don't offer it a contract.'

A Bird Story was already playing inside. Very little dialogue. I considered adding some context. Mercedes reached for the volume and found, to her delight, no setting that increased me.

The actual bird hopped sideways. I explained that I respected its creative process. Shawna put a hand on my shoulder and pulled me back from the glass.

'It wants the balcony, baby. Not a meeting.'

We watched the screen's small story unfold. Rosa rested her feet on Tank's lap. He adjusted without making a speech about the labour.

The real bird stayed another moment, then flew off. I opened my mouth.

'Don't,' Porsche said. 'It wasn't a metaphor about your freedom.'

Nigga, some nights a man cannot even lose a bird without being edited.

Aiden's verdict. Try the small wordless story when gesture and atmosphere sound sufficient. The balcony bird has declined representation and will not be appearing on my next album.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/327410/>

P183 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

OPUS: Rocket of Whispers

Edition considered: PC release

Gather and build toward a meaningful farewell in a world shaped by loss, with exploration and crafting supporting the emotional story.

What you do. Travel through locations, gather materials, craft what is needed and follow the characters working toward their shared purpose.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Gathering and travel add practical work, while plague, bereavement and grief make the story emotionally demanding despite its gentle appearance.

Why it might click. Rocket of Whispers connects exploring a ruined snowy world with building a rocket to honor the dead. Objects found along the way reveal history as well as supplying materials. The gathering has an emotional purpose shared by the surviving characters.

The full catch. Expect travel, searching, equipment crafting, and keeping track of needed supplies. Plague aftermath, loss, and saying goodbye are central. The store's single-player description is explicit; two protagonists do not imply two-player control. Check navigation and repeated collection demands.

Try this first. Explore an early area and bring back one useful material or discovered story. Notice whether the search feels purposeful or repetitive. A strong emotional premise need not compensate for a gathering loop you do not enjoy.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Rocket Is Not for My Grand Entrance

I said the rocket ought to have my name on it. Mercedes looked at the screen, then at me. 'Nigga, hear what it's for first.'

OPUS: Rocket of Whispers gave us a reason to build that was larger and sadder than arrival. Rosa sat forward. Tank stopped playing with the hotel matchbook.

I had been imagining fireworks over the casino. The story was imagining how to say goodbye. My splendid launch announcement suddenly had no useful place to go.

Shawna took the little model rocket out of my hand. 'You can help without getting on it.'

We followed the work. Gathering, making, keeping a purpose alive while the world carried loss around it. Mercedes asked to read the next part herself.

I nodded and moved the model away from the drinks. That was all. No joke to rescue my entrance.

Later, Tank asked whether I still wanted the name painted on the rocket. 'No,' I said. He put down the pen. Nigga understood.

Aiden's verdict. Visit when work, grief and a purpose worth carrying sound welcome. My name has been removed from the rocket so its actual reason can remain visible.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/742250/>

P184 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

OPUS: Echo of Starsong - Full Bloom Edition

Edition considered: PC Full Bloom Edition

Travel through an emotional science-fiction story where mysterious songs, remembered relationships and exploration give the journey its distinctive sense of longing and discovery.

What you do. Read conversations, explore locations, manage journey resources and work through light puzzles connected to the characters' search.

Mixed controls | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. The voiced edition uses Japanese or Chinese audio with English text; resource choices and reading still need attention.

Why it might click. Full Bloom presents a voiced, visual-novel-style space adventure following Jun and Eda in search of mysterious starsongs. Their journey connects personal motives with conflict, ancient places, and other travelers. Music and the relationship between the leads are central attractions.

The full catch. The official page describes light puzzles and resource management alongside narrative scenes. English subtitles/interface are listed, while the checked full-audio languages are Japanese and Chinese. Check reading, exploration, and sound-puzzle presentation; the word accessible in marketing is not a complete control audit.

Try this first. Follow an early exchange, then inspect one exploration or travel decision. Confirm language settings and whether the sound-related information is presented in a usable way. Continue if the relationship interests you as much as the scenery.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P184 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

OPUS: Echo of Starsong - Full Bloom Edition

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Love Song Has Failed the Airlock

I sang three notes at the hotel balcony and announced that the stars had heard me. Tank shut the door. 'Nigga, the neighbours heard you. Different audience.'

Echo of Starsong had a much better use for a voice in the dark. Mercedes listened closely. Porsche leaned against her chair, finally still.

I tried to translate the feeling into a grand romantic speech for Shawna. She touched my mouth with two fingers.

'You could just sit with me.' 'Baby, I'm offering the cosmos.' 'The cosmos has chairs.'

We sat. The game moved through a world where a sound could carry more than my explanation of it. I watched Mercedes replay a little moment because she wanted to hear how it landed.

The hotel pianist began another song outside. Tank closed the inner door this time, gently.

I kept my promise and said nothing. Shawna rested against me. Nigga, somehow I had offered less and ended up closer to what I wanted.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the journey when voice, memory and a strange universe draw you in. My balcony performance remains grounded until the neighbours withdraw their complaint.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually opened Steam app1504500 and verified exact Full Bloom Edition title, voice-language table, narrative/exploration/light puzzle/resource description. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1504500/>

P185 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

I Was a Teenage Exocolonist

Edition considered: PC release

Shape a life in a science-fiction colony, where relationships, remembered experiences and card-based decisions develop across years with consequences for the surrounding community.

What you do. Choose activities, build relationships, use experience cards and make decisions as the character grows within the colony.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Cards, skills, schedules and branching relationships require heavy tracking; the attractive setting also includes danger, death and difficult personal material.

Why it might click. This narrative roleplaying game follows ten formative years in an alien colony. Experiences become cards used in challenges, while activities and relationships influence the future. Its appeal is watching personal growth and a larger community's fate affect one another.

The full catch. Cards, skills, schedules, and branching relationships create substantial system and memory demands. The attractive watercolor setting includes danger, death, and difficult personal material. Inspect challenge rules and content information rather than treating a youthful cast as proof of lightness.

Try this first. Choose an early activity and learn one card challenge deliberately. Pay attention to a character whose company you enjoy. Decide whether the cards make your history feel meaningful or add a management layer you would prefer to avoid.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Childhood Has Refused the Rematch

I told Tank that if I could grow up again, I would make every correct decision. He looked at the jacket I had chosen that morning. 'Nigga, you still got time tonight.'

I Was a Teenage Exocolonist let years gather into experiences and choices. I wanted to optimise the whole life before meeting anybody in it.

Mercedes asked which friend I cared about. I pointed at the numbers. She waited. The numbers did not introduce themselves.

Shawna sat across from me and picked up one of the hotel playing cards. 'What did you learn the year we met?' 'That destiny recognised me.' 'Try again.'

Rosa laughed. Tank hid his face behind his drink, badly.

I looked at my wife. 'That somebody could hear all my bullshit and still ask what I meant.'

She smiled and set the card down. The game's next choice waited. Nigga, I was suddenly less interested in making a perfect life than in noticing who was there.

Aiden's verdict. Explore a changing life if cards, relationships and consequential choices sound absorbing. My childhood rematch has been postponed until I improve tonight's jacket selection.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1148760/>

P186 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Growing Up

Edition considered: PC release

Guide a life through interests, skills and school choices, with a nostalgic setting and everyday decisions gradually opening different possible futures for the character.

What you do. Choose activities, develop abilities, manage opportunities and take part in school-related tasks and minigames as time passes.

Mouse / pointer | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Numerous skills, planning decisions, exams and minigames can turn the life story into a substantial menu and tracking task.

Why it might click. Growing Up combines a coming-of-age story with choosing activities and developing skills. Friendships and family continuity give the schedules a narrative context, while its nineties setting offers a particular flavor of ordinary life and remembered ambitions.

The full catch. The primary description explicitly includes aptitude mini-games, exams, daily scheduling, many skills, and varied outcomes. This is a management-rich life game, not only dialogue. Check the mini-game inputs and whether balancing the systems feels enjoyable rather than like another planner.

Try this first. Set one early schedule, try its associated activity, and see how a friendship develops around it. Use the result to judge the management loop. There is no need to optimize a whole childhood before deciding whether you like playing one day.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Hotel Has Lost My Perfect Childhood Schedule

I made a schedule for becoming an impressive adult. Mercedes read it. 'Nigga, you're already an adult.' 'Exactly. We have proof the method works.'

Growing Up put school, interests and changing opportunities in front of us. I looked at the available activities and began naming the ones I would have conquered.

Tank asked whether learning to pack had been available. Shawna asked whether listening counted as an elective. Rosa wanted to know why lunch was missing.

I told them greatness required sacrifice. Rosa put a plate in my hand. 'Start by sacrificing this conversation.'

The game kept a life moving through ordinary choices. I watched an interest develop and wondered what would happen if I followed it without turning it into a trophy.

Porsche found my schedule beneath a cushion. She had used the back to write a song title. It was the only part anybody wanted to keep.

Nigga, adulthood had produced mixed but extremely legible results.

Aiden's verdict. Try shaping a life when small interests becoming future possibilities sounds appealing. My perfect schedule is available on the reverse of a much better song.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1191120/>

P187 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Volcano Princess

Edition considered: PC release

Guide a young character's development through activities and relationships in a fantasy setting, seeing how many choices shape the life ahead of her.

What you do. Choose activities, develop skills, manage relationships and consider how different opportunities fit the character's growing interests and future.

Mouse / pointer | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Menus, statistics and many activities require planning; parental death and conflict accompany the development story, so inspect each activity's controls.

Why it might click. Volcano Princess mixes a fantasy coming-of-age story with arranging a daughter's activities, studies, and relationships. Different interests can lead toward different lives. The attraction is seeing a character develop through the choices and people around her.

The full catch. Menus, stats, planning, and multiple activity types are a substantial part of play. The story begins after a parent's death and includes conflict and combat-related training. Inspect each activity's controls and avoid treating the parenting premise as a simple conversation game.

Try this first. Choose one early activity and see how its result connects to a conversation or new opportunity. Check the calendar and character information together. Continue if guiding development is enjoyable without needing a supposedly perfect outcome.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Princess Has Chosen a Career I Didn't Announce

I told Shawna I would be an excellent royal parent. She looked around the suite I had filled with unnecessary lights. 'Nigga, you can barely raise the curtains.'

Volcano Princess asked what kind of life could emerge from activities, relationships and guidance. I immediately selected an imaginary crown big enough to explain my involvement.

Mercedes took it off me and put it on the lamp. The lamp looked calmer with authority than I did.

'What if she wants something else?' Rosa asked. 'Who?' 'The person whose life you're planning.'

Tank leaned forward. Nigga enjoyed a question with a visible target.

I watched the options without announcing the future. A choice could be interesting because it belonged to somebody, not because it made a fine speech for the parent.

Shawna turned off two of my extra lights. The room improved. 'See?' she said. 'You can support a future without being the brightest thing in it.' The lamp kept the crown.

Aiden's verdict. Visit the life-shaping fantasy if its many choices sound enjoyable. The crown stays on the lamp until I learn whose future the evening is discussing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1669980/>

P188 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Long Live The Queen

Edition considered: PC release

Plan a young ruler's education while dangerous events test what she has learned, making preparation and consequences the central attraction of the story.

What you do. Select lessons and activities, develop abilities and make story decisions whose outcomes depend on the skills already learned.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. This is a difficult planning detour with dangerous outcomes and death; substantial skill tracking matters more than the gentle-looking artwork.

Why it might click. Long Live The Queen makes preparation and choices the center of a perilous royal coming-of-age story. Learning which skills and decisions help the young heir survive can become a puzzle across attempts. It is an option for someone who actively enjoys that kind of consequence.

The full catch. The official premise emphasizes threats and survival. Skill planning, hidden consequences, and character death make this a deliberate detour rather than a low-pressure suggestion. Cute presentation does not soften the underlying challenge into a guaranteed easy evening.

Try this first. Inspect the training choices and follow an early consequence. Ask whether discovering how the system works is enjoyable even when an outcome goes badly. If avoiding punishing decisions is a hard preference, choose another story immediately.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Crown Fits but the Coronation Cake Is Suspicious

I borrowed the hotel magician's crown and said ruling looked comfortable. Tank examined the velvet cushion. 'Nigga, that's where they hide the rabbit.'

Long Live the Queen offered a harsher education. Choosing what to learn could become a question of surviving what came next. My promise to improvise began losing value immediately.

Mercedes asked which lesson I would take. I chose public speaking. Shawna laughed once. 'Of course this nigga wants a better last sentence.'

Rosa brought out the cake. I stared at it because the game had made royal hospitality feel complicated.

'It's chocolate,' she said. 'Can you establish that?' 'Eat it or don't. I'm not testifying.'

Tank took a slice while I hesitated. Nothing happened except pleasure.

I put the crown back on its cushion and read the game's choices more carefully. The magician came to collect it. 'How was being king?' 'Nigga, I need a tutor and a less imaginative caterer.'

Aiden's verdict. Take the difficult royal planning only if failure and preparation are part of the appeal. Rosa's chocolate cake has been cleared without a succession crisis.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/251990/>

P189 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Roadwarden

Edition considered: PC release

Follow a text-led journey through a difficult region, choosing routes and responses while supplies, time and encounters give the travel meaningful consequences.

What you do. Read locations and conversations, choose actions, manage supplies and decide which paths or duties to pursue on the journey.

Dialogue / text choices | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Heavy reading, survival resources, health and limited in-game time add pressure; exact input timing remains unverified.

Why it might click. Roadwarden offers a richly written fantasy journey through settlements, roads, and uncertain loyalties. Its text-based roleplaying combines conversation, inventory problems, survival, and discoveries about a particular place. The pleasure is becoming familiar with a world through attentive decisions.

The full catch. The source explicitly mentions hit points, survival mechanics, and quests restricted by in-game time. Reading at your own pace does not remove that strategic pressure. Expect substantial text and several tracked resources; inspect any typed-response or menu operations.

Try this first. Reach an early conversation or travel choice and identify what it costs in the game's systems. Make one decision because you are curious about its result. Judge whether the prose and the management work well together for you.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Badge Does Not Open the Hotel's Back Door

I put on a badge and announced that no road was closed to me. Tank pointed at the service door. I pulled. It stayed shut.

Roadwarden gave a traveller duties, danger and limited resources. I gave the hotel staff a growing reason to ask why a man in evening clothes kept trying their door.

Shawna read the next passage. 'You could ask where it leads.' 'Baby, authority shouldn't have to ask.'

Rosa walked over, asked a waiter and learned it led to the bins. My authority had been passionately demanding rubbish access.

Mercedes wanted to follow one path in the game. Porsche wanted to know what it would cost us. We looked at the options instead of assuming the badge supplied an answer.

Tank clipped my badge onto the bread basket. 'This is protecting something worth having.'

I sat down and read. Nigga, the road got more interesting when I stopped pretending the title on my chest already knew where to go.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the text journey when routes, duties and difficult trade-offs sound rewarding. My badge now guards the bread, a post with excellent public support.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1155970/>

P190 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Life and Suffering of Sir Brante

Edition considered: PC release

Follow a life shaped by a rigid social order, with consequential choices about identity, loyalty and ambition giving the narrative its serious weight.

What you do. Read the character's developing life, choose responses and commitments, and follow how decisions alter relationships and possible futures.

Dialogue / text choices | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Dense reading and long-term planning accompany oppression, death and costly consequences; this is a deliberately heavy narrative option.

Why it might click. This narrative roleplaying game follows a life within a harsh fantasy empire. Decisions, learned traits, family ties, and social position shape possible paths. It offers the pleasure of tracing how personal ambitions interact with an unjust and powerful order.

The full catch. The publisher calls it a hardcore narrative RPG and emphasizes costly consequences, oppression, death, and rebirth. Dense reading and long-term planning are central burdens. Treat it as a deliberate heavy-story option, not a gentle alternative simply because much of the action is written.

Try this first. Read an early chapter and inspect how one decision changes a relationship or trait. Decide whether you want to inhabit this society's pressures. You can value the writing without accepting the emotional weight of a full life inside it.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Noble Birth Has Been Questioned by Room Service

I told the waiter I came from greatness. He asked which room. I said the question was larger than that. Nigga waited with the tray until I supplied a number.

The Life and Suffering of Sir Brante placed a life inside a hard social order. I began imagining how effortlessly I would rise above it.

Shawna looked at the waiter still holding my breakfast. 'Start by letting him put that down.'

I moved. Mercedes read the next choice and stopped smiling. The story had consequences no amount of my cheerful self-description could erase.

Tank asked what I would give up. I said the system ought to change. 'Sure, my nigga. What do you choose right now?'

Rosa pulled a chair closer. We read the available answers together, each one leaving something uncomfortable behind.

The waiter brought the bill. I signed without adding my title. It seemed the least I could do while a fictional life was asking a much harder question than which room had ordered eggs.

Aiden's verdict. Enter the harsh social story if compromised choices sound worth wrestling with. Room service has accepted my room number and declined the supplementary history of greatness.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected Steam primary description/category declarations for PC release. Premise and explicit features are supported; practical workload and routing are editorial judgments. No full-path input verification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1272160/>

P191 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Suzerain

Edition considered: PC base game; Kingdom of Rizia expansion separate

Lead a fictional country through political choices, competing interests and personal relationships, with reports and conversations revealing the consequences of your decisions over time.

What you do. Read briefings, speak with political figures, choose policies and manage relationships that affect the country and the president's family.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Dense reading, many factions and difficult consequences create heavy tracking; the base-game card excludes the separate Rizia expansion.

Why it might click. As President Anton Rayne, you navigate Sordland's political institutions, economy, international relationships and family life. The attraction is sustained argument: people want incompatible things, and a policy decision can become a personal problem later.

The full catch. This is a dense reading and decision game with a codex, reports and many relationships to remember. Political violence and harsh outcomes add pressure. The inspected description does not establish every input's timing or hold requirements. This card covers the base game, excluding the Rizia expansion.

Try this first. Read the opening political setup and one conversation. Judge whether identifying factions feels intriguing or like an unwanted meeting. A companion can discuss priorities without supplying the supposedly correct ideology.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The President Has Lost Control of the Minibar

I announced my candidacy for president of the penthouse. Tank asked whether my platform included opening the minibar. I promised prosperity.

Suzerain handed us a country with institutions, rivals and citizens who could not eat a speech. Rosa put the hotel bill beside the screen. 'Practice on this first.'

I offered to cut unnecessary spending. Shawna pointed at the ice sculpture of me. I said we should protect national heritage.

Mercedes wanted to know what the political ally was really asking for. Porsche wanted to read the report before choosing. I wanted everyone to appreciate how presidential my jacket looked.

'Nigga, you dressed for a coup at a wedding,' Tank said.

The game made the next decision uncomfortable. I stopped smiling for an audience and read it twice.

Behind me, the sculpture's chin melted into the bucket. Shawna collected the water before it reached the carpet. My first administration survived because somebody else knew what mattered.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the political story when conflicting interests and long consequences sound absorbing. My administration has surrendered the minibar and is negotiating the peaceful removal of its chin.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1207650/>

P192 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Yes, Your Grace

Edition considered: PC first game

Hear a kingdom's petitioners while balancing scarce resources, family needs and dangerous alliances, giving each political choice an immediate human face and cost.

What you do. Listen to requests, allocate resources, speak with family members and consider alliances and preparations as the kingdom's problems develop.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Requests conflict and resources run out; strategic preparation and harsh family outcomes prevent the throne screen from guaranteeing carefree play.

Why it might click. King Eryk hears petitioners, manages scarce resources and tries to protect his family and kingdom. Small requests sit beside larger alliances and threats, giving decisions an immediate human face rather than reducing everything to an abstract national graph.

The full catch. Resources run out, requests conflict and family decisions can hurt. The presentation includes strategic preparation and dangerous events; a throne screen is not a promise of carefree play. Verify the controls and pause behavior in the chosen PC version before assuming all situations wait.

Try this first. Hear the first petition and look at the resources attached to an answer. Ask whether saying no feels satisfyingly consequential or simply unpleasant. Stop without treating a difficult decision as something you must finish tonight.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The King Has Granted Six Requests with Four Coins

I sat in the largest chair and invited petitions. Tank asked for a drink. Rosa asked for the kitchen to stop reheating the same potatoes. Shawna asked for her husband back.

'Nigga, one request at a time.' 'Mine's been pending all evening,' my wife said.

Yes, Your Grace made a throne look less like a reward and more like somewhere other people's needs came to sit on you. Mercedes read a request aloud.

I promised we could help everybody. Porsche turned the screen toward the resources. They had the nerve to remain finite.

The waiter arrived with the new potatoes. Rosa thanked him by name. He smiled and left. A complete act of government had happened without my chair.

Tank lifted his glass. 'You want to grant something useful?'

I stood and gave Shawna the seat beside me. She pulled me into it. The king lost a little elevation and gained a much better evening. Nigga, I endorsed the reform.

Aiden's verdict. Take the throne if hearing people and making imperfect choices sounds compelling. My wife's petition has finally been granted, leaving the king with fewer speeches and better company.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1115690/>

P193 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Orwell: Keeping an Eye On You

Edition considered: PC first game

Investigate digital records for a surveillance programme, deciding which details to submit and discovering how your selections can change somebody else's life and apparent guilt.

What you do. Read messages, profiles and files, connect information, and choose which pieces of evidence to pass onward through the interface.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Dense records, names and relationships require tracking; evidence-transfer controls and any timing demands need a direct check.

Why it might click. You investigate digital records for a state surveillance program and decide what information to submit. The pleasure lies in connecting messages, profiles and apparent contradictions, then noticing how your selection shapes somebody else's fate.

The full catch. Expect substantial reading, interface switching and memory for names and relationships. Surveillance, terrorism and personal intrusion are central themes. Selecting or transferring evidence needs a direct input check; the premise alone cannot certify mouse-only ease, no dragging or an absence of timed sections.

Try this first. Examine one person's available records and identify two details that might mean different things together. Before forwarding evidence, decide whether the ethical discomfort interests you. A companion can compare interpretations while one person operates the interface.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P193 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Orwell: Keeping an Eye On You

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Search History Has Asked My Wife to Leave the Room

I projected my browser history onto the penthouse wall to demonstrate transparency. The first search was can velvet survive a hot tub. Shawna folded her arms.

Tank read the next one. 'Nigga, who asks for romantic trousers with emergency pockets?' 'A prepared husband.'

Orwell had made us consider what a digital detail could imply when somebody selected it. I explained that my history needed context. Mercedes said this was the first intelligent thing I had said since turning on the projector.

Porsche wanted to follow the fictional investigation. Rosa wanted the actual wall returned to its previous innocence.

I switched off my history. A normal-sized screen was suddenly enough to discuss what someone had said, what the record showed and what we were only guessing.

Shawna leaned close. 'Did you buy the trousers?' 'Baby, that's privileged.'

She smiled. 'Then stop presenting the privilege to the whole fucking hotel.' I put the projector remote somewhere my reputation could not reach it.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the surveillance mystery if selected evidence and its consequences interest you. My trousers remain outside the investigation unless their emergency pockets produce something relevant.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/491950/>

P194 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Orwell: Ignorance is Strength

Edition considered: PC sequel

Investigate political information and manipulation in a darker surveillance story, where deciding what to investigate and when affects the narrative that emerges from the records.

What you do. Read digital records, compare accounts, choose investigative leads and consider how selected information shapes a political story.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. The time-of-day system adds scheduling pressure; dense records remain, and actual real-time or pause behavior is not fully verified.

Why it might click. This second Orwell story places you in a darker investigation shaped by political narratives and information manipulation. It can reward a reader who enjoys noticing how an apparently factual detail becomes a persuasive weapon.

The full catch. The official description introduces a time-of-day system and decisions about whom to investigate and when. That establishes scheduling pressure inside the story, not a verified real-time countdown or a no-timer guarantee. Expect dense records, unsettling politics and morally compromised work.

Try this first. Read the first assignment and inspect how the interface represents time before making several moves. Decide whether tracking opportunities sounds engaging. Discuss one competing interpretation with a companion without assuming the game offers a neutral choice.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Hotel Announces I Returned a Towel

I told the casino host to announce that I had personally restored resources to the community. He asked what I meant. Tank held up the towel I had brought back from the pool.

'Nigga, it's technically true.' Shawna smiled without kindness. 'So is you finally doing the minimum.'

Orwell: Ignorance is Strength made selection and presentation part of the problem. Mercedes read a statement on the screen and wanted to know what had been left out.

I asked the host to mention the quality of the towel. Porsche asked him to mention how long I had kept it. The man quietly stopped taking requests.

At the bar, somebody was trying to relaunch the departed cocaine guest's investment story. Rosa asked whether the actual facts had improved while he was gone.

Nobody answered.

I gave the host the microphone back. The towel went to laundry. Nigga, it had accomplished more by being folded than by appearing in my speech.

Aiden's verdict. Visit when the way information becomes persuasion sounds worth examining. The towel has returned to useful service and will not be giving interviews about my generosity.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/633060/>

P195 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Emily is Away

Edition considered: PC first game

Follow a relationship through a nostalgic instant-messenger interface, where brief exchanges and changing profiles convey uncertainty, growing apart and things left unsaid across several years.

What you do. Read messages and profiles, choose responses, and use the messenger's keyboard interactions as conversations move through different stages.

Dialogue / text choices | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Test the actual typing demand and text size; relationship regret can weigh more heavily than the small interface suggests.

Why it might click. A simulated desktop and instant messenger frame a relationship across several years. Buddy profiles, changing circumstances and brief exchanges turn a familiar piece of technology into a story about growing apart, uncertainty and what people leave unsaid.

The full catch. Reading is central, and the messenger presentation includes keyboard interaction that should be tried directly. Do not assume every message is simply a pointer click or that arbitrary typing works identically across versions. Relationship regret may carry more weight than the small interface suggests.

Try this first. Choose a screen name and follow the first conversation far enough to feel its rhythm. Check the actual typing demand and text size. The useful question is whether the intimacy of messaging appeals, rather than whether you chose the best reply.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Away Message Says I'm with Destiny

I changed my status to WITH DESTINY. Shawna looked over my shoulder. 'Nigga, you're with the room-service menu.' 'Destiny comes hungry.'

Emily is Away put a familiar little chat window in front of us. Short replies, old names, years moving beneath ordinary words. Mercedes read an exchange and went quiet.

I started composing an answer that would explain every feeling anybody had ever misunderstood about me. Tank watched the sentence grow.

'My nigga, you messaging her or submitting a bid?'

Shawna took my actual phone and changed the status to LOOKING FOR A FORK. It was insulting and immediately more useful.

On the game screen, one small response carried more than my paragraph. Porsche asked us to wait before advancing it. We did.

The waiter brought the fork. I thanked him, put the phone face down and let the fictional conversation remain somebody else's. Destiny had arrived carrying cutlery and did not ask for a speech.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the messenger story when a brief reply can bring back an entire era. My actual status remains available to correction by people standing beside me.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/417860/>

P196 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

We Know the Devil

Edition considered: PC release

Three teenagers at a religious camp face an unsettling story about closeness, exclusion and belonging, with relationships carrying the tension of the visual novel.

What you do. Read the characters' exchanges and make choices about their time together, following how closeness shifts among the three.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Psychological horror, religious pressure and isolation are central; quiet-looking controls do not make the subject gentle or certify all inputs.

Why it might click. This visual novel uses a small cast and a threatening camp setting to explore belonging, exclusion and queer identity. Which characters spend time together matters, creating room for conversation about relationships rather than inventory puzzles or navigation.

The full catch. Psychological horror, religious pressure, isolation and an alarming soundscape are integral to the experience. Light movement demands would not make the subject gentle. The inspected page supports its visual-novel form but does not independently verify every advance input or the absence of all timing demands.

Try this first. Read the opening exchange and listen to a short portion of the atmosphere at a comfortable volume. Decide whether this kind of unease is welcome before pursuing a route. Nobody owes the camp a complete visit.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Retreat Has Been Cancelled by the People Invited

I called our late-night gathering a retreat. Mercedes asked what we were retreating from. Tank pointed at the microphone in my hand.

We Know the Devil put three people together with an ugly question about belonging. I had planned an icebreaker requiring everybody to name something they admired about me. Shawna unplugged the speaker.

'Nigga, that's not intimacy. That's customer feedback.'

Rosa pulled another chair into the circle. Porsche sat beside Mercedes. Nobody had to justify where they wanted to be.

The game's unease reached the room. A choice could bring two people closer while leaving somebody outside. I looked at my own little arrangement of seats and quit trying to improve it.

Tank handed me a drink without a joke. I put the microphone down.

For a while we listened. When Mercedes wanted to stop, Porsche closed the game and stayed where she was. Nigga, together could be an ordinary fact if I stopped announcing it like a prize.

Aiden's verdict. Enter the unsettling relationship story only when its horror is welcome. My retreat has been reduced to chairs and company, with no compulsory admiration exercise.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected primary product description supports the stated premise and features. Control-family, memory burden and recommendation are editorial assessments, not a complete accessibility audit. Timing or hold uncertainty is retained in the card. Exact PC edition only; source checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/435300/>

P197 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

A Normal Lost Phone

Edition considered: PC release

Piece together a fictional person's life through messages, photographs and apps, discovering relationships and circumstances behind a disappearance by reading the details closely.

What you do. Navigate the fictional phone, read message threads, inspect pictures and connect information found across its different apps.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. The recorded Steam page says unavailable; establish an existing playable copy, then check small text and navigation across apps.

Why it might click. Messages, pictures and apps form a narrative investigation into Sam's life and disappearance. The appeal is close reading: an ordinary digital object gradually reveals relationships and circumstances that were invisible at first glance.

The full catch. The inspected Steam page says this game is no longer available on that store as of September 20, 2026. Existing access must be established before planning a session. Expect personal, potentially sensitive material, small interface details and searching across apps; the page does not certify input comfort.

Try this first. If you already have a legitimate playable copy, inspect one message thread and test the fictional phone's navigation. Ask whether piecing together a person's circumstances feels compelling, and stop before curiosity becomes an obligation to finish.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Missing Phone Contains Fourteen Unflattering Versions of Me

Porsche held up a phone she had found under my chair. I announced that its contents would reveal a life of exceptional taste. She opened the photographs.

Tank leaned over. 'Nigga, why you got nine pictures of your elbow?' 'Lighting study.'

A Normal Lost Phone invited us to understand a fictional life through a device. My own device invited the room to understand that I could not find the front camera.

Shawna took it before Porsche reached the beach photographs. My wife looked at one, then at me. 'Baby, you asked me not to send this.' 'I believe in preserving art privately.'

She locked the screen. The joke belonged to us; the rest of the room could live without the image.

Mercedes returned to the game listing and noticed the availability catch. We checked that before planning anything.

Tank handed me the phone face down. 'Your elbow available everywhere, though.' Nigga, the distribution was beyond my control.

Aiden's verdict. Consider the fictional phone only after establishing a playable copy. My elbow archive remains technically available, but Shawna has suspended its international exhibition programme.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually verified Steam app 523210 identifies A Normal Lost Phone and explicitly states it is no longer available on Steam, observed September 20, 2026. Premise comes from the product description. Existing access, controls and availability elsewhere are not established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/523210/>

P198 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Another Lost Phone: Laura's Story

Edition considered: PC release

Reconstruct Laura's life through her fictional phone, connecting personal and professional details to understand the circumstances behind her disappearance rather than exploring a physical landscape.

What you do. Read messages, examine photographs and navigate apps, separating what the phone shows from what you infer about its owner.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Close reading and app navigation are central; difficult personal circumstances and unverified control details remain meaningful catches.

Why it might click. A fictional found phone holds Laura's photographs, messages and apps. Following connections between professional life, relationships and social habits creates a story through investigation rather than through moving an avatar around a large landscape.

The full catch. Expect close reading, app navigation, inference and difficult personal circumstances. The official game site verifies the premise, while a retailer verifies this PC edition; neither settles every control demand or current availability elsewhere. Automated Steam matches were wrong, so those unrelated products are excluded from this card.

Try this first. Start by examining the fictional phone layout and a short exchange. Compare an observation with an interpretation, keeping them separate. Decide whether the interface is legible and the personal investigation welcome before following every available thread.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P198 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Another Lost Phone: Laura's Story

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Laura's Calendar Is Not Evidence About My Wife

I suggested reconstructing the party from everybody's calendar. Shawna opened mine. It contained DINNER, TRIUMPH and a private appointment titled ASK NICELY.

Tank looked up. 'Nigga, who's that with?' 'Mind your business.' 'Then close the projector.'

Laura's Story required noticing connections inside a fictional phone. I began drawing conclusions before Mercedes had finished reading. Porsche moved the screen away from my pointing finger.

'You got a fact?' 'I got a feeling.' 'Then let the fact finish getting here.'

Rosa collected a plate and asked what Laura's actual messages showed. We looked. My beautiful theory lost three of its four legs.

Shawna closed my real calendar. 'Your last appointment still open?' I glanced at her. She smiled and put the phone in her bag.

I sat back. The fictional investigation could continue without turning every private detail into entertainment. Later, if my wife wanted, I had one ordinary question to ask and no audience to impress.

Aiden's verdict. Follow the fictional clues when careful attention to an ordinary life sounds compelling. My private calendar has left the screen and will be keeping its own appointments.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Official game site anotherlostphone.com is credited to Accidental Queens and directly describes the narrative investigation, phone apps, friendships, professional life and disappearance. GameHouse separately verifies the PC title. Incorrect automated Steam matches were excluded. Neither source certifies full-path timing or holds; checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://anotherlostphone.com/>

Source 2: <https://www.gamehouse.com/games/another-lost-phone-lauras-story>

P199 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Slay the Princess - The Pristine Cut

Edition considered: PC Pristine Cut

Question a confident narrator through a branching psychological-horror story, where choices and beliefs reshape the princess, the situation and the meaning of what happens.

What you do. Listen to narration, read choices and decide what to believe or do as the story changes around those decisions.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Intense violence, gore and suicide themes are explicit; voice acting does not settle every timed or held-input question.

Why it might click. The Pristine Cut expands a fully voiced psychological-horror visual novel whose branching story turns on what you do, believe and question. Narration, performance and shifting interpretations are major attractions for somebody who enjoys arguing with a story's apparent authority.

The full catch. The developer explicitly warns of intense violence, gore, partial nudity, strong language and suicide themes. This is a substantial content catch, not a gentle princess tale. Full voice acting does not establish no timed or held inputs; check the exact interface before making that assumption.

Try this first. Read the content notice first. If the premise still appeals, hear the initial narration and inspect how dialogue advances. Choose whether to continue for its argument and atmosphere, without accepting the narrator's urgency as your own.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Narrator Sounds Like a Man Selling Me a Suite

The narrator told us what had to be done. I admired his confidence. Shawna asked why. I said a man should respect a clear introduction.

Slay the Princess made that a very poor starting position. Mercedes folded her arms. Porsche leaned closer. Tank looked at me as if the game had personally requested his testimony.

'Nigga, if confidence meant trustworthy, you'd own my house.'

I tried to defend the voice. Shawna picked up the hotel brochure I had signed without reading. It promised a private pool; the pool had twelve strangers and a saxophonist in it.

The next line on the screen made the room quieter. We checked the content notice again. Nobody needed to prove anything by continuing.

Rosa chose another chair, ready to leave the story if she wanted. I moved my leg out of her way.

Tank nodded at the narrator. 'Let him sell the basement to somebody else.' Nigga, even my speaking voice had started looking suspicious.

Aiden's verdict. Enter the horror only if its argument with authority sounds welcome. My hotel brochure has been admitted as evidence against judging a narrator by confidence alone.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually verified exact Steam title Slay the Princess - The Pristine Cut, app 1989270. Publisher description supports branching fully voiced psychological horror and expanded Pristine Cut; developer mature-content notice supplies the explicit content catches. No full-playthrough timing or hold audit.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1989270/>

P200 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Scarlet Hollow

Edition considered: PC episodic release; current completion status must be checked

Enter a branching horror mystery where character traits, family relationships and a troubled town shape what you notice and how people respond to you.

What you do. Choose traits, read conversations, investigate unsettling events and make decisions that affect relationships and the story's branches.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. The recorded release is unfinished; disturbing imagery remains despite the no-jumpscare statement and declared play without timed input.

Why it might click. Character traits and choices shape a branching horror mystery around a family visit and a troubled town. Conversations can reveal different details, making personality and relationships part of the investigation rather than merely decoration around clues.

The full catch. The inspected description lists five available episodes and another major update before the conclusion as of September 20, 2026: this is unfinished. The developer declares no jumpscare and Steam lists play without timed input, but disturbing imagery and tension remain. Neither statement certifies every hold or device.

Try this first. Inspect the opening traits and read the first family exchange. Decide whether you want a tense serial whose ending is still pending. A companion can debate impressions while the person playing keeps authority over the actual choices.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Family Reunion Has Reserved a Chair for the Thing Outside

I set an extra place at the party for the mysterious arrival Scarlet Hollow had made me expect. Tank asked who was coming. I said the town had secrets.

'Nigga, this hotel got secrets. One of them is where they keep hot coffee.'

A family visit, a funeral and a place with something wrong beneath it sounded like a story Mercedes wanted to hear. She chose a trait before I finished explaining which trait I thought suited her.

Shawna turned to me. 'You can have your own opinion without assigning hers.'

The curtain moved. I looked over sharply. Rosa was closing the balcony because the room had become cold.

Porsche checked how much of the story was available. We noted the unfinished ending before settling in. Even my enthusiasm could not invent another episode.

Tank stole the extra chair for Rosa's feet. 'Whatever's outside can knock.' Nigga, the family reunion acquired better hospitality the moment I stopped furnishing it for monsters.

Aiden's verdict. Visit the ominous family story if its serial form appeals, including the unfinished conclusion. Any creature arriving at our party must accept that Rosa has the chair.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description on September 20, 2026 says five episodes available and another major update before the conclusion. Developer states no jumpscare; the Steam category declares playable without timed input. Those are sourced declarations, not a complete no-hold or no-distress certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1609230/>

The Suite Was Booked Until Morning

The hotel manager arrived to ask whether we wanted the room for another night. He had a clean jacket, a tired smile and the courage of a man whose commission depended on my inability to finish anything quietly.

'What makes you think we're leaving?' I asked. He glanced at the breakfast carts waiting in the hall. Nigga had brought evidence.

The party had thinned into the people I wanted there when the music stopped. Mercedes sat barefoot at the piano bench. Porsche had finally put one phone away. Tank was asleep against Rosa's shoulder, denying it whenever she moved.

'I heard that,' he said. 'Nobody spoke,' Rosa told him. 'I'm ahead.'

Shawna stood by the window looking at the city. Her shoes were in my hand. I could have claimed I was making a gallant gesture. She had handed them to me after I stepped on the hem of her dress and asked what else I was doing with all that strength.

The games were still on the table. Nobody had finished the whole shelf. Nobody looked disappointed by this tremendous failure of ambition.

We had found conversations worth another visit. A bartender who let people talk. A family decision somebody wanted to argue about later. A strange place whose people stayed in the room after its screen went dark.

I wanted to give the evening a title. Mercedes wanted to hear the last line of her song without the hotel air conditioner rattling over it. Porsche walked over and turned the fan down.

That was the kind of support a nigga could actually use.

The manager asked again about the extra night. I looked at Shawna. She looked at the bed visible through the open doorway, then back at me.

'You got a speech about it?' she asked. 'I can make a compelling case.' 'Make a short one.'

I held up the shoes. 'I've already got your luggage.'

She laughed. The manager smiled at the carpet. Professional nigga. Knew when a sale was none of his business.

Rosa touched Tank's cheek. 'Come on.' 'Dessert?' 'We ate it.' 'Both?'

She kissed him. He stopped looking for the second plate.

Mercedes called me over before they left. She wanted the recording of the song from the room microphones. Not the crowd, not my introduction, not a highlight reel with my face at the start.

'Just the song,' she said. 'I got you.' 'Say what I asked for.'

I said it. She nodded. A simple exchange. No audience required.

Porsche slipped the recording drive into Mercedes's hand. 'Already done.'

Nigga, I had arrived at my own helpful moment after the help.

I could have made a joke. Instead I watched Mercedes close her fingers around it. The little relief in her shoulders belonged to her. It did not need me stepping in front of it.

At the bar, the host had left a note about the guest with the cocaine. His things were gone, his car had been arranged, and the hotel wanted to know who had called his investment pitch a hostage situation.

Porsche lifted one finger without looking up.

The manager decided he did not need a written statement.

Tank woke properly at the mention of a car. He checked Rosa had her coat, checked Mercedes and Porsche had theirs, then asked whether I knew where my keys were.

I held up Shawna's shoes.

'Nigga,' he said, 'those ain't interchangeable.'

Shawna took the shoes and put her hand in mine. 'He's staying.'

My brother grinned. Rosa pulled him toward the door before he could ask the sort of question married people should leave other married people to answer privately.

The elevator opened. My giant face split again.

'Still ugly in the middle,' Tank called.

'Nigga, get home.'

The doors closed on his laugh.

I switched off the stage lights. Shawna left one lamp on beside the sofa. The game we had chosen waited where we left it, with a conversation still unfinished. That felt right. A good night did not owe me an ending to everything it had started.

My wife kissed me, slow enough to interrupt the next sentence before I spent it.

'Now,' she said, 'you can tell me what happens when you arrive.'

I put the controller safely on the table.

The hotel kept the suite until morning.

Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. The Tellings Cut: original revised Panorama prose and production by ChatGPT; original game research and selection system retained. This is a separate adult comic companion to Ten Toes Down. Source novels and the first Panorama edition remain intact. All people participating in the fictional party scenes are adults; Lillian is addressed as the reader.

Voice sources sampled for this revision: the Niggatorial Tellings Book I funeral and first Vegas party, selected passages from Books II-VI, and the edition editorial record. Source repository Sodelin/Ten-Toes-Down; working base 4cdof7a6e36977ff0ac705a59ebe65407d1f2bee. Selected passages were read closely; no full reread of all six novels is claimed. The added game-night story is newly composed fiction.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

This adult comic edition includes frequent reclaimed in-group language, strong profanity, fictional cocaine and party references, sexual banter and non-graphic innuendo. Those scenes are separate from the factual game descriptions and are not descriptions of the developers or real readers.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS / THE TELLINGS CUT

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 6 OF SIX

Two Controllers and a Suite We Couldn't Leave Quietly

Native cooperative games, shared puzzles and stories for an optional companion

Forty real games. Aiden has made it everybody's problem.

Adult comic edition: reclaimed in-group language, profanity, fictional cocaine references and sexual innuendo.

New ChatGPT prose under Nolan's creative direction.

Tellings Cut 2.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

How to find a game in this book

Each game starts with a short pitch, what you actually do, the controls and pace, the main catch, and a first action to try. These practical sections use plain language. The longer Aiden scene comes after them.

For a fast comparison, read the pitch and main catch on two or three pages. Use the alphabetical index to jump to a title. Choose the full story only when you want the comedy; it is never a prerequisite for understanding the game.

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; Aiden's ministry and rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. The labels mean: A place to start = a promising candidate; Read the catch first = a meaningful obstacle needs checking; A more demanding detour = a narrower or harder option. They describe the game, not the reader. Check the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

Choose a game by its name

This is the quick route. Click any title, or turn to its page. Read the short pitch and main catch first; Aiden's scene follows the practical guide. The case number works across every format.

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P206	Animal Crossing: New Horizons	12	P235	Pilgrims	49
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A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 6. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index near the front always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P201	P202	P203	P204	P205	P206	P207	P208
2. Ready for conversation	P209	P210	P211	P212	P213	P214	P215	P216
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P217	P218	P219	P220	P221	P222	P223	P224
4. Here for the atmosphere	P225	P226	P227	P228	P229	P230	P231	P232
5. Open to a wildcard	P233	P234	P235	P236	P237	P238	P239	P240

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

Player Two Had Already Stolen My Chair

I had the hotel bring the second controller in a glass case. Black velvet underneath. Little spotlight above. Nigga, if friendship was going to arrive, it could arrive properly.

Tank looked through the glass. 'Where's the charger?' 'In the drawer.' 'Then why the fuck is the useful part hiding?'

I told him presentation mattered. He opened the drawer, connected the charger and sat in the chair I had chosen for myself. Friendship had arrived and immediately taken liberties.

The casino had given us a different suite because the first one now contained a piano the lift could not carry. I asked whose idea the piano had been. Shawna showed me the text. It was mine, in capitals, followed by three fire symbols.

'That was enthusiasm,' I said. 'It weighs eight hundred pounds,' my wife replied.

She had changed into a dress that made me forget how lifts worked. I put a hand at her waist. She kissed me before I could make a public statement about the dress. Then she handed me a bag of cables.

'Untangle those, baby.' 'You always know how to keep me interested.' 'I know how to give your hands a job.'

Across the room, Rosa wanted the table pulled away from the wall. She and Tank were playing together, and the hotel had arranged one comfortable seat and one chair that looked like it had been hired for an interrogation.

Tank picked up the bad chair. He did not threaten it. The chair simply appeared to recognise that its remaining career would be elsewhere.

Mercedes wanted the sound low enough to talk over. Porsche wanted a screen she could see without sitting behind somebody's shoulder. These were modest requests. I had spent more arranging the controller's lighting than meeting either one.

Dre came through the door carrying a casserole. Grown man, blue shirt, smile that suggested he had already seen the parking charge and decided to stay cheerful out of spite.

'Which controller's blue?' he asked.

I pointed at the glass case. He set down the casserole and opened it.

'Nigga, that's the display.' 'Now it's the controller.'

Dre was a Crip. He had brought food and wanted a particular colour of plastic. I had brought no food and wanted my arrival televised. Tank said one of us was contributing more to peace.

I offered Dre the gold controller instead. He looked at it. 'You keep that motherfucker. It matches whatever you about to say.'

Rosa took the casserole to the table. The party improved before anyone turned on a game.

Darnell arrived next with sunglasses on and the same yacht story I had heard before we changed suites. He set a little case on the bar and said tonight could become legendary. Porsche looked at the case, looked at his restless speech and asked whether he had brought the cocaine or the boat.

'Both are investments,' he said.

'Then take your portfolio back downstairs. Mercedes wants to hear the game.'

He tried to tell Tank what a man of his size could do on a yacht. Rosa called Tank over to taste the casserole. My brother left Darnell holding his own introduction. Nigga had been defeated by dinner without anybody raising a fist.

The hotel host collected Darnell and his case. There would be another bar somewhere for his endless performance. This room had other plans.

I finally got the cable untangled and held it up like a captured serpent. Shawna plugged it in. The controller lit.

'We did that together,' I said. 'Yes, baby. Eventually.'

The games did not all mean the same thing by together. Some wanted two characters moving through one place. Some put different clues on different screens. Some let a second person help with only part of the work. Others belonged to one player, with room beside them for somebody who liked a story.

Tank gave me a controller. 'What do I do?' he asked.

I nearly said Trust me.

Shawna was watching. Mercedes was watching. Dre had a fork halfway to his mouth, waiting to see whether I would fuck up a question that short.

I looked at the screen and told Tank what his character could do. Then I asked which job he wanted.

'Look at that,' Rosa said. 'He can be trained.'

My wife smiled. 'Depends what you're offering.'

Nigga, I stayed interested.

We put both chairs where the screen was clear. No spotlight on either player. No announcement about which one mattered. Dre passed the casserole, Porsche turned the music down and the room became a place where somebody could try something without my voice getting there first.

I sat beside my brother. He handed me the smaller controller.

'Why I get this one?'

'Matches the amount of advice I'm requesting.'

P201 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Secret of Mana

Edition considered: 1993 SNES original / Collection of Mana on Switch; not 2018 remake

Explore a colourful retro adventure together once companions join, with towns, magic and party equipment giving the shared journey a continuing sense of purpose.

What you do. Move through connected areas, fight enemies in real time and use ring menus to manage the party's items, equipment and magic.

Direction + buttons | Action continues while you think | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Real-time combat and held actions remain; original SNES three-player play needs an adapter, and cooperation begins after allies join.

Why it might click. The original 1993 adventure offers a colourful party journey with native cooperative fighting once companions join. Its overhead view removes free-camera steering, while towns, equipment, magic and connected areas give the journey continuity.

The full catch. Combat runs in real time. Original manual instructions include held dashing and charged attacks, plus Y opening the paused ring menu. Original SNES two-player play needs two controllers; a third needs a multiplayer adapter. Collection of Mana supports up to three. The 2018 remake is excluded.

Try this first. Enjoy the solo opening together or use an existing shared save after an ally joins. Try moving, opening the ring and one familiar encounter. The second player should choose their own role rather than automatically receiving every difficult job.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Sword Does Not Care How Much My Suit Cost

I held the controller like a sword and promised Tank I would protect him. He looked at the screen. 'Nigga, protect yourself. That thing's already biting you.'

Secret of Mana had put us together in a world where my introduction did not stop the fighting. I tried to explain my strategy. Shawna reached across and opened the ring menu.

Silence. A little breathing room. My brother looked over. 'Now tell me all the shit you meant to do.' I shortened the strategy considerably.

Dre wanted the blue controller back when we finished. Rosa wanted Tank beside her after one more area. Everybody had a future that depended on me moving my character instead of narrating it.

We tried again. This time I followed Tank through the opening and actually helped.

'There,' he said. 'Two niggas in the same fight.' I grinned. Shawna kissed my shoulder. 'Much better than one hero and a witness.'

Aiden's verdict. Try the old adventure if both players actually want its fighting and menus. My suit receives no armour bonus, despite the tailoring and deeply persuasive receipt.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo Collection of Mana page confirms original Secret of Mana supports 1-3 players. Original manual text inspected through archival transcription establishes ring pause, held actions and SNES controller/adapter rules. Ally-gated joining follows party availability. No 2018 PC remake metadata is used.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/en-ca/store/products/collection-of-mana-switch/>

Source 2: https://www.world-of-nintendo.com/manuals/super_nes/secret_of_mana.shtml

P202 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Spiritfarer: Farewell Edition

Edition considered: PC Farewell Edition

Build and travel on a ferry while caring for spirits, sharing everyday chores and eventually saying goodbye to people whose stories become familiar.

What you do. Explore islands, gather resources, cook and craft, build the boat, and try Stella's or Daffodil's role in local cooperation.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Chores and resources accumulate, roles differ, and later timed challenges remain alongside jumping, gliding and bereavement.

Why it might click. Build and travel on a ferry, care for spirits, gather materials and eventually say goodbye. The Farewell Edition includes the expanded character stories. Native local cooperation pairs Stella with Daffodil, giving two people a shared place to inhabit.

The full catch. Movement includes jumping and gliding; chores, recipes and resources accumulate. The cat's role differs from Stella's. A previously inspected secondary walkthrough identifies Elena's later timed Gold Dragon challenge, so the gentle presentation is not a no-rush guarantee. Bereavement is the central theme.

Try this first. Meet a passenger, walk around the boat and try one chore in each role. Check whether both people enjoy what their character can do. Leave the larger building plan alone until the small shared activity feels worthwhile.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Ferry Has Asked Me to Remove the Jacuzzi

I designed our ferry with a private deck for romantic evenings. Rosa asked where the passengers would sleep. I pointed beneath the stairs. Shawna put down the pencil.

'Nigga, it's a boat for them.'

Spiritfarer made the people aboard matter more than my floor plan. Tank chose the cat and immediately looked more relaxed than I had all night. Mercedes wanted to hear what a passenger needed.

I promised to handle everything. The game showed me several things needing handling. Porsche watched my face. 'Your mouth hired your hands again.'

We cooked something. Built a little. Stopped to listen. I deleted the jacuzzi from the drawing.

Shawna leaned against me when the conversation turned toward goodbye. I did not try to make it cheerful.

Tank's cat moved across the screen. Rosa smiled at it, then at him. 'You make a good passenger.' 'Nigga, I'm staff.' She kissed his cheek. 'Then ask for a break.'

Aiden's verdict. Come aboard when caring for people and sharing chores sounds welcome, including the grief. My jacuzzi has been removed so an actual passenger can unpack.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Steam publisher description confirms Farewell Edition activities and local Daffodil cooperation. Prior inspected GuideStrats walkthrough supplies the secondary-source warning about Elena and the timed Gold Dragon; not represented as a developer access statement.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/972660/>

Source 2: <https://guidestrats.com/spiritfarer-elena-guide/>

P203 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Pode

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch release

Guide a rock and fallen star through beautiful caverns, combining their different abilities to solve spatial puzzles and bring the environment to life together.

What you do. Move the two characters, explore cave rooms and coordinate their positions and special abilities to open ways forward.

Direction + buttons | Timing needs checking | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Spatial positioning and movement still need checking; gentle art does not establish no held actions, tricky jumps or timed sections.

Why it might click. A rock and a fallen star explore Norwegian-inspired caverns, using different abilities to bring an ancient environment to life and solve spatial puzzles. The Switch edition supports one or two players on one system.

The full catch. You still move characters through three-dimensional spaces and coordinate their positions and abilities. The store's cooperative and gentle-looking presentation does not prove no held movement, no tricky jumps or no timed sections throughout. The assigned edition is Switch; PC controller requirements are not imported here.

Try this first. Try the first shared room and let each person explain what their character appears able to change. Check movement, positioning and the viewpoint before tackling a long puzzle. Switch roles only if both people would like to.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Star Needs the Rock to Stop Laughing

I chose the star before Tank finished asking which character I wanted. Nigga, some decisions arrive already wearing my name.

He chose the rock. Shawna looked at us. 'At least one of you knows how to stay grounded.'

Pode wanted the two little travellers to use their different abilities. I wanted Tank to appreciate my glow. He moved to the useful place and waited while I demonstrated it.

'Brother, you coming?' 'I'm establishing the mood.' 'The door don't care.'

Mercedes laughed. Rosa told Tank to give me a moment. He gave me exactly the moment I needed to realise I was the delay.

I moved beside him. Something in the room changed. The way ahead appeared because the two characters were finally doing something together.

Shawna brushed my sleeve. 'There you are.' I glanced at her. 'You like me shining?' 'Baby, I like you where the other person asked you to stand.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose the mountain when complementary abilities sound enjoyable to explore together. The star may shine as brightly as it likes after it reaches the correct fucking spot.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/pode-switch/>

P204 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Stardew Valley

Edition considered: PC current release; platform and version must be recorded

Grow a farm and become familiar with a community, sharing work and exploration while seasons, friendships and personal projects give the place continuity.

What you do. Plant crops, manage tools and resources, visit neighbours and explore activities together in the chosen cooperative PC setup.

Direction + buttons | Action continues while you think | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. The active day, inventories and multiple activities add pressure; verify multiplayer pause behavior before expecting menus to stop time.

Why it might click. Farming, friendships, seasons, crafting and exploration create a place that can grow alongside a group. The current inspected PC listing advertises online cooperation and shared-screen support, allowing genuine joint work rather than only discussion beside one controller.

The full catch. An active day, energy, inventories, travel, fishing and combat create different demands. Multiplayer pause behavior must be checked; a partner does not automatically stop the clock. Many recipes and social schedules can turn leisure into planning. Record the actual installed version before comparing features.

Try this first. Plant a small patch or take one walk together. Inspect movement, item selection and what happens to time when a menu opens. Avoid choosing a mining or fishing challenge as the sole measure of whether village life appeals.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Farm Has Opened with a Champagne Debt

I announced that the farm would pay for itself. Tank looked at the champagne I had ordered to celebrate it. 'Nigga, the farm hasn't met you yet.'

Stardew Valley gave Rosa a small patch she wanted to plant. I proposed expanding before the first seed touched soil. Shawna asked whether growth was the only word in my vocabulary.

'There's pleasure.' 'Then let Rosa have some.'

My wife leaned close enough that I briefly forgot agriculture. On the screen, time kept moving. Tank pointed. 'Your romantic speech got opening hours, my nigga.'

We settled on a little work and a walk. Mercedes wanted to meet someone in town. Porsche wanted to see what the house could become.

I put away the imaginary expansion plan. A plant doing one ordinary thing became more interesting than the empire I had promised.

Rosa looked over. 'You enjoying your farm?' 'Yes.' 'Good. Stop calling it an empire. The carrots don't owe you a salute.'

Aiden's verdict. Plant a small evening here if the routine and relationships appeal. My champagne debt belongs to the host, and no carrot is obliged to finance it.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/413150/>

P205 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Minecraft

Edition considered: Java & Bedrock Edition for PC; editions need separate control profiles

Create a shared place from blocks in Creative mode, using unlimited resources to focus on a modest build instead of surviving the world's dangers.

What you do. Look around, move through the world and place or remove blocks while coordinating a building project on compatible editions and devices.

Movement + camera | Action continues while you think | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Camera movement and precise placement remain; Java and Bedrock differ, and PC versions do not provide console-style split-screen.

Why it might click. Creative mode supplies unlimited resources, damage immunity and flight for shared building. Java and Bedrock both support multiplayer, but they have different compatibility and input profiles. A modest construction can give two people an enjoyable shared purpose.

The full catch. Moving while steering a three-dimensional view and precisely placing blocks can be substantial work. Creative mode changes survival pressure, not those demands. Official comparison lists controller support for Bedrock, not Java, and split-screen only on consoles; do not plan PC couch split-screen.

Try this first. Choose the exact edition and arrange compatible separate-device play if sharing online or locally. In Creative mode, try looking around and placing a few blocks before planning anything large. A wall with one window is an adequate architectural brief.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Cathedral Has a Bedroom but No Front Door

I built the bedroom first. Shawna inspected the Minecraft structure. 'How do we get in?' 'Baby, romance finds a way.' Tank pointed at the wall. 'This nigga expects romance to bring a pickaxe.'

Creative mode had given me resources and I had spent them on a ceiling that looked impressive from a room nobody could enter.

Dre added a doorway. Rosa made a little window. Mercedes chose a colour that did not announce my ownership to the horizon.

I called it collaboration. Porsche called it six adults repairing a man's approach to shelter.

Shawna walked her character inside and looked around. The place finally had a view. I tried the camera and found that building the dream still required knowing where I was looking.

'You like it?' I asked. 'I like the window.' 'That wasn't mine.'

She smiled. 'I know, baby.' Nigga, the cathedral survived because several people loved something about it more than they loved my explanation.

Aiden's verdict. Build together if the camera and placing blocks feel good. Our cathedral now admits visitors through a door, ending a deeply impractical phase of romantic architecture.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.minecraft.net/en-us/about-minecraft>

P206 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Animal Crossing: New Horizons

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

Make an island home through collecting, crafting, decorating and meeting animal neighbours, with different ways to spend time alongside other players on Switch.

What you do. Walk around the island, speak with residents, gather materials and place objects while trying the specific shared-system or visiting mode.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Storage, tools and repeated menus add work; shared-system roles and installed-version restrictions need checking before assuming equal freedom.

Why it might click. Collect materials, meet animal neighbours and gradually arrange an island home. The current Switch page supports up to four people sharing one system and larger visits with separate systems, though these are different ways of playing together.

The full catch. Crafting, tool selection, storage and repeated dialogue can create menu work. Same-system roles and restrictions deserve a practical check before assuming everyone has identical freedom. The page reflects current updates, so check the installed version; this card does not certify every activity as untimed.

Try this first. Walk around, talk to one neighbour and try placing or collecting an object. If playing together, test the specific visiting or shared-system mode and let both people describe what they can actually do. An unproductive beach stroll is a valid result.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Island Has Voted Against My Statue

I picked a place for my statue before choosing where anybody would sleep. Rosa stood behind me with a plate. 'Nigga, eat something. You're founding a problem.'

Animal Crossing offered a beach, neighbours and things to make. Shawna wanted a quiet corner near the water. I offered to name it after her.

'You could let me choose it.' 'Baby, I'm honouring you.' 'Then hear the sentence.'

Tank found a place for a bench. Dre suggested the statue could face the sea so nobody on the island had to look at me.

Mercedes laughed and started arranging something smaller. I watched the little place become personal without every object receiving a dedication.

Porsche asked how our shared mode worked before taking a controller. We checked instead of making promises.

The bench looked good. Shawna sat beside me in the real room. I left the statue unfinished. Nigga, some islands acquire beauty through a cancellation.

Aiden's verdict. Visit the island if collecting, neighbours and decorating sound pleasant. My statue remains offshore in theory, allowing the bench to provide the evening's actual monument.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/animal-crossing-new-horizons-switch/>

P207 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Portal 2

Edition considered: PC release

Solve a dedicated two-player puzzle campaign together, using portals and complementary perspectives to discover how unusual test chambers can be crossed or rearranged.

What you do. Walk and look around in first person, aim portals and coordinate actions with the other player to solve chambers.

Movement + camera | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. First-person aiming and coordinated manoeuvres remain substantial catches; the timed-input declaration is not a complete cooperative-play audit.

Why it might click. The dedicated two-player campaign has its own robots, story and chambers designed around joint portal solutions. Humour and mechanical discoveries make it attractive to companions who like discussing how a space works.

The full catch. First-person movement, aiming, spatial transformations and coordinating actions remain substantial catches. Steam declares play without timed input, but that declaration is not a tested guarantee that every cooperative manoeuvre avoids urgency or awkward timing. Both camera comfort and joint execution need direct trials.

Try this first. Enter the cooperative introduction and test looking, walking and placing a portal before pursuing a complex solution. Describe a location without pointing at the other person's screen. Stop if the camera or required coordination outweighs the pleasure of solving.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Portal Opens Directly into My Bad Idea

I said Portal 2 would reward two men with excellent spatial judgement. Tank looked at the suite door I had tried to push while it said PULL.

'Nigga, which two?'

The chamber gave us places to look and a reason to explain them clearly. I described one panel as the place that obviously wanted a portal. Shawna asked whether obvious was a location.

Mercedes sat behind Tank, waiting to see our plan. Porsche sat behind me, waiting for the hotel to invoice it.

I aimed at the wrong wall. My brother said nothing. That was worse than laughter. Dre laughed for him.

We stopped. I described the actual panel. Tank told me what he needed. The next attempt worked well enough to make us both grin.

I reached for a grand conclusion. Shawna kissed my cheek first. 'Good job, baby.' Nigga, I accepted the smaller celebration and avoided building another wrong door out of words.

Aiden's verdict. Enter the chambers if camera movement and shared spatial reasoning sound enjoyable. My theory of obvious walls has been withdrawn after consultation with an actual door.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/620/>

P208 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Untitled Goose Game

Edition considered: PC release with two-player update

Cause slapstick trouble together in a village, coordinating distractions and stealing objects while watching the inhabitants react to two very determined geese and their pranks.

What you do. Move around the village, honk, handle objects and work together to distract people or complete comic tasks.

Direction + buttons | Action continues while you think | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Pursuit and useful timing occur in real time; object handling and later time challenges need checking despite the charming premise.

Why it might click. The updated PC game lets two people play the whole village prank campaign together. Watching people react, coordinating distractions and creating ridiculous little situations can be as entertaining as completing the written objectives.

The full catch. Stealth, pursuit, object handling and positioning operate in real time. Some tasks require observing routines and acting at a useful moment; held inputs and later time challenges need checking. A charming goose is still capable of making a control scheme demanding.

Try this first. Explore the first garden together and try moving, honking and handling one object before attempting an elaborate prank. Agree whether either person wants hints. Enjoy an accidental comic moment without turning every task into a performance target.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Goose Has Taken My Wife's Shoe

I described our goose partnership as a precision operation. Tank honked before I finished. Nigga, some collaborators establish their own tone.

Untitled Goose Game gave us a village full of people trying to get on with life. I respected the goose's ambition and disliked how closely everybody said it resembled me.

Shawna's shoe lay beside the sofa. I lifted it to demonstrate a theft. She held out her hand.

'You want to carry that, baby?' 'I'm illustrating the premise.' 'Then illustrate returning it.'

On the screen, Tank caused a distraction while I tried to move the object. Mercedes laughed at the result. The plan had gone wrong in a way better than my plan.

Porsche wanted a turn. I passed the controller instead of explaining what she should do with it.

Shawna took her shoe and settled beside me. Tank honked again. 'That one was for the shoe.' Nigga, the village had acquired standards my party was still learning.

Aiden's verdict. Try shared mischief when watching a plan fail can be part of the fun. My wife's shoe has been returned before the goose acquired legal counsel.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/837470/>

P209 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Unravel Two

Edition considered: PC release

Help two connected Yarnys through beautiful environments, using their physical link to turn movement and obstacles into a shared puzzle with an emotional story.

What you do. Run, jump, swing and help the other Yarny cross obstacles while exploring the route together in local cooperative play.

Direction + buttons | Action continues while you think | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Active platforming and chases remain; being linked can add coordination pressure when the two players want different paces.

Why it might click. Two Yarnys work through natural and built environments, helping one another across obstacles. Native local cooperation makes the physical connection between characters a direct shared puzzle, with an emotional story running through the journey.

The full catch. This is an active platforming game: jumping, swinging, running and reaction demands are explicit. Coordination can amplify frustration when one person wants a slower pace. Its warmth does not establish an easy route through every chase or challenge; check any assistance options in the actual build.

Try this first. In an early safe area, each person should try movement and one simple shared traversal. Ask whether being physically linked feels funny and satisfying or restrictive. Do not make completing a chase the admission test for an enjoyable evening.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Yarn Is Around My Belt and the Romance Is Over

I tied two pieces of decorative yarn together to explain Unravel Two. Shawna asked why one end was around my belt. I said love required commitment.

Tank caught the other end on a chair. My shirt pulled sideways. Nigga, the demonstration had become a wardrobe negotiation.

The game connected its little partners for a reason. Ours were connected because I had mistaken flirtation for equipment setup.

'You want me to untie it?' Shawna asked. 'Depends where this goes.' 'Toward a usable chair.'

Mercedes picked up a controller and wanted to try the actual movement. Porsche joined her. They negotiated a route without involving anybody's trousers.

Rosa freed the chair while Tank tried very hard not to laugh. He failed. I accepted this as a contribution to morale.

I sat beside my wife, with both feet on the floor and my belt serving one job. 'Still committed,' I told her. She kissed me. 'Much easier to reach now.'

Aiden's verdict. Take the linked adventure if its movement sounds fun for both people. All demonstrations involving my belt have ended so the chairs can resume normal service.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1225570/>

P210 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

80 Days

Edition considered: PC release

Plan an alternate-history journey around the world, balancing routes and resources while conversations and unexpected encounters give each trip its own character and possibilities.

What you do. Choose destinations and transport, read encounters, manage luggage and money, and consider Fogg's wellbeing along the route.

Mouse / pointer | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Travel deadlines and schedules add pressure; inspect clock behavior, and remember shared discussion is not native cooperative control.

Why it might click. As Passepartout, choose routes and encounters across an alternate-history world while managing Fogg's wellbeing, money and travel. This is single-player storytelling that can be discussed beside the screen; its shared appeal does not make it native cooperative play.

The full catch. The premise includes a travel deadline, schedules and an in-game clock. The inspected store language stresses continuous time, so do not assume a fully untimed experience or confuse the multiplayer journey feed with joint control. Reading, inventory and route planning are significant.

Try this first. Inspect the opening route choices and how time behaves in each screen before committing to a journey. Let the person operating choose whether advice is welcome. One interesting encounter is enough to assess the prose and decision rhythm.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Suitcase Contains Three Hats and No Practical Husband

I packed for 80 Days as if every city had requested a formal photograph. Shawna opened the suitcase and found three hats, two jackets and no room for hers.

'Nigga, are you travelling or touring yourself?'

The game gave us routes, money, luggage and somebody else's needs. Tank asked what I would leave behind to catch the connection. I pointed at his bag.

He closed my suitcase on the largest hat. Rosa laughed before she could stop herself.

Mercedes wanted to follow an interesting encounter. Porsche wanted to compare the route. They had more useful things to say about the journey than I had managed with six pieces of tailoring.

Shawna took out two hats and fitted in her clothes. I tried to object. She held up the dress she planned to wear.

Nigga, my priorities became flexible immediately.

We chose one direction together. The remaining hat sat on my knee, reduced from an international strategy to an accessory with reasonable luggage requirements.

Aiden's verdict. Travel by story if routes and compromises sound appealing. My spare hats will remain at the hotel, where they can pursue their international careers without us.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected publisher or platform product description supports the premise and stated multiplayer features. Movement burden and editorial fit are inferences, not a full control audit. Exact edition limits and unknowns appear in the card; sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/381780/>

The Nigga Giving Directions Was Looking at the Wrong Screen

'Left,' I told Tank. He moved left.

'Other left.'

He stopped moving. Rosa reached for her drink. Mercedes closed her eyes with the patience of a woman waiting for a chorus she knew would be bad.

'My nigga,' Tank said, 'how many lefts you brought?'

I leaned closer to his screen. The object I had been describing was on mine. This was an important distinction in a game designed around people seeing different things, and a terrible distinction for a man who had already given directions confidently.

Shawna pulled my chair back six inches. 'Start over.'

'He understood the spirit.'

'He walked into the fucking wall.'

Dre laughed into his casserole. Nigga had brought enough food to witness several of my corrections without leaving for supplies.

I tried again. I described a mark, where it was and what sat beside it. Tank told me what he saw. We found the connection. Something on the screen opened.

I grinned. 'Teamwork.'

'Information,' my brother said. 'Try it again sometime.'

That should have been the end of my helpfulness. Unfortunately, success is where I usually begin adding accessories.

I reached toward his controller to show him a move. His hand stayed where it was. Mine hovered in the air between us, a little monument to poor timing.

'Ask,' he said.

I lowered it. 'You want me to show you?'

'No. Tell me what you noticed.'

I told him. He tried it his way. It worked.

Mercedes looked at Porsche. 'You remember the studio?'

Porsche nodded. She had once touched a control while Mercedes was listening to a take. The argument had been short, expensive and educational. They did not retell it for us. Porsche simply moved her own hand away from Mercedes's screen.

Two corrections in one room. Nigga, the hotel ought to have charged tuition.

Shawna's phone buzzed. The pianist wanted to know whether he could practise in our bedroom while the other room was being moved. My wife turned the screen toward me.

'You want to answer this?'

I considered a joke involving practice, stamina and the room's intended acoustics. Shawna waited, smiling like she knew every bad sentence lined up behind my teeth.

I typed No, thank you. Then I put the phone down.

'Damn,' Tank said. 'He used a whole sentence and nobody needs a lawyer.'

Rosa stood to get water. Tank started to stand too. She touched his shoulder. 'I got it. You finish your turn.'

He stayed. She brought two glasses. Nobody had to perform dependence or heroism to make a simple kindness count.

On the other sofa, Dre and Mercedes traded controllers because each wanted to try the other role. Porsche watched and offered nothing until asked. The silence did not make her less involved. She was the first one to laugh when the plan went wrong.

I looked at the party I had nearly drowned in instructions. People wanted different things from the same screen. They were managing this without a microphone.

Shawna slipped her hand behind my neck. 'You having fun?'

'Nigga, don't tell anybody.'

'I could post it.'

'Use the good angle.'

She kissed my cheek instead. I forgot which screen I had been watching.

Tank caught me looking away. 'Now stay out of my left.'

P211 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Past Within

Edition considered: PC release; two devices required

Exchange clues across two separate perspectives in a Rusty Lake mystery, making describing what you see the central cooperative activity rather than sharing one controller.

What you do. Use separate devices to inspect scenes, describe symbols and objects, and combine information from the past and future to solve puzzles.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Both players need copies, devices and communication; eerie imagery and remembering described clues add demands, while exact input behavior remains unchecked.

Why it might click. Two players occupy different times and exchange information to solve a Rusty Lake mystery. Separate perspectives make describing, listening and comparing observations the actual cooperative activity rather than a decorative addition to a solo puzzle.

The full catch. This is co-op only: each player needs their own copy, a device and a way to communicate. Eerie imagery and puzzling symbols may be unwelcome. Reading, remembering descriptions and manipulating the interface still need checking; the premise does not establish a complete absence of timed or held actions.

Try this first. Set up both perspectives and exchange one precise observation before pursuing a solution. Try any unfamiliar interaction separately. Decide whether the pleasure comes from explaining what you see, and whether either person wants brief written notes.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P211 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

The Past Within

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Future Self Has Already Lost the Room Key

I chose the future in The Past Within because I expected it to appreciate me. Tank chose the past and asked whether he could prevent the evening's piano order.

Our screens showed different information. I described a symbol as bold, commanding and suggestive of greatness. Shawna put down her glass.

'Nigga, what shape?' 'Triangle.' 'Start there.'

Mercedes tried not to laugh. Porsche did not try. Dre passed the casserole while my brother compared the actual marks with the ones on his screen.

I told him where another detail sat. He told me what he needed. We made a connection without the future once being required to admire my jacket.

Then I reached for our room key and found an empty pocket.

Tank held it up. 'Past saw you leave this by the ice.'

Nigga, the past was annoyingly well informed. Shawna took the key from him and said the future could stay with her until I improved my record.

Aiden's verdict. Try the two perspectives if precise descriptions and shared discoveries sound satisfying. My future may retain its ambitions, but the room key is travelling with somebody competent.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1515210/>

P212 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Kirby and the Forgotten Land

Edition considered: 2022 Nintendo Switch original; not Switch 2 Star-Crossed World edition

Explore colourful three-dimensional stages and rescue Waddle Dees, with a second player joining as Bandana Waddle Dee and a town developing between adventures.

What you do. Move through stages, use character abilities, fight enemies and explore together, trying the distinct Kirby and Bandana Waddle Dee roles.

Direction + buttons | Action continues while you think | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Platforming and combat remain; timed Treasure Road challenges and held abilities are explicit, and the cooperative roles differ.

Why it might click. Explore three-dimensional stages, rescue Waddle Dees and develop a town between adventures. Original Switch local cooperation adds Bandana Waddle Dee beside Kirby. Nintendo's Spring-Breeze mode gives more health and easier enemies.

The full catch. This remains platforming and combat. Nintendo explicitly describes timed Treasure Road challenges and abilities involving held buttons, such as charging a hammer or aiming a bomb. The second role differs. The 2022 Switch original is assessed here, not the Switch 2 expansion or upgrade.

Try this first. Try the opening area in Spring-Breeze mode if desired, testing movement and each character's basic actions. Check whether both people like their role before pursuing a boss or time challenge. The official page lists a demo, whose current availability can be checked on the console.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Kirby Has Inhaled My Grand Entrance

I said Kirby understood appetite. Shawna looked at the plate I had balanced on my knee. 'Baby, Kirby finishes what he starts.'

The Forgotten Land gave one of us Kirby and the other Bandana Waddle Dee. I selected the star without discussion. Tank put his controller down.

'Nigga, we trying roles or appointing royalty?'

Mercedes wanted to see the overgrown place. Porsche wanted to know how her character moved. They had managed to ask practical questions before I had finished celebrating my selection.

I offered Tank a turn as Kirby. He smiled like a man accepting a overdue payment.

We tried a little movement. Some actions worked differently. Shawna pointed at the screen rather than at me, which let the information arrive without becoming a verdict on my greatness.

At the buffet, the waiter removed my unfinished plate. I protested.

Rosa looked at the empty space. 'Mouthful mode.' Nigga, the entire room understood the joke before I found a defence.

Aiden's verdict. Visit the bright adventure if its active roles sound enjoyable to try. My buffet plate has entered a new mode in which somebody else clears it.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/kirby-and-the-forgotten-land-switch/>

P213 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Kirby's Return to Dream Land Deluxe

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch Deluxe edition

Share a colourful platform adventure with several character choices, helping rebuild a ship while abilities and a helper option offer different ways to participate together.

What you do. Choose characters, move through stages, float, jump and fight together while trying the main adventure's available assistance.

Direction + buttons | Action continues while you think | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Active moves and platforming remain despite Helper Magolor; later modes and subgames have different demands from the opening adventure.

Why it might click. The Deluxe Switch platform adventure supports up to four local players, including different Kirbys and familiar companions. Repairing Magolor's ship gives the group a shared journey, while character abilities and separate subgames provide variety.

The full catch. Floating, fighting, jumps and different move sets remain active demands. Nintendo confirms Helper Magolor for the main adventure, but that does not erase every challenge. The later Magolor Epilogue must be unlocked and has its own action; do not treat all modes as equivalent.

Try this first. Use an early main-adventure section to test movement and a character's basic ability. Examine Helper Magolor if helpful. Leave competitive subgames and coordinated team attacks for later, and keep the first shared session free from a completion target.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Four Kirbys and One Nigga Still Wants Top Billing

I liked the possibility of several Kirbys until Mercedes selected one before me. Then I suddenly developed an interest in preserving artistic distinction.

Tank watched my face. 'Nigga, it's a colour. You're not losing the album cover.'

Return to Dream Land Deluxe let us choose a party instead of making everybody attend my personal adventure. Rosa wanted a character she liked. Dre wanted to see what his could do.

Shawna told me to choose while the room still had an evening left. I chose. Nobody applauded the colour.

We tried the first little stretch together. I began announcing every useful thing I did. Porsche announced the next useful thing somebody else did. The room became pleasantly crowded with competence.

'You keeping score?' I asked. 'Nigga, you started the broadcast.'

I stopped announcing. A helper appeared where it mattered, and the party moved on. Tank grinned at me. 'Look at that. Four heroes, no opening act.'

Aiden's verdict. Gather a party if colourful platforming sounds welcome to everyone. My application for permanent top billing has been rejected on the grounds that the others also have controllers.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/kirbys-return-to-dream-land-deluxe-switch/>

P214 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Super Mario Bros. Wonder

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch release

Discover playful changes in side-scrolling courses, with local multiplayer and character choices that can reduce enemy-damage concerns while keeping the platforming adventure active and surprising.

What you do. Run and jump through courses, try power-ups or character abilities, and help other players as unexpected Wonder effects change the surroundings.

Direction + buttons | Action continues while you think | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Jumps, gaps and moving hazards remain; enemy-damage protection does not establish an easy, no-hold route through every course.

Why it might click. Side-scrolling courses change in imaginative ways when Wonder effects appear. Up to four local players can tackle them together. Nabbit and Yoshis avoid damage from enemies, and Yoshis can carry other players.

The full catch. Running, jumping, gaps, moving hazards and coordination remain part of an action game. Enemy-damage protection does not certify an effortless or no-hold path through every course. Character restrictions also matter: Nintendo says Nabbit and Yoshis do not transform with power-ups.

Try this first. Pick characters for their actual appeal and try one early course without collecting every optional item. Check movement and jump controls before introducing extra badges. A companion should match the agreed pace rather than racing ahead to demonstrate expertise.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P214 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Super Mario Bros. Wonder

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Talking Flower Has Asked Me to Keep It Down

I told the room that no flower could outtalk me. Mercedes said this sounded like a promise the hotel ought to insure against.

Wonder turned the landscape strange while I tried to claim I had expected it. Tank looked over. 'Nigga, your face didn't.'

Shawna chose her character. Dre asked what the protected characters gave up in exchange. I appreciated that he wanted information before being persuaded, although I would have preferred a less public demonstration.

The first surprising thing happened. Rosa laughed. I missed half of it explaining the beginning. My wife touched my arm. 'Baby, watch.'

I watched. The game did something else. This time I laughed before I found the explanation.

Porsche pointed at the talking flower. 'That's your competition.' I said the flower lacked my stage presence. Tank said it had the advantage of leaving gaps between remarks.

Nigga, the room was taking botany's side. I put down the microphone and let the next surprise get here first.

Aiden's verdict. Choose the courses when movement and surprise sound like fun. The talking flower gets equal speaking time, and nobody owes my commentary an encore between jumps.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/super-mario-bros-wonder-switch/>

P215 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Tick Tock: A Tale for Two

Edition considered: PC release; two-device format

Solve an eerie clockwork mystery through two separate screens, combining what each person can see and turning clear description into the main shared pleasure together.

What you do. Inspect your own scenes, describe clues and symbols, and use information from the other player's screen to solve linked puzzles.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Two players need separate devices and setup; clue communication can be demanding, and the clock imagery does not establish actual timer behavior.

Why it might click. Separate screens hold pieces of an eerie clockwork mystery, and two people combine what they see to escape. The developer describes cross-platform play, so communication rather than a shared physical controller is the central partnership.

The full catch. It requires two players and separate devices; check the exact copies and setup needed on the chosen platforms. Describing symbols and retaining another person's clues can be demanding. The clock imagery and promotional urgency do not establish the actual timer behavior; inspect it directly.

Try this first. Choose the two perspectives and compare one visible clue. Try describing shape, location and order before proposing a theory. Establish that asking for a repeat is ordinary cooperation, then see whether the eerie atmosphere adds pleasure or merely pressure.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Clockmaker Has Never Heard My Description of a Clock

I told Tank there was a clock on my screen. He asked what it showed. I said craftsmanship, age and a certain sadness. Nigga put his controller in his lap.

Tick Tock needed information, not my audition for an antique programme. Shawna waited until I looked at her.

'Numbers, baby.'

I gave him the numbers. He gave me something from his screen. The room stopped being an audience and became a place where two people could actually compare clues.

Dre kept time on the microwave while his casserole warmed. I accused him of adding atmosphere. He said food had needs entirely unrelated to my mystery.

Mercedes asked whether we wanted a note of the symbols. I said yes. No speech about outsourcing memory. She wrote them where we could both see.

Tank found the connection. I grinned at him. 'We good together.' 'Nigga, we better when you describe the fucking clock.'

Aiden's verdict. Try it when exchanging separate clues sounds pleasurable rather than tiring. My antique commentary is available later, after the actual numbers have safely reached the other player.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/790740/>

P216 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Captain Toad: Treasure Tracker

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch version

Explore compact three-dimensional puzzle courses, turning the view to discover hidden routes, treasures and mechanisms, with Switch two-player support depending on the installed setup.

What you do. Move through small courses, rotate the view, inspect paths and treasures, and try the actual second-player role on the console.

Movement + camera | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Camera rotation, hazards and aiming remain; check the installed version's cooperative roles instead of assuming both players control identical characters.

Why it might click. Compact three-dimensional courses invite you to inspect routes, hidden items and mechanisms from different angles. The Switch release includes two-player support, making it a possible shared puzzle expedition once the actual roles and update level are clear.

The full catch. Camera rotation, hazards, aiming and some moving challenges remain relevant. Nintendo's current product text describes second-player turnip assistance and newer features separately; verify the installed version's cooperative roles rather than assuming identical control. This card excludes VR and separately sold extra stages.

Try this first. Explore an early course and rotate the view deliberately before moving near a hazard. Try the second-player role on the actual console. Ask whether discovering a route together feels satisfying and whether the camera is comfortable.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Treasure Is Behind the Bag I Brought to Find It

I packed a telescope, evening shoes and a little flask for Captain Toad's expedition. Rosa asked whether I intended to look for treasure or attend its wedding.

Tank moved my bag off the coffee table. Underneath was the controller I'd spent five minutes requesting from everybody else.

'Nigga, we found the first one.'

Captain Toad's little world wanted looking from different angles. I rotated our model and discovered a passage I had confidently described as impossible.

Shawna smiled. 'You want to revise that?' 'I was testing the architecture.' 'The architecture passed.'

Porsche checked the second-player job before handing Mercedes another controller. The distinction mattered. Two people in a picture did not automatically mean the same evening for both.

I put the telescope away and looked at the screen.

Tank took the flask. 'Expedition supplies?' 'Private reserve.' He returned it unopened. 'Keep it. You need something that still believes in your equipment choices.'

Aiden's verdict. Inspect the little worlds if changing the view sounds satisfying. My expedition bag must remain under the table so the treasure can stop being the controller itself.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/captain-toad-treasure-tracker-switch/>

P217 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Yoshi's Crafted World

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch release

Explore a playful world made from everyday craft materials, sharing two-player movement and discovering new details when familiar stages are viewed from their reverse side.

What you do. Move and jump through stages, aim at objects, collect items and explore with another Yoshi, trying Mellow mode if desired.

Direction + buttons | Action continues while you think | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Jumping, aiming and enemies remain despite Mellow wings; collecting everything can also add repeated travel and extra tasks.

Why it might click. Everyday craft materials become a playful landscape for two local Yoshis. Collecting objects and seeing stages from the reverse side can turn a familiar route into a fresh observation game. Mellow mode gives Yoshi wings.

The full catch. Jumping, aiming, enemies and movement still exist, and searching for every collectible can add repeated travel. Wings change part of the challenge; they do not prove every input is comfortable or every sequence untimed. Both players should test their controls rather than relying on the handmade appearance.

Try this first. Try an opening section, with Mellow mode if desired, and practise one jump and one aimed action. Enjoy the scenery without making complete collection a requirement. Let either player decide that looking together is more pleasant than controlling a character.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P217 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Yoshi's Crafted World

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Cardboard City Has Refused My Gold Trim

I asked the waiter whether we could have the empty champagne carton. He brought it. I announced a new building project. Tank moved his drink out of range.

Yoshi's Crafted World had made ordinary scraps look inventive. Rosa cut a little doorway in our carton while I considered whether the hotel sold gold ribbon.

'Nigga,' Mercedes said, 'let a box be impressive without being rich.'

Shawna tried the game's movement. Porsche asked what the wings changed. Dre watched the aiming instead of assuming every soft-looking thing would be easy.

I put my name across the carton roof. Rosa turned the roof around. The blank side looked surprisingly elegant.

Tank added a bottle-cap window. Mercedes chose a colour. The tiny house became something I liked and could no longer plausibly claim alone.

My wife set it beside the screen. 'You keeping it?' 'Of course.' 'Good. Then help carry it.' Nigga, ownership had developed a physical requirement.

Aiden's verdict. Visit the craft world if its movement and handmade scenery appeal. Our champagne-carton house remains unsigned, with all gold trim currently unavailable for perfectly excellent reasons.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/yoshis-crafted-world-switch/>

P218 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Snipperclips - Cut it out, together!

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game; Plus expansion separate

Reshape paper characters together to interact with objects and solve inventive physical puzzles, finding humour in experiments that do something different from what you expected.

What you do. Move and rotate the characters, overlap their shapes, cut deliberately and work together to manipulate objects in cooperative puzzles.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Precise overlap, rotation and unstable objects can require repeated attempts; competitive and action-focused modes have different demands.

Why it might click. Partners reshape paper characters to interact with objects and solve physical puzzles. The Switch base game includes cooperative play; its competitive Blitz activities and larger Party challenges are distinct choices, not one uniform experience.

The full catch. Precise overlap, rotation, movement and manipulating unstable objects can take repeated attempts. Some modes are action-focused. The cheerful visual style does not establish no holds or no urgency, and the Plus expansion should not be assumed to be part of the base release.

Try this first. Begin with an ordinary cooperative puzzle, test how cutting and restoring a shape work, and agree before cutting the other character. See whether the shared experimentation is funny even when it fails. Leave competitive activities out of the initial trial.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / She Cut My Crown into Something Useful

I cut a paper crown for myself. Mercedes took one look and asked whether the scissors were still available. Nigga, success attracts collaborators.

Snipperclips gave reshaping a practical purpose. Two little characters could change what the other was able to do. I offered to improve Shawna's shape without asking.

She caught my wrist. 'Try that sentence again.'

I asked. She said she wanted a different cut. We lined it up together and tried it.

Tank lifted my actual paper crown. 'What you want this to be?' 'Regal.' Rosa took it and made a stand for the little snack sign.

The stand held. My crown had found honest work.

On the screen, our first shape was wrong. We changed it and laughed. Shawna leaned against me while I adjusted. Nigga, being useful to my wife was turning out more enjoyable than deciding what she should become. The scissors stayed on her side of the table.

Aiden's verdict. Try reshaping together if negotiating a funny practical solution sounds appealing. My crown has become a snack stand and finally supports somebody besides the nigga wearing it.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/snipperclips-cut-it-out-together-switch/>

P219 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Blanc

Edition considered: PC release

Help a wolf cub and fawn find their families through a hand-drawn snowy landscape, using their different strengths in a wordless cooperative journey together.

What you do. Guide the two animals through the environment, follow tracks and use their complementary abilities to get past shared obstacles.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Two buttons still involve positioning and coordination; separation, harsh weather and movement demands need checking despite the gentle artwork.

Why it might click. A wolf cub and a fawn travel through a hand-drawn black-and-white landscape, following their families' traces and using complementary abilities. The PC release supports local and online cooperation, with text-free storytelling.

The full catch. The developer describes two buttons plus movement, but a small button count does not settle coordination, precision, repetition or held movement. Navigation and obstacles still need both players. Separation and harsh weather give the gentle artwork an emotional edge.

Try this first. Move each animal through the opening space and try its first useful action. Check whether the viewpoint and character positions are easy to read together. Agree that either person can request a pause or a repeated explanation without apologising.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Snow Has Covered My Excellent Footwork

I said I could track anything through snow. Tank pointed at the shoe I'd misplaced beside the sofa. 'Nigga, start indoors.'

Blanc put a wolf cub and a fawn into a much more important search. Rosa wanted the two little animals to find their families. Dre wanted to try the fawn.

I volunteered to lead. Shawna asked whether leading meant watching what the other character needed. I said naturally. She waited until I actually did it.

The black-and-white scene made the room's gold lamps look loud. Mercedes dimmed one. We could see the tracks better without my idea of flattering light.

The animals moved differently. We tried each action instead of making the button count a promise.

Tank found my shoe underneath the table and slid it back with his foot.

'Great tracker,' he said. I put it on. 'Nigga, I was preserving the evidence.' Rosa smiled at the screen and let the animals keep their own story.

Aiden's verdict. Follow the snowy pair if their complementary actions feel enjoyable. My tracking credentials remain suspended until both shoes can be located without assistance from the rest of the room.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1982340/>

P220 / A PLACE TO START

Hidden Through Time

Edition considered: PC first game

Search lively illustrated scenes for hidden objects, using clues and small visual jokes to make patient shared observation feel like a succession of discoveries together.

What you do. Inspect hints, scan each scene, adjust the view and select hidden objects, with others welcome to look beside the player.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Dense scenes and small targets can be tiring; test zooming, panning and clicking, and do not assume native co-op.

Why it might click. Search colourful scenes for hidden objects across historical settings, using hints and visual detail. The PC game also offers a map editor and community creations, though the initial appeal can simply be one busy picture enjoyed together.

The full catch. Dense scenes, small objects and repeated scanning may be the main burden. Zooming, panning and clicking deserve direct checks; a hidden-object premise does not establish a complete no-timer or no-hold path. The inspected product lists single-player: shared looking is not verified native co-op.

Try this first. Open one ordinary scene and inspect a clue, a small object and the available view controls. Search without a race or a requirement to clear the whole picture. Ask whether the artwork makes looking pleasant before adding community maps.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / History Has Hidden My Watch on My Wrist

I offered a reward for finding my watch. Shawna looked at my wrist and then at Tank. My brother stood, touched the watch and held out his hand.

'Nigga, that's not finding.' 'Then why you paying?'

Hidden Through Time presented a better search: busy little scenes with objects tucked into all the things happening around them. Mercedes leaned forward. Porsche had already spotted something and was waiting to be asked.

I began dividing the picture into zones. Rosa found an object before I finished the first sentence. Dre found another.

The room laughed at my face. I put down the invisible map of my method and actually looked.

There was one. Small, funny, hidden in an ordinary detail. I pointed without grabbing the mouse.

Shawna selected it and smiled. 'You want the reward?' 'Baby, recognition is enough.'

Tank pocketed my promised cash. 'Good. Nigga's growing.' The watch kept time through the whole ugly transaction.

Aiden's verdict. Look together if the crowded pictures make searching pleasant. My watch has been recovered at considerable personal expense, and future rewards require a wrist inspection first.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected official Nintendo platform page or matched Steam publisher description supports the stated premise, mode and edition. Control demands are editorial observations or explicit checks, not a complete accessibility certification. Sources checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/524910/>

P221 / A PLACE TO START

Tiny Lands

Edition considered: PC first game

Compare miniature three-dimensional scenes without a time limit or mistake penalty, enjoying small visual discoveries while turning the view to inspect another angle together.

What you do. Rotate and zoom the scenes, compare details and select differences, taking as much time as the ordinary search needs.

Movement + camera | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Small visual differences and camera manipulation still need checking; the no-time-limit promise does not establish hold-free or drag-free input.

Why it might click. Rotate and compare miniature three-dimensional scenes to find their differences. The publisher explicitly states that there is no time limit and no penalty for mistakes, making patient shared observation a plausible way to enjoy it.

The full catch. The scenes still require visual discrimination, zooming and rotation. Check whether the actual camera manipulation uses uncomfortable holds or drags. The inspected description presents a single-player comparison game; shared looking is an informal arrangement, even though Remote Play Together appears among store features.

Try this first. Compare one pair of scenes at whatever pace feels pleasant. Rotate once, zoom once and make an uncertain selection to understand the feedback. Nobody needs to find every difference before deciding whether the artwork and observation suit the mood.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P221 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Tiny Lands

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Difference Is That One Aiden Looks Employed

I put two pictures of myself side by side and asked the room to find the difference. Tank pointed. 'That nigga knows where his keys are. This one called me.'

Tiny Lands offered better subjects and fewer witnesses. Little scenes turned beneath our view, each angle making another detail possible.

Shawna found something while I was explaining how carefully I intended to look. Mercedes found something else. Porsche said nothing, which made me suspect she had found three.

'Nobody timing this?' Dre asked. We checked the stated rule. No time limit. He settled back with his plate.

I tried a wrong answer. The world did not punish me for it. Nigga, an arrangement several hotel managers ought to investigate.

Rosa asked me to turn the view slightly. I did. There was the detail she'd noticed.

Tank looked at my photographs again. 'Still different.' 'How?' 'One of these niggas just followed directions.' My wife laughed before I could deny the improvement.

Aiden's verdict. Take the small scenes when unhurried looking sounds welcome. My two portraits remain a separate puzzle, with the solution apparently involving whether I listened before the photograph.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Tiny Lands Steam publisher description explicitly states no time limit and no punishment for mistakes, and describes adjustable angle and zoom. Single-player comparison is explicit; Remote Play Together is not treated as proof of native cooperative roles. Held/dragged camera input remains to check.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1354910/>

P222 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

PHOGS!

Edition considered: PC release

Guide two connected dog heads through playful physics puzzles, with stretching and grabbing turning different intentions into comic shared problem-solving across food, sleep and play worlds.

What you do. Move the two heads, grab objects, stretch and coordinate their actions to cross obstacles in the chosen cooperative setup.

Direction + buttons | Action continues while you think | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Connected movement and grabbing can require precision or holds; test the controller arrangement before assuming shared-controller play is easiest.

Why it might click. Red and Blue stretch, grab and bounce through physics puzzles in food, sleep and play worlds. The PC release explicitly supports local and online co-op as well as single-player and shared-controller arrangements.

The full catch. Two connected heads create funny movement but also coordination demands. Grabbing, stretching, positioning and repeated physical attempts can matter more than the cheerful setting suggests. Check the chosen controller arrangement and any holds directly; shared-controller play is a separate configuration, not automatically the easiest one.

Try this first. Try moving toward one object together and agree which head will act first. Test grabbing and releasing before pursuing a larger challenge. Judge whether accidental entanglement feels playful or irritating, and adjust the partnership rather than blaming either person.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My End of the Dog Has Different Dinner Plans

I claimed the red end of the dog. Dre claimed blue before I finished. Tank looked at the screen. 'Nigga, at least the Crip brought his own half.'

PHOGS! connected us through the middle. I wanted to inspect something impressive. Dre wanted food. The body between us expressed the disagreement with excellent clarity.

Rosa watched us pull in opposite directions. 'You two could speak.'

I told Dre where I wanted to go. He told me what he wanted to grab. We found a way to do both without treating the other head as faulty equipment.

Shawna leaned over my shoulder. 'You learn that, we might finish a holiday together.' 'Baby, I always take you somewhere nice.' 'Eventually. After your scenic argument.'

The dog stretched. Tank laughed at my expression. Mercedes wanted a turn.

I handed over my end. Nigga, I had never surrendered half a dog before, but the evening was expanding everybody's experience.

Aiden's verdict. Try the two-headed dog if funny physical compromise sounds enjoyable. My half must explain its travel plans before dragging the other half toward another scenic argument.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/850320/>

P223 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Pikuniku

Edition considered: PC release; co-op levels separate from solo story

Explore an absurdly cheerful world with a darker story underneath, or choose separate local cooperative levels for a shared dose of comic physical puzzles instead.

What you do. Move, jump and kick through the story's situations or work with another player in the distinct cooperative challenge levels.

Direction + buttons | Action continues while you think | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. The solo campaign and co-op levels are different modes, and simple drawings do not remove active movement or timing demands.

Why it might click. A deliberately silly puzzle-exploration adventure pairs peculiar characters with a story about a deceptively cheerful dystopia. The separate local cooperative levels offer a different way to enjoy its physical comedy with another player.

The full catch. The story campaign is not the same as the dedicated co-op challenges. Movement, jumping, kicking and physical timing can require active coordination. Do not infer an untimed or hold-free experience from the simple drawings or the description's invitation to explore at your own pace.

Try this first. First decide whether the goal is shared story viewing or actual two-player puzzles. Try one short movement section in that mode and see whether the comic physics are enjoyable. Leave progress targets aside while testing the basic legwork.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P223 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Pikuniku

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Revolution Has Kicked Over My Champagne

I stood to announce the revolution and knocked my champagne over with the chair. Tank lifted the controller away from the spill. 'Nigga, the regime has suffered its first loss.'

Pikuniku made strange legs and cheerful colours look capable of hiding a serious problem. I appreciated that. My own evening clothes had hidden several.

Mercedes asked whether we wanted the story or the separate cooperative levels. Porsche said she wanted to kick something fictional. Rosa said the glass had already supplied enough real-world physics.

I helped clean the spill before volunteering to lead anybody anywhere. Shawna watched me return the towel.

'Look at that,' she said. 'A revolutionary with follow-through.'

We tried moving the little characters. The first attempt was ridiculous. The second was better and somehow funnier.

I started composing a slogan. Tank honked a laugh before any words came out. 'My nigga, let the legs talk.' For once, the legs had a more convincing programme than I did.

Aiden's verdict. Enter the absurd movement if it sounds funny rather than frustrating. The revolution may continue after I finish paying for the champagne it liberated onto the carpet.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/572890/>

P224 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Overboard!

Edition considered: PC release

Play the culprit in a replayable shipboard mystery, using conversations and manipulation to change what other characters believe before the journey reaches its destination.

What you do. Choose where to go, question or mislead characters, and track what people have seen as you construct a possible cover story.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The eight-hour story schedule creates pressure; reading, character movements and replay matter, while exact real-time clock behavior needs checking.

Why it might click. You play the culprit on a 1930s liner and try to escape justice through conversations, lies and manipulation. Characters remember events and move independently, making a replayed situation reveal new possibilities. A companion can discuss schemes beside the single-player screen.

The full catch. The story gives you eight in-game hours, with schedules and missed opportunities creating pressure. The inspected description does not resolve every real-time or pause detail, so test how the clock advances. Reading, remembering movements and replaying failed plans are central burdens.

Try this first. Inspect the first choices and clock behavior before pursuing an elaborate cover story. Discuss one possible explanation only if the player wants advice. Decide whether mischievous replay and moral inversion feel entertaining rather than exhausting.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P224 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Overboard!

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / My Alibi Has Been Corrected by the Woman in It

I said I could get away with anything if Shawna supplied the alibi. My wife looked up slowly. Tank put his plate down. Nigga, the room recognised an impending donation to comedy.

Overboard! made the culprit's story part of the game. I told everybody I had been upstairs being an exceptionally attentive husband.

'At what time?' Shawna asked. I gave her one.

'Baby, you were downstairs explaining your watch to the bartender.'

Mercedes laughed. Porsche asked whether my witness wanted to amend the statement. My witness wanted another drink and the truth about where I had left her shawl.

On the screen, somebody remembered something inconvenient. I felt an immediate connection to the material.

I retrieved the shawl and put it around my wife's shoulders. 'How about now?' I asked.

She caught my hand. 'Now you're doing better.' Tank grinned. 'Nigga found an alibi he can actually produce.' The fictional murder remained beyond our marriage's available services.

Aiden's verdict. Try the fictional cover-up when lies and remembered details sound entertaining. My wife will provide company, but all alibis must survive her recollection of the evening.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1546920/>

P225 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Expelled!

Edition considered: PC release

Navigate a devious boarding-school mystery through gossip and remembered actions, trying to change the outcome of an accusation before the school day is over.

What you do. Talk to characters, investigate secrets, choose where to go and use information to alter how the accusation develops.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. One school day limits opportunities, and replay needs route memory; the official clock language does not establish every paused-screen behavior.

Why it might click. Verity Amersham navigates a 1922 boarding school after being accused of attempted murder. Conversations, secrets and manipulation reshape the day, offering a replayable narrative puzzle that can invite lively discussion from an optional companion.

The full catch. One school day limits the investigation, and characters act on what they witness. The official description's ticking-clock language establishes schedule pressure, not a verified rule for every paused screen. Expect reading, route memory and potentially unpleasant choices; it remains a single-player game.

Try this first. Inspect the opening accusation and the timetable or clock as presented. Try one conversation and observe the consequence of an action before designing a perfect route. Let curiosity about the characters decide whether another run sounds worthwhile.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Headmistress Has Put My Name on the Wrong List

I told the casino host I had once been considered exceptionally promising. Shawna asked by whom. I said history. Tank said history had declined to provide a reference.

Expelled! had a sharper problem: get through one school day without the accusation deciding everything. Mercedes wanted to hear the next conversation before judging anybody.

I offered a strategy based on charm. Porsche pointed at the host still waiting for my room number. 'Nigga, your charm hasn't secured the towels.'

The game gave us gossip, secrets and people remembering what they had seen. Rosa asked what we actually knew. I looked back at the text.

Shawna smiled. 'Don't write your own reference this time.'

I stopped trying to win the whole room and chose one question. It produced more than my introduction had.

The host returned with the towels. 'For Mr Aiden?' 'Captain,' I began. Tank took them. 'Nigga, accept the delivery before they expel you from your own suite.'

Aiden's verdict. Choose the school mystery if scheming through a consequential day sounds appealing. My reference letter remains unsigned, and the towels have wisely arrived without endorsing it.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2963890/>

P226 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Machinarium

Edition considered: PC release

Help a small robot through a hand-drawn mechanical city, reading gestures and solving puzzles as he works toward people he cares about along the way.

What you do. Inspect scenes, interact with objects, solve logical puzzles and use visual thought bubbles to understand the robot's problems.

Mouse / pointer | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Small targets, inventory logic and minigames can be demanding; wordless storytelling does not establish obvious solutions or entirely untimed play.

Why it might click. Guide a small robot through a hand-drawn mechanical city, solving logical puzzles and helping people he cares about. Animated thought bubbles replace long spoken conversations, giving a companion plenty to observe without requiring two playable characters.

The full catch. Inventory logic, small targets, brain teasers and minigames can become demanding. Wordless presentation does not mean obvious solutions or zero timing. Check the chosen PC interface and any puzzle assistance directly; the inspected source does not certify a fully untimed completion path.

Try this first. Explore the opening scene and try one object interaction. Ask whether the drawings and character gestures are appealing even before solving anything. Share a single suggestion only when requested, allowing the player to keep the satisfying discovery.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Robot Has Repaired Everything I Claimed Was Decorative

I told the hotel staff the crooked lamp was intentional. Tank straightened it. 'Nigga, now it's intentionally useful.'

Machinarium put a small robot into a world full of things that needed understanding. Mercedes watched a gesture on the screen and smiled. No grand explanation. She had seen what mattered.

I brought over a diagram I had drawn on a napkin. Porsche turned it upside down and said it made the same amount of sense.

Shawna wanted to try the object herself. I moved the mouse toward her and kept my commentary in my mouth, where it had less opportunity to damage the evening.

The little robot found a way through. Tank nodded at the screen. 'That nigga works.'

Rosa gave me a loose button from my jacket. 'Since we're repairing things.'

I looked at my wife. She held out her hand, smiling. 'Sit close.' Nigga, suddenly I was delighted to own something broken and small enough to fix together.

Aiden's verdict. Meet the little robot when mechanical puzzles and expressive gestures sound appealing. The lamp is repaired, and my jacket has developed an excellent reason to sit closer.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/40700/>

P227 / A PLACE TO START

Botanicula

Edition considered: PC release

Follow five little tree creatures through a world of peculiar inhabitants, music and playful reactions as they try to protect the last seed of their home.

What you do. Explore scenes, click on creatures and objects, interpret their reactions and try unusual combinations to solve the group's problems.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Minimal text shifts work toward visual interpretation and hotspots; some tasks may need precision or repeated attempts despite relaxed marketing.

Why it might click. Five tree creatures travel to protect the last seed of their home from parasites. The attraction is discovery: peculiar inhabitants, playful animations and inventive sound turn looking and clicking into a sequence of small surprises.

The full catch. Minimal text shifts the work toward interpreting visual behaviour, finding hotspots and inferring unusual puzzle rules. Some tasks may need precision or repeated attempts; the publisher's broad relaxed-play language is not a whole-game input audit. Shared observation remains distinct from native cooperative control.

Try this first. Explore a small area and interact with several visible creatures without trying to clear everything. Check the pointing demands and whether the nonverbal clues feel inviting. A companion can enjoy the reactions without supplying a running solution commentary.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Last Seed Does Not Want My Investment Advice

I called the little seed an asset. Rosa took it out of my hand. 'Nigga, it's trying to grow. Leave it alone.' Botanicula gave five strange friends a reason to go into a world I could not have improved by naming its departments. Mercedes clicked something because it looked curious. It answered in a way that made her laugh.

I began suggesting a strategy. Porsche held up one finger and tried another thing. More laughter. Apparently the room had discovered play without waiting for my instructions.

Tank arranged five little objects beside the screen. My cufflink volunteered as one character. I objected on financial grounds.

'Nigga, it can afford an adventure.'

Shawna watched the creatures move. I watched her smiling at them. The seed's value became a considerably less interesting question than what might happen next.

Rosa returned my cufflink when we stopped. Nothing had happened to it. My attempt to assign it a heroic backstory met immediate and justified resistance.

Aiden's verdict. Explore if odd creatures and surprising reactions make you curious. The seed is exempt from my investment vocabulary, and the cufflink has returned without requesting a medal.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/207690/>

P228 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Samorost 3

Edition considered: PC release

Explore alien worlds through a space gnome's curiosity, with a magical flute, unusual creatures and music making unfamiliar places inviting to investigate and understand.

What you do. Inspect scenes, listen to sounds, try object interactions and follow visual or musical patterns through the exploration puzzles.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Unusual puzzle logic, audio information and small hotspots need checking; the exploration premise does not certify no timers or dragging.

Why it might click. A space gnome follows the mystery of a magical flute through alien worlds full of creatures, images and music. The pleasure can lie in interpreting an unfamiliar place together, with one person operating the adventure and another noticing details.

The full catch. Sound and visual patterns matter to the experience, and some puzzle logic is deliberately strange. Check any audio-dependent clue, hotspot size and object manipulation directly. The inspected description supports exploration and puzzles, not a guarantee of no timers, no dragging or easy completion.

Try this first. Visit the opening area, listen at a comfortable volume and try a few visible interactions. Decide whether uncertainty feels intriguing or obstructive. Invite a companion to describe one noticed detail without immediately searching for an external solution.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Space Gnome Has Put My Flute on Mute

I found a little flute among the hotel's decorative instruments and said the cosmos had been waiting for my sound. Tank closed his eyes. 'Nigga, the cosmos can wait longer.'

Samorost 3 had music and creatures that made sense on their own strange terms. Mercedes wanted to listen. I wanted to demonstrate that I understood the theme.

Shawna took the flute before I could test my understanding against the room's eardrums.

'Later,' she said. 'In private?' 'In a different building.'

Porsche laughed into her drink. Dre moved closer to the screen, interested in an odd little movement nobody had explained yet.

We tried an interaction. The response made us look at another part of the scene. I liked not knowing exactly what kind of place we had reached.

The flute stayed on the table. My wife put her hand over mine when I reached for it. Nigga, apparently the universe had a volume control and she knew where it was.

Aiden's verdict. Visit the strange worlds if sound and observation invite curiosity. My flute remains decorative, allowing the space gnome's music to reach the people who actually requested it.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/421120/>

P229 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

LEGO City Undercover

Edition considered: 2017 PC release; not original Wii U edition

Explore a large comic LEGO city together in the 2017 PC release, using disguises, vehicles and story missions to turn different neighbourhoods into shared adventures.

What you do. Walk and drive around the city, change roles, investigate objectives, fight and explore collectibles with another player.

Movement + camera | Action continues while you think | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Camera control, driving and action create broad demands; check split-screen legibility and controller setup before committing to the city.

Why it might click. Chase McCain pursues a criminal through a large LEGO city, using disguises, vehicles and comic situations. The 2017 PC release explicitly supports two-player cooperation, so companions can participate in the city rather than only watch its story.

The full catch. Open-world navigation, camera control, driving, fights, jumping and collecting create a broad action workload. A familiar toy aesthetic does not simplify every task. Check split-screen legibility and each controller setup before assuming the shared view works comfortably.

Try this first. Try walking, looking around and one simple objective together before driving fast or chasing collectibles. Agree on a meeting place and whether exploration or story is the purpose. Stop when the city's activity becomes more busy than amusing.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Undercover Officer Has Put His Name on the Car

I chose an undercover outfit in the same colour as my usual jacket. Then I added sunglasses. Tank looked me over. 'Nigga, you're hiding as yourself with weather.'

LEGO City Undercover offered a city, disguises and jobs I could change when one became inconvenient. I liked the flexibility. Shawna asked whether responsibility changed with the hat.

Mercedes wanted to drive somewhere. Porsche wanted to explore on foot. We checked the version and the shared view before promising both could do exactly what they imagined.

I announced our first objective in a detective voice. Rosa asked why the detective sounded like he was selling a nightclub.

Dre pointed at the screen. 'Your car.'

I had left it at an angle that suggested the driver had departed during an argument with geometry. Tank laughed and took his turn.

The city continued without being impressed. Nigga, it had seen enough costumes to recognise that a good disguise still needed somebody who could park.

Aiden's verdict. Roam the comic city if both players welcome driving and action. My disguise may remain in service after the car demonstrates an ordinary relationship with the curb.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/578330/>

P230 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

LEGO Star Wars: The Skywalker Saga

Edition considered: PC base game

Share familiar film adventures through LEGO humour, with many characters and places to explore across a large local cooperative action game covering the Skywalker films.

What you do. Move and aim through story scenes, fight, use vehicles and switch character abilities while exploring together in local cooperative play.

Movement + camera | Action continues while you think | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Combat, camera movement, vehicles and character menus add work; the large scope and split-screen controls need a modest first trial.

Why it might click. The nine Skywalker films become a large comic action adventure with local cooperative play. Familiar scenes, many characters and places to explore can make a lively shared journey for people who already enjoy the setting.

The full catch. Combat includes aiming and attack combinations, and the game adds vehicles, camera movement, character abilities and extensive menus. The large scope can overwhelm a simple evening plan. Split-screen comfort and both players' controls need checking; brand familiarity does not remove those demands.

Try this first. Choose one starting trilogy and test a small opening section together. Try looking, moving, attacking and selecting a character without pursuing every collectible. Decide whether the shared jokes justify the action load before treating the whole saga as a commitment.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Jedi Has Caught His Cape in the Mini Fridge

I said the Force would guide us. Then my cape caught in the minibar door and stopped me taking a second step. Tank pointed at the fridge. 'Nigga, strong with this one.'

The Skywalker Saga offered enough places and characters for me to promise an entire galaxy before dinner. Rosa looked at the cooling food. The galaxy received a smaller booking.

Shawna freed the cape and kissed my cheek. 'One scene, baby.' 'You doubt my stamina?' 'I know your attention span.'

Mercedes picked a character she actually liked. Porsche joined her. Neither required my explanation of where every vehicle came from.

I sat down and tried the controls instead of treating familiarity as competence. Dre watched the aiming. Tank watched my cape, which was still within reach of another door.

The first joke landed. We laughed together.

Nigga, I had finally brought balance to the evening by reducing my proposed universe to something that fit between a meal and my wife's next good idea.

Aiden's verdict. Try a small galactic outing if familiar jokes justify the action load. My cape has been released from refrigeration and will observe all future adventures from a hanger.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched Steam publisher description inspected for exact title, premise and explicit mode claims. Control burden and preference routing are editorial judgments; unknown timing and held-input demands remain visible. No full-playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/920210/>

P231 / A PLACE TO START

LEGO Builder's Journey

Edition considered: PC release; Creative mode separate

Arrange small LEGO scenes through atmospheric geometric puzzles, or explore the separate Creative Mode when making a little construction is more appealing than following the narrative.

What you do. Select, rotate and place pieces, adjust the view, and either solve a small scene or build a model in Creative Mode.

Mixed controls | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Precise placement and camera control may involve holds or drags; shared design discussion does not establish native cooperative play.

Why it might click. Small geometric LEGO puzzles tell an atmospheric story through placed pieces and changing situations. The PC release separately includes Creative Mode for free construction and photographs, offering another route when arranging objects is more appealing than solving the narrative.

The full catch. Selecting, rotating, positioning and viewing small pieces may require precision. A quiet presentation does not prove every placement avoids holds or dragging. This is single-player; discussing designs beside someone is optional shared activity, not verified native cooperative control.

Try this first. Try one simple placement and rotate the view before choosing a longer puzzle. Alternatively, inspect Creative Mode and make a tiny scene. Let the person's interest in solving or building determine the mode instead of insisting on story progress.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Monument Is Smaller Than the Receipt

I proposed a LEGO monument big enough to dominate the view. Mercedes put six bricks in front of me. 'Nigga, dominate these first.'

Builder's Journey made a small piece matter because of where it went. I kept trying to turn the little scene into a portrait of my ambition. Tank kept asking how anybody was supposed to cross it.

Shawna moved one brick. The route worked.

'That was in my plan,' I said. 'Baby, your plan was a statue.'

Rosa wanted to try making something of her own. We looked at the separate Creative Mode rather than insisting the evening remain a puzzle.

Dre made a little bridge. Porsche changed its colour. I added one piece that actually helped, then waited for somebody to notice.

Mercedes did. 'That fits.'

Nigga, two words nearly made me unbearable. Shawna caught the beginning of my speech and kissed it shut. The monument remained small, the bridge remained useful, and everybody's view improved.

Aiden's verdict. Build or solve if small arrangements feel satisfying. My monument has become a bridge, and its opening ceremony will last no longer than crossing the actual thing.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected matched Steam publisher description or manually verified official product page supports the named game, premise and explicit mode features. Unknown controls remain visible; fit and burden are editorial suggestions, not a complete playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1544360/>

P232 / A PLACE TO START

The Gardens Between

Edition considered: PC release

Manipulate time through dreamlike islands built from two friends' memories, discovering how familiar objects connect without text, speech or pressure to finish quickly.

What you do. Move time forward and backward, watch how objects interact and adjust the sequence to help the friends progress through each island.

Direction + buttons | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Sequence puzzles still need attention, and moving time may require sustained input; simple controls do not establish no holds.

Why it might click. Manipulate time through dreamlike island scenes built from two friends' memories. The publisher explicitly describes a single-player game with no text, speech or time pressure, giving shared observation room to focus on images and sequences.

The full catch. You control the flow of time rather than simply steering each friend independently. Understanding cause and sequence can still be demanding, and sustained input to move time needs a direct check. Simple controls do not automatically mean no holds. This is shared thinking beside one player, not native co-op.

Try this first. Move time forward and back in the opening scene, noticing one object that changes or interacts differently. Check how the input feels before pursuing a long sequence. Decide whether the visual friendship story gives the puzzle enough emotional interest.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / I Rewound the Evening and Still Ordered the Piano

I wanted to reverse the moment I had ordered the piano. Tank said I should go further back and stop myself discovering capital letters.

The Gardens Between let time become something to move through a small world. I watched a scene change and immediately imagined correcting every bad entrance I had made tonight.

Shawna leaned close. 'You'd make a different one.' 'Baby, that is cruelly accurate.'

Mercedes noticed an object that mattered when the sequence shifted. Porsche asked to see it again. We moved back, looked, moved forward. No one demanded a faster answer.

Rosa rested against Tank. The little friendship on the screen made him put an arm around her without a joke.

I tried to explain the emotional significance. My wife pressed one finger to my lips.

Nigga, she had found the only rewind I actually needed. The next moment arrived quieter. We watched it together, and I left the piano where it was instead of ordering a replacement mistake.

Aiden's verdict. Move through the memories if watching a sequence change sounds inviting. My piano cannot be rewound, but the next unnecessary purchase remains beautifully preventable tonight.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher description explicitly calls The Gardens Between single-player and states no text, speech, time pressure or complex UI. Time manipulation, friendship and island puzzles are supported. The card retains uncertainty about sustained input and does not equate simple controls with no holds.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/600990/>

P233 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Day of the Tentacle Remastered

Edition considered: PC Remastered edition

Solve a comic adventure across three time periods, using changes in one era to create possibilities for another while following three unlikely friends and a tentacle's ambition.

What you do. Explore rooms, collect and use objects, switch characters and connect consequences between the different periods of the story.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Character switching, inventories and cross-era consequences create heavy tracking, and cartoon logic may feel inventive or frustrating.

Why it might click. A cartoon adventure links three protagonists across time, turning changes in one era into possibilities in another. The Remastered edition offers revised art and audio alongside classic presentation options, with comedy built into the puzzle logic.

The full catch. Inventories, character switching and consequences across different periods create a real memory burden. Cartoon logic may feel inventive or arbitrary. The source does not establish every timing or hold demand; preview the interface and selected presentation rather than assuming a classic adventure is automatically easy.

Try this first. Explore an early room and identify one useful object or conversation. Try switching the presentation if you prefer, then decide whether the humour and inventory handling appeal. A companion can keep one current question visible without delivering the whole solution.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Tentacle Wants Power but Hasn't Seen the Hotel Bill

I respected the purple tentacle's ambition until Tank asked whether its world takeover included paying for my suite. Nigga, suddenly I had questions about leadership.

Day of the Tentacle sent three friends into different times. I saw a chance to prevent several fashion decisions. Shawna said the future would be grateful if I started with the jacket I was wearing.

Mercedes wanted to try an object in another era. Porsche remembered something we had seen earlier. Their conversation had a direction. Mine had tailoring.

I put the jacket over a chair and actually read the inventory.

The connection was ridiculous in a way that made sense once it happened. Tank laughed. Rosa wanted to see what else the past could change.

I suggested sending my room bill backwards. Dre asked whether history had done anything to deserve it.

Nigga, the tentacle could keep the conquest. I was busy learning that moving one ordinary thing might accomplish more than announcing possession of the whole world.

Aiden's verdict. Travel through the joke if strange object connections sound delightful. The hotel bill is forbidden from entering history until I identify a century that actually owes me money.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected matched Steam publisher description or manually verified official product page supports the named game, premise and explicit mode features. Unknown controls remain visible; fit and burden are editorial suggestions, not a complete playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/388210/>

P234 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Trine Enchanted Edition

Edition considered: PC Enchanted Edition

Combine a wizard, knight and thief's different abilities in a fantasy adventure, using physical puzzles and cooperative action to find more than one way forward.

What you do. Move through stages, create or manipulate objects, fight and use character-specific abilities while coordinating with local or online partners.

Mixed controls | Action continues while you think | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Platforming, aiming and combat remain; character roles differ, and difficulty or saving features do not establish a no-reflex route.

Why it might click. Wizard, knight and thief combine different abilities in a fantasy world of physical puzzles and combat. Enchanted Edition supports up to three players locally or online, and the original 2009 release is also included as a separate launcher choice.

The full catch. Platforming, fighting, aiming and grappling remain active demands, with different burdens by character. The inspected description declares saving options and the store lists adjustable difficulty, but neither establishes a no-reflex or no-hold path. Choose Enchanted Edition deliberately rather than mixing its features with the original.

Try this first. In an early section, try each preferred character's movement and one ability. Discuss whether roles feel satisfying before combining them under pressure. A companion should not become the compulsory combat department unless that is genuinely the role they want.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Wizard Has Put a Box in Front of My Seduction

I chose the wizard because I liked making things appear. Shawna asked whether that included the shoes I had promised to find. Tank chose the knight before I answered.

Trine gave us different abilities. I created a box and placed it exactly where my brother needed to walk.

'Nigga, your magic got a traffic problem.'

Mercedes wanted to try the thief. Porsche watched the route. Rosa asked whether anybody had actually said what help they wanted before I started delivering furniture.

I moved the box. Tank crossed. One useful result, achieved after my initial obstacle had been removed.

Shawna found her shoes beneath the real chair I had moved earlier. She held them up.

'Baby, you create problems in several dimensions.' 'I also create opportunities.'

She leaned close enough to make me forget the answer I was composing. Then she handed me a controller. 'Here's one. Ask your brother where he wants the next fucking box.' Nigga, desire can sharpen a man's listening.

Aiden's verdict. Try the fantasy action if different jobs and physical puzzles appeal. My wizard may summon another box after somebody confirms it will not obstruct a person or a marriage.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected matched Steam publisher description or manually verified official product page supports the named game, premise and explicit mode features. Unknown controls remain visible; fit and burden are editorial suggestions, not a complete playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/35700/>

P235 / A PLACE TO START

Pilgrims

Edition considered: PC digital game; not the board game

Experiment with characters and objects in an illustrated adventure that welcomes different solutions, turning unexpected reactions and short comic situations into much of the pleasure.

What you do. Explore situations, choose items or characters to try, and watch how their combinations change a small story or solve a task.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Unusual responses still need interpretation, and item or card manipulation may involve dragging or holds that should be checked.

Why it might click. A playful illustrated adventure encourages trying items and characters in different situations, with multiple solutions rather than one fixed route through every task. Its brief, expressive reactions can be enjoyable to discover with someone watching beside you.

The full catch. Interpreting unusual responses and managing available objects still requires attention. Test how cards or items are selected and moved; do not assume that a playful interface avoids dragging or held actions. The inspected publisher description presents single-player experimentation, not verified native cooperative control.

Try this first. Try a couple of early combinations and watch what happens without demanding immediate progress. Check whether manipulating the items feels comfortable. A companion can suggest an experiment, but the person playing gets to choose which curiosity to follow.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P235 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Pilgrims

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Traveller Has Refused the Plan I Made for Him

I told the little traveller where his journey ought to go. Mercedes tried a different item. The response made her laugh. Nigga, insubordination had immediate rewards.

Pilgrims seemed comfortable with an experiment that did not match my preferred solution. I found this generous and slightly threatening.

Tank offered to write my plan down. I said yes. He wrote TRY SOMETHING on the hotel coaster and passed it back.

'That's not a plan.' 'Then you won't mind changing it.'

Shawna tried another combination. Rosa wanted to see what the odd character would do. Dre laughed at a reaction before anybody decided whether it counted as progress.

I stopped asking whether we had used the right thing. The room was enjoying what happened. That seemed an inconveniently complete answer.

Porsche pushed the controller toward me. I tried something because it looked funny.

It was. Nigga, I looked around for somebody to appreciate my discovery of play. My wife smiled and let me have the moment without naming it.

Aiden's verdict. Experiment here if amusing reactions feel worthwhile on their own. My comprehensive travel plan has been condensed to a coaster, improving both its accuracy and its luggage requirements.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected matched Steam publisher description or manually verified official product page supports the named game, premise and explicit mode features. Unknown controls remain visible; fit and burden are editorial suggestions, not a complete playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1049280/>

P236 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

The Longest Journey

Edition considered: Original PC release

Spend time with April Ryan's journey between parallel universes, following conversations and puzzles through a large imaginative world that can be shared as a story.

What you do. Explore locations, speak with people, examine objects and solve inventory puzzles while following April's changing understanding of the two worlds.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. The older PC release needs readability and compatibility checks; long conversations, repeated travel and inventory puzzles add substantial work.

Why it might click. April Ryan moves between parallel universes in a substantial original PC adventure filled with conversations, places and puzzles. Its appeal is spending time with a large imaginative world; another person can share the story and discuss clues beside the player.

The full catch. This older PC release needs a compatibility and readability check on the actual machine. Long dialogue, inventory puzzles, repeated travel and remembering multiple locations add work. Do not infer no timers, no holds or modern interface options from its age or genre.

Try this first. Launch the exact original release, inspect text and save behavior, then hear an opening conversation and try an object interaction. Decide whether the people and world justify the interface effort before treating the title as a promise to finish a very long journey.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / Both Universes Have Declined My Late Checkout

I told the concierge I needed a room in a parallel universe. He said he would check availability after I settled the one in this universe. Nigga had powerful grounding in reality.

The Longest Journey offered April Ryan two worlds to discover. Mercedes wanted to hear the people. Porsche wanted to know where the next clue might lead.

I began drawing a map around my own photograph. Shawna turned the paper over. 'Baby, this journey got a protagonist already.'

Tank moved the chair so we could see the older interface clearly. Rosa asked whether the text was comfortable before getting attached to the story.

We followed one conversation. It led to another question. My appetite for the world grew without my having to own the middle of it.

The concierge called back. No parallel suite. I told him to keep looking.

Shawna took the phone. 'He's staying here.' Then she put her hand on my chest. Nigga, this universe retained a persuasive advantage.

Aiden's verdict. Visit the older adventure if its people justify the interface effort. My parallel accommodation remains unavailable, leaving the current universe with the difficult responsibility of my continued presence.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected matched Steam publisher description or manually verified official product page supports the named game, premise and explicit mode features. Unknown controls remain visible; fit and burden are editorial suggestions, not a complete playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/6310/>

P237 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Broken Age

Edition considered: PC complete two-act release

Follow two teenagers in very different worlds as they question the lives arranged for them, with expressive characters, voice performances and puzzles linking the adventure.

What you do. Switch between the protagonists, explore their scenes, speak with characters and use objects to solve the developing puzzles.

Mouse / pointer | Timing needs checking | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Two threads and later inventory reasoning add heavy tracking; an approachable opening does not establish simple puzzles throughout.

Why it might click. Vella and Shay navigate very different worlds while trying to take control of their lives. The complete two-act point-and-click adventure combines hand-drawn scenes, voice performances, odd characters and puzzles, with switching between the protagonists part of the structure.

The full catch. Two story threads and inventory reasoning can require remembering details across scenes. Later puzzle complexity should not be inferred from an approachable opening. The developer page supports the premise and point-and-click form, not a full no-timer or no-hold certification. This is shared viewing of a single-player adventure.

Try this first. Hear an opening conversation, try one interaction and look at the character-switching interface. Choose which story to follow by interest. A companion can remember an earlier clue without taking over every decision or explaining a solution before it is wanted.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P237 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Broken Age

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Talking Spoon Does Not Want to Be My Assistant

I picked up a spoon and announced that it had been promoted. Rosa took it back. 'Nigga, it's serving dessert. Let it finish the job it likes.'

Broken Age gave two people reasons to question the lives arranged for them. Mercedes looked at me when that became clear. I pretended to study the artwork.

Shawna chose which story to follow first. I said I would have chosen the same one. She smiled. 'Good. Then we don't need your permission.'

Tank settled beside Rosa with his dessert. Porsche wanted to try an object before hearing another theory. Both requests were granted faster than my spoon's imaginary appointment.

The painted world did something strange. I laughed and leaned closer.

Rosa handed me a clean spoon. 'This one's yours.' 'Can it have a title?' 'If it helps you find your mouth.'

Nigga, the room had reduced my authority to a practical route. The dessert was excellent, and for once I had no reason to improve the arrangement.

Aiden's verdict. Follow the two stories when unusual characters resisting their assigned lives sounds appealing. My spoon has returned to dessert service and declined all further executive responsibility for breakfast.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected matched Steam publisher description or manually verified official product page supports the named game, premise and explicit mode features. Unknown controls remain visible; fit and burden are editorial suggestions, not a complete playthrough audit. Checked September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://www.doublefine.com/games/broken-age>

P238 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Dinkum

Edition considered: PC release; current version status must be checked

Build a town and explore an Australian-inspired landscape with friends, choosing whether default survival or the separate Creative Mode better suits the appeal of making a place.

What you do. Gather resources, farm, build and meet residents, or inspect Creative Mode before deciding which shared town activities to pursue.

Movement + camera | Action continues while you think | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Default play includes wildlife and combat; camera comfort, visitor permissions and some host-only town tasks still need checking.

Why it might click. Explore, gather, farm and build a settlement in an Australian-inspired landscape, meeting residents and inviting friends online. The full PC release combines town creation with survival and also includes a separate Creative Mode, offering a different focus for building.

The full catch. Default play includes wild animals, tools, combat, gathering, crafting and a three-dimensional view. Creative Mode changes building options, not the need to check camera comfort. Official launch notes leave some town quests to the host. Record the installed version rather than relying on old Early Access advice.

Try this first. Try walking, looking around and one modest town task before entering dangerous terrain. Inspect Creative Mode if building is the attraction, then check the chosen multiplayer permissions. Ask whether both players enjoy their available tasks rather than assigning one all the work.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

P238 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Dinkum

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Crocodile Has Rejected Our Welcome Drink

I proposed greeting the wildlife with a complimentary cocktail. Tank looked at the crocodile on the screen. 'Nigga, that's not a hotel guest.'

Dinkum had building and community wrapped around a world that could bite back. Rosa wanted a pleasant little town. Mercedes wanted to know which parts we actually wanted to play.

Shawna asked whether my plan involved somebody else doing every dangerous job while I chose the furniture. I said leadership required taste.

'So does dinner,' Dre said. 'You ain't cooked that either.'

We checked the creative option before pretending the default adventure had no teeth. Porsche wanted to understand what a visitor could change. I finally had a useful reason to read a menu.

The town began as one modest task. No grand opening. No invitations mailed to reptiles.

Tank passed me the controller. 'You doing this one?'

I did. Nigga, it was harder to maintain my title as visionary while actually working, but the little place improved considerably.

Aiden's verdict. Build here if the chosen mode and visitor roles suit both people. The crocodile receives no welcome drink, no invitation and absolutely no authority over the furniture.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Matched PC Steam description supports Australian-inspired survival, farming and online cooperation. Official launch announcements explicitly confirm the April 23, 2025 UTC exit from Early Access, Creative Mode and revised multiplayer permissions. Some town/building quests remain host-only in those launch notes. Current build behavior still needs checking; observed September 20, 2026.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1062520/>

Source 2: https://store.steampowered.com/news/posts/?appids=1062520&enddate=1745490680&feed=steam_community_announcements

P239 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Farm Together

Edition considered: PC first game

Grow and decorate a shared farm that keeps moving while you are offline, making return visits part of the pleasure without requiring continuous attendance from players.

What you do. Plant and tend crops, care for animals, arrange the farm and set permissions for friends helping with the ongoing work.

Movement + camera | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Repeated tending and expansion can become a workload; check camera controls, menus and permissions, and remember this is the first game.

Why it might click. Grow crops, keep animals, decorate a farm and invite other players to cultivate it together. The first Farm Together explicitly lets time progress while you are offline, creating a place that can be revisited rather than requiring continuous attendance.

The full catch. Repeated tending, expansion, currencies, waiting and item menus can become a workload. Movement and camera handling need a direct check. Online farm permissions matter when sharing; the source does not establish every activity as untimed or hold-free. This card covers the first game, not its sequel.

Try this first. Plant or tend one small area and inspect how a friend joins and what they may change. Try camera movement and a basic interaction. Decide whether returning to growing things feels pleasant without agreeing to an attendance schedule.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The Carrots Have Grown Without My Personal Approval

I returned to the farm and announced that production had continued under my leadership. Tank looked at me. 'Nigga, you were upstairs looking for your cufflink.'

Farm Together let time pass while we were away. Rosa liked the idea of coming back to something. I liked the idea of claiming credit for it.

Mercedes wanted a path leading somewhere pretty. Porsche wanted to choose what to plant. Dre asked which permissions a visitor had before he accidentally redesigned the whole place.

I began proposing a schedule. Shawna put her hand over the phone I was reaching for.

'No alarms, baby. We're talking about a game.'

I left the phone down. We tried one little area and decided that would do for now.

Tank asked whether I had found the cufflink. I said yes. Rosa lifted it from beside his plate and handed it over.

Nigga, several systems had progressed without me. The carrots were merely the most polite about explaining it.

Aiden's verdict. Return to the farm if its persistent little jobs feel pleasant. My cufflink and the carrots may continue their independent lives without receiving an attendance schedule from me.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually verified Steam app 673950 is the first Farm Together, published by Milkstone Studios. Product description explicitly supports shared farming, permissions and time advancing offline. These claims are not imported from Farm Together 2; exact control comfort remains untested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/673950/>

P240 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Staxel

Edition considered: PC release

Restore a farm and shape a blocky village with friends online, sharing one place or becoming neighbours while building projects give the world personal character.

What you do. Move around the world, place building materials, grow crops and help villagers, coordinating a small farm or construction project with friends.

Movement + camera | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. First-person camera movement, crafting and precise block placement add demands; establish the session setup and check sustained inputs before building.

Why it might click. Restore a farm, meet villagers and alter a voxel world through building and cultivation. The PC game explicitly supports online cooperation, allowing friends to share a farm or become neighbours while making their own projects.

The full catch. First-person movement, camera steering, selecting materials, crafting and placing blocks can create substantial coordination and menu demands. Farming tasks add routine work. The publisher's creative premise does not certify no holds, no timed activities or a frictionless multiplayer setup.

Try this first. Try looking around, moving through a doorway and placing or interacting with a simple object. If sharing online, establish who owns the session and how both people join. Choose one small project only after the controls feel worth using.

AIDEN AFTER HOURS / The House Got Better When I Put Down the Floor Plan

I promised the next house would have a sensible entrance. Shawna looked at the blank patch in Staxel. 'Start there, baby. Before the honeymoon balcony.'

Tank wanted a workshop. Rosa wanted a place to sit. Mercedes wanted the colour to remain undecided until she saw the walls. Dre wanted to make sure his casserole dish came home with him.

Everyone had an ordinary request. I had a drawing with two fountains.

Porsche folded the drawing and put it beneath my glass. 'There. It holds something.'

We tried the movement, placed a little piece and discussed where another might go. The house became less like my announcement and more like somewhere people could actually want to be.

Shawna moved her chair beside mine. I asked what she wanted next.

'A window.' I made room for one.

Nigga, sunlight entered without a dedication. Tank found a place for Rosa's chair. Mercedes picked a colour. I looked at the little house and stopped trying to make my name fit above the door.

Aiden's verdict. Make a place together if the camera and building controls feel worthwhile. My fountains have been postponed so the house can accommodate the people who actually want to visit.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Manually verified Steam app 405710 is Staxel, with explicit online co-op and shared-farm or neighbour play in the publisher description. Voxel building, village life and crops are supported. Camera workload and first trial are editorial checks, not access certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/405710/>

The Last Controller Did Not Need an Owner

At some point, the night stopped trying to impress the hotel.

The champagne fountain was off. The little spotlight had been turned toward the floor so Rosa could find her earring. The glass controller case held half a casserole, which Dre said was finally a sensible use of expensive glass.

I had my shoes off. Shawna had her feet in my lap. There were several things I might once have called beneath my station. None of them had prepared me for how pleased I was to be sitting still.

Tank and Rosa finished a small puzzle. They looked at each other before they looked at the screen. My brother raised his hand; she met it with hers.

'That's us,' he said.

'That's the puzzle,' she replied.

'Let me be romantic, woman.'

She kissed him. 'Now that's us.'

Dre asked whether somebody wanted the blue controller. Nobody did at that moment. He put it on the table within reach. No speech about team loyalty. No obligation to keep playing because the thing was already warm.

Mercedes was listening to the recording from the other night. Porsche sat close enough to hear but did not touch the phone. At the little catch in the last line, Mercedes smiled.

'Keep that,' she said.

'Kept it,' Porsche answered.

I wanted to tell them I had always known the recording mattered. Instead, I let the two words be enough.

The hotel host appeared in the doorway with a question about the empty glass case. I explained that it was now a food service installation. He looked at the casserole and decided to charge us nothing further for language.

'And your friend downstairs?' he asked.

Darnell had apparently told the bar that I was investing in his yacht. I had done no such thing. I had asked whether the nigga had eaten.

Shawna lifted her head. 'Did you sign anything?'

'Baby, I signed for ice.'

'With him, that's seed capital.'

Tank started laughing. Rosa told the host that any boat with my money in it needed my wife on the call. The host wrote nothing down. A talented man. He knew which questions should remain sentences rather than become forms.

I called Darnell and told him no. No yacht, no meeting, no introduction to somebody richer. He tried to tell me about the view.

'Nigga, I got a view.'

Shawna looked up at me and smiled.

I ended the call.

The game on the screen offered another stage. Nobody moved toward it immediately. This was allowed. There was still music in the room, and a good story could wait while somebody finished laughing.

I had spent the week making a very large answer to a very small invitation. Some of that largeness had been fun. Some had been me purchasing objects to avoid asking what anybody actually wanted.

Tonight they had told me.

Rosa wanted to eat before the food went cold. Tank wanted to sit with her. Mercedes wanted her work heard without losing the rest of her evening. Porsche wanted to help without taking over. Dre wanted the blue controller and a plate returned clean.

Shawna wanted me.

Nigga, it took a little effort to say that without making it sound like a conquest. She wanted me here, paying attention, available for the joke, the touch, the next ordinary thing. She had never needed the hotel to announce it.

I looked down at her. 'You ready?'

'For what?'

I considered the grand answer. The city, the night, a promise involving sunrise and the kind of expensive breakfast I always ordered too much of.

'Whatever you want next,' I said.

She held out her hand.

Tank made a noise behind his glass. Rosa elbowed him. Dre opened the case and began wrapping the remaining food. Mercedes took her phone. Porsche found her shoes without requiring a search party.

We got everyone to the lift. No final speech. I hugged my brother, thanked Dre for the casserole and told Mercedes I wanted to hear the new song when she wanted to share it.

'Ask me then,' she said.

'I will.'

The doors closed. The hotel went on being expensive around us.

Shawna took the second controller from my hand and put it beside the first. Both could wait.

'Come here, baby.'

I did.

The light by the bed went out before I found anything else to announce.

Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. The Tellings Cut: original revised Panorama prose and production by ChatGPT; original game research and selection system retained. This is a separate adult comic companion to Ten Toes Down. Source novels and the first Panorama edition remain intact. All people participating in the fictional party scenes are adults; Lillian is addressed as the reader.

Voice sources sampled for this revision: the Niggatorial Tellings Book I funeral and first Vegas party, selected passages from Books II-VI, and the edition editorial record. Source repository Sodelin/Ten-Toes-Down; working base 4cdof7a6e36977ff0ac705a59ebe65407d1f2bee. Selected passages were read closely; no full reread of all six novels is claimed. The added game-night story is newly composed fiction.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and <https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

This adult comic edition includes frequent reclaimed in-group language, strong profanity, fictional cocaine and party references, sexual banter and non-graphic innuendo. Those scenes are separate from the factual game descriptions and are not descriptions of the developers or real readers.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.